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Sociology

Civil Services (Main) Examination

(New Edition : 2015)



Aditya Mongra @ Professor's Classes

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about faculty

Dear Candidate, our faculty is highly qualified and experienced, both in Civil Services Examination as well as in academics.

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about Civil Services as a career

Dear Candidate, before I introduce you to this work I would like to share a few things with you. As you know Civil Services Examination is considered to be one of the toughest examinations. But I believe that there is no such thing as EASY or DIFFICULT per se because I feel that it is our thinking that makes it so. Therefore, if you begin your journey to IAS with a positive attitude that **'YES, I CAN DO IT'**, then trust me your journey would become not only a pleasant and enjoyful learning experience but also far more easier than otherwise. Further, before you decide to take Civil Services Examination or any other examination, make sure that your decision is well thought of. For that, firstly, you must take time and introspect and see whether your aptitude and interest matches with the career that you are planning to choose. Since it is the most important step for anyone, any amount of time spent on this is worth.

Secondly, whatever decision you take must be your own independent decision and must be taken with the conviction that whatever may be the outcome you will never regret having taken such decision. Thirdly, one must also make a comparative analysis of the requirements or the level of preparation that an examination demands and the ability or level of preparation one actually has. This is important because it will not only help you in placing the examination in right perspective but also enable you to set realistic expectations from yourself. It will go a long way in guarding you from negative thoughts often arising out of self-doubts during the course of preparation. Thus, saving you both, time as well as energy.

Last, but not the least, I would like to caution those students who go on a shopping spree collecting study material from various coaching institutes during the course of their preparation for this examination. I wish to make it clear that this examination does not require too much of content. Rather, on the basis of my personal experience as well as that of toppers, I can confidently say that ***this examination is less about content and more about analysis, both comparative as well as contemporary***.

That's why in light of the changing pattern of the Civil Services Examination, I always suggest my students to:

Read Adequately * Think Logically * Write Relevantly

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how to prepare Sociology

Dear Candidate, given the **Limited Time** that you have and the **Infinite Syllabus** that you have to prepare for the Civil Services Examination, it becomes very important to manage your time wisely and utilize your energy efficiently. It becomes all the more important in light of the fierce competition that you face ahead. Here, I recall a line from the book *You Can Win* by Shiv Khera, that,

"Winners don't do different things, they do things differently".

Now, I would like to brief you about how our approach is different from the rest, and also the best, for preparing Sociology optional for the Civil Services Examination.

Firstly and foremostly, you must understand that no matter how many sleepless nights you may spend preparing for this examination, ultimately, it is only those 3 hours (at the examination hall during the Mains (Written) Examination) that are going to decide your fate. So it is very important for the candidates to prepare their subject strictly in an **Exam Oriented** manner. What is important here is not how much you have studied for the exam but how much you would be able to write at the time of the exam? So, what is important here is not to master the subject in all its possible details but rather, one should prepare the subject strictly in a professional manner keeping in mind the demands for 'conceptual clarity', 'analytical reasoning' and 'correct writing expression' as set forth by Union Public Service Commission. Only then one can hope to cover the syllabus for this exam in a time-bound manner with better chances of success. This you would realize step-by-step as you move along these notes and with vital inputs from my side at regular intervals.

Secondly, one must follow a **Theme-Based Approach** instead of Topic-Based Approach, whereby one should identify the major theme that underlies a given topic and runs through several other related sub-topics. Particularly, in light of the revised syllabus and the changing orientation of the Civil Services Examination, it has become all the more important to adopt theme-based approach because many a times questions are also asked on topics which are not mentioned in the syllabus. Though at the outset such questions may appear to be out of syllabus to the candidate but actually they are not. Questions on such topics are basically of implied nature and thus very much a part of the major theme that underlie the mentioned topic. So by following a theme-based approach we can

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cover not only the topics that are mentioned in the syllabus but also those which are implied in nature.

Thus, following a theme-based approach you would not only realize the depth of understanding that is expected from candidates at this examination but also it would keep you focused throughout your preparation. Please note that the theme-based approach would help you develop **Mental Framework** of the entire syllabus. Further, once you are confident that you have understood the broader dimensions of the theme then it would also resist your temptation to collect more and more material on the same topic. Thus, saving you both time as well as energy. You will learn this art as we proceed with the syllabus.

So, when I say **Read Relevantly**, I simply imply that given the limitations of time and energy, one should focus only on the important themes that underlie a given topic. Otherwise, given the vastness of the syllabus it would be impossible to do justice with all the topics mentioned in the syllabus in a time span of 3-4 months. Students must understand that just any information on the topic mentioned in the syllabus may not be equally important from the examination point of view. Hence we have to exercise selectivity.

To **Think Logically** implies that you must correlate your arguments in a logical manner. This will happen only if you have a thorough grasp of the concepts. So, **Conceptual Understanding** and **Conceptual Interlinking** both are very important. But equally important is its practical application in the contemporary scenario. So, whatever concepts or theories you study in the syllabus, you must also try to relate them with the contemporary society and changes therein. Please remember that conceptual clarity and its practical application is equally important at the Interview stage as well, as you may be asked to define or explain any sociological concept and to contextualize it in the light of contemporary developments, both in national and international arena.

Write Relevantly is the most critical stage of all. As I mentioned in the beginning that no matter how much you might have studied and what all sources you might have referred, ultimately it is your answer sheet that determines your destiny. Thus, your written answer must be a perfect blend of *conceptual clarity*, *conceptual interlinking* and *sociological language*. More importantly, such an answer needs to be produced on paper within the Time-and-Word Limit.

Dear Candidate, ultimately, you get only those 3 hours to convince the examiner that how dedicated you are about Civil Services and what importance does it carry in your life. So, with our **Dialectical Approach** (see page. 48) to answer writing we will make sure that all your efforts and sacrifices made

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during the course of preparation for this exam find a reflection in our answers. So along with working hard **(Hard Work)**, we also need to work smartly **(Smart Work)**. As you would proceed with the chapters you would be guided about note-making and answer-writing. Please follow the instructions sincerely.

Thank You

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Dear Candidate, after years of experience gained while preparing for this exam as well as in academics, I can say with firm conviction that this exam requires only **one and a half year** of dedicated and focused preparation. Generally those who take more time than this are the ones who either do not have the right guidance or realize the significance of these crucial aspects when it is already too late. In my view, an intensive but focused study of 3-4 months is more than sufficient to prepare Sociology optional for the civil services exam. I would also like to say that with regular answer-writing practice, a sincere candidate can easily score 250-300 marks, particularly in the new format of the Sociology Paper. I am sure that with these notes and with this approach you will start your preparations with an edge over other candidates. How far and how well you carry this advantage would largely depend upon the consistency and sincerity of your effort. Hence I request you to go through these notes step by step and follow the instructions sincerely.

all the best

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a word of caution

Dear Candidate, you just need to sincerely follow the topic-specific instructions that would be provided during the course. You will never find yourself alone while preparing this subject because I will always be there beside you with some useful tips and vital inputs. If at any stage you need some clarification, you can freely contact me on phone, email, or Facebook.

Now, you need to give at least three readings to the entire syllabus. But, these readings need to be done in a proper and professional manner. Remember, your aim is to qualify Civil Services Examination, not to master the subject. If you keep this thing in mind, I assure you that you will never waste even a single minute on unnecessary pursuits for collecting unnecessary and irrelevant material available in the market. In order to qualify this examination, all you need to do is that you must focus upon understanding the principle arguments related to the mentioned topic in the syllabus and develop you own understanding out of it. This is what I had already mentioned that conceptual clarity combined with its practical application in our daily life is the key to your success in Civil Services Examination.

As far as these three readings are concerned, I want to you to follow a very simple approach. In your first reading, just read these notes as a story. In your second reading, please underline, mark or highlight the important points and attempt the **Notes-Making Assignment** and **Writing-Skill Assignment** with a pencil. It is only in your third reading that you will refer to the suggested readings (that too only selectively), that I have mentioned wherever necessary and attempt the test given at the end of each topic in **Test Yourself** section. Please make sure that you get each and every test evaluated so that I can suggest you the corrective course of action before it is too late.

Just do this and see the difference in your preparation. You will not only be able to complete the entire syllabus in the shortest possible time but that too with conceptual clarity and good writing skills.

Wish you all the best

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Oath

- I believe that **Life** is the most beautiful gift bestowed upon us by **Mother Nature**. Mother Nature has blessed us all with Life so that we live happily and spread happiness all around. Mother Nature has empowered us all with its supreme divine power to realize our dreams. It is entirely up to us how we take care of our lives and what we make of it. We must respect Life and Mother Nature.

- I believe that there is no substitute for **Hard Work** and there is no shortcut to success. Those who tend to opt for shortcuts, their march to success is often cut short.

- I will place highest value on time and will try my best for its optimum utilization. I believe that **Time Management** is the key to success.

- I will set **Realistic Goals** and will make my best effort to achieve them.

- I believe that no success is final and no failure is fatal. It is the **Courage** to continue that counts.

- I will never, never, never, **Never Give Up**.

- I will adhere to the **Six Ethics of Life:**

Before you Pray	-	Believe
Before you Speak	-	Listen
Before you Spend	-	Earn
Before you Write	-	Think
Before you Quit	-	Try
Before you Die	-	Live

- I will be **Honest** and **Truthful** in my daily life.

- I will abide by the **Discipline**, code of conduct, terms and conditions of my institute.

(signature)

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Dear Candidate, I am also enclosing two sheets, one for your **Monthly Schedule** and another for your **Weekly Schedule** to facilitate better Time Management. You can get these sheets printed and photocopied and with regular practice you can yourself evaluate your performance.

Rule: While recording the numbers of hours in your Weekly Schedule, make sure that you deduct half an hour from each of your sitting. For example, if in one sitting you have studied for 2 hours, then, record only one and a half hours in the Weekly Schedule. If in the next sitting, you have studied for 3 hours, then, record two and a half hours only.

Dear Candidate, by following this method, you can tentatively arrive at the amount of qualitative time you are devoting to your preparations for the Civil Services Examination. By following this method, if any sincere candidate is devoting 8-10 hours per day on a regular basis, he is doing justice with his time, labour and above all, his aim.

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1. Sociology – The Discipline

Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology

Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences

Sociology and common sense

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Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology

Instructions: Dear Candidate, in this topic the examiner is primarily interested in testing your overall understanding about the process of transformation that took place in Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth century. Further, he is interested to know that why this process of transformation, which included large-scale social, economic and political changes, is associated with the idea of modernity or why this transformation came to be identified as modernization. Last, but not the least, he wants to know that how the prevailing social conditions of those times created the need for a new discipline and how the intellectual conditions of those times contributed to the emergence of Sociology as a distinct discipline.

Theme: *Process of modernization in Europe (in the eighteenth and nineteenth century) and its impact on the emergence of sociology.*

Related Concepts: Feudalism, Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Industrial Revolution, Enlightenment, French Revolution and Modernity.

Important: Dear Candidate, I have discussed this topic in detail here only to facilitate your thorough understanding and command over related concepts. But while writing an answer in the examination it would not be possible for you to incorporate each and every detail mentioned here. Hence, I suggest you to exercise selectivity in picking up only the relevant content as per the demand of the question. Given the Time and Word Limit in the examination, you will be able to write a concise and precise answer only if you remain focused on the theme.

My advice to you here is to understand and focus on the theme rather than the topic. I believe that given the changing pattern and focus of the Civil Services Examination, the topic-based approach is an outdated one because it leaves the candidate with a fragmented knowledge. While, on the other hand, a theme-based approach would help the candidate to interlink the concepts more easily. Thus, it would not only give the candidate a comprehensive understanding of the subject but also help him perform well both at the written as well as the interview stage of the examination.

To facilitate your better understanding and to enable you to interlink the concepts, these notes have been written in a continuing series of interlinked concepts and theories.

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Modernity has often been viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition. If tradition looked to the past, modernity presumably turned its eye to the future. Modern culture is frequently associated, as Swedish social theorist **Goran Therborn** (1995) notes, "with words like progress, advance, development, emancipation, liberation, growth, accumulation and enlightenment". One might add to this the idea that modernism is often depicted as an expansive, and thus global, phenomenon. The association with these terms suggests that modern culture possesses an optimistic orientation about our ability to collectively resolve problems, to remedy human suffering, and to enrich social life. It presupposes our ability to acquire knowledge of both the natural and the social worlds and to use this knowledge to beneficially control and mold these worlds. As **Wagner** (2008) sees it, "modernity is associated with the open horizon of the future, with unending progress towards a better human condition brought about by a radically novel and unique institutional arrangement". Historians as well as social theorists generally agree that from the fourteenth century to the sixteenth century A.D., Europe had been witnessing changes in its political, social and economic structures, which marked the beginning of what we call the modern period.

Before proceeding further with our discussion on modernity, we must understand that if modernity is viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition, then what was tradition like? In other words, what were the features of society of medieval Europe? [Note: Medieval period, also sometimes called as Middle Ages, roughly refers to the period from A.D. 600 to about A.D. 1500]

Society of medieval Europe (before fourteenth century) was largely feudal in character. Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Western Europe from tenth to fifteenth century. It had emerged on account of downfall and decentralization of Roman Empire and absence of any central authority. The word 'feudal' comes from *feud* which originally meant a *fief* or land held on condition or service. In a feudal society, land was the source of the power. Thus, feudal system was based on allocation of land in return for service.

Feudalism was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. The fiefs may further be subdivided by a vassal among other knights who would then be his vassals. Such fiefs consisted of one or more *manors*, that is, *estates* with serfs whose agricultural production provided the economic basis for the existence of the feudal class. When receiving a fief a vassal took an oath of homage and fealty (fidelity) to his lord and owed him loyalty as well as a specified amount of military service. Upon the death of a vassal the fief would technically revert to the overlord, but it was a common practice for

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the eldest son to take his father's place as vassal of the lord, and thus, in effect, fiefs were passed on through primogeniture.

Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. The feudal estates of medieval Europe had three important characteristics. Firstly, estates were legally defined. In other words, each estate had a status, in the precise sense of a legal complex of rights and duties, of privileges and obligations. The differences between estates can also be seen in the different penalties imposed for similar offences. Secondly, the estates represented a broad division of labour, and were regarded in the contemporary literature as having definite functions. 'The nobility were ordained to defend all, the clergy to pray for all, and the commons to provide food for all.' Thirdly, the feudal estates also acted as political groups.

Thus, the feudal society in Europe was a hierarchical and graded organization in which every person was allotted a position. At the top stood the king. He bestowed fiefs or estates on a number of lords who were known as dukes and earls. These lords in turn distributed a part of their fiefs among a number of lesser lords who were called barons and, in return, secured their military support. Thus the dukes and earls were the king's vassals, that is to say, they owed allegiance directly to the king. The barons were the vassals of the dukes and earls. The knights formed the lowest category of feudal lords. Usually they were the vassals of barons for whom they performed military service. Knights did not have any vassals of their own. Every feudal lord was expected to pay homage to his overlord and could then be in vested with some formal rights. Every feudal lord, except the knight, was first a vassal and then an overlord with a number of vassals under him. The relationship from top to bottom was one of allegiance. No vassal owned any land; he only held the land as of his overlord. The vassal was in every way his lord's man. He recognized no other authority than of his overlord. In time of need, for example, when the kind fought a war, he could demand military assistance from his vassals, these vassals - the dukes and the earls - demanded the same assistance from their vassals, the barons, and the barons from their vassals, the knights. Every feudal lord contributed a detachment of warriors, and thus a fighting army would be formed.

Feudal life, as explained in the previous section, was based on agriculture. The village farm was the *manor*, the size of which varied from place to place. Its centre was the manor house of the lord where he lived or which he visited, for the lords often possessed several manors. The manor included a large farm which supported all those who worked on it, a pasture area where the manor cattle grazed,

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and common woods which supplied fuel and timber. A manor always had a number of cottages where the common people lived, some workshops to provide for manor needs, and a chapel. *Manorialism* was an essential element of feudal society. It was a system of land tenure and the organizing principle of rural economy. It was characterized by the vesting of legal and economic power in a lord, supported economically from his own direct landholding and from the obligatory contributions of a legally subject part of the peasant population under his jurisdiction. These obligations could be payable in several ways, in labour, in kind or in coin, etc. *Manor* was the lowest unit of territorial organization in the feudal system in Europe. It may also be referred as the land tenure unit under manorialism. Country people often lived on a manor. On a manor there was a village, church, lord's house or castle, and the farmland upon which the people worked.

Please note that the Roman Catholic Church was as powerful an institution as feudalism in western Europe during medieval times. At the head of the Church was the Pope, who was accepted as the vicar of Christ. Popes were often stronger than the kings and could force them to obey their orders. Christianity taught that man's life on earth was not the end of existence, and that he should give up pleasures in this life in order to have a life of the spirit after death. Many Christian monks - St. Francis, St. Benedict, St. Augustine - laid great stress on purity, resistance to temptation and the pursuit of 'goodness'. Some people withdrew from worldly life and led a life of virtue and penance. Some men became monks and took the vows of obedience, poverty and chastity. Some women became nuns and lived in nunneries. The institutions where the monks lived together were called monasteries. This may remind you of the Budddhist *bhikshus* and their *viharas*. Life in monastery was well organized. Monks and nuns had to observe rigid rules of discipline. They could not marry or own property. They either worked or prayed. The slightest disobedience brought hard punishment. Some monasteries, like those funded by St. Benedict, were centres of learning and assured the members a well-ordered life. Through their strict rules of discipline, they trained groups who by their example and preaching, sought to uplift the moral life of the people, educate the laity and tend the sick. Gradually, however corruption crept into the monasteries. They acquired land and amassed wealth, helping to make the Church one of the biggest land-owners in medieval times. With cultivation and other work done by serfs, the life of many monks and nuns was no longer frugal and austere. Luxury, good food and drink, and idleness became common. Some great leaders sought to reform this state of affairs by introducing a new religious order - that of wandering monks. Members of this order had no homes but moved among the people, living on charity and setting an example of a life of chastity and self-sacrifice.

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During the early Middle Ages, Churches were the only centres of education and learning. The kinds of schools to which parents sent their children, when the Greek and Roman civilizations were still flourishing, had disappeared. The education that churches could provide was like a drop in the ocean. For a long time, monks and priests were the only literate men in Europe. Learning was kept alive by the Church and the monks in the monasteries. However, the learning fostered by the Church was a narrow type. Subjects that it taught were grammar, logic, arithmetic and theology. The only calling for which this education was suitable was that of a monk or a priest. The language of learning was Latin, which only churchmen could read. Everything was dominated by faith and anybody who appealed to reason against dogma was punished. Science had come to standstill. Magic and superstition held the day. Belief in witches was common and the punishment for witches was to burn them alive.

However, by the end of the Middle Ages (fourteenth century onwards), some changes started taking place in European societies which marked the decline of feudal system.

The revival of trade (discussed later under 'commercial revolution') was accompanied by the growth of towns. Old towns became larger and many new towns emerged, mainly as centres of manufacture and trade. Towns, often walled, gradually freed themselves from feudal control. They had their own governments and the townsmen elected their officials. They had their own militia and their own courts. Unlike the serfs, there were no restrictions on their movements. They could come and go as they pleased and buy and sell property. Towns provided asylum to serfs who escaped from feudal oppression. The towns encouraged the cultivation of cash crops needed for manufactures, and peasants received their payments in money. The peasants could now pay their dues to the lord in cash rather than by labour.

With the growth of trade, there was increasing use of money. Money had little use in feudal societies. A feudal manor was more or less self-sufficient for its needs. There was very little of buying and selling and whatever there was, was done through barter. The use of money indicated far-reaching changes in economy. In feudal societies, the indictor of a man's wealth was land. Some people had wealth, particularly the Church and sometimes the nobles, in the form of gold and silver, but it was idle wealth. It could not be used to make more wealth. With the growth of trade and manufactures, this changed, marking the beginning of the transition from feudal economy to capitalist economy in which wealth is used to make a profit. This is done by investing money in business, in trade and industry. The profits made are re-invested to make further profits. Such wealth or money is called 'capital'. Money, not the landed property, increasingly became the measure

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of man's wealth. In feudal societies, there were three classes of people: the prayers, that is, the clergy who prayed, the soldiers or the knights who fought, and workers or the peasants who worked for both the prayers and the soldiers. With the growth of trade a new class emerged - the 'middle class' - comprising mainly the merchants. Even though small in number, they began to play an important role in society because of the wealth they possessed. This early phase of capitalism is known as 'mercantile capitalism'. Thus mercantile capitalism is a system of trading for profit, typically in commodities produced by non-capitalist production methods.

Simultaneous with these developments changes took place in the system of manufacturing goods. In the early medieval period, most of the non-agricultural products required by the peasants were produced in the household of the peasant and by serfs, who were skilled craftsmen, for the lord. With the growth of towns, many of these activities shifted to towns where people skilled in particular crafts organized themselves into 'guilds'. Each craft guild had master craftsmen, journeyman and apprentices. To learn a craft, a person joined a master as an apprentice or learner. After having learned the craft, he worked as a journeyman with the master on a wage or, if he had mastered the craft, he would himself become a master craftsman. The units of production were small, consisting of three or four people, and each unit had a shop to sell its produce. There were no inequalities within a unit or between units of the same guild. The guild system, was not suited to the requirements of large scale production required by an expanding market for goods, and the system began to decline. Inequities appeared with the system, with masters refusing to let journeymen become masters and paying them low wages. With the introduction of 'the putting out system', their independence declined. The merchant, under this system, would bring the master craftsmen the raw materials, the craftsmen would work with their tools as before in their homes and the produce would be taken away by the merchant who had supplied them with raw materials. Thus, in effect, unlike before, the craftsmen did not own what they produced. They were increasingly reduced to the position of wage-earners, except that they still owned the tools used by them and worked at home.

Subsequently, this system gave way to the factory system (discussed later under 'industrial revolution') under which the production was carried out in a building owned by the capitalist with the help of machines also owned by him. The workers, owing nothing, worked only for wages. In industries, such as mining and metal-working, the new system came into being early. The period saw tremendous expansion of manufactures. This was accompanied by a growing differentiation in towns and the emergence of working class.

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As a result of these developments, the feudal system broke down. The towns which were free from the control of the lords began to undermine the stability of the feudal society. In course of time, towns became very prosperous. Kings who were quite powerless in the feudal system began to take the help and support of townsmen to increase their power and to enforce their will over the lords. The kings also started having their own armies and thus freed themselves from their earlier dependence on the lords for soldiers. This led to the emergence of strong nation-states. Thus, feudalism began to decline although it was finally ended in most countries only in the 18th and 19th centuries. In its place, a new system of society (Capitalist Society) began to emerge.

However, feudalism served its purpose of bringing a measure of orderliness, safety and security to medieval life. It allowed social and economic activity to run its normal course. But feudalism had also another side to it. It developed, and was dependent on, a rigid class system. Man was divided from man, class from class, and this stood in the way of political unity. The nobles looked down upon the common man, and their inherited authority brought with it one-man rule and oppression. The lords were often too powerful for the kings to control and fought among themselves for small selfish ends. The king had no contact with the common man, who was left entirely to the mercy of his lord, and the lord was usually irresponsible and unmindful of the welfare of common people. The feudal system also led to economic stagnation. The wealth produced by the peasants and the artisans was wastefully consumed by the feudal lords, in luxurious living and in wars. Individual enterprise and initiative were all but unknown. Further, the desire for the new lands and riches encouraged the lords and leaders of the Church to fight the 'holy wars', or the Crusades.

The medieval period, lasting roughly from fifth through the thirteenth centuries A.D. have often been called the "Dark Ages" and to some extent it was truly so. The helplessness of the common man, the arbitrary rule of the king and the barons and the absence of national unity were some of the aspects of the darker side of those times. Education was very uncommon and people led a miserable life. The prevailing European view of the "Dark Ages" was that civilization had stagnated. Not only were scientific and artistic advances rare, but much of the knowledge of the classical period was lost. Cultural activities came to an end with the arrival of invading "barbarians", and the western Roman Empire disintegrated into thousands of isolated villages where there was little interest in, or time for, study. Memory of the classical period faded except in a few sequestered monasteries, where ancient texts were stored and in the Islamic world, where scholars translated Greek texts into Arabic. During the "Dark Ages" the overwhelming majority of Europeans were crude illiterates, and even educated

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people knew less about science, medicine, and art than their counterparts in the classical period.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Please note that in the notes-making assignment you have to identify only those points which constitute the central theme of the given topic. To gain an edge over other candidates, you need to continuously enrich your notes with vital but relevant inputs. For this you may also include here some recent data, case studies or examples. For this you may refer newspapers (*The Hindu*, *The Times of India*, *The Indian Express*), magazines (*Yojana*, *Kurushetra*, *Frontline*, *The Economic and Political Weekly*, *Mainstream*) and government publications (*India Year Book*, *The Economic Survey*, *The Census of India*) etc.

Please take this exercise seriously because you would need to refer these self-made notes only just a couple of days before exam. So, be as brief and precise as possible. The first exercise is done for you to help you understand the approach as well as the methodology better.

Identify five important features of feudal society (only in the form of Pointers).

- Dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe
- Based upon a system of land tenure (King → Dukes and Earls→ Barons → Knights → Peasants)
- Characterized by estate system of stratification (Clergy, Nobility and Commoners)
- Largely subsistent economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority
- Started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres (Commercial Revolution)

2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Now, once you have made your notes on the given topic in the pointers form, it is time to practice writing short notes so as to sharpen your answer-writing skills. Dear Candidate, I repeat that no matter for how many hours or years you may have studied but ultimately it is only those 3 hours in the examination hall that would decide your fate. Hence I always suggest my students to continuously monitor their

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progress in writing-skills by regularly writing answers and getting it evaluated by me.

The first exercise is done for you.

Write a short note on feudalism. (100-120 words)

Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe. It was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies whereby one section or estate was distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. Feudal society was largely subsistent and stagnant economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority. However, feudal social order started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres in western European societies. (Total Words: 126)

3. For Interview

Questions may be asked on the following to test your conceptual clarity and grasp of the subject.

Feudalism * Estate system of stratification * Manorialism * Factors responsible for the decline of feudalism * Karl Marx on feudalism

However, fourteenth century onwards the society in Europe started changing. A number of interrelated developments took place in the period from about fourteenth to seventeenth century which marked the beginning of modern age.

Anthony Giddens also states in *The Consequences of Modernity* (1990) that modernity refers to 'modes of social life or organization which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards and which subsequently became more or less worldwide in their influence'. According to Giddens, modernity represents a sharp qualitative break from previous traditional social orders.

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Let us first understand that what were these changes which took place from about fourteenth to seventeenth century in Europe and marked the beginning of modern age? How the new social order which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards was qualitatively different from the previous traditional social orders.

Historians generally agree that from fourteenth to sixteenth centuries, Europe had been witnessing changes in its social, economic and political structures, which marked the beginning of the modern period. In the next section, we will learn about the various social, economic and political changes that Europe witnessed in the form of Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Enlightenment, Industrial Revolution, French Revolution, etc.

One of the first developments that marked the beginning of a new era was the **Renaissance**. The medieval Dark Age was followed by the Renaissance, coming in the fourteenth century and lasting to the end of the sixteenth century. The Renaissance refers, in a literal sense, to the intellectual rebirth of Europe as people tried to recapture the artistic, philosophical, scientific, and commercial glory of the 'classical period'. It is important to emphasize that the conventional nineteenth-century assessment was that the Renaissance had been a period of rediscovery. There was a great appreciation for the cultural accomplishments of the Greeks and Romans and a genuine desire to replicate those accomplishments and, hence, to recapture the cultural glory of earlier times. [Please note that the "Classical Period" of Western history, the era of Greece and, later, Rome, lasted roughly from the eighth century B.C. until the fourth century A.D. Many note-worthy scientific and artistic advances were made during that period. To name just a few: geometry was developed; money came into circulation; trade expanded; accounting practices emerged; shipbuilding improved; the Phoenician alphabet was made more precise with the inclusion of vowels; literature was born; comedies and tragedies were written; amphitheaters were constructed; great philosophical debates raged; engineers achieved wondrous feats (literally, the "wonders of the ancient world"); monuments were built; medicine advanced; libraries were constructed; elements of democratic governmental forms came into being; and education expanded. In short, civilization flowered. Advances were intermittent, to be sure, but over time the total stock of knowledge increased and diffused widely to other parts of the world. At least it was the nineteenth-century European view that the classical period of the Greeks and Romans marked such a flowering of civilization.]

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The term 'Renaissance' literally means rebirth and is, in a narrow sense, used to describe the revival of interest in the learning of the classical civilizations of Greece and Rome. This revival first began in Italy when a number of scholars from Constantinople migrated to Italy and a number of Italian scholars went to Constantinople and other cities of the old Byzantine empire in search of Greek classics. The Renaissance emerged in Italy roughly between A.D. 1300 and A.D. 1550 and then spread to northern Europe during the first half of the 16th century. The renaissance started in Italy because of several factors. First, Italy always had a cultural advantage over the rest of Europe because its geography made it the natural gateway between the East and the West. Venice, Genoa, Milan, Pisa and Florence traded uninterruptedly with the Asian countries and maintained a vibrant urban society. The Italian cities had grown up in an atmosphere of freedom from feudal control. Freedom encouraged thinking and a spirit of adventure. The rulers of the Italian states were patrons of learning and the arts.

During the 13th and the 14th centuries, mercantile cities expanded to become powerful city states dominating the political and economic life of the surrounding countryside. Italian aristocrats customarily lived in urban centres rather than in rural castles unlike their counterparts in northern Europe and consequently became fully involved in urban public affairs. The neo-rich mercantile communities which came to be known as the *bourgeoisie* tried to gain the status of aristocracy. Merchant families tried to imitate an aristocratic life-style. Their wealth and profession became an important factor for the development of education in Italy. There was not only a demand for education for the development of skills in reading and accountancy, necessary to become successful merchants, but also the richest and most prominent families looked for able teachers who would impart to their offspring the knowledge and skills necessary to argue well in the public arena. Consequently Italy produced a large number of educators, many of whom not only taught students but also demonstrated their learning in the production of political and ethical treaties and works of literature.

Another reason, why the late medieval Italy became the birthplace of an intellectual and artistic renaissance, was because it had a far greater sense of rapport with the classical past than any other region of Europe. In Italy the classical past appeared immensely relevant as ancient Roman monuments were present all over the peninsula and the ancient Latin literature referred to cities and sites that Italians recognized as their own. Further, Italian renaissance was also facilitated by the patronage that it received in abundance. The wealthy cities of Italy vied with each other to construct splendid public monuments and support writers whose role was to glorify the urban republic in their writing and speeches. As a result, hundreds of classical writings, unknown to Europeans for centuries, were circulating first in Italy and then other parts of Europe. The interest in classical

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learning and in other achievements of the civilizations of Greece and Rome deeply influenced Europeans. The Renaissance, however, was not, as mentioned earlier, a mere revival of ancient learning and knowledge of the achievements of ancient Greece and Rome. It was marked by a series of new developments in the field of art, literature, religion, philosophy, science and politics.

The early phase of Renaissance was described as a period of revival as it concentrated in reviving the old learning which was disseminated through the traditional methods. The latter phase was described as a period of innovation as much new knowledge was generated during this period, which laid the foundation for the growth of modern thought. This new knowledge was spread by a new medium, i.e print. This meant that a large number of people and countries could share the knowledge and debate the changes. Though, the study of classical and Christian antiquity existed before the renaissance, there was a significant difference between the learning of the middle age scholars and the renaissance thinkers. The renaissance thinkers recovered the works of lesser-known scholars and made them popular along side the more famous ones. The Greek scientific and the philosophical treatises were made available to the westerners in Latin translations. The renaissance thinkers used classical texts in new ways such as to reconsider their preconceived notions and alter their mode of expression.

So, rational thinking tempered with a spirit of scientific enquiry about the universe and the existence of humanity in it, became the important characteristic of the renaissance outlook. These rational ideas also helped in developing a society that was increasingly non-ecclesiastical in comparison to the culture of the Middle ages. The intellectual and cultural life of Europe for centuries had been dominated by the Catholic Church. The renaissance undermined this domination. The revival of pre-Christian classical learning and of interest in the cultural achievements of ancient Greece and Rome were, in themselves, also an important factor in undermining the domination of the Church.

The chief characteristic of the Renaissance way of thinking was *humanism*. It was the heart and soul of the Renaissance. Basically, it meant a decisive shift in concern for human as distinct from divine matters. Humanism was a system of views which extolled man, stressed his essential worth and dignity, expressed deep faith in his tremendous creative potential, and proclaimed freedom of the individual and inalienable rights of the individual. It was centered on the man of flesh and blood with all his earthly joys and sorrows, opposed to religious asceticism and defended his right to pleasure and the satisfaction of earthly desires and requirements. It meant the glorification of the human and natural as opposed to the divine and other-worldly. The humanists rejected and even ridiculed religious asceticism, mortification of the flesh and withdrawal from the world. They urged

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man to seek joy on this earth rather than in an afterlife which the Church advocated. Their works were permeated with the faith that a man with an active mind and body was capable of knowing and controlling the world, of performing miracles and fashioning his own happiness. The proper study of Mankind, it was asserted, is Man, Humanity rather than Divinity. The Renaissance men, hungered after more knowledge. They came to feel that human life is important, that man is worthy of study and respect, that there should be efforts to improve life on this earth. Because of this interest in human affairs, the study of literature and history became major areas of study. Literature and history came to be called the 'humanities' which were primarily concerned with understanding the affairs of man in his earthly life, not with life after death.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main characteristics of Renaissance. (only Pointers)

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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

'Renaissance marked a qualitative shift in the history of western European society'. Discuss. (150 words)

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3. For Interview

Renaissance	*	Factors responsible for its origin in Italy

Another development which marked the beginning of the modern age was the 'commercial revolution', fostered by a series of 'voyages of discovery'. The "Commercial revolution" refers to the expansion of trade and commerce that took place from the 15th century onwards. It was of such a large scale and organized manner that it is called a Revolution. The Commercial revolution signaled a shift from the largely subsistence and stagnant economy of medieval Europe to a more dynamic and world wide system. This expansion was as a result of the initiative taken by certain European countries to develop and consolidate their economic and political power. These countries were Portugal, Spain, Holland and England.

The same spirit of curiosity that led some of Europe's Renaissance men to effect new developments in art, literature, science, and religion led others to adventure and the discovery of new lands. The main motivation behind these adventures was the profits that trade with the East would bring. Earlier, Europe trade with the Oriental or Eastern countries like India and China was transacted by land routes. The northern Italian cities of Venice and Genoa were the major centres of trade. The result of the Italian monopoly was that the prices of goods like spices and silks imported form the East was extremely high. For example, after his first voyage to India, Vasco Da Gama found that the price of pepper in Calicut was one-

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twenty sixth of the price prevailing in Venice. The prosperity of the Italian cities that had grown rich from their trade with eastern countries aroused the envy of the other European nations; they longed to have a share in the trade.

But after 1453, the Turks cut off this trade through Asia Minor and if the Europeans were to continue to have spices, these products had to be brought by a different route. Finding new routes was a challenge to the adventurous sailors of the Renaissance. Thus, a shift from land routes to sea-routes began. Helped by some remarkable inventions, daring sailors sailed for distant lands. Invention of mariner's compass, astrolabe and newly prepared maps and guidebooks greatly facilitated these voyages. With the help of the compass, navigators determined the directions on high seas. The Astrolabe helped in determining the latitude of a particular area. These voyages were financed by rulers and merchants who sponsored the costly voyages of the sea-farers for the profits that the voyages would bring. The discoveries of the sea-farers extended the knowledge about the world and the old maps which were both inaccurate and incomplete had to be redrawn.

The voyages and discoveries of **Columbus**, **Vasco da Gama** and **Magellan** changed man's idea of the world, revolutionized trade and started waves of colonization that have determined the course of world history ever since. Portugal and Spain were among the first Europe countries, which financed these explorations and discoveries. Britain, France and Holland soon followed Spain and Portugal. Soon parts of Asia, Africa, Malacca, the Spice Islands, West Indies, N. America and S. America came under the control of Spain, Portugal, Britain, France and Holland. Commerce expanded into a world enterprise. The monopoly of the Italian cities was destroyed. European markets were flooded with new commodities; spice & textiles from the East, tobacco from N. America, Cocoa, Chocolate & quinine from S. America, ivory and, above all, human slaves from Africa. With the discovery of Americas, the range of trade widened. Formerly, the items sought for were spices and cloth, but later, gold and silver were added to the list. As the commercial revolution progressed, the position of Portugal and Spain declined. Britain, France and Holland came to dominate Europe and the world. This marked the early phase of capitalism known as 'mercantile capitalism'. It was characterized by growth of trade and commerce and generating profits through trade.

Subsequently, this accumulated wealth or capital was further reinvested in land & agriculture (scientific farming and sheep-rearing) to generate further profits. This led to the transformation of agriculture in Europe, called as 'agricultural revolution'. The agrarian revolution saw the transformation of a system of subsistence into a system of surplus by production of cash crops for the

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market, the surplus being made possible by reformed and mechanized cultivation. So, mercantile capitalism was followed by the capitalistic transformation of agriculture or agrarian capitalism. The first sign of capitalistic transformation of agriculture manifested itself in England in the form of land enclosures which began to occur in the rural economy as early as 1560, when landholders began to assert rights of private property over feudal land. It has been called by the historians as Enclosure Movement. Essentially, the enclosure movement can be described as a system whereby tenant holdings in feudal land and agriculture became enclosed and made available for the private use of landholder. As, a result peasant families were evicted from their holdings and in many cases thrown off the land. While many of the first enclosures were initiated by landlords in order to appropriate tenant holdings, in latter stages of change they were used to make way for sheep pastures. However, by 1710 the first Enclosure Bill appeared which legalized the enclosure of tenant holdings by Parliamentary Acts. With parliamentary approval, enclosures could proceed at a more advanced rate and eventually became commonplace by mid century as conversions became more rapid. By 1800, 4000 Parliamentary Acts had been passed and in excess of six million acres of land had been enclosed.

As the pace of economic change began to intensify, the rate of enclosures accelerated to the point where the displaced population of agricultural workers began to increase dramatically and this began to mobilize a transfer of the population to the centers of industry. As statutory enactments gave the power of eviction to landlords, legal proceedings multiplied the rate of local evictions and at the same time restricted the use of pastures from domestic animals, prohibited the use of arable land from tenant agriculture, and displaced agricultural workers and hereditary tenants. In practice, enclosures became a society-wide depopulation movement fueled by mass evictions and foreclosures which coercively separated peasants from their means of livelihood by removing them from their own agricultural holdings. As serfs were forced off the land, landlords were able to assert rights of modern private property over land to which they previously held only feudal title. This hastened the transformation of land into a commercial commodity, first by subjecting it to buying and selling, and second by extending its capacity to produce money rent. Under these circumstances, customary rights and obligations in land began to be forcibly dissolved, and with this went the bonds connecting peasants to the land through heredity tenure and leasehold. As soon as money rents replaced labour rent, peasants were forced to focus their attention on their own holdings, making money rent a precondition to economic survival. Those who were unable to pay were eventually ruined or evicted. At this point it became possible to express the value of land in money, and this led to the transformation of land into private property and eventually a commercial commodity. As land became subject to buying and selling, the economic balance between serfs and

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landlords was upset and feudal obligations in land and livelihood began to deteriorate.

As the breakdown of feudal obligations in land continued, it began to place the serf population under new forces of social differentiation and fragmentation. This put the serf population at the disposal of the new forces of production, which put into play a massive demographic transfer of the agricultural population into the industrial centers, bringing about a more complete transition to a new category of labour based on wages. At this stage, the flow of population from the old feudal economies to the new economies of industry became a more urgent fact of economic change, and this began to complete the process of transforming the agricultural worker of previous centuries into the wage labourer of the industrial economy. By 1840 the transition to an industrial economy was more or less complete. Several consequences ensued as a result of the displacement of the serf population from the rural economies. Firstly, as the transfer of the population proceeded, it brought about a massive social displacement which dispersed families, uprooted local economies and undermined regional modes of life and livelihood. Secondly, it dissolved the serf's relationship to the land and altered the system of economic livelihood, forcing serfs to sell their labour for a wage, and severing the serf's feudal relation to the agricultural means of production. Thirdly, the shift to an industrial economy meant that wage labourers were unable to employ the means of production on their own as they once did in a feudal economy, and as a result they lost control over the ability to put the means of production to work. Further, as the shift to an industrial economy became finalized, the old class structure of feudal society was replaced by the formation of a new commercial class who were at the center of power and industry. This began to bring about the transfer of the ownership of the means of production to the commercial classes and, consequently, as the means of production fell into private hands, it became the property of one class.

During much of the eighteenth century, the last remnants of the old economic order were crumbling under the impact of the industrial revolution. In historical terminology, industrial revolution means primarily the period of British History from the middle of the eighteenth century to the middle of nineteenth century. England in the 18th century was in the most favourable position for an industrial revolution. Through her overseas trade, including trade in slaves, she had accumulated vast profits which could provide the necessary capital. In the trade rivalries of European countries, she had emerged as an unrivalled power. She had acquired colonies which ensured a regular supply of raw materials. The term 'industrial revolution' was first used in the 1880s to denote the sudden acceleration of technical developments by the application of steam power to machines which replaced tools. The term got popularized when Arnold Toynbee's

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Industrial Revolution appeared in 1884. As discussed earlier, the new system of society which had been emerging in Europe from the 15th century was called *capitalism.* Under capitalism, the instruments and the means by which goods are produced are owned by private individuals and the production is carried out for making profit. The workers under this system do not own anything but work for a wage. The owners of wealth under capitalism who are called capitalists do not keep their wealth or consume it or use it for purposes of display but invest it to make profit. Goods are produced for sale in the market with a view to making profit. This system is in marked contrast with the feudal system in which goods were produced for local use and the investment of wealth for making profit did not take place. Economic life under feudalism was static as goods were produced for local consumption and there was no incentive to produce more by employing better means of producing goods for a bigger market. In contrast, the economy under capitalism was fast moving with the aim of producing more and more goods for bigger markets so that more profits could be made.

The desire to produce more goods at low cost to make higher profits led to the Industrial Revolution and further growth of capitalism. The Industrial Revolution began in England in about 1750. It was then that machines began to take over some of the works of men and animals in the production of goods and commodities. That is why we often say that the Industrial Revolution was the beginning of a 'machine age'. You have read before that the guild system had given way to the 'domestic' or the 'putting-out' system. In the 18th century, the domestic system had become obsolete. It started giving way to a new system called the 'factory system'. In place of simple tools and the use of animal and manual power, new machines and steam power came to be increasingly used. Many new cities sprang up and artisans and dispossessed peasants went there to work. Production was now carried on in a factory (in place of workshops in homes), with the help of machines (in place of simple tools). Facilities for production were owned and managed by *capitalists,* the people with money to invest in further production. Everything required for production was provided by the capitalists for the workers who were brought together under one roof. Everything belonged to the owner of the factory, including the finished product, and workers worked for wages. This system, known as the factory system, brought on the *Industrial Revolution.* This phase of capitalism is known as industrial capitalism. Industrial capitalism is capitalism's classical or stereotypical form.

The eighteenth century saw the growth of free labour and more competitive manufacturing. The cotton industry was the first to break the hold of the guilds and chartered corporations, but with each decade, other industries were subjected to the liberating effects of free labour, free trade, and free production. By the time large-scale industry emerged – first in England, then in France, and later in

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Germany – the economic reorganization of Europe had been achieved. Large-scale industry and manufacture simply accelerated the transformations in society that had been occurring for decades. These transformations involved a profound organization of society. Labour was liberated from the land; wealth and capital existed independently of the large noble estates; large-scale industry accelerated urbanization of the population; the extension of competitive industry hastened the development of new technologies; increased production encouraged the expansion of markets and world trade for securing raw resources and selling finished goods; religious organizations lost much of their authority in the face of secular economic activities; family structure was altered as people moved from rural to urban areas; law became as concerned with regularizing the new economic processes as with preserving the privilege of the nobility; and the old political regimes legitimated by "divine right" successively became less tenable.

Thus, the emergence of a capitalist economic system inexorably destroyed the last remnant of the feudal order and the transitional mercantile order of restrictive guilds and chartered corporations. Such economic changes greatly altered the way people lived, created new social classes (such as the bourgeoisie and urban proletariat), and led not only to a revolution of ideas but also to a series of political revolutions. These changes were less traumatic in England than in France, where the full brunt of these economic forces clashed with the Old Regime. It was in this volatile mixture of economic changes, coupled with the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, that political and intellectual revolutions were to be spawned. And out of these combined revolutions, sociology emerged.

The 'Renaissance' period also saw the beginning of the 'Scientific Revolution'. It is an undeniable fact that, if we want to seek out the cause of the Scientific Revolution, we must look for them among the wider changes taking place in that sea-change of European history known as the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution cannot be explained without reference to the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution, like the Protestant Reformation, can and should be seen as one of the outcomes of the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution marked an era of description and criticism in the field of science. It was a clear break from the past, a challenge to old authority. The impact of the scientific revolution was crucial not just in changing material life, but also man's ideas about Nature and Society. It is worth noting that science does not develop independent of society, rather, it develops in response to human needs. For example, various vaccines were developed out of the necessity to cure diseases. Apart from influencing the physical or material life of society, science is intimately connected with ideas. The general intellectual atmosphere existing in society influences the development of science. Similarly, new developments in science can also change the attitudes and

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beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. The emergence of sociology in Europe owes a great deal to the ideas and discoveries contributed by science.

As stated earlier, the medieval society was characterized by the feudal system. The Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. New, daring ideas could not flower in such an atmosphere. Thus the development of science was restricted mainly to improvement in the techniques of production. However, the renaissance thinkers rejected the blind acceptance of authority. They asserted that knowledge could be gained 'by going out and studying mentally and manually the Book of Nature', and not by speculation. This new outlook marked a break with the past and prepared the way for the advancement of science. It was summed up by **Francis Bacon**, an English philosopher, who said that knowledge could be gained only by observation and experimentation. According to Bacon, he who seeks knowledge should *first look at things that happen in the world around him*. He should then ask himself *what causes these things to happen* and, after he has formed a theory or belief, as to the possible cause, he should experiment. *The experiment is to test his belief* and see whether the assumed cause does, in fact, produce the result he has observed. Bacon believed that the 'true and lawful end of the sciences is that human life be enriched by new discoveries and powers.'

One of the first achievements of the Renaissance in science was in astronomy. The year 1543 marked the development of modern astronomical studies with the publication of Copernicus' *Six Books Concerning the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres*. **Copernicus** (1473-1543) was a polish scholar who lived in Italy for many years. His work in mathematics and astronomy demolished the hypothesis of the geocentric (Earth-centred) universe derived from Ptolemy and other astronomers of the past. In its place he advanced the revolutionary new hypothesis of the heliocentric (Sun-centred) universe. This meant that the earth moved round a fixed Sun and not the other way round. The Copernican hypothesis had radical implications. It destroyed the idea of the earth's uniqueness by suggesting that it acted like other heavenly bodies. More importantly, his theory contradicted the earlier notions about the centrality of the earth to the cosmic order. The very idea of an open universe of which the earth was but a small part shattered the earlier view of a closed universe created and maintained in motion by God. This was an important break with the ancient system of thought. For over a thousands years, it was believed that the earth was the centre of the universe. It was one of the basic dogmas of the philosophers of the time. Its refutation was an attack on the conception of the universe held by the Church. This was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. Copernicus' book was published in 1543, the year in

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which he died. He had hesitated from publishing it for fear of the hostility of the Church. About half a century after the publication of Copernicus' book, in 1600, Giordano Bruno was burnt at the stake on the charge of heresy. He had advocated ideas which were based on Copernicus' view of the universe.

The next major steps toward the conception of a heliocentric system were taken by the Danish astronomer **Tycho Brahe** (1546-1601) and the German astronomer **Johannes Kepler** (1571-1630). Tycho Brahe constructed the most accurate tables of astronomical observations. After his death, these observations came into the possession of Kepler, who after much work, agreed to the heliocentric theory, though he abandoned the Copernican concept of circular orbits. The mathematical relationship that emerged from a consideration of Brahe's observations suggested that the orbits of the planets were elliptical. Kepler published his findings in 1609 in a book entitled *On the Motion of Mars*. Thus, he solved the problems of planetary orbits by using the Copernican theory and Brahe's empirical data. However, in the same year when Kepler published his book, an Italian scientist **Galileo Galilei** (1564-1642), first turned a telescope invented by him on to the sky. Through this instrument he saw stars where none had been known to exist, mountains on the moon, spots moving across the sun and the moon and the orbiting Jupiter. Some of Galileo's colleagues at the University of Padua were so unnerved that they refused to look through the telescope because it revealed the heaven to be different from the teachings of the Church and the Ptolemaic theories. Galileo published his findings in numerous works, the most famous of which is his *Dialogues on the Two Chief Systems of the World* (1632). This book brought down on him the condemnation of the Roman Catholic Church. His life was spared only after he agreed to withdraw his views. He spent the rest of his life virtually under house arrest.

Isaac Newton was born in England in 1642, the year Galileo died. He solved the major remaining problems on the planetary motions and established a base for the modern physics. Much of the researches of Newton were based on the work of Galileo and other predecessors. In 1687, he published his treatise, *The Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*. In this work he proposed that the planets and, in fact, all other particles in the universe moved through the force of mutual attraction, a law which came to be known as the Law of Gravitation. In this way, Newton combined mathematics and physics for the study of astronomy. Incidentally, he was preceded in this by **Varahamihira** and **Aryabhatta** in the 5th and 6th centuries A.D. in India.

The modern age of science that began with these Renaissance scientists not only increased man's knowledge but also established a method of study that could be applied to other branches of knowledge. Significant discoveries, for example

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were made in the study of the human body and circulation of the blood which helped to fight many superstitions. In 1543, the year in which Copernicus' book was published, **Vesalius**, a Belgian, published his profusely illustrated *De Humani Corporis Fabrica*. Based on his study of the dissections of the human body, this book provided the first complete description of the anatomy of the human body. **Servetus**, a Spaniard, published a book explaining the circulation of blood. He was condemned to death for questioning the Church belief in Trinity. A completed account of the constant process of circulation of blood, from the heart to all parts of the body and back to the heart was given by Harvey, an Englishman, in about 1610. This knowledge helped to start a new approach to the study of the problems of health and disease. It is important to remember that what the Renaissance scientists began learning by questioning, observation, and experimentation is the method that scientists continue to use even today. This is scientific method. It is by applying this method that our knowledge has grown so greatly. The knowledge produced during scientific revolution deeply influenced the attitudes and beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. This is very important. Please keep this in mind when we discuss the ideas of enlightenment scholars later.

As mentioned earlier, that in medieval Europe Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. Any idea or action which challenged the authority of the Church was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. This newly emerging scientific knowledge, which was based on empirical observation and experimentation, was not only different but also contradictory to the many teachings of the Church. This stimulated the process of 'reformation' in the religious sphere of the European society. Thus, European people with new spirit of inquiry and thought started questioning the superstitious beliefs and malpractices of the Catholic Church.

The term 'Reformation' refers to two major developments in the history of Europe towards the later part of the Renaissance. The first was the Protestant reformation which resulted in a split in Christianity and the secession of a large number of countries from the Roman Catholic Church and establishment of separate Churches in those countries, generally on national lines. The second development concerned reforms within the Roman Catholic Church, generally referred to as Catholic Reformation or Counter Reformation. But Reformation was not merely a religious movement. It was intimately connected with, and was in fact a part of, the social and political movement of the period which brought about the end of the medieval period and the emergence of the modern world.

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The Catholic Church, during the early medieval period, had become a vast hierarchical organization headed by the Pope in Rome. The Pope was the supreme authority over the entire hierarchy and he exercised this authority directly. The position of the Pope is often described by the phrase 'papal monarchy'. Systematic efforts were made to extend the authority of the Church over everyone, high or low, making an oral confession of his sins to a priest at least once a year and suffering the punishment imposed was made obligatory for everyone. The people who did not follow this were excommunicated. An excommunicated person was supposed to have been temporarily consigned to hell. If he died, his body could not be buried with the prescribed rituals. Other Christians were forbidden from associating with him. An important component of the religious thinking propagated by the Church was the theory of sacraments. A sacrament was defined as an instrument by which divine grace is communicated to men. The sacraments were regarded indispensable for securing God's grace and there was no salvation without them. Another was the theory of priesthood. It was held that the priest who was ordained by a bishop (who was confirmed by the Pope) was the inheritor of a part of the authority conferred by Christ on Peter. The priest, according to this theory had the power to co-operate with God in performing certain miracles and in releasing sinner from the consequences of their sins. Besides the sacraments, various other beliefs came to be accepted.

Reformation is often described as a revolt against abuses which had grown in the Catholic Church. Some of the priests and higher-ups in the Church hierarchy received their appointments through corrupt means. Many such appointees were utterly ignorant. They led lives of luxury and immorality. Religious offices were sold to the highest bidder and those who bought positions after spending money made good by taking high fees for the services they performed. The Popes and the higher clergy lived like princes. A new abuse was the sale of letters which remitted punishments of the sinners who bought them, both in this life and after their death in purgatory. Normally, the priests imposed a penance or punishment on a person who had sinned and he was required to perform a special service or make a pilgrimage to a holy place. But increasingly sinners with enough money could be freed from doing penance for their sins by paying the clergy for a "Letter of Indulgence". The sale of indulgences which began to be considered as passports to heaven became one of the major immediate issues which caused the protestant Reformation. Besides the sale of indulgences, one could now gain salvation in exchange for fees. The priests, the bishops and the wandering monks could pronounce a marriage lawful or unlawful. By payment of fees, the problem could be solved. There were fees for every transaction in life, from birth to death, fees for the peace of the soul and fees for the souls of the people dead long ago. The wandering monks when they wanted to, heard confessions, awarded punishments for sins and remitted the punishments for fees.

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The Protestant Revolution can be said to have begun in 1517 when **Martin Luther**, a monk of the Order of St. Augustine, nailed his ninety-five theses or statements which attacked the sale of indulgences, on the door of the Church in Wittenberg in Germany. He challenged people to come and hold debates with him on his theses and sent copies of his theses to his friends in a number of cities. During the next two years Luther wrote a series of pamphlets. He knew that his doctrines could not be reconciled with those of the Catholic Church and that he had no alternative but to break with the Catholic Church. In 1520, the Pope ordered him to recant within sixty days or be condemned as a heretic. Luther burnt the proclamation of the Pope in public. During this period, he was protected by the ruler of Saxony who was his friend. Many rulers in Germany were hostile to the Church and when Luther was excommunicated, he remained unharmed. During the next 25 years, he occupied himself with the task of building an independent German Church, and in expounding his doctrine. He rejected the entire system of the hierarchy of the Catholic Church, introduced German as the language of Church services, abolished the special status of priests as representatives of God on earth, eliminated most of the sacraments, and emphasized faith rather than pilgrimages. He gave the highest priority to the supreme authority of the scriptures. Another important change was the abandonment of the view of the Catholic Church that the Church was supreme over the state. The German rulers and common people of Germany supported Luther. There were political reasons for the support of the rulers. They wanted to be free from the authority of Popes and get possession of the wealth in German monasteries for themselves. The common people liked Luther's teaching because it gave them an opportunity to demand more freedom from their rulers.

Ulrich Zwingli and **John Calvin** became the leaders of the Protestant movement in Switzerland. Under the leadership of Calvin, the Swiss cities became a refuge for Protestants fleeing to other countries in western Europe due to religious persecution. Calvin established an academy for the training of Protestant missionaries, who in return would spread the true word of God in other lands. As part of the work of propagating his version of Protestantism, Calvin composed a treatise entitled, *The Institutes of the Christian Religion*, wherein he gave a more concise and logical definition of the Protestant doctrines than what had been given by any other leader of this movement.

In England the Protestant movement was led by political leaders, particularly King Henry VIII and Queen Elizabeth I. Their reforms were not driven by the ides of religious or social reforms but by the interests of the state and more practically, the personal ambition of Henry VIII. Henry VIII sought to divorce his wife Catherine of Aragon and wanted to marry his beloved Anne Boleyn. The Pope refused to grant the divorce on the ground that Henry, before marrying Catherine,

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had asked for and had received a special Papal dispensation declaring his marriage with Catherine as valid and indissoluble. Rebuffed by the Pope, Henry promptly declared himself the "sole protector and supreme head of the Church and the Clergy of England". After that he married Anne Boleyn. From this marriage was born Elizabeth I, who later became the Queen of England. England's final break with the Pope came in 1529, when in a special session of the British Parliament a series of laws were passed to make the English Church completely free from the jurisdiction of the Pope. The King of England was also declared as the head of the English Church, which hereafter came to be known as the Anglican Church.

The Roman Catholic Church had been shaken to its very root by the movements started by Luther, Zwingli and Calvin. To counter the damage caused by the Protestant Movements, a series of reforms began within the Catholic Church, which came to be known as the 'Counter-Reformation'. During Counter-Reformation efforts were made to restore the Catholic Church's universal authority. One of these efforts took place in the Council of Trent (1545) summoned by Pope Paul III. The Council was to consider the ways and means to combat Protestantism. So it decided to settle the doctrinal disputes between the Catholics and the Protestants; clean up moral and administrative abuses within the Catholic Church and organise a new crusade against the Muslims. The next step was the organization of an order of missionaries, known as the Jesuits, with the dedicated purpose of spreading the message of Christ. The above measures adopted by the Catholic Church were not sufficient to bring the whole of Europe under the authority of the Pope. The campaign, however, did achieve a considerable measure of success in checking the further spread of Protestantism. Though much of Europe remained Protestant, new lands overseas were being won to the Catholic Church.

Reacting to economic and political changes, the concomitant reorganization of social life, much of the eighteenth century was consumed by intellectual ferment. The intellectual revolution of the eighteenth century is commonly referred to as the ***Enlightenment***. In England and Scotland, the Enlightenment was dominated by a group of thinkers who argued for a vision of human beings and society that both reflected and justified the industrial capitalism that first emerged in the British Isles. For scholars such as Adam Smith, individuals are to be free of external constraint and allowed to compete, thereby creating a better society. In France, the Enlightenment is often termed the *Age of Reason*, and it was dominated by a group of scholars known as the *philosophes*. It is out of the intellectual ferment generated by the French philosophes that sociology was born.

This section is very important, not only for your written examination but also for the interview. Please read it carefully.

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The term 'Enlightenment' is used in an academic and technical sense to indicate the intellectual movement in 18th century western and central Europe especially in England and France. Its historical significance lay in breaking the shackles of ideas imposed by tradition or authority whether of state or Church. For a long period in history up to that time, the standard method of arriving at the truth lay in an appeal to authority. It meant in practice, that truth was determined by one's superiors and one was not expected to doubt or question their wisdom. To buttress their claim, both state and Church would base their authority on supernatural sanction rather than on popular sovereignty. This had been the basis of absolutism and absolute monarchs ruled in nearly all parts of Europe. Conflicts between Church and state were not infrequent but these rarely concerned the common man in an age when communications were poor and his struggle for existence much harder.

Things in the meantime had changed fast during the 16th and 17th Centuries. Significant advances had been made in discoveries of new lands and routes; technologies as applied to agriculture and industries had increased production, and that possibly accounts for the rapid increase of population that took place both in England and France. Urban areas expanded and a middle class emerged to avail itself of the new opportunities in sectors like banking, industry, trade, journalism and above all education that served as a catalyst in the movement of ideas.

The essence of Enlightenment lay in its challenge to absolutism, the questioning of authority through a new conception of truth. In the course of Enlightenment, reason supplanted authority as the accepted method of arriving at the truth. All who look part in this movement of ideas were convinced that human understanding is capable by its own power and without recourse to supernatural assistance, of comprehending the system of the world. A new optimism was breathed about man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. The basic difference between the Absolutist view and Enlightened view centered round the individual. Under absolutism, the individual had to submit to the authority which was supposed to possess the monopoly of the truth; but under Enlightenment the individual acquired a new importance, dignity and self respect. Any man's opinion was potentially worth something. One no longer had to be a bishop or prince to claim access to truth. Enlightenment stood for the classic trilogy - Liberty, Equality, Fraternity; and as such represented the fight against oppression imposed by the old social hierarchy that had developed a vested interest in keeping people ignorant and superstitious. A challenge was thrown to religious education since it was believed that such education sapped a young person's courage and killed initiative by training him to fear and obey.

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Thus, the enlightenment was a period of remarkable intellectual development and change in the philosophical thought. A number of long-standing ideas and beliefs – many of which related to social life – were overthrown and replaced during the Enlightenment. The most prominent thinkers associated with the Enlightenment were the French philosophers **Charles Montesquieu** (1689-1755) and **Jean Jacques Rousseau** (1712-1778).

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and judicial, at one place. He believed in the theory of separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Rousseau in his book *The Social Contract* argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. For Rousseau, the social contract is the sole foundation of the political community. By virtue of this social contract, individuals lose their natural liberties (limited merely by their ability to exercise force over one another). However, man's natural liberty promoted unlimited acquisitiveness and avarice and thus encouraged individuals to destroy the freedom of others weaker than they. By submitting to a law vested in a social contract – a mandate that can be withdrawn at any time – individuals find in the laws to which they consent a pure expression of their being as civilized human entities.

Although the Enlightenment was fueled by the political, social, and economic changes of the eighteenth century, it derived considerable inspiration from the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. As noted earlier, the scientific revolution reached a symbolic peak, at least in the eye of eighteenth-century thinkers, with Newtonian physics. In the light of various revolutionary developments in science, particularly Physics, the universe (physical world) came to be viewed as orderly or patterned. It was argued that with scientific inquiry (based on empirical observation and application of reason) the underlying natural laws governing the universe can be discovered. Further, the knowledge of these laws would facilitate better prediction and greater control over the physical world. Thus, Physics was to become the vision of how scientific inquiry and theory should be conducted. And the individual and society were increasingly drawn into the orbit of the new view of science. This gradual inclusion of the individual and society into the realm of science represented a startling break with the past, because heretofore these phenomena had been considered the domain of morals, ethics, and religion.

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So, the enlightenment thinkers argued that just as the physical world was governed by the natural laws, it was likely that social world was, too. Thus it was up to the philosopher, using reason and research, to discover these social laws. And once such social laws are discovered, then with the knowledge of those laws we can control and create a better society (social engineering).

It is important to note that almost all enlightenment thinkers also shared 'a vision of human progress.' Humanity was seen to be marching in a direction and was considered to be governed by a "law of progress" that was as fundamental as the law of gravitation in the physical world. For example, with economic modernization and advancement of technology agricultural and industrial revolution took place leading phenomenal increase in the agricultural and industrial outputs. With commercial revolution (trade and commerce), unprecedented wealth or capital was generated. Further, scientific revolution demolished the traditionally held superstitious beliefs (sanctified by Church) and ushered in the age of reason. With its emphasis on empirical observation and application of reason, it significantly changed the social outlook of man and brought about social modernization.

At psychological level, modernity was reflected in terms of reflexivity. Reflexivity refers to the reflexive monitoring of action: that is, the way in which humans think about and reflect upon what they are doing in order to consider acting differently in future. Humans have always been reflexive up to a point, but in pre-industrial societies the importance of tradition limited reflexivity. Humans would do some things simply because they were the traditional things to do. However, with modernity, tradition loses much of its importance and reflexivity becomes the norm (psychological modernization). Social reflexivity implies that social practices are constantly examined and reformed in the light of incoming information about those very practices, thus continuously altering their character.

Further, with the rise various social and political movements, demands for greater individual freedom and democratization were being made. For the first time in human history, the idea of fundamental rights of the individuals was being entertained in the public discourse. Traditional authoritarian and autocratic systems of governance were being challenged. The enlightenment scholars argued that all humans had certain inalienable "natural rights" which must be respected such as right to freedom of speech and expression, right of participation in the decision-making process, etc. This marked a significant step towards political modernization.

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Thus, the enlightenment scholars saw these developments as the sign of progress and the enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main features of Enlightenment period.

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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Write a short note on 'Enlightenment'. (100-120 words)

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3. For Interview

Enlightenment Philosophy * Major Enlightenment Philosophers

Now let us briefly discuss the developments taking place in France, the birthplace of Sociology. In the years preceding the revolution, France retained the political and economic characteristics of a feudal society: rigid social hierarchy, social and economic inequality, monarchy, etc. The French society was divided into feudal **'estates'**. The structure of the feudal French society comprised the 'Three Estates'. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. **The First Estate** (the Church) consisted of the clergy, which was stratified into higher clergy, such as the cardinal, the archbishops, the bishops and the abbots. They lived a life of luxury and gave very little attention to religion. In fact, some of them preferred the life of politics to religion. They spent much of their time in wasteful activities like drinking, gambling, etc. The Church owned one-fifth of the cultivated lands in France and enjoyed great influence with the Government. Like the nobles, the higher clergy was also exempt from paying most of the taxes. With the nobles they supported absolute monarchy. The Church collected tithe, a tax from the people for providing community services. It also maintained institutions of learning. In comparison to the higher clergy, the lower parish priests were over worked and poverty-stricken.

The Second Estate consisted of the nobility. There were two kinds of nobles, the nobles of the sword and the nobles of the robe. The nobles of the sword were big landlords. They were the protectors of the people in principle but in reality they led a life of a parasite, living off the hard work of the peasants. They led the life of pomp and show and were nothing more than 'high born wastrels'; that is, they spent extravagantly and did not work themselves. They can be compared to the erstwhile zamindars in India. The nobles of the robe were nobles not by birth but by title. They were the magistrates and judges. Among these nobles, some were very progressive and liberal as they had moved in their positions from common citizens who belonged to the third estate. However, these noble families continued to enjoy all the privileges such as non-payment of most of the taxes, avenues to higher positions in the French administration, and income from various feudal dues of the peasants.

The Third Estate comprised the rest of the society and included the peasants, the merchants, the artisans, and others. There was a vast difference between the condition of the peasants and that of the clergy and the nobility. The

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peasants worked day and night but were overloaded with so many taxes that they lived a hand to mouth existence. They produced the food on which the whole society depended. Yet they could barely survive due to failure of any kind of protection from the government. The King, in order to maintain the good will of the other two estates, the clergy and the nobility, continued to exploit the poor. The poor peasants had no power against him. While the clergy and the nobility kept on pampering and flattering the King.

As compared to the peasants, the condition of the middle classes, also known as the **bourgeoisie** comprising the merchants, bankers, lawyers, manufacturers, etc. was much better. These classes too belonged to the third estate. But the poverty of the state, which led to a price rise during 1720-1789, instead of adversely affecting them, helped them. They derived profit from this rise and the fact that French trade had improved enormously also helped the commercial classes to a great extent. Thus, this class was rich and secure. But it had no social prestige as compared with the high prestige of the members of the first and the second estates. In spite of controlling trade, industries, banking etc. the bourgeoisie had no power to influence the court or administration. They were looked down upon by the other two estates and the King paid very little attention to them. Thus, gaining political power became a necessity for them.

The clergy and the nobility both constituted only two per cent of the population but they owned about 35 per cent of the land. The peasants who formed 80 per cent of the population owned only 30 per cent of the land. The first two estates paid almost no taxes to the government. The peasantry, on the other hand, was burdened with taxes of various kinds. It paid taxes to the Church, the feudal lord, taxed in the form of income tax, poll tax, and land tax to the state. Thus, you can see how much burdened and poverty stricken the peasants had become at this time. They were virtually carrying the burden of the first two estates on their shoulders. On top of it all the prices had generally risen by about 65 per cent during the period 1720-1789. The French system of taxation was both unjust and unfair.

Like in all absolute monarchies, the theory of the Divine Right of King was followed in France too. For about 200 years the Kings of the Bourbon dynasty ruled France. Under the rule of the King, the ordinary people had no personal rights. They only served the King and his nobles in various capacities. The King's word was law and no trials were required to arrest a person on the King's orders. Laws too were different in different regions giving rise to confusion and arbitrariness. There was no distinction between the income of the state and the income of the King. The kings of France, from Louis XIV onwards, fought costly wars, which ruined the country, and when Louis XIV died in 1715, France had

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become bankrupt. Louis XV instead of recovering from this ruin kept on borrowing money from bankers. His famous sentence, "After me the deluge" describes the kind of financial crisis that France was facing. Louis XVI, a very weak and ineffective king, inherited the ruin of a bankrupt government. His wife, Queen Marie Antoinette, known for her expensive habits, is famous for her reply, which she gave to the poor, hungry people of France who came to her asking for bread. She told the people that, 'if you don't have bread, eat cake'.

Now let us examine the intellectual developments in France, which proved to be the igniting force in bringing about the French revolution. France, like some other European countries during the eighteenth century, had entered the age of reason and rationalism. Some of the major philosophers, whose ideas influenced the French people, were rationalists who believed that all true things could be proved by reason. Some of these thinkers were Locke (1632-1704), Montesquieu (1689-1755), Voltaire (1694-1778), and Rousseau (1712-1778).

Locke, an Englishman, advocated that every individual has certain rights, which cannot be taken by any authority. These rights were (i) right to live, (ii) right to property, and (iii) the right to personal freedom. He also believed that any ruler who took away these rights from his people should be removed from the seat of power and replaced by another ruler who is able to protect these rights.

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law,* held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and juridical, at one place. He believed in the theory of the separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Voltaire became internationally famous as a great writer and critic whose style and pungent criticism were inimitable. It was through his plays and writings that he launched his bitter attacks against the existing institutions like the church and the state. He made fun of the eccentricities of the nobles. He advocated religious toleration and freedom of speech. He also stood for the rights of individuals, for freedom of speech and expression.

Probably the greatest French philosopher of the age was **Jean Jacques Rousseau**. In his book *The Social Contract*, he argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. He further explained that the king and his subjects are parties to a contract, and therefore if the king does not rule the people according to their general will, he loses their loyalty. Rousseau was advocating popular sovereignty

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theory. His writings cast such a spell on his admirers that they were ready to revolt against the oppressive monarchy.

The major ideas of these and several other intellectuals struck the imagination of the French people. Also some of them who had served in the French army, which was sent to assist the Americans in their War of Independence from British imperialism, came back with the ideas of equality of individuals and their right to choose their own government. The French middle class was deeply affected by these ideas of liberty and equality. So far you have leant about the basic picture of the French society just before the Revolution. Now let us discuss some of the major events that took place during the Revolution.

It is worth noting that when the American colonists revolted against the oppressive rule of the mother country and won a resounding victory at Saratoga, the French government decided to help them with men, money and materials. It caused a serious strain on the finances of the country and cast a heavy burden on the poor peasants. Turgot was appointed as the Minister of Finance to suggest remedies. He advised the king to tax the privileged class. He was summarily dismissed at the instance of the queen. Unfortunately, France witnessed near-famine conditions in 1788 with the result that there was a serious food shortage. It was at this critical juncture that the king was advised by his courtiers to summon the Estates-General (French Parliament) to get approval for further dose of taxation.

When the Estates-General was summoned, the king ignored the importance of the Third Estate (600 representatives elected by the common people) and tried to consult the representatives of the three estates separately. The representatives of the third estate advised the king to bring together the representatives of all the three estates at one place for discussion of state problems. The king discarded their advice. Subsequently, it led to a quarrel between the king and the representatives of the third estate. This led to the formation of the National Assembly. The meeting of the National Assembly led by middle class leaders and some liberal minded nobles was met with stiff resistance. On 20th June 1789 when a meeting was to be held in the Hall at Versailles near Paris, the members found that it was closed and guarded by the King's men. Therefore, the National Assembly members led by their leader Bailey went to the next building which was an indoor tennis court. It was here that they took an Oath to draw a new constitution for France. This Oath, which marks the beginning of the French Revolution, is popularly known as the Oath of the Tennis Court.

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Next, on July 14th, 1789 took place one of the most important events of the French Revolution. It was the storming of the Bastille, an ancient royal prison that stood as a symbol of oppression. On this date the mobs of Paris, led by some middle class leaders, broke open this prison and set its inmates free. The causes for this event were the shortage of food, on the one hand, and the dismissal of a very popular minister called Necker, on the other. The mobs of Paris rebelled against the ruling class, especially the King. This day is celebrated in France as its Independence Day.

Shortly after these events, the National Assembly drafted the 'Declaration of the Rights of Man,' which was a central political document defining human rights and setting out demands for reform. The political rights and freedoms proclaimed by the 'Declaration' were so wide-ranging in their human emancipation that it set the standard for social and political thinking, and formed the central rallying point of the revolution. The 'Declaration' stated at the outset that all human beings were born free and equal in their political rights, regardless of their class position, and this proceeded to set up a system of constitutional principles based on liberty, security and resistance to oppression. With philosophical authority, the 'Declaration' proclaimed that all individuals had the prerogative to exercise their 'natural right' and that the law rather than the monarch was the expression of the common interest. This led to the elimination of all social distinctions on the one hand, and the right to resist oppression on the other. Thus, the ideas of Liberty, Equality and Fraternity were enshrined in this declaration. Liberty and equality put an end to the age of serfdom, despotism and hereditary privileges found in the old feudal society.

By August the National Assembly began to deal directly with political and legal reforms, first by eliminating feudal dues and then by abolishing selfdom. Second, by compelling the church to give up the right to tithes, the National Assembly altered the authority and class position of the clergy. Third, in declaring that 'all citizens, without distinction, can be admitted to ecclesiastical, civil and military posts and dignities,' it proclaimed an end to all feudal social distinctions.

As the criticism of social and political inequalities spread throughout society, there was a widespread critique of economic inequality altogether and this led to putting into question all other forms of subordination. With this came the idea that human beings, without distinctions, were the bearers of natural rights – a concept which had a corrosive effect on all other forms of inequality. Finally, from the assertions inherent in the 'Declarations of Rights,' a new category of social person came into being which came fundamentally to rest in the concept of the 'citizen,' whose social and political rights were brought within the framework of the state.

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As the political changes began to take effect, there were abrupt social changes in the form of altered politics and in the form of the political reorganization of the feudal way of life. This brought with it two central historical shifts. First, it transformed the existing class structure of feudal society and led to the decline of class privilege and a change in the relations of subordination which had existed up until that time. Second, it set loose political and legal reforms which brought about a change from a political aristocracy based on sovereign authority to a democratic republic based on the rights of the citizen. Thus French Revolution of 1789 marked the phase of political modernization.

Now let us once again return to our discussion of enlightenment. As we had discussed earlier, the enlightenment scholars saw these socio-economic and political developments as the sign of progress. The enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. So, enlightenment thinkers represented intellectual modernity. But there were also some scholars who viewed these changes otherwise. These scholars were not only skeptic about these changes taking place in European society but even condemned these changes. We call these scholars as Counter–Enlightenment scholars and their views as a Conservative Reaction to enlightenment (anti–modernity). The most extreme form of opposition to Enlightenment ideas was French Catholic counterrevolutionary philosophy, as represented by the ideas of **Louis de Bonald** (1754-1840) and **Joseph de Maistre** (1753-1821). These men were reacting against not only the Enlightenment but also the French Revolution, which they saw partly as a product of the kind of thinking characteristic of the Enlightenment. De Bonald, for example, was disturbed by the revolutionary changes and yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages.

In general, these scholars deplored the disruption of socio-economic and political fabric of the traditional medieval society caused by Industrial Revolution and French Revolution. As mentioned earlier that there was massive dislocation of rural population due to enclosure movement. The newly emerging social life in towns and cities was bereft of close-knit community and kinship bonds, we-feeling, stability and harmonic social order. Since these cities had emerged spontaneously, without any proper planning, they lacked even the basic amenities such as proper sewage and sanitation. As a result, due such unhygienic living conditions, epidemics were a common phenomenon. Further, these newly emerging industrial cities were marked by gross socio-economic disparities. Workers, including women and children, were forced to work for long hours in the factories marked by inhuman working conditions. In this new mode of production, worker had lost control over both, the process of production as well as his product. He was simply reduced to a wage-labourer. In Marxist terms, the worker became alienated from the product of his labour.

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Further, demand for political rights fuelled by the writings of enlightenment scholars, often led to civil wars leading to political anomie. Furthermore, religion too, which until now regulated the social order started declining. Religion, as the source of solace and meaning of life, started losing its appeal with the advances in science. So, Conservatives saw these changes, i.e. decline of family & community life, decline of religion, economic exploitation of workers in factories, rising socio-economic disparities and political turmoil as a sign of social decay and not as progress. Hence, they were preoccupied with their concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society.

So, while enlightenment scholars glorified change, conservatives deplored such changes and emphasized on stability, peace and harmony. However, the idea that there must be peace and harmony in social life came to be generally accepted by scholars of both the traditions.

Thus, the social conditions prevalent in Europe in 18th and 19th centuries, generated by social changes such as Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Counter-Reformation, Industrial Revolution and French Revolution created the need for a distinct discipline to understand and analyze these changes. As we know that the existing knowledge that was prevalent during those times was largely religious in nature. Traditionally, the only source of knowledge was religion, propagated by the Church. But, the then existing body of religious knowledge had no answer to these challenges. Further, with the growth of science, religion itself was under attack and religious ideas were loosing their plausibility. So, there was a need for a new body of knowledge. A new body of knowledge was needed to understand what was happening and also help people to find solutions to the newly emerging problems.

That is how, the social changes created by modernity in Europe in the late 18th and early 19th century created the need for new knowledge.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

How?

As the early social theorists were largely preoccupied with understanding the puzzle of social change unfolding in Europe and to create a harmonic social order, hence, we can say that the goals of sociology were dictated by the conservative reaction. As we had already discussed that how the Conservative scholars were

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preoccupied with concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society. Therefore, sometimes it is also said that the early sociology developed as a reaction to the Enlightenment.

But, as far as the methodology or means to understand and study these social changes was concerned, it was largely influenced by the intellectual contributions of the Enlightenment scholars. Unlike conservatives, who yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages, early social theorists emphasized on the need for scientific study of society based on empirical observation and reason (an idea of Enlightenment scholars) to be the basis of this new knowledge. They argued that through scientific study of society, social scientists can discover social laws that govern social order and thus, through corrective social legislation, can create a harmonic society. So, that is how the intellectual conditions helped in creating a new discipline which would use scientific method to study society, discover the laws that govern society and use that knowledge of laws to create a peaceful and harmonic society.

So, social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology and that is how modernity and social change in Europe led to the emergence of sociology.

SOCIOLOGY
No Stories, Only Strategic Discussion
Q. What is Sociology ?
A. 250 - 300 Marks
If your definition of Sociology matches ours then visit us before it is too late.

Regular Batch (Evening)	15th Jan. 2015
Weekend Batch (Morn. & Eve.)	17th Jan. 2015
Answer Writing Programme	18th Jan. 2015

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Test Yourself

Q1. Write a note on 'Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of Sociology'. (300-350 words/ 30 marks)

Dear Candidate, before I give you a model answer for this question, I wish to discuss with you the correct strategy of writing an answer. I call this '**Dialectical Approach**', a term borrowed from Hegel. But before you apply the dialectical approach to a question make sure that you have read that question at least three times and understood it. It is a very common error on the part of the candidates to write in the examination 'what they know' rather 'what has been asked by the examiner.' Hence, the key to score well in this examination is to read the mind of the examiner and accordingly answer the question, meeting the expectations of the examiner. If you do this, you would get marks as per your expectations too.

All you have to do for this is to follow a very simple process. Firstly, read the question carefully and underline the keywords. Secondly, try to understand from which dimension the question has been framed on the topic. This is very important because questions can be framed from multiple dimensions or angles on the same topic. You would have no problem doing this if you sincerely follow the theme-based approach. Thirdly, divide the question into 3-4 logical sub-questions. When you do this it will not only keep you focused on the main theme but also help you complete the paper in time.

Now, let me share with you something about the structure of your answer. Your answer must be divided in four sections, viz. **introduction**, **thesis**, **anti-thesis** and **synthesis**. The Introduction section is the most important section of your answer as it introduces yourself as a candidate to the examiner. The examiner forms an image about you and your understanding of the concept just by reading the introduction. Hence, you must start by directly addressing the question, without beating the bush. By this I mean that given the limitations of Time and Word Limit, please avoid developing the background and glorifying the thinkers. In the introduction, briefly explain the key concept asked in the question. The introduction section should constitute nearly 20 % of the total length of your answer.

The next section is Thesis. In this section, you need to identify the main arguments in favour of the given concept or statement. Here, you must enrich your answer by highlighting the works of the scholars and case studies in support of

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your argument. In the Anti-Thesis section, you must write a critique of the concept or statement. This would balance your answer. Both, Thesis and Anti-Thesis should constitute nearly 30% each of the total length of your answer. Last, but not the least, is the Synthesis section. You may also call it as concluding remarks. Please remember that the concluding remarks reflect your overall understanding of the subject to the examiner. Your concluding remarks are not supposed to be your personal opinion about the ideas or concepts asked in the question. Rather, your concluding remarks must reflect the insight that you have gained as a student of Sociology. Thus, when write synthesis, make sure it is an academic conclusion rather than personal opinion.

Structure of the Model Answer:

Introduction: Briefly discuss the concept of modernity and the process of social change in Europe that brought about modernity

Thesis: Arguments in favour of the modernization process, viz. the ideas of Enlightenment scholars, with examples

Anti-thesis: Conservative reaction to Enlightenment

Synthesis: Emergence of Sociology as a by-product of the confluence of the two intellectual currents – Enlightenment and Conservatives

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Model Answer

Modernity refers to the rational transformation of social, psychological, economic and political aspects of society. In this sense, the process of modernization could be said to have begun in the late 18th and early 19th century in Western Europe. During that period, the entire social structure and the economic and political institutions were undergoing transition, particularly in the backdrop of Renaissance and Enlightenment movement. With industrial revolution, traditional feudal agrarian society was in decline and a new capitalist industrial society was emerging. The commercial and scientific revolutions which marked the period laid the foundations for the transformation of a predominant rural, agricultural and manual way of life to an urban industrial and mechanized pattern of living.

These extensive changes integral to the process of industrialization however, involved a major paradox. They brought a new society with great productive potential and more sophisticated and complex ways of living while at the same time generating extensive disruptions in traditional patterns of life and relationship. Thus, creating new problems of overcrowding, unhygienic urban conditions, poverty and unemployment. Demand for greater political rights gave rise to social and political movements, such as French Revolution, often leading to civil wars.

However, the early scholars who were carefully observing the changes in the patterns of social life with the rise of industrial society were divided in their opinion with regard to the nature, impact and direction of such changes. Enlightenment scholars like Rousseau, Montesquieu, Adam Smith, Saint Simon and Augusts Comte had a positive view of the newly emerging social order. They considered such changes as progressive and hence desirable. They favoured modern scientific knowledge, advanced technology, individualism and political ideas of justice and liberty. They encouraged the forces of liberalization and industrialization. Whereas, the Conservatives like Louis de Bonald, Joseph de Maistre and other such scholars had a rather skeptic view of these profound and far reaching institutional changes that were taking place in society. They were preoccupied with the concern for social stability and order in the society as the new social order was marked by violent political revolutions, class wars, extreme economic inequalities and widespread misery and poverty.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

Total Words: 355

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Dear Candidate, after completing a given topic and preparing your notes in pointer form, you must attempt questions asked so far in previous years and get them evaluated. Always remember that Civil Services Examination is not about more information or content, it is more about analysis. So,

Read Adequately * Think Logically * Write Relevantly

All the best

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	Morning Session							Noon Session					Evening Session							
Day/Date	5-6	6-7	7-8	8-9	9-10	10-11	11-12	12-1	1-2	2-3	3-4	4-5	5-6	6-7	7-8	8-9	9-10	10-11	11-12	Total Hours
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Basic Concepts

Society:

The concept of society constitutes the core of the discipline of Sociology. It is the very subject matter of Sociology. Sociology is nothing but a scientific study of society and a variety of interactions that unfold within and between individuals and groups. Social beings express their nature by creating and re-creating an organization which guides and controls their behaviour in various ways. This organization, society, liberates and limits activities of men, sets up standards for them to follow and maintain. It is a necessary condition of every fulfilment of life. Society is the web of social relationships and it is always changing. Society exists only where social beings "behave" towards one another in ways determined by their recognition of one another i.e. mutual recognition.

However, society is not limited to human beings. There are animal societies of many degrees. The remarkable social organizations of the insects, such as the ant, the bee, etc., are well known. **Kingsley Davis** argues that irrespective of their types all the societies have certain common needs which must be fulfilled. These needs which may be regarded as "primary needs" define the necessary conditions for the existence of any society. According to Kingsley Davis, these societal needs may be classified into four major categories – the need for population (which include need for nutrition, protection, and reproduction), specialization, solidarity, and continuity. To meet these minimum requirements for survival, animals depend largely upon instinctual learning and communication. This meeting of the basic conditions of continued existence by means of learned, normative behaviour (i.e. culture) rather than primarily by hereditary mechanisms constitutes the major difference between human and animal societies.

Society involves both likeness and difference. Without likeness and the sense of likeness there could be no mutual recognition of "belonging together" and therefore no society. Society exists among those who resemble one another in some degree, in body and in mind, and who are near enough or intelligent enough to appreciate the fact. Society, as **F.H. Giddings** expressed it, rests on ***"consciousness of kind."***

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Society, however, also depends on difference. For example, the family rests upon the biological difference between the sexes. There are other natural differences, of aptitude, of capacity, of interest. Further differences are developed in the process of specialization. These differences, natural and developed, show themselves in society in the social division of labour.

According to **MacIver**, ***society means likeness and in a society difference is subordinate to likeness***. He argues that the division of labour in society is co-operation before it is division. For it is because people have like wants that they associate in the performance of unlike functions. It may also be borne in mind that while society means likeness, the converse of the statement is not true. Likeness may exist without giving birth to society. Similarly, while difference is necessary to society difference by itself does not create society. The likeness of men's wants is necessarily prior to the differentiation of social organization. As MacIver observes, ***"Primary likeness and secondary difference create the greatest of all social institutions – the division of labour."***

Harry M. Johnson enlists four characteristics of a society, viz. definite territory, progeny, culture and independence.

Definitions:

"Society is a system of usages and procedures, authority and mutual aid, of many groupings and divisions, of controls of human behaviour and of liberties."
- MacIver and Page

"The term society refers not to group of people, but to the complex pattern of the norms of interaction, that arise among and between them." **- Lapiere**

"Society is the complex of organized associations and institutions within the community." **- G. D. H. Cole**

"Society is not a group of people; it is the system of relationships that exists between the individuals of the group." **- Prof. Wright**

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According to **MacIver**, ***"Society is a web of social relationships"***. But what is meant by social relationship? Can the relationship existing between fire and smoke or between pen and ink be called social relationship? Obviously not, because psychical awareness of the presence of one another is lacking. Without this awareness, there can be no social relationship, and therefore no society. A social relationship, thus implies 'reciprocal awareness'. Society, **as F. H. Giddings** expressed it, rests on **"consciousness of the kind"**. This reciprocal recognition may be the **"we-feeling"** of **Cooley** or a **"common propensity"** of **W. I. Thomas**.

If we analyze these definitions it will appear that these fall under two types: (1) **the functional definition** which views society as a process and (2) **the structural definition** which views society as a structure. It should be noted however that there is really no conflict between the two views of society, viz. society viewed as social relationships or as a process and society viewed as a structure. As a matter of fact, these two views complement each other.

From the functional point of view, society is defined as a complex of groups in reciprocal relationship, interacting upon one another, enabling human organisms to carry on their life-activities and helping each person to fulfill his wishes and accomplish his interests in association with his fellows. When we view society as social relationships or as a process, we should bear in mind two features, which characterize society: (i) **mutual recognition**, that is, different members in a society recognize the presence of one another, and orient their behaviour one way or the other. This idea of reciprocal awareness is implied in Giddings' definition of society as "a number of like-minded individuals, who know and enjoy their like-mindedness, and are, therefore, able to work together for common ends". In the case of physical relationship, such as the relationship between a typist and the typewriter, there is no such mutual recognition. The psychical condition, a characteristic feature of social relationship, is lacking here, (ii) the second feature is a **sense of belonging together** or a **consciousness of kind**, as Giddings puts it. A society consists of people who share attitudes, beliefs and ideals in common. There might, of course, be feuds and mutual hostility among members of a society. But these are, in the nature of things, transitory and occasional. In the words of **MacIver**: ***"Co-operation crossed by conflict marks society wherever it is revealed…"***

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From the structural point of view, society is the total social heritage of folkways, mores, and institutions; of habits, sentiments and ideals. The structure of a human society is similar to the structure of a building, which has three components: (i) the building material such as bricks, mortar, beams and pillars, (ii) all these are arranged in a definite order and are placed in relationship to one another, and (iii) all these put together make a building one unit. The same three sets of features can be used to describe the structure of a society. A society consists of (i) males and females, adults and children, various occupational and religious groups and so on, (ii) the interrelationship between various parts (such as relationship between husband and wife, between parents and children and between various groups), and (iii) all the parts of the society are put together to work as a unit. Thus, the term social structure refers to the way the various parts are organized and follow stable patterns of collective rules, roles and activities. Although, the structure itself remains invisible, it silently shapes our actions. The basic elements of social structure which guides our actions are statuses, social roles, norms and values.

Society as a Process and Society as a Structure:

The concepts of **status** and **role** are integral to the understanding of society as a process as well as structure. While ***status refers to a position occupied by an individual in a group or in society***, ***role is the expected behaviour of an individual who holds a certain status***.

Status is usually defined as the rank or position of a person in a group, or of a group in relation to other group. In fact, some sociologists prefer to use the term 'position' instead of status. **Role** is the behaviour expected of one who holds a particular status. Each person may hold a number of statuses and be expected to fill roles appropriate to them. In a sense, status and role are two aspects of the same phenomenon. **A status is a set of privileges and duties; a role is the acting out of this set of duties and privileges.**

Status, thus, is the 'socially defined location or place' which an individual occupies in a system of interaction or society. Thus, in any interaction, none of the participant is without status. It should also be clear that every individual occupies multiple statuses. Even a young infant is a son, a grandson, a brother, a nephew,

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and so on. There is, however, one key status in terms of which the individual is ultimately and evaluated. In modern societies, one's occupation indicates one's key status. Individuals in society play different roles and societies evaluate these roles differently. Some roles are regarded more valuable and the persons who perform these roles are given higher status.

It is important to note that interaction among the members in a social situation takes place on the basis of identity of each participant. This identity of an individual is established either on the basis of his birth or on the basis of his achievements, which refers to his position or status in a group or in a society. Status may be ascribed or achieved. **Ascribed status** is assigned to an individual either on the basis of his birth and biological characteristics such as sex, age and race or the status of his/ her parents. In India caste plays a significant role in determining the status of an individual, which is an example of ascribed status. **Achieved status** is a position which an individual attains through personal efforts. For instance, one can become a doctor, engineer or lawyer by one's own efforts. Persons occupying the status may be replaced but the positions will continue to exist in the social structure.

Each distinctive status, whether ascribed or achieved, has certain role expectation. Role is the expected behaviour of an individual who holds a certain status. **While status is the positional aspect of behaviour, role is the behavioural aspect of a given status or position**. Role may be defined as a pattern of behaviour, structured around specific rights and duties and associated with a particular status position within a group or social situation. A person's role in any situation is defined by the **set of expectations** for his behaviour held by others and by person himself. However, actual performance may vary from individual to individual. **Ralph Linton**, in his famous work '***The Study of Man***', has referred to role as *dynamic aspect of the status* and argued that a role is the totality of all the cultural patterns associated with a particular status.

The concept of role was initially developed by **Ralph Linton**. According to Linton, individuals occupy positions in different aspects of social life. Some examples of this are being a father or mother in a family. A person can also be a teacher in a school. He or she can also simultaneously be an office holder in an association. These positions are called statuses by Linton. In Linton's words,

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'statuses are the polar positions... in patterns of reciprocal behaviour'. A polar position comprises 'a collection of rights and duties'. Thus he conceived of status as a group of rights and duties. When a person is enacting these rights and duties, he is said to be performing a role. For example, when a teacher gives a lecture, he is performing his duty or performing his role of a teacher. Linton pointed out that a role is the dynamic side of status. It puts into action the various rights and duties.

Please note that if we consider just a point of time, both status and role would appear to be static concepts. Status is fixed and unchanging. So also is role. Viewed in this context, the society is a structure. However, if we consider a period of time, both status and role would appear to be dynamic concepts. Status changes in relation to other statuses from time to time. There is a corresponding change in role also. Viewed in the context of period of time, it would thus appear that society is a process and that social relationships are in a state of flux. If there is any equilibrium in society, it is a moving equilibrium. The society is thus viewed both as a process as well as structure. One who studies society must take into account both these views.

As **MacIver** has also said: ***"Society exists only as a time-sequence. It is a becoming, not a product"***. This is the essence of society. Thus, society is to be interpreted in a wider sense. It is both a structural and functional organisation. It consists in the mutual interactions and mutual interrelations of the individuals but it is also a structure formed by these relations.

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Community:

According to **MacIver and Page,** ***"wherever the members of any group, small or large, live together in such a way that they share the basic conditions of a common life, than such a group may be called a community."*** The mark of a community is that one's life may be lived wholly within it. The basic criterion of community then is that all of one's social relationships may be found within it. Communities need not always be self-sufficient. Some communities are all-inclusive and independent of others. But modern communities, even very large ones, are much less self-contained. Economic and, increasingly so, political interdependence is a major characteristic of our great modern communities. Communities may exist within greater communities: the town within a region, the region within a nation, and the nation within the world community which, perhaps, is in the process of development.

MacIver defines community as ***"an area of social living marked by some degree of social coherence."*** The bases of community are ***locality*** and ***community sentiment***. Most communities are settled and derive from the conditions of their locality a strong bond of solidarity. To some extent this local bond has been weakened in the modern world by the extending facilities of communications: this is especially apparent in the penetration into rural areas of dominant urban patterns. But the extension of communication is itself the condition of a larger community. Community sentiment is another key feature of a community. Locality, though a necessary condition, is not enough to create a community. A community, to repeat, is an area of common living. There must be the common living with its awareness of sharing a way of life as well as the common earth. Some scholars argue that a community always occupies a territorial area. The area need not be fixed for ever. The people may change their area of habitation from time to time just as nomadic community does.

Some other important **definitions** of community given by some of the prominent scholars are as follows:

"Community is a social group with some degree of 'we-feeling' and living in given area." **-Bogardus**

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"Community is the smallest territorial group that can embrace all aspects of social life." **-Kingsley Davis**

"Community is any circle of people who live together and belong together in such a way that they do not share this or that particular interest only, but a whole set of interests." **-Manheim**

Difference between Society and Community:

While society may be defined as a web of social relationships, community, on the other hand, consists of a group of individuals living in a particular area with some degree of 'we-feeling'. A definite geographic area is not an essential aspect of society but community always denotes a definite locality or geographic area. While society is abstract, community is concrete. Community sentiment or a sense of 'we-feeling' may be present or may not be present in society but community sentiment is an essential element of community. There can be no community in its absence. Society is wider; while there can be more than one community in a society. The objectives and interests of society are more extensive and varied as compared to that of a community. Society involves both likeness and difference. Common interests as well as diverse interests are present in society. But likeness is more important than difference in community. There is common agreement of interests and objectives on the part of members.

Association:

An association is a group of people organized for a particular purpose or a limited number of purposes. According to some scholars, to constitute an association there must be, firstly, a group of people. Secondly, these people must be organized ones i.e. there must be certain rules for their conduct in the group. Thirdly, they must have a common purpose of specific nature to pursue. Thus family, church, trade union, music club all are the instances of association. Associations may be formed on several bases, for example, on the basis of duration i.e. temporary or permanent like Flood Relief Association which is temporary and State which is permanent. On the basis of power i.e. sovereign like state, semi-

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sovereign like university, etc. On the basis of function i.e. biological like family, vocational like Trade Union, recreational like music club, etc.

"An association may be defined as an organisation deliberately formed for the collective pursuit of some interest or set of interests which its members share."

- MacIver

Difference between Association and Community:

An association, according to **MacIver and Page,** may be defined as a group organized for the pursuit of an interest or group of interests in common, whereas the mark of a community is that one's life may be lived wholly within it or in other words, its members share the very basic conditions of a common life. Membership of an association is voluntary i.e. individuals are at liberty to join them, while on the other hand, by birth itself individuals become members of a community. An association does not necessarily imply the spatial aspects while a community is marked by a locality. An association may be stable and long-lasting or it may not be so but a community is relatively more stable and permanent. Further, associations may have their legal status but a community has no legal status. Associations may have their own rules and regulations to regulate the relations of their members. They may have written or unwritten rules. A community regulates the behaviour of its members by means of customs, traditions and social norms, etc. Association is partial and it may be regarded as a part of the community. While community on the other hand is integral as it may have within its boundary, several associations.

Thus an association is not a community, but an organization within a community and a community is more than any specific organizations that rise within it. However, association may become communities at least temporarily over a period of time; for example, the military units may create their own communities when isolated for a period of time. The qualification, expressly organized, enables us to distinguish between association and other social groups. As we shall see, there are many forms and types of social groups, class and crowd, primary and secondary groups, face-to-face groups and great associations. But a social class, for example, is not an association. Organizations established on class lines such as certain political parties are associations, but a class itself is not a group expressly

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organized to pursue certain ends or to fulfil certain functions. Nor is the group we term a crowd an association, though certain crowds in some situations may acquire the characteristics of temporary associations.

Institution:

Institutions are the forms of procedure which are recognized and accepted by society and govern the relations between individuals and groups. In other words, a social institution refers to an interrelated system of social roles and norms organized about the satisfaction of an important social need or function. The social roles and norms comprising the social institution define proper and expected behaviour oriented to the fulfilment of the particular social, economic, political or physical need. Marriage, education, property, religion, etc. are some of the main institutions in any given society. The concept of institution is one of the most important in the entire field of sociology. In fact, **Durkheim** has gone to the extent of defining sociology as the science of social institutions.

Some important **definitions** of institution are as follows:

"Institutions may be defined as the established forms or conditions of procedure characteristic of group activity." **-MacIver and Page**

"Institutions represent the social structure and the machinery through which human society organizes, directs and executes the multifarious activities required to satisfy human needs." **-H. E. Barnes**

"A social institution is a structure of society that is organized to meet the need of people chiefly through well established procedures." **-Bogardus**

In the following section some of the key characteristics of institution are discussed. Essentially institutions are social in nature. Institutions come into being due to the collective activities of the people. Another important feature is their universality. They exist in all the societies and existed at all the stages of social

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development. The basic institutions like family, religion, property and some kind of political institutions are observed even in the tribal or primitive societies. Further it is important to note that institutions are nothing but standardized norms and procedures. They prescribe certain ways of doing things. They prescribe rules and regulations that are to be followed, for example, marriage as an institution governs the relations between the husband and wife. Institutions are formed to satisfy some of the most basic and vital needs of man, such as, need for self-preservation, the need for self-perpetuation, the need for self-expression, etc.

Institutions also act as the controlling mechanisms in a society. Institutions like religion, morality, state, government, law, legislation, etc., control the behaviour of men. These mechanisms preserve the social order and give stability to it. Further institutions are relatively permanent. Institutions normally do not undergo sudden or rapid changes. Changes take place slowly and gradually in them. Institutions are abstract in nature. They are not external, visible or tangible things. Institutions may have their own symbols, material or non-material, for example, the state has flag, emblem, etc. as its symbols while religion may have its own symbols like crucifix, crescent, star, swastika, etc. Institutions, though diverse, are interrelated. The social, economic, political, religious, educational and other types of institutions are essentially interlinked with each other.

Related to the concept of institution are the concepts of **custom**, **folkways** and **mores**. This section deals with the concept of custom and its interrelationship with the concept of institution. The concepts of folkways and mores are discussed subsequently.

Underlying and sustaining the more formal order of institutions and associations there exists an intricate complex of usages or modes of behaviour. Thus there are accepted procedures of eating, conversing, meeting folks, wooing, training the young, caring for the aged, etc. These socially accredited ways of acting are the customs of society. We conform to the customs of our own society, in a sense, "unconsciously," for they are a strongly imbedded part of our group life. They are so strongly imbedded, indeed, that we frequently make the error of identifying our particular customs with the only correct ways of doing this or that, or even with human nature itself.

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Distinction of institution and custom: The difference between a social usage or custom on the one hand and an institution on the other is essentially one of degree. Institution implies a more definite recognition. We would call the marriage feast an institution, but various courtship practices are better named customs. Marriage itself is an institution and not a custom. Institutions have external insignia, marks of public recognition, which customs as such do not require. The term "institution" stresses the impersonal factor in social relationships. When we speak of customs we think of the accepted ways in which people do things together, in personal contacts. When we speak of institutions we think rather of the system of controls that extends beyond personal relations.

Institutions are often classified into (i) ***Primary institutions*** and (ii) ***Secondary institutions***. The most basic institutions which are found even in primitive societies like religion, family, marriage, property, some kind of political system, are primary in character. As societies grew in size and complexity, institutions became progressive and more differentiated. Accordingly, a large number of institutions are evolved to cater to the secondary needs of people. They may be called secondary institutions. For example, education, examination, law, legislation, constitution, parliamentary procedure, business etc.

William Graham Sumner, an American Sociologist, viewed man as pitted against nature on one hand and against other men with a competing economic interest, on the other. The cooperation and conflict are the basic processes among the members of the society. In their attempt to conquer nature individuals engage in cooperation with each other. Similarly, individuals having common or compatible economic interests join hands and form groups in their struggle against other groups and individuals having conflicting economic interest. In their struggle for survival the social groups spontaneously develop various ways of acting. The best and fittest under the particular conditions are selected. These methods are repeated and their repetition produces habits in the individual and custom in the group. These persisting ways of doing things that develop in the spontaneous and unconscious manners are called ***Folkways***. They arise no one knows when and how and grow as if by the play of internal life and energy.

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He further argued that some folkways are considered crucial for the survival of the group. The special significance attached to these folk ways is manifested in the form of special sanctions which existed against their violation. Such folkways were called by Sumner as ***'Mores'***. According to Sumner, folkways also form the basis of group cohesion. Thus members of a group having similar folk ways develop a strong ***"we feeling"*** also termed as ***"in-group"*** feeling while groups having different folk ways display a sense of distrust and hostility towards others have been termed as ***"out-group"*** feelings. Each group, therefore, nourishes its pride and vanity, boasts of its own superiority and looks with contempt towards outsiders. To this attitude of superiority concerning the folkways of one's "in-group" and of judging others in terms of these folkways, Sumner gave the name ***ethnocentrism***.

He argued that the subject matter of sociology was the study of evolution, nature and functions of ***social institutions***, both crescive and enacted. The ***crescive institutions*** are those which develop spontaneously in an unplanned manner like folkways and mores. While ***enacted institutions*** consist of the laws that are the result of conscious and deliberate human efforts. The crescive ones are more akin to primary institutions whereas the enacted ones resemble secondary institutions. Thus according to Sumner, folkways are simply the customary, normal, habitual ways a group does things. Mores are those strong ideas of right and wrong which require certain acts and forbid others. Mores are time and space bound. They keep changing according to time and situations.

Culture:

The classic definition of culture, framed by **E.B. Tylor** in his book *Primitive Culture* (1871) reads, "**Culture…. is that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society**."

Stated more simply, culture is everything which is socially learned and shared by the members of a society. In other words, culture is the totality of learned and socially transmitted behaviour from one generation to the next. It includes symbols signs and languages, besides religion, rituals, beliefs and

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artifacts. In fact, culture is a guiding force in everyday life. It is the culture that distinguishes one society from the other. Each society has a culture of its own that is historically derived and passed on from one generation to another and constantly enriched by those who live it.

Some of the important **definitions** of culture are as follows:

"Culture is the expression of our nature in our modes of living and our thinking, intercourse, in our literature, in religion, in recreation and enjoyment."

- MacIver

Culture is "the **super-organic** environment as distinguished from the organic or physical, the world of plants and animals." **- Spencer**

"Culture is the sum total of human achievements, material as well as non-material, capable of transmission, sociologically, i.e., by tradition and communication vertically as well as horizontally." **- Mazumdar**

Thus, on the basis of various viewpoints mentioned above from various sociologists and anthropologists, some of the chief characteristics of culture have been summarized in this section. Firstly, culture is shared in common by the members of a given society or community. Culture, therefore, refers not to the beliefs and activities of individuals, but to those of groups or people who are organized in communities. It is fundamentally a social phenomenon. Secondly, culture is learnt and acquired by human beings in interaction with others. An individual acquires the characteristics of his parents and his group in two ways. On the one hand, he acquires the physical characteristics and features of his parents, such as skin colour, stature, texture of hair and colour of the eyes, through genetic transmission, over which he has no control. On the other hand, he learns and acquires the thoughts, attitudes, language and habits of his parents, and through them, of his group, by way of cultural transmission. Thirdly, culture is not only learnt and acquired by individuals in a social context, but it is also accumulated

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and transmitted from generation to generation, through the mechanism of symbolic communication or language.

Herskovits, an American anthropologist, has also identified certain characteristics of culture in his book *Man and His Works*. He argues that ***culture consists of man made part of the environment***, in other words, it is socially created. He states that culture is learned, thus implying that it is an acquired behaviour. He further argues that culture derives from the biological, environmental, psychological, and historical components of human experience. Culture is structured – it consists of organized patterns of thinking feeling and behaving. Culture is dynamic. Culture is variable, it is relative. Culture exhibits regularities that permit its analysis by the methods of science.

There is consensus among a large body of scholars that culture constitutes a structural unity, in that it's various elements or constituent parts are mutually inter-related and inter-dependent. Thus, it is possible, for the purpose of analysis and understanding to delineate the major components or divisions of culture. The major components of culture, which are universal in nature, can be summarized as follows: technology, economic organisation, social organisation, political organisation, ideology, arts and language. Technology refers to the system of tools, implements and artifacts, made and used by a people to meet their basis needs. Economic organisation includes the techniques which are employed by a people in organising the production and distribution of goods and services. Social organisation refers to the framework of social and inter-personal relations. Political organisation refers to the ways and methods of controlling conflict, and deals with the maintenance of the social order. Ideology includes a guiding set of beliefs, values and ideals. Arts include the forms which ensure the fulfilment of man's aesthetic urges. Language is the medium through which all the above operate.

Robert Bierstedt, in his book *The Social Order*, has classified the contents of culture into three categories, i.e. ***ideas***, ***norms*** and ***material***. In other words, the components of culture may be classified into three dimensions, i.e., cognitive, normative and material. Ideas refer to the cognitive dimension of culture which includes beliefs and knowledge. Cognition is the process that enables humans to comprehend and to relate to their surroundings. Thus, the first and the most important component of culture is idea, which consists of myth, superstitions,

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scientific facts, art and religion. The normative dimension is the second large component of culture. It includes rules, expectations and standardized procedures, in short, ways of behaving in almost all the situations that we confront and in which people participate. The normative dimension of culture is of critical importance in promoting recurrence and predictability in human interaction. Norms can be classified as folkways, mores, customs and laws, etc. which guide individual conduct.

The third major component of culture is the material culture, referring to what we have or possess as members of society. The culture provides knowledge, rules for organizing work and tools for human survival. Material culture refers mainly to basic conditions, which generally include material items that the members of a society have and use, and also to science, technology and instruments of production, transport and communication. Material cultural is often counter posed with non-material culture, under which the cognitive and normative dimensions of culture are classified, refers to intangible product of human creation. In simpler terms, culture may be divided into ***material*** and ***non-material culture***. Non-material culture (implying cognitive and normative dimension) consists of the words people use, the ideas, norms, customs, and beliefs they hold, and the habits they follow. Material culture consists of manufactured objects such as tools, furniture automobiles, buildings, roads, bridges, and, in fact any physical substance which has been changed and used by people. Such manufactured objects are called artifacts.

Culture is often confused with society, but the two words have different meanings. Whereas a culture is a system of norms and values, a society is a relatively independent, self-perpetuating human group which occupies a territory, shares a culture, and has most of its associations within this group. A society is an organization of people whose association are with one another. A culture is an organized system of norms and values which people hold. In other words, society may be perceived as a chain of social relations among groups of individuals who are held together by commonly shared institutions and processes. All processes of the human life-cycle are carried out and regulated in society. Thus, there is an integral reality of the individual, culture and society. All these are mutually inter-dependent, so that any one of them cannot be adequately understood without

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reference to the other. Culture depends for its existence and continuity on groups of individuals whose social relations form society.

Further, though man is generally defined as a social animal, but man's social nature is not particularly unique to him. A society can exist even at the sub-human level. Ants and bees, for example, have genuine societies. The chimpanzees in the wild live in their society much like human beings: they form stable relationships; they move about and hunt in groups. Culture exists only in human societies. In other words, there can be an animal society without culture. Consequently, what differentiates man qualitatively from other species of animals is not his social nature, but his culture. Man is essentially a cultural or symbolic animal. Man's capacity for symbolic communication or language sharply differentiates him from other animals. Language plays a crucial role in the process of enculturation, whereby the individual acquires and imbibes the value, beliefs, customs and habits of his society. Language facilitates the sharing and accumulation of experiences and skills; it is also instrumental in the transmission of cultural traditions from one generation to another. It is worth noting that while among the animals the basic needs are satisfied through the mechanism of instincts, wherever in man they are fulfilled and regulated through culture. Thus, in actual life, society and culture cannot be separated. Even though culture is a broader category, it cannot exist and function without society. Society, in other words, is a necessary pre-condition for culture. Similarly, neither society nor culture can exist independent of human beings.

Culture also needs to be distinguished from race. **Race** may be defined as a human population whose members share some hereditary biological characteristics which separate them from other groups. It must be noted that racial features are largely determined by genetic and biological factors, whereas cultures and language are learnt, acquired and transmitted through training and education. In this context it is worth highlighting the role of culture in determining the sex roles in society. In human societies, men and women differ not only in anatomical and physical features, but also in respect of behaviour, role and attitude. It is generally held that men and women behave differently because of their biological differences as nature has prescribed different roles and behaviour patterns for them. This is mistaken view. The differences between the roles and behaviour patterns of men and women, though related to certain anatomical and physical processes, are not

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entirely determined by them. Sex roles and traits, in other words, are not biologically given, they are conditioned by culture.

Margaret Mead, a distinguished American anthropologist, made a comparative study of the respective role of men and women in three primitive societies in New Guinea. She found that in each of these cultures, the sex roles were radically different from those of Western culture. For example, in the Tchambuli tribe, women are masculine and men feminine, in terms of Western cultural standards. Women are dominant, responsible and are engaged in aesthetic matters, and with being charming. Among the Arapesh, both men and women show feminine traits; they do not indulge in aggressive behaviour. Among the Mundugumor, both men and women exhibit masculine traits. Their behaviour reflects violence and aggressiveness. Mead, therefore, concluded the sex roles are culturally conditioned.

Another distinction of significance is that of culture and civilization. **Alfred Weber** is well known for his cultural sociology and the analysis of the distinction between the concepts of culture and civilization. Culture and civilization are closely related terms. **Civilization** refers to a historical phase of culture. A civilization is characterised by certain distinctive features, such as cities and urbanization, occupational specialisation, monumental structures such as temples, palaces and tombs, classes and hierarchies, and above all, the art of writing. For example, civilization emerged for the first time in human history as early as 4th millennium B.C. in ancient Mesopotamia. Some of the important points of difference between culture and civilization may be summarized as follows. Firstly, civilization has precise standard of measurement, but not culture. Secondly, civilization is always advancing, but not culture. Civilization is unilinear and cumulative and tends to advance indefinitely. Cultural on the other hand, advances slowly and is often subject to retrogression. In contemporary scenario, rise in religious fundamentalism in some societies can be cited as an example of this. Thirdly, civilization is borrowed without change or loss, but not culture. Further, civilization is external and mechanical while culture is internal and organic. In this context **MacIver** appropriately remarks, *"Civilization is what we have, culture is what we are"*.

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Some of the key concepts and terms related to culture have been described in detail in the following section:

Real and ideal culture: The ideal culture includes the formally approved folkways and mores which people are supposed to follow (the cultural norms); the real culture consists of those which they actually practice. In most societies some behaviour patterns are generally condemned yet widely practiced. In some places these illicit behaviour patterns have existed for centuries side by side with the cultural norms which are supposed to outlaw them. **Malinowski** cites as an example of this type of behaviour among ***Trobriand Islanders***, a group whose incest taboos extend to third and fourth cousins. Similarly, selling cigarettes and other tobacco products to children may be banned and declared illegal as a norm but yet widely practiced in reality.

Diffusion: The process by which culture traits or complexes spread from one society to another or one part of a society to another.

Acculturation: The modification of the culture of a group or an individual through contact with one or more other cultures and the acquiring or exchanging of culture traits. In other words, it refers to the process whereby an individual or a group acquires the cultural characteristics of another through direct contact and interaction. From an individual point of view this is a process of social learning. From a social point of view acculturation implies the diffusion of particular values, techniques and institutions and their modification under different conditions. It may give rise to culture conflict and to adaptation leading to a modification of group identity. Some scholars defined acculturation as 'those phenomena which result when groups of individuals having different cultures come into first hand contact, with subsequent change in the original cultural patterns of both groups.

[A note on distinction between diffusion and acculturation: Diffusion generally refers to the spread of specific cultural traits or elements, whereas acculturation refers to the changes brought about in whole cultures. When groups of individuals, having different cultural traditions, come into contact, changes take place in their original cultural patterns. This is referred to as acculturation or culture contact. Diffusion on the other hand, refers to the spread of cultural traits and patterns from major centres of civilization to smaller cultures and occasionally the other way

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round. Some scholars argue that when culture traits or complexes have been diffused we talk about diffusion, but when a whole way of life is in process of change under the influence of another culture we call it acculturation. The processes of acculturation and diffusion have been going on in human society since very ancient times. Thus as far back as the third millennium B.C. we find trade and cultural relations between the Mesopotamian civilization and the Indus civilization. An interesting illustration of the diffusion of cultural traits is provided by the mathematical symbol of zero. The zero was invented, along with the system of numerals, for the first time in India. This system of numerals was adopted by the Arabs during the 5th century. The Arabs, in turn, transmitted the Indian system of numerals to Europe. Similarly, paper, gun powder, compass, etc. were invented in China which later spread through the Muslim world from Samarkand and reached Europe.]

Culture shock: The often rather severe psychological and social maladjustment many individuals experience when they visit or live in a society different from their own. Culture shock involves bewilderment due to new customs, unknown expectations, a feeling of being conspicuous, "different," and foreign, and often a foreign language.

Ethnocentrism: An attitude of regarding one's own culture or group as inherently superior. The ethnocentric attitude judge the worth of other cultures in terms of its own cultural, and since other cultures are, of course, different, they are held to be inferior, Ethnocentrism reflects an inability to appreciate the viewpoint of others whose cultures have, for example, a different morality, religion, or language. The term was introduced by **William G. Summer** in his work *Folkways*. Ethnocentric view is seen as a threat to the inter-group solidarity and communal harmony in a complex society where diverse groups belonging to different-different cultural backgrounds live together. However, for an individual ethnocentrism may be appealing because it reaffirms the individual's "belongingness" to the group. It is also considered functional for intra-group solidarity. It is argued that ethnocentric groups seem to survive better than tolerant groups because ethnocentrism reinforces nationalism and patriotism. Without ethnocentrism, a vigorous national consciousness is probable impossible. Nationalism is but another level of group loyalty.

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Xenocentrism: This word means a preference for the foreign. It is exact opposite of ethnocentrism. It is the belief that our own products, styles, or ideas are necessarily inferior to those which originate else-where. For example, there are many occasions when people seem happy to pay more for imported goods on the assumption that anything from abroad is better.

Cultural relativism: Cultural relativism refers to the view that the values, ideas and behaviour patterns of a people are not to be evaluated and judged in terms of our own values and ideas but must be understood and appreciated in their cultural context. For example, premarital pregnancy is bad in our society, where the mores do not approve it and where there are no entirely comfortable arrangements for the care of illegitimate children. Premarital pregnancy is good in a society such as that of the Bontocs of the Philippines, who consider a woman more marriageable when her fertility has been established and who have a set of customs and values which make a secure place for the children. Similarly, adolescent girls in the United States are advised that they will improve their marital bargaining power by avoiding pregnancy until marriage, while adolescent girls in New Guinea are given the opposite advice, and in each setting the advice is probably correct.

Subculture: The culture of an identifiable segment of a society. A sub-culture is part of the total culture of society but it differs from the larger culture in certain respects-for example, in language, customs, values, or social norms. It is agreed that ethnic groups have subcultures, but writers also refer to the subcultures of occupations, adolescents, criminals, social classes, etc.

Contraculture: A subculture that stands in opposition to important aspects of the dominant culture of the society. The term was introduced by **J. Milton Yinger** to designate a particular type of subculture, in which certain values and social norms of the dominant culture are specifically rejected, and contrary values and norms deliberately accepted. In fact, the value and normative system of the contraculture can really by understood only in terms of its theme of opposition to the dominant culture. However, it should be remembered that a contraculture rejects some, but not all, of the norms of the dominant culture. For example, delinquency and drug addiction often have a contracultural aspect. The terms contraculture and counterculture are often used interchangeably in sociological literature.

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Culture lag: This concept was introduced by **William F. Ogburn**, who applied it especially to modern industrial societies in which the material culture, through rapid advances in technology and science, has developed at a much faster rate than that part of the non-material culture (ideas, values, norms, etc.) which regulates man's adjustment to the material culture. Cultural lag as a concept and theory was developed by Ogburn as part of a wider theory of technological evolutionism. It suggests that there is a gap between the technical development of a society and its moral and legal institutions. The failure of the latter to keep pace with the former in certain societies, is cited as the basic factor to explain (at least some) social conflict and problems.

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Scope of Sociology and its comparison with other social sciences

Sociology is the study of man's behaviour in groups, or of interaction among human beings. It seeks to understand the nature and purpose of human association; the manner in which the various kinds of association arise, develop, and change; and the beliefs and practices that characterize them. Thus sociology is a scientific study of society and a variety of interactions that unfold within and between individuals and groups.

The principal task of sociology is to obtain and interpret the facts regarding human association, not to solve social problems. Its ultimate aim, however, is to improve man's adjustment to life by developing objective knowledge concerning social phenomena which can be used to deal effectively with social problems. In this respect sociology bears the same relation to the solution of social problems as, say, biology and bacteriology bear to medicine, or mathematics and physics to engineering. Without the research done in the theoretical and experimental sciences, modern techniques for curing disease or those for bridge-building would be impossible. Similarly, without the investigations carried on by sociology and the other social sciences, no really effective social planning or lasting solutions to social problems would be possible.

Sociology has been defined in a number of ways by different sociologists. Lester Frank Ward and William Graham Sumner defined it simply as "the science of society," and Franklin Henry Giddings as "the science of social phenomena." Sociology has also been defined as "the science of institutions" (Durkheim) and as "the science of social organization and social change" (Kovalevsky). Others have conceived of sociology as the science that studies human relationships (Simmel), as the study of "social action" (Weber) or of "social processes" (Small), or as "the science of collective behaviour" (Park).

The subject matter of sociology is society itself rather than the individual. Most sociologists, however, regard the study of the individual as essential to an understanding of society. Although sociology deals with problems involving values, sentiments, and interests very close to man's heart, it endeavors to keep aloof, to refrain from passing judgment as to the goodness or badness of a thing, its propriety or impropriety, its desirability or undesirability. It is ethically neutral. Sociology takes this attitude because of the conviction, long accepted in all science, that the true nature of any phenomenon cannot be discovered or cannot be adequately understood (and, hence, that the problems connected with it cannot be effectively solved) if the investigator makes up his mind in advance about the subject being investigated. In other words, it the investigator has predilections, he will tend to see the phenomenon or problem not as it actually is, but rather as he

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wishes it to be. Only an objective study can reveal the real nature and purpose of the phenomenon. Because of the lack of an objective approach many erroneous conclusions regarding social phenomena have been made. Of course, it is impossible to achieve complete objectivity in anything, particularly when dealing with human values, but a large measure of it can be attained with the proper effort and training.

In order to arrive at a complete, rounded picture of man, the sociologist is often obliged to draw upon findings of biology, psychology, anthropology, geography, and history. Furthermore, since man's social life cannot be divorced from his economic and political activities, the sociologist has to utilize the data made available by economics and political science. This dependence upon other discipline might give one the impression that sociology is a kind of parasite, living off the efforts of other sciences. As a matter of fact, these contributing sciences (particularly psychology, economics, and political science) are just as dependent, if not more so, upon the data and conclusions of sociology, for their special problems cannot be fully or satisfactorily understood apart from the more general social aspects of life with which sociology is chiefly concerned.

Sociology includes within its scope all of man's behaviour which may be called social. Since many different phases of social life have to be studied, the science of sociology can be subdivided into specialized areas of inquiry, each of which may employ techniques of its own. This subdivision was inevitable since no individual could possibly become expert in every phase of this ramified subject. The specialized areas of inquiry include such problems, phases of social life, and institutional forms as the origin and nature of human group life; the pattern of man's spatial distribution and the factors determining it; institutions, such as the family, school, and church; the nature of group behaviour; the community; and social problems, such as poverty, crime and delinquency, vice, and physical and mental disease. Then, too, since no science can exist and develop without cultivating a philosophy and methodology of its own, some sociologists devote their main attention to the philosophical and methodological aspects of the science.

Sociology is divided into several major fields. *Sociological Theory* analyzes principles, concepts, and generalizations of the science. *Historical Sociology* studies societies of the remote as well as of the recent past to discover origins of, and find explanations for, our present ways of life. *The Family* considers the origin, evolution, and function of this institution, the forms it has assumed in various periods of history and in different societies, as well as the contemporary problems connected with it. *Human Ecology and Demography* investigate the spatial distribution of human groupings (primarily communities and neighborhoods), their relationship to one another, and the forces determining their

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distribution and relationship, and also analyze population changes and movements. *The Community* (a field closely allied with and dependent upon ecology and demography) analyzes the organization and problems of both rural and urban types of communities. Since the problems of city and country are in many respects quite distinct, this field of study is subdivided into *Rural and Urban Sociology.*

Sociology of Religion studies the church as a social institution, inquiring into its origin, development, and forms, as well as into changes in its structure and function. *Educational Sociology* studies the objectives of the school as a social institution, its curricular and extracurricular activities, and its relationship to the community and its other institutions. *Political Sociology* studies the social implications of various types of political movements and ideologies and the origin, development, and functions of the government and the state. *Sociology of Law* concerns itself with formalized social control, or with the processes whereby members of a group achieve uniformity in their behaviour through the rules and regulations imposed upon them by society. It inquires into the factors that bring about the formation of regulatory systems, as well as into the reasons for their adequacies and inadequacies as a means of control. *Social Psychology* seeks to understand human motivation and behaviour as they are determined by society and its values. It studies the socialization process of the individual, i.e., how he becomes a member of society; it also studies the public, the crowd, the mob, and various other social groupings and movements. Analysis of mass persuasion, or propaganda, and or public opinion has been one of its major interests. *Social Psychiatry* deals with the relationships between social and personal disorganization, its general hypothesis being that society, through its excessive and conflicting demands upon the individual, is to a large extent responsible for personal maladjustments, such as various types of mental disorder and antisocial behaviour. In its applied aspects it is concerned with remedying this situation.

Social Disorganization deals with the problems of maladjustment and malfunctioning, including problems of crime and delinquency, poverty and dependency, population movements, physical and mental disease, and vice and prostitution. Of these subdivisions, crime and delinquency have received perhaps the greatest attention and have developed into the distinct field of *Criminology*. *Group Relations* is concerned with studying the problems arising out of the coexistence in a community of diverse racial and ethnic groups.

Although the foregoing are the main divisions of sociology, new areas and subareas are evolved as the problems coming within the scope of this science are explored more thoroughly and systematically, and as new techniques are devised and developed for dealing with them, Thus, in addition to the areas listed above, there are a number of others such as *Cultural Sociology, Folk Sociology,*

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Sociology of Art, Industrial Sociology, Medical Sociology, Military Sociology, Sociology of Small Groups, and such special topics as social stratification, mass media of communication, public opinion, and bureaucracy.

Sociology, therefore, is the study of social life as a whole. It has a wide range of concerns and interests. It seeks to provide classifications and forms of social relationships, institutions and associations, relating to economic, political, moral, religious and social aspects of human life.

Sociology has a long past but only a short history. Since the dawn of civilization, society has been a subject for speculation and inquiry, along with every other phenomenon that has agitated the restless and inquisitive mind of man. There is warrant, indeed, for saying that *The Republic of Plato* is the greatest of all sociological treatises in the West, and the *Analects* of Confucius in the East. But it is only within the last hundred years that the study of society has become a separate subject and a separate science.

All inquires were once a part of philosophy, that great mother of the sciences (*mater scientiarum*), and philosophy embraced them all in an undifferentiated and amorphous fashion. One by one, however, with the growth of Western civilization, the various sciences cut the apron strings, as it were, and began to pursue separate and independent courses. Astronomy and physics were among the first to break away, and were followed thereafter by chemistry, biology and geology. In the nineteenth century two new sciences appeared: psychology, or the science of human behaviour; and sociology, or the science of human society. Thus what had once been natural philosophy became the science of physics; what had been mental philosophy or the philosophy of mind, became the science of psychology; and what had once been social philosophy, or the philosophy of history, became the science of sociology. To the ancient mother, philosophy, still belong several important kinds of inquiry – notably metaphysics, epistemology, logic, ethics, and aesthetics – but the sciences themselves are no longer studied as subdivisions of philosophy.

Sociology as a science, and particularly as a separate field of study, did not make its appearance until about the middle of the nineteenth century. Emerging like other sciences, however, it was preceded by a series of attempts to explain human relations and behaviour, few, if any, of which could be strictly called scientific. "Social thought" existed, of course, in ancient times and thereafter, consisting now and then of systematic thinking and analysis, but based primarily upon speculation. In fact, this effort to understand the nature of social life may be regarded as having prepared the ground for the development of sociology as the scientific study of society. Perhaps the earliest attempts at systematic thought regarding social life, at least as far as Western civilization is concerned, may be

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said to have begun with the ancient Greek philosophers, particularly the great masters of human thought, **Plato** (427-347 B.C.) and **Aristotle** (384-322 B.C.). But their efforts were little more than profound reflections. This was inevitable, as their method of investigation consisted primarily of logical deduction. Now, logic is an indispensable tool, to be sure, in all orderly thinking, but in itself it is not a means of arriving at scientific truth, at an understanding of reality. Consequently, the labourious investigations of many of ancient sages resulted in blueprints, so to speak, of an ideal state, a Utopia where unruffled peace and justice prevail. Aristotle showed a more realistic but, in the main, he succeeded only in drawing up the prerequisites, arrived at mainly through the syllogistic process, of the ideal social order. Moreover, the ideal social order which these two thinkers described was mainly an idealization of the society in which they lived.

Social thought of this prescientific kind, with few exceptions, advanced very little between the time of Plato and Aristotle and early modern times. The works that could lay claim to any systematic social thought at all during and immediately preceding the Middle Ages reflected the teachings of the Church and were for the most part metaphysical speculations regarding the place of man on earth. In any case, none of the thinkers associated with those eras thought of themselves, and few are now thought of, as sociologists. However, there was one exception as discussed by George Ritzer in his book *Sociological Theory*. This refers to one **Abdel Rahman Ibn-Khaldun** (1332-1406), born in Tunis, North Africa. He challenged the divine theory of kingship. In his book '*Muqadimma*', he presented his ideas which are quite similar to the present day sociology. For example, he was committed to the scientific study of society, empirical research, and the search for causes of social phenomena. He devoted considerable attention to various social institutions (for example, politics, economy, etc.) and their interrelationships. He stressed the importance of linking sociological thought and historical thought.

However, barring this one exception, it was not until the sixteenth century that there appeared writers who treated life's problems on a more realistic level. Perhaps the most notable among these was the Italian **Niccolo Machiavelli**, in whose work, *The Prince*, published in 1513, we find an attempt at an objective discussion of the state and statecraft. This book, unlike his other works, was devoted chiefly to an exposition of the principles governing the successful state, or rather the successful ruler of a state. It is a practical guide for the ruler who would maintain his power. Insofar as Machiavelli sought to base his theories of the state upon historical data, he may be considered in a sense an objective writer. Another author in this period worth noting was **Sir Thomas More**. Although his book *Utopia*, Published in 1515, represented an approach virtually the opposite of that found in Machiavelli's writings, it was nevertheless a step in the direction of dealing with everyday social problems, albeit by means of depicting an ideal social

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order which presumably was presented for emulation. More's *Utopia* pictured a perfect state where all the problems with which society, or rather the England of his day, was beset, have been solved and where complete justice reigns. This perfect society is made possible by putting into practice the rules of natural law. More's technique of presenting a picture of the ideal life as a way of pointing out what real life ought to be was utilized by several other writers among them Thomasso Campanella, in his *City of the Sun*, Sir Francis Bacon, in his *New Atlantis*, and James Harrington, in his *Commonwealth* of *Oceana*.

Considerable strides toward the objective analysis of social forces were made in the writings of the Italian **Vico** and the Frenchman **Montesquieu**, who, while primarily political philosophers, had considerable influence upon the consequent rise of a science of society. Giovanni Battista Vico in his book *The New Science,* contended that society was subject to definite laws which can be discovered through objective observation and study. Charles Louis de Secondat Montesquieu exerted an even greater influence than Vico in the direction of scientific investigation of social phenomena through his brilliant works, particularly his *Esprit des lois (The Spirit of Laws),* which presents a keen analysis of the role certain external factors, especially climate, play in the life of human societies. To these two writers may be added two more, **Condorcet** and **Saint-Simon**, whose contributions toward the development of a science of society were even more direct. In his *Historical Sketch of the Progress of the Human Mind,* Marie Jean Antonie Condorcet formulated a theory of social change which had a far-reaching influence upon later sociological theories. In this book he propounded a stage theory of social evolution, according to which civilization passed through ten developmental stages, each higher than the preceding one, the highest still to be attained in the future. Claude Henri Comte de Saint-Simon, though primarily a utopian reformer, insisted that social reform can be achieved only when scientific or "positive" data have been collected. These four writers, although their contributions were primarily in the field of political thought and philosophy, may be considered among the forerunners of sociology.

It was in the nineteenth century that a French philosopher named **Auguste Comte** (1798-1857) worked out, in a series of books, a general approach to the study of society. He believed that the sciences follow one another in a definite and logical order and that all inquiry goes through certain stages, arriving finally at the last, or scientific, stage. He thought that it was time for inquiries into social problems and social phenomena to enter the last stage and so he recommended that the study of society become the science of society. The name that Comte gave to this new science was "sociology", and this, from a number of points of view, was an unfortunate choice. "Sociology" is composed of two words; *socius*, meaning companion or associate; and *logos*, meaning word. Thus, the term

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formed from these two parts means talking about society, as geology (*geos*, earth) means talking about the earth; biology (*bios*, life), talking about life; and anthropology (*anthropos*, man) talking about man. Unfortunately, however, *socius* is a Latin word and *logos* is a Greek word, and the name of our discipline is thus an "illegitimate" offspring of two languages. John Stuart Mill, another philosopher and social thinker of the nineteenth century, proposed the word "ethology" for some part of the new science. This term has the merit of being all Greek, but apparently it never appealed to other writers. When, in the latter half of the century, an Englishman, **Herbert Spencer** (1820-1903) developed his systematic study of society and frankly adopted the word "sociology" in the title of his work - on the ground that "the convenience and suggestiveness of our symbols are of more importance than the legitimacy of their derivation" – it became the permanent name of the new science, and sociology, especially with Spencer's own contributions, was well launched on its career.

Auguste Comte is traditionally considered to be the father of sociology. He is regarded as such not because of any significant contributions to the science, but rather because of the stimulating effect he had upon it. Comte is credited with the coining of the term "sociology" (in 1839) and with having defined the scope of this social science and the methods which it should employ. Judging him by his extensive work, we must regard him as a sociologist. Comte devoted his main efforts to an inquiry into the nature of human knowledge, a gigantic task which he performed with singular brilliance, seeking to classify all knowledge and to analyze the methods of achieving it. His major labours were directed toward determining the nature of human society and the laws and principles underlying its growth and development, as well as the methods to be employed in studying social phenomena. He saw the needs for the creation of a distinct science of society, which he at first called "social physics" and, later, "sociology," that should concern itself with an analysis and explanation of social phenomena.

Comte's chief work is his *Cours de philosophie positive (Positive Philosophy),* published in six volumes, during 1830-1842. It formulated his theory of the three stages through which human knowledge develops, namely, the Theological, the Metaphysical, and the Positive, or empirical. Comte maintained that only when this last stage has been reached is real science possible. In the Positive stage, objective observation is substituted for speculation and there is a concentration upon the discovery of causal relationships. Social phenomena, like physical phenomena, he asserted, can be studied objectively by employing the positive method. He thus blazed the trail for a science of society – for sociology.

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Sociology came into its own as an autonomous discipline with the appearance of the sociological works of the Englishman Herbert Spencer, who is considered one of the most brilliant intellects of modern times. He undertook to create what Comte had merely indicated as desirable – an all encompassing science of society. This resulted in a multivolume work, called *Synthetic Philosophy*, the chief sociological part of which is the *Principles of Sociology*. Spencer employed the inductive method in his study of social phenomena; he arrived at his conclusions after an examination and analysis of data based mainly upon what was then known of the life of primitive man. One of his most noteworthy theories was that social phenomena, or the "superorganic," as he termed them, like the organic, undergo an evolutionary process of growth from the simple and homogeneous to the complex and heterogeneous. Primitive man to him represented the simple human type from which civilized man evolved. Another significant contribution of his is the so-called *organic analogy*, in which society is compared with the human organism. Spencer was influenced by theory of evolution of his contemporary Charles Darwin, although to an extent he also anticipated it. Many of Spencer's theories had to be greatly modified or even abandoned in the course of the development of sociology, but the contributions of this pioneer can hardly be exaggerated.

In the next section, let us explore the relationship of sociology with other social sciences. As stated earlier, sociology is nothing but a scientific study of society. But, as we know that man's social life cannot be divorced from his economic and political activities, the sociologist has to utilize the data made available by economics, political science, history, psychology and other social science disciplines, in order to arrive at a comprehensive understanding of the social phenomena. Particularly with the rise of interdisciplinary approach and growing interdependency of these disciplines, it would be useful to have a look at the nature of these disciplines and their relationship with sociology.

Sociology and Anthropology:

Anthropology is a study of the biological and socio-cultural aspects of human beings. It is a scientific study of man in all its dimensions, both biological and socio-cultural. The branch of anthropology that studies the biological aspects of humankind is called physical or biological anthropology, while the study of social and cultural aspects is known as social anthropology. In the United States of America, this branch is, however, known as cultural anthropology. The third branch of anthropology is a study of languages in a comparative perspective. It is known as linguistic anthropology or anthropological linguistics. The branch of anthropology that studies the pre-historic past of mankind, before writing began, is

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called archaeological anthropology or pre-historic archaeology. Of the four branches of anthropology, sociology is most closely related to social anthropology.

It is often said that although sociology and social anthropology had quite different origins (the one in the philosophy of history, political thought, and the social survey, the other in physical anthropology and ultimately in biology) they are now practically indistinguishable. Sociology as a subject came into existence during the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century. Social anthropology had its beginnings as a discipline during the second half of the nineteenth century but it came to occupy a respectable place in the first half of the twentieth century. Initially, there was a period of extreme divergence when the functional approach was generally adopted in anthropology while sociology (at least in the European countries) continued to be historically oriented and concerned with problems of social development; and that finally, in recent years, there has been a new convergence of the two disciplines.

The division of labour that traditionally developed was that sociology concentrated on the study of complex, modern, and urban-industrial societies, whereas social anthropology studied tribal, peasant, and pre-literate societies of the world, those societies that were largely untouched by the forces of civilization. In the beginning, sociologists studied the societies which were their own, while anthropologists studied societies that were different from theirs. This was the reason why sociology came to be regarded as the study of one's own society, while anthropology earned the reputation of being the study of 'other cultures'. In other words, the broad differences between sociology and social anthropology that emerged during the period of divergence can easily be related to differences in the object of study. Social anthropologists, once field work had become a fundamental requirement, were involved in studying small societies, of a very different character from their own societies, relatively unchanging, and lacking historical records. The methods followed from these facts; such societies could be observed as functioning wholes, they could be described and analysed in ethically neutral terms since the anthropologist as an outsider was in no way involved in their values and strivings, and since they changed little and had no records of past changes, a historical approach was unnecessary and more or less impossible. The distinction between sociology and social anthropology could be applied without much problem where the different between the 'our' and 'their' societies, i.e. between 'civilized' and 'primitive' societies, was huge and perceptible. For example, it was the case in America, Australia, New Zealand, or Africa, where the native population was totally different from its white colonizers.

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However, due to forces of industrialization, urbanization and globalization, this situation has now radically altered. Many if not most primitive societies are changing under the influence of Western ideas and technology, larger groupings are beginning to predominate over tribal societies, and social and political movements are developing which involve the social anthropologist in the same kind of value problems which the sociologist has had to face in studying his own society, or societies of the same civilization. For example, both sociologist and anthropologists have to face the fact of revolutionary movements in the Third World. In brief, we can see that the object of study now is societies in the process of economic growth and social change, and thus an object for both the sociologist and the social anthropologist, who work increasingly in Africa and Asia upon the same kinds of problems. It should be added that as primitive societies, regarded as the preserve of the social anthropologist, have more or less disappeared, so to some extent the special prerogatives of the sociologist in studying advanced societies have been challenged. There is an increasing number of anthropological studies in advanced societies; studies of the 'little community', of kinship groups, etc. Sociology and social anthropology are still divided by differences of terminology, approach and method but there is both convergence and a desire to further it. With the passage of time, social anthropologists have included within their orbit of study to societies, such as urban and industrial, that were supposed to be studied by sociologists. It all happened because tribal societies were on their way to transformation because of urbanization and industrialization. At the same time, sociology has increased it scope to include tribal and peasant societies. The outcome of all this is that in so far as the subject matters of sociology and social anthropology are concerned, there is hardly any distinction.

We should also note that, among contemporary societies, there is a third very important category of those which are neither primitive nor industrially advanced. In such societies, of which India may be taken as an example, the distinction between sociology and social anthropology has little meaning. Sociological research in India, whether it is concerned with the caste system, village communities or the process of industrialization and its effects, is and should be carried out by sociologist and social anthropologists.

Because at one time, sociology and social anthropology specialized in the study of different types of societies, they contributed to the development of different theoretical interests. Sociologists have made significant contribution to survey methods of data collection, whereas anthropologists' contribution has been to fieldwork methodology. Anthropologists have contributed immensely to the understanding of kinship and religion, because these two have been institution of crucial importance in simple societies. To the understanding of social stratification, education, and urban-industrial society, the contribution of sociologists is

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unparalleled, because these institutions are of primary importance in modern societies. These specializations apart, there are more similarities between sociology and social anthropology than are between either of them and other social sciences. Both studied human society in a holistic manner, and attempted to generalize. Both were comparative in nature. In fact, a French sociologist Emile Durkheim called anthropology as 'comparative sociology'. Social anthropology was considered a branch of sociology, or better, as a 'sociology of primitive societies'.

Sociology and History:

Both, sociology and history are social science disciplines and both are concerned with human activities and events. The relationship between sociology and history is also connected with another question, whether sociology is a science of society, like one of the natural and biological science, or a kind of history writing (historiography). Sociologists of the nineteenth and early twentieth century thought that sociology was a 'natural science of society'. But later, the weaknesses of this view started surfacing, and sociologist felt that there was no doubt that their subject was social science.

History is a study of the past, which people have already lived. Data for historians come in the form of records from archives, museums, libraries, and personal collections of people. Historians of ancient times also study inscriptions. Historical data may not be complete. Some might have been destroyed, lost, stolen or inaccessible. Therefore, historians have to build up their interpretations of the past on the limitations of the material.

Sociologists must hold up the past to understand the present. What is common between sociology and history is the society. Sociology is concerned with the present and to some extent with future. History studies the past. The present society cannot be analyzed without reference to the past society; and it is here that these are related to each other. This has given rise to a special kind of sociology and history i.e. historical sociology. According to this, sociological analysis is based on historical data. This is primarily done by the use of primary sources available in archives or by the use of written history.

Historians are concerned with specific societies. They tell about the system that prevailed in a society at a particular time. Whatever comparisons historians make are of limited scale. They may compare societies inhabiting the same area, but vast comparisons of societies different in scale and time are beyond the scope of history. Therefore, historians rarely attempt to generalize about human society as a whole. They provide a detailed account of a specific social situation. By comparison, sociology is principally concerned with the study of contemporary

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societies. Sociologists not only refer to the historical data but they also generate their own data by studying various contemporary societies, for which the term 'primary data' is used. Primary data can be collected through various methods of sociological research such as, survey, questionnaire, interview, schedule, field work (including both participant and non-participant observation), focus group discussion, etc. As a result, collected data by sociologist are more comprehensive than the historian who has to content himself with whatever is available.

The essential difference between history and sociology is that the former is concerned with the past, the latter is mainly concerned with present day societies. While history does not concern itself with contemporary societies, sociology certainly extends its frontiers to include past societies in its scope. The other significant difference is that the historian interests himself in the particular character of events over a period of time. The sociologist is interested in the regular and the recurrent social phenomena; generally, we may say that history occupies itself with the differences in similar events and sociology deals with the similarities in different events. History seeks to establish the sequence in which events occur; it is the arrangement of social events in time. Sociologist is concerned with relationship between events occurring more or less at the same time. Historians generally restrict themselves to the study of the past, from the more recent to the remotest one. Sociologist shows interest in the contemporary scene or the recent past. Sociologist seeks to know the inter-relations between events with a view to propose causal sequences. The historian prides himself on the explicitness and concreteness of details. The sociologist abstracts from concrete reality; and then categorizes and generalizes about the observed phenomena.

To summarize we may say that while sociology is an observational, comparative, and generalizing science, history, on the other hand, is a particularizing or individualizing discipline. Sociology is an analytical disciplines where as history is a descriptive discipline. Sociology emphasizes on the regular and the recurrent where as history investigates the unique and the individual. An event that has occurred only once in the human past is of no sociological significance unless it can be related to a pattern of events that repeats itself generation after generation, historical period after historical period and human group after human group.

Sociology and Political Science:

Political science is also known as the 'science of government' or the 'science of polity or politics'. Political science studies political institutions such as the state, government, political parties, executive, legislative and judicial institutions. Political science also studies behaviour of the people in power. Thus,

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the concept of power is important. Political science can be defined as a study of power. Power is the ability of a person or a group to control or influence the behaviour of others despite their resistance. 'Authority' refers to the power that is legitimized and institutionalized in a society. This form of power is attached to a social status and is accepted as proper and legitimate by all members of the society.

Sociology also studies power in terms of its social contexts. In other words, the processes which enable a man or a group to wield power and exercise dominance in society - are the focal points of study in sociology. Thus, the stratification of society in terms of power by different groups, castes, classes and tribal groups becomes the basis of sociological analysis. The interface of political science and sociology can be termed as political sociology. Political sociology, in fact, acts as a bridge between political science and sociology.

Political science generally studies the complex, advanced, and modern societies; in other words, those societies that have the machinery of state and written law. It is concerned with larger systems, i.e. whole societies and their political states. Sociology studies all types of societies, irrespective of whether they happen to be classified as 'tribal', 'peasant', or 'urban-industrial'. It is comparative in nature. It also gives information about the distribution of power in those societies (tribal and peasant) that political scientists do not study. For instance, sociologists and social anthropologists also study those societies that were without the institution of state. They were called the stateless societies. One of the outstanding examples of which was the Nuer of the Sudan. Anthropologists described how in stateless societies order was maintained. The absence of state does not imply the absence of deviance and conflict. Each society has its own procedures to handle the cases of the breakdown or rules and customs. Sociology supplements the understanding of political scientists by providing information about the mechanisms of social control in simple societies.

Sociology is devoted to the study of social aspects of society, whereas political science restricts itself mainly to the study of power as embodied in formal organizations. Sociology stresses upon the inter-relations between institutions such as state, government, political parties, whereas as political science focuses its attention on the governmental processes. Nevertheless, political sociology has for long shared with political science, many of the common interests and a very similar style. If we look at the relationship between political science and sociology in India, the study of caste and the role it plays in electoral politics would give useful insights. How caste becomes an interest group and an instrument of mobilization? This has brought sociology close to political science in particular.

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Sociology and Economics:

Economics studies the aspects of production, distribution and exchange, and consumption in society. It begins with the observation that resources are scarce and limited whereas human needs are unlimited. Hence, there is a need to strike a balance between limited resources and unlimited needs and wants. The strategy human beings adopt is to make the best use to the resources available with them, and at the same time, put a check on one's needs. The process of striking a balance between the two, resources and needs, is called economization, and the science of economics studies this.

Today, economics is regarded as the most developed of all social science. It has been able to develop both the traditions of qualitative and quantitative research. One of the branches of economics is called econometry, which is concerned with a quantitative assessment of economic phenomena. Compared to the other social sciences, including psychology, modem economics is highly mathematical.

Thus, the economist concentrates on the study of economic behaviour of the people, while the sociologist is interested in the study of sociology of economic life, such as income, occupation, consumption patterns and styles of life etc. The sociologist critically examines the limitations of economic theory and makes contribution to the study of economic phenomena.

Economics concentrate upon the study of economic systems in modern, complex, and urban-industrial societies. Economics looks at modern economic institutions (finance, banking, market) in a comparative perspective, aiming to arrive at general propositions. Although it recognizes the role of social factors (such as kinship, religion, values) in influencing economic behaviour of man, it considers them as essentially 'irrational', which tend to slow, or even retard the growth of economy. It asserts that for developing economy, one has to take rational decisions because they will lead to gains and profits. Each economic system is based on the principle to the maximization of gains and returns. Thus, economics is primarily concerned with the relationship between demands and supply in a society, the rational use of resources for fulfilling one's needs and the issues of economic development.

However, for sociologist, economic institution is one of the several institutions of human society. He examines the functioning of the economic institution in relationship with other institutions of society such as social, political, religious and cultural institutions. The contribution that social factors make to economics is examined in detail in sociology. Sociologists submit that social factors exercise a tremendous impact on the decisions people make with respect to

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resources, their use and distribution. The factors that seem irrational to economists are in fact, quite meaningful from the perspective of people. From their studies in tribal and peasant societies, sociologists have confirmed this point. In many societies, people indulge in what is called 'wasteful expenditure' but this is done knowingly to enhance one's prestige and honour.

Sociologists look at the social aspects of economy. In this term, their work is different from that of the economist, who is mainly concerned with the economic consequences of people's actions. For instance, Adam Smith, a foremost economist, explained that division of labour in society came when there was need to have mass production. Adam Smith argued that if there had to be more production, division in society had to come. Thus, for him the division of labour in the society was required for mass production. Division of labour brings about differentiation and social ranking in terms of differential wages and rewards. However, eminent sociologist Emile Durkheim took a different view on division of labour. He argued that transformation of mechanical (simple) society into organic (complex) society was not for large scale production but it was a need of the society itself. Increased population, differentiated needs and rules and regulations necessitate division of labour.

Economic and sociology have a two-way relationship in general. There is much give and take between the two. For instance, anthologists have described the exchange theory in terms of marriage relations drawing from the property system. The origin of caste has also been analyzed in terms of economic division of labour reflected through *jajmani* system. Thus, the relations between economic and sociology are deep rooted.

Sociology and Psychology:

Sociology is the scientific study of modern society. It studies the behaviour of people in groups. In other words, it takes a macro level perspective in its study of behaviour. Psychology, on the other hand, takes a micro level perspective and studies the individual behaviour. The intimate interaction between sociology and psychology has given birth to a hybrid discipline 'social psychology', which studies the behaviour of the people in group settings but the focus is always on the individual.

The individual and society are the two main concepts in social sciences. Society is defined as an enduring set of relations between persons. It is an aggregation of individuals, which is different from a crowd. Each individual of a society has its own identity, autonomy, and mental makeup. This would explain why there is a variation between the behaviours of two individuals belonging to

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the same society. The knowledge about how one should behave comes from society. The individual internalizes this knowledge and behaves accordingly. However, while putting this knowledge into action, the individual introduces the element of variation. Even when it is the same kind of situation, each individual will behave differently.

The discipline that focuses upon the individual is known as psychology. It studies the mental structure of the individual, his memory, intelligence, deep-rooted complexes and psychological problems, etc. In other words, psychology tries to understand why an individual behaves in the manner he does. It studies psychic (or mental) facts. It addition to a qualitative assessment, psychology makes a lot of use of quantitative techniques, for it measures phenomena is precise terms. For understanding certain psychological phenomena, knowledge of the human biological system is also required. Thus, psychology pays a lot of attention to the understanding of human body, especially the nervous system.

The branch of psychology that studies the behaviour of people in a situation of crowd or mob is called social psychology. Crowd behaviour is often called collective behaviour, which is the subject matter of psychology, and is distinguished from behaviour that takes place in enduring groups and institutions (such as neighbourhood, family). The latter is called social behaviour, the study of which is the subject matter of sociology. Social psychology lies in between sociology and psychology.

If psychology is the study of psychic facts, the facts that pertain to the mental structure of the individual, sociology is the study of social facts. An example will clarify the distinction between sociology between and psychology. Suppose, a law court is in session, and the accused, lawyers, and judges are discussing the case. The rules according to which they would decide the case are of interest to sociologists. The rights and duties of each of the members involved in the judicial process are also of sociological interest. In short, sociologists are interested in the totality of the judicial process. But, of interest to psychologists is what goes in the minds of people engaged in the court proceedings. That is the reason why sociologists make a distinction between social and psychic facts, the former are studied by sociologists and the latter, by psychologists.

Here, we should note that the concepts of status and role, link the disciplines of psychology and sociology. Status is usually defined as the rank or position of a person in a group, or of a group in relation to other group. Role is the behaviour expected of one who holds a particular status. However, Theodore M. Newcomb made a distinction between the expected behaviour (prescribed role) related to a position or status and the actual behaviour (role behaviour). He pointed out that the

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way in which a person behaves may not always be what is expected of him. That is to say, sometimes a person's actual behaviour may not conform to his expected role. Newcomb regards 'prescribed role' as a sociological concept and 'role behaviour' as a psychological concept. Thus, the concepts of status and role link society with individual, and in turn, they establish a link between sociology and psychology.

Sociology and Philosophy:

Philosophy, in literal sense, implies enquiry or search for knowledge about life and the universe. Sociology originated largely in a philosophical ambition; to account for the course of human history, to explain the social crisis of the European nineteenth century, and to provide a social doctrine which would guide social policy. In its recent development sociology has for the most part abandoned such aims; and some would say that it has abandoned them too completely. However this may be, there remain connections between sociology and philosophy in at least three respects. First, there can be, and is, a philosophy of sociology in the sense of philosophy of science; that is, an examination of the methods, concepts, and arguments used in sociology. And this philosophical scrutiny is more common and more needful in sociology than in, for example, the natural sciences, because of the peculiar difficulties experienced with sociological concepts and reasoning. Secondly, there is a close relationship between sociology and moral and social philosophy. The subject matter of sociology is human social behaviour, which is directed by values as well as by impulses and interests. Thus the sociologist studies values and human valuations, as facts. But he should also have some acquaintance with the discussion of values, in their own context, in moral and social philosophy. Only by some training in social philosophy can the sociologist become competent to distinguish the different issues, and at the same time to see their relationships to each other. Thirdly, it may be held that sociology leads on directly to philosophical thought. All that is intended here is to suggest that sociology raises, to a greater extent than other social sciences, philosophical problems, and consequently that the sociologist who is at all concerned with the larger aspects of his subject is led on to consider philosophical issues which are always in the background of sociological reflection. It is not, in my view, at all harmful to sociological theory or research that the sociologist should interest himself in such problems and should seek to acquire a philosophical education which will equip him to deal with them, for much of the weakness of sociological theory is due to philosophical naivete, and much of its triviality comes from disregard of the larger issues involved in any study of man. The vigour and the stimulating character of early Marxism in the field of social research was due in large measure to the fact that Marxism was not only a sociological theory but a philosophical world view and a revolutionary doctrine.

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Sociology and Social Work:

The relation between sociology and social work is like the relation between a 'pure science' and an 'applied science'. Social work is concerned with the 'technology of application' of ideas for improving human lot. Social work is essentially an American interest. It grew out of a concern for human welfare. In the early twentieth century, it was realized that social scientists were mainly concerned with acquiring knowledge about the working of society and leading a philosophical dialogue on it. The question of the ideal society also figured. But which technology should be adopted for building it up was not given a serious thought. As changes were taking place in the society of the twentieth century, the gap between the poor and the rich was fast increasing. Groups of people who were leading the life of a destitute were also emerging. Against this background, the central question was how to improve upon the condition of people. Knowledge was of no significance unless it was put to use. Social work was a product of this background. It charted out the suitable technology for human upliftment. But, for any type of action, it is essential to have a complete knowledge of the social situation, and sociology provided such knowledge. Therefore, social work is dependent upon sociological insights. Sociology generates holistic knowledge about society. It also discusses the possibility of applying this knowledge. The branch of sociology that takes up the areas of application is called applied sociology. Between sociology and social work lies applied sociology. Let us now understand the difference between social work and applied sociology. The latter is an attempt to explore the areas where sociological knowledge may be put to use, but sociologists themselves do not carry out the action. What should be the nature of action and how it should be carried out are the areas that interest sociologists. Social workers, on the other hand, not only plan action but they also carry it out. Therefore, social work, truly speaking, is an applied area; it is the 'technology of action'.

Thus, being a social science, sociology shares a wide variety of commonality with other social sciences. This commonality is because of the fact that in order to build a theoretical framework for the society, man has to be studied in totality. The commonalities are in terms of data and method but there are differences also in the approach of study and in the perspectives adopted for study. Sociology has many similarities with other social sciences. It is concerned with history, economics and political science as it studies the bearing of the present on the past, political and economic aspects of social life. Sociology also studies the impact of historical events, state, government and economy on social life of the people. Despite this two-way relationship, sociology has its distinct nature and scope of study.

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Sociology and Common Sense

To many people, sociology appears to be a labourious study of the obvious, an expensive way to discover what everybody already knows. To these people, sociology is merely common sense. But sociology is more than common sense because it is based largely on scientific evidence. Often ideas or beliefs derived from common sense turn out to be false, contradicted by facts from sociological research.

Sociological findings such as those that contradict commonly held myths may surprise you. Of course, not every finding in sociology is surprising. In fact, some confirm what you have known all along. You should not be surprised, therefore, to learn from sociology that there is more joblessness among Blacks than among Whites or that there are more poor people than rich people in prison. But many other commonsense ideas have turned out to be false. By systematically checking commonsense ideas against reliable facts, sociology can tell us which popular beliefs are myths and which are realities. For thousands of years, people's common sense told them that the earth was flat, that big objects fell faster than small ones, and that character was revealed in facial features; yet today we know none of these is true. Today, science is replacing common sense as a source of dependable knowledge.

When we do not know where our ideas come from or that they are based on, we sometimes call them "common sense". If we call them common sense, we do not have to prove they are true, for then others will join us in the collective self-deception of assuming they have already been proved. If one presses for proof, one is told that the idea has been proved by experience. The term "common sense" puts a respectable front on all sorts of ideas for which there is no systematic body of evidence that can be cited. What often passes for common sense consists of a group's accumulation of collective guesses, hunches, and haphazard trial-and-error learnings. Many common sense propositions are sound, earthy, useful bits of knowledge. "A soft answer turneth away wrath", and "birds of a feather flock together", are practical observations on social life. But many common-sense conclusions are based on ignorance, prejudice, and mistaken interpretation. When medieval Europeans noticed that feverish patients were free of lice while most healthy people were lousy, they made the common sense conclusion that lice would cure fever and therefore sprinkled lice over feverish patients. You may have heard the encouraging message that "Absence makes the heart grow fonder," but you may still remember the discouraging warning "Out of sight, out of mind". When facing such conflicting commonsense ideas, how can we tell which are correct and which are false? We can get the answer from sociological research. It has shown, for example, that the effect of one person's absence on another depends

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on the strength of the initial relationship. If two people have loved each other deeply, like Romeo and Juliet, absence will make their hearts grow fonder, but a high school romance tends to disintegrate because such relationships are usually not deep or serious enough to begin with. Common sense thus preserves both folk wisdom and folk non-sense, and to sort out one from the other is a task for science.

Only within the past two or three hundred years has the scientific method become a common way of seeking answers about the natural world. Science has become a source of knowledge about our *social* world even more recently; yet in the brief period since we began to use the scientific method, we have learned more about our world than had been learned in the preceding ten thousand years. The spectacular explosion of knowledge in the modern world parallels our use of the scientific method. You will learn more about scientific method in the section 'Science, scientific method and critique.'

In sum, it is not true that sociology is only common sense. If it were, we wouldn't bother to study sociology. Why would we spend our time learning something we already know? Common sense requires only a willingness to believe what it tells us. It cannot tell us whether those beliefs have any basis in fact. But sociology can. This is one of the reasons that sociology is exciting. It enables us to see that what has long been familiar - or just common sense - may turn out to be unfamiliar or uncommon. While common sense gives us familiar and untested ideas, sociology offers factually supported ideas as well as the excitement of discovering something new about ourselves.

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Dear Candidate, after completing a given topic and preparing your notes in pointer form, you must attempt questions asked so far in previous years and get them evaluated. As I have discussed before, what really counts here is how you are articulating the learned knowledge in the given Time and Word Limit. Always remember that Civil Services Examination is not about information, it is more about analysis. So, you must practice by writing more and more answers and getting them periodically evaluated.

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about faculty

Dear Candidate, our faculty is highly qualified and experienced, both in Civil Services Examination as well as in academics.
(formerly associated with University of Delhi and Vajiram and Ravi)

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about Civil Services as a career

Dear Candidate, before I introduce you to this work I would like to share a few things with you. As you know Civil Services Examination is considered to be one of the toughest examinations. But I believe that there is no such thing as EASY or DIFFICULT per se because I feel that it is our thinking that makes it so. Therefore, if you begin your journey to IAS with a positive attitude that **'YES, I CAN DO IT'**, then trust me your journey would become not only a pleasant and enjoyful learning experience but also far more easier than otherwise. Further, before you decide to take Civil Services Examination or any other examination, make sure that your decision is well thought of. For that, firstly, you must take time and introspect and see whether your aptitude and interest matches with the career that you are planning to choose. Since it is the most important step for anyone, any amount of time spent on this is worth.

Secondly, whatever decision you take must be your own independent decision and must be taken with the conviction that whatever may be the outcome you will never regret having taken such decision. Thirdly, one must also make a comparative analysis of the requirements or the level of preparation that an examination demands and the ability or level of preparation one actually has. This is important because it will not only help you in placing the examination in right perspective but also enable you to set realistic expectations from yourself. It will go a long way in guarding you from negative thoughts often arising out of self-doubts during the course of preparation. Thus, saving you both, time as well as energy.

Last, but not the least, I would like to caution those students who go on a shopping spree collecting study material from various coaching institutes during the course of their preparation for this examination. I wish to make it clear that this examination does not require too much of content. Rather, on the basis of my personal experience as well as that of toppers, I can confidently say that ***this examination is less about content and more about analysis, both comparative as well as contemporary***.

That's why in light of the changing pattern of the Civil Services Examination, I always suggest my students to:

Read Adequately * Think Logically * Write Relevantly

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how to prepare Sociology

Dear Candidate, given the **Limited Time** that you have and the **Infinite Syllabus** that you have to prepare for the Civil Services Examination, it becomes very important to manage your time wisely and utilize your energy efficiently. It becomes all the more important in light of the fierce competition that you face ahead. Here, I recall a line from the book *You Can Win* by Shiv Khera, that,

"Winners don't do different things, they do things differently".

Now, I would like to brief you about how our approach is different from the rest, and also the best, for preparing Sociology optional for the Civil Services Examination.

Firstly and foremostly, you must understand that no matter how many sleepless nights you may spend preparing for this examination, ultimately, it is only those 3 hours (at the examination hall during the Mains (Written) Examination) that are going to decide your fate. So it is very important for the candidates to prepare their subject strictly in an **Exam Oriented** manner. What is important here is not how much you have studied for the exam but how much you would be able to write at the time of the exam? So, what is important here is not to master the subject in all its possible details but rather, one should prepare the subject strictly in a professional manner keeping in mind the demands for 'conceptual clarity', 'analytical reasoning' and 'correct writing expression' as set forth by Union Public Service Commission. Only then one can hope to cover the syllabus for this exam in a time-bound manner with better chances of success. This you would realize step-by-step as you move along these notes and with vital inputs from my side at regular intervals.

Secondly, one must follow a **Theme-Based Approach** instead of Topic-Based Approach, whereby one should identify the major theme that underlies a given topic and runs through several other related sub-topics. Particularly, in light of the revised syllabus and the changing orientation of the Civil Services Examination, it has become all the more important to adopt theme-based approach because many a times questions are also asked on topics which are not mentioned in the syllabus. Though at the outset such questions may appear to be out of syllabus to the candidate but actually they are not. Questions on such topics are basically of implied nature and thus very much a part of the major theme that underlie the mentioned topic. So by following a theme-based approach we can

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cover not only the topics that are mentioned in the syllabus but also those which are implied in nature.

Thus, following a theme-based approach you would not only realize the depth of understanding that is expected from candidates at this examination but also it would keep you focused throughout your preparation. Please note that the theme-based approach would help you develop **Mental Framework** of the entire syllabus. Further, once you are confident that you have understood the broader dimensions of the theme then it would also resist your temptation to collect more and more material on the same topic. Thus, saving you both time as well as energy. You will learn this art as we proceed with the syllabus.

So, when I say **Read Relevantly**, I simply imply that given the limitations of time and energy, one should focus only on the important themes that underlie a given topic. Otherwise, given the vastness of the syllabus it would be impossible to do justice with all the topics mentioned in the syllabus in a time span of 3-4 months. Students must understand that just any information on the topic mentioned in the syllabus may not be equally important from the examination point of view. Hence we have to exercise selectivity.

To **Think Logically** implies that you must correlate your arguments in a logical manner. This will happen only if you have a thorough grasp of the concepts. So, **Conceptual Understanding** and **Conceptual Interlinking** both are very important. But equally important is its practical application in the contemporary scenario. So, whatever concepts or theories you study in the syllabus, you must also try to relate them with the contemporary society and changes therein. Please remember that conceptual clarity and its practical application is equally important at the Interview stage as well, as you may be asked to define or explain any sociological concept and to contextualize it in the light of contemporary developments, both in national and international arena.

Write Relevantly is the most critical stage of all. As I mentioned in the beginning that no matter how much you might have studied and what all sources you might have referred, ultimately it is your answer sheet that determines your destiny. Thus, your written answer must be a perfect blend of *conceptual clarity*, *conceptual interlinking* and *sociological language*. More importantly, such an answer needs to be produced on paper within the Time-and-Word Limit.

Dear Candidate, ultimately, you get only those 3 hours to convince the examiner that how dedicated you are about Civil Services and what importance does it carry in your life. So, with our **Dialectical Approach** (see page. 48) to answer writing we will make sure that all your efforts and sacrifices made

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during the course of preparation for this exam find a reflection in our answers. So along with working hard **(Hard Work)**, we also need to work smartly **(Smart Work)**. As you would proceed with the chapters you would be guided about note-making and answer-writing. Please follow the instructions sincerely.

Thank You



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Dear Candidate, after years of experience gained while preparing for this exam as well as in academics, I can say with firm conviction that this exam requires only **one and a half year** of dedicated and focused preparation. Generally those who take more time than this are the ones who either do not have the right guidance or realize the significance of these crucial aspects when it is already too late. In my view, an intensive but focused study of 3-4 months is more than sufficient to prepare Sociology optional for the civil services exam. I would also like to say that with regular answer-writing practice, a sincere candidate can easily score 250-300 marks, particularly in the new format of the Sociology Paper. I am sure that with these notes and with this approach you will start your preparations with an edge over other candidates. How far and how well you carry this advantage would largely depend upon the consistency and sincerity of your effort. Hence I request you to go through these notes step by step and follow the instructions sincerely.

all the best

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a word of caution

Dear Candidate, you just need to sincerely follow the topic-specific instructions that would be provided during the course. You will never find yourself alone while preparing this subject because I will always be there beside you with some useful tips and vital inputs. If at any stage you need some clarification, you can freely contact me on phone, email, or Facebook.

Now, you need to give at least three readings to the entire syllabus. But, these readings need to be done in a proper and professional manner. Remember, your aim is to qualify Civil Services Examination, not to master the subject. If you keep this thing in mind, I assure you that you will never waste even a single minute on unnecessary pursuits for collecting unnecessary and irrelevant material available in the market. In order to qualify this examination, all you need to do is that you must focus upon understanding the principle arguments related to the mentioned topic in the syllabus and develop you own understanding out of it. This is what I had already mentioned that conceptual clarity combined with its practical application in our daily life is the key to your success in Civil Services Examination.

As far as these three readings are concerned, I want to you to follow a very simple approach. In your first reading, just read these notes as a story. In your second reading, please underline, mark or highlight the important points and attempt the **Notes-Making Assignment** and **Writing-Skill Assignment** with a pencil. It is only in your third reading that you will refer to the suggested readings (that too only selectively), that I have mentioned wherever necessary and attempt the test given at the end of each topic in **Test Yourself** section. Please make sure that you get each and every test evaluated so that I can suggest you the corrective course of action before it is too late.

Just do this and see the difference in your preparation. You will not only be able to complete the entire syllabus in the shortest possible time but that too with conceptual clarity and good writing skills.

Wish you all the best

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Oath

- I believe that **Life** is the most beautiful gift bestowed upon us by **Mother Nature**. Mother Nature has blessed us all with Life so that we live happily and spread happiness all around. Mother Nature has empowered us all with its supreme divine power to realize our dreams. It is entirely up to us how we take care of our lives and what we make of it. We must respect Life and Mother Nature.

- I believe that there is no substitute for **Hard Work** and there is no shortcut to success. Those who tend to opt for shortcuts, their march to success is often cut short.

- I will place highest value on time and will try my best for its optimum utilization. I believe that **Time Management** is the key to success.

- I will set **Realistic Goals** and will make my best effort to achieve them.

- I believe that no success is final and no failure is fatal. It is the **Courage** to continue that counts.

- I will never, never, never, **Never Give Up**.

- I will adhere to the **Six Ethics of Life:**

Before you Pray	-	Believe
Before you Speak	-	Listen
Before you Spend	-	Earn
Before you Write	-	Think
Before you Quit	-	Try
Before you Die	-	Live

- I will be **Honest** and **Truthful** in my daily life.

- I will abide by the **Discipline**, code of conduct, terms and conditions of my institute.

(signature)

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Dear Candidate, I am also enclosing two sheets, one for your **Monthly Schedule** and another for your **Weekly Schedule** to facilitate better Time Management. You can get these sheets printed and photocopied and with regular practice you can yourself evaluate your performance.

Rule: While recording the numbers of hours in your Weekly Schedule, make sure that you deduct half an hour from each of your sitting. For example, if in one sitting you have studied for 2 hours, then, record only one and a half hours in the Weekly Schedule. If in the next sitting, you have studied for 3 hours, then, record two and a half hours only.

Dear Candidate, by following this method, you can tentatively arrive at the amount of qualitative time you are devoting to your preparations for the Civil Services Examination. By following this method, if any sincere candidate is devoting 8-10 hours per day on a regular basis, he is doing justice with his time, labour and above all, his aim.

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1. Sociology – The Discipline
Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology
Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
Sociology and common sense

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Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology

Instructions: Dear Candidate, in this topic the examiner is primarily interested in testing your overall understanding about the process of transformation that took place in Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth century. Further, he is interested to know that why this process of transformation, which included large-scale social, economic and political changes, is associated with the idea of modernity or why this transformation came to be identified as modernization. Last, but not the least, he wants to know that how the prevailing social conditions of those times created the need for a new discipline and how the intellectual conditions of those times contributed to the emergence of Sociology as a distinct discipline.

Theme: *Process of modernization in Europe (in the eighteenth and nineteenth century) and its impact on the emergence of sociology.*

Related Concepts: Feudalism, Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Industrial Revolution, Enlightenment, French Revolution and Modernity.

Important: Dear Candidate, I have discussed this topic in detail here only to facilitate your thorough understanding and command over related concepts. But while writing an answer in the examination it would not be possible for you to incorporate each and every detail mentioned here. Hence, I suggest you to exercise selectivity in picking up only the relevant content as per the demand of the question. Given the Time and Word Limit in the examination, you will be able to write a concise and precise answer only if you remain focused on the theme.

My advice to you here is to understand and focus on the theme rather than the topic. I believe that given the changing pattern and focus of the Civil Services Examination, the topic-based approach is an outdated one because it leaves the candidate with a fragmented knowledge. While, on the other hand, a theme-based approach would help the candidate to interlink the concepts more easily. Thus, it would not only give the candidate a comprehensive understanding of the subject but also help him perform well both at the written as well as the interview stage of the examination.

To facilitate your better understanding and to enable you to interlink the concepts, these notes have been written in a continuing series of interlinked concepts and theories.

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Modernity has often been viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition. If tradition looked to the past, modernity presumably turned its eye to the future. Modern culture is frequently associated, as Swedish social theorist Goran Therborn (1995) notes, "with words like progress, advance, development, emancipation, liberation, growth, accumulation and enlightenment". One might add to this the idea that modernism is often depicted as an expansive, and thus global, phenomenon. The association with these terms suggests that modern culture possesses an optimistic orientation about our ability to collectively resolve problems, to remedy human suffering, and to enrich social life. It presupposes our ability to acquire knowledge of both the natural and the social worlds and to use this knowledge to beneficially control and mold these worlds. As Wagner (2008) sees it, "modernity is associated with the open horizon of the future, with unending progress towards a better human condition brought about by a radically novel and unique institutional arrangement". Historians as well as social theorists generally agree that from the fourteenth century to the sixteenth century A.D., Europe had been witnessing changes in its political, social and economic structures, which marked the beginning of what we call the modern period.

Before proceeding further with our discussion on modernity, we must understand that if modernity is viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition, then what was tradition like? In other words, what were the features of society of medieval Europe? [Note: Medieval period, also sometimes called as Middle Ages, roughly refers to the period from A.D. 600 to about A.D. 1500]

Society of medieval Europe (before fourteenth century) was largely feudal in character. Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Western Europe from tenth to fifteenth century. It had emerged on account of downfall and decentralization of Roman Empire and absence of any central authority. The word 'feudal' comes from *feud* which originally meant a *fief* or land held on condition or service. In a feudal society, land was the source of the power. Thus, feudal system was based on allocation of land in return for service.

Feudalism was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. The fiefs may further be subdivided by a vassal among other knights who would then be his vassals. Such fiefs consisted of one or more *manors*, that is, *estates* with serfs whose agricultural production provided the economic basis for the existence of the feudal class. When receiving a fief a vassal took an oath of homage and fealty (fidelity) to his lord and owed him loyalty as well as a specified amount of military service. Upon the death of a vassal the fief would technically revert to the overlord, but it was a common practice for

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the eldest son to take his father's place as vassal of the lord, and thus, in effect, fiefs were passed on through primogeniture.

Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. The feudal estates of medieval Europe had three important characteristics. Firstly, estates were legally defined. In other words, each estate had a status, in the precise sense of a legal complex of rights and duties, of privileges and obligations. The differences between estates can also be seen in the different penalties imposed for similar offences. Secondly, the estates represented a broad division of labour, and were regarded in the contemporary literature as having definite functions. 'The nobility were ordained to defend all, the clergy to pray for all, and the commons to provide food for all.' Thirdly, the feudal estates also acted as political groups.

Thus, the feudal society in Europe was a hierarchical and graded organization in which every person was allotted a position. At the top stood the king. He bestowed fiefs or estates on a number of lords who were known as dukes and earls. These lords in turn distributed a part of their fiefs among a number of lesser lords who were called barons and, in return, secured their military support. Thus the dukes and earls were the king's vassals, that is to say, they owed allegiance directly to the king. The barons were the vassals of the dukes and earls. The knights formed the lowest category of feudal lords. Usually they were the vassals of barons for whom they performed military service. Knights did not have any vassals of their own. Every feudal lord was expected to pay homage to his overlord and could then be in vested with some formal rights. Every feudal lord, except the knight, was first a vassal and then an overlord with a number of vassals under him. The relationship from top to bottom was one of allegiance. No vassal owned any land; he only held the land as of his overlord. The vassal was in every way his lord's man. He recognized no other authority than of his overlord. In time of need, for example, when the kind fought a war, he could demand military assistance from his vassals, these vassals - the dukes and the earls - demanded the same assistance from their vassals, the barons, and the barons from their vassals, the knights. Every feudal lord contributed a detachment of warriors, and thus a fighting army would be formed.

Feudal life, as explained in the previous section, was based on agriculture. The village farm was the *manor*, the size of which varied from place to place. Its centre was the manor house of the lord where he lived or which he visited, for the lords often possessed several manors. The manor included a large farm which supported all those who worked on it, a pasture area where the manor cattle grazed,

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and common woods which supplied fuel and timber. A manor always had a number of cottages where the common people lived, some workshops to provide for manor needs, and a chapel. *Manorialism* was an essential element of feudal society. It was a system of land tenure and the organizing principle of rural economy. It was characterized by the vesting of legal and economic power in a lord, supported economically from his own direct landholding and from the obligatory contributions of a legally subject part of the peasant population under his jurisdiction. These obligations could be payable in several ways, in labour, in kind or in coin, etc. *Manor* was the lowest unit of territorial organization in the feudal system in Europe. It may also be referred as the land tenure unit under manorialism. Country people often lived on a manor. On a manor there was a village, church, lord's house or castle, and the farmland upon which the people worked.

Please note that the Roman Catholic Church was as powerful an institution as feudalism in western Europe during medieval times. At the head of the Church was the Pope, who was accepted as the vicar of Christ. Popes were often stronger than the kings and could force them to obey their orders. Christianity taught that man's life on earth was not the end of existence, and that he should give up pleasures in this life in order to have a life of the spirit after death. Many Christian monks - St. Francis, St. Benedict, St. Augustine - laid great stress on purity, resistance to temptation and the pursuit of 'goodness'. Some people withdrew from worldly life and led a life of virtue and penance. Some men became monks and took the vows of obedience, poverty and chastity. Some women became nuns and lived in nunneries. The institutions where the monks lived together were called monasteries. This may remind you of the Budddhist *bhikshus* and their *viharas*. Life in monastery was well organized. Monks and nuns had to observe rigid rules of discipline. They could not marry or own property. They either worked or prayed. The slightest disobedience brought hard punishment. Some monasteries, like those funded by St. Benedict, were centres of learning and assured the members a well-ordered life. Through their strict rules of discipline, they trained groups who by their example and preaching, sought to uplift the moral life of the people, educate the laity and tend the sick. Gradually, however corruption crept into the monasteries. They acquired land and amassed wealth, helping to make the Church one of the biggest land-owners in medieval times. With cultivation and other work done by serfs, the life of many monks and nuns was no longer frugal and austere. Luxury, good food and drink, and idleness became common. Some great leaders sought to reform this state of affairs by introducing a new religious order - that of wandering monks. Members of this order had no homes but moved among the people, living on charity and setting an example of a life of chastity and self-sacrifice.

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During the early Middle Ages, Churches were the only centres of education and learning. The kinds of schools to which parents sent their children, when the Greek and Roman civilizations were still flourishing, had disappeared. The education that churches could provide was like a drop in the ocean. For a long time, monks and priests were the only literate men in Europe. Learning was kept alive by the Church and the monks in the monasteries. However, the learning fostered by the Church was a narrow type. Subjects that it taught were grammar, logic, arithmetic and theology. The only calling for which this education was suitable was that of a monk or a priest. The language of learning was Latin, which only churchmen could read. Everything was dominated by faith and anybody who appealed to reason against dogma was punished. Science had come to standstill. Magic and superstition held the day. Belief in witches was common and the punishment for witches was to burn them alive.

However, by the end of the Middle Ages (fourteenth century onwards), some changes started taking place in European societies which marked the decline of feudal system.

The revival of trade (discussed later under 'commercial revolution') was accompanied by the growth of towns. Old towns became larger and many new towns emerged, mainly as centres of manufacture and trade. Towns, often walled, gradually freed themselves from feudal control. They had their own governments and the townsmen elected their officials. They had their own militia and their own courts. Unlike the serfs, there were no restrictions on their movements. They could come and go as they pleased and buy and sell property. Towns provided asylum to serfs who escaped from feudal oppression. The towns encouraged the cultivation of cash crops needed for manufactures, and peasants received their payments in money. The peasants could now pay their dues to the lord in cash rather than by labour.

With the growth of trade, there was increasing use of money. Money had little use in feudal societies. A feudal manor was more or less self-sufficient for its needs. There was very little of buying and selling and whatever there was, was done through barter. The use of money indicated far-reaching changes in economy. In feudal societies, the indictor of a man's wealth was land. Some people had wealth, particularly the Church and sometimes the nobles, in the form of gold and silver, but it was idle wealth. It could not be used to make more wealth. With the growth of trade and manufactures, this changed, marking the beginning of the transition from feudal economy to capitalist economy in which wealth is used to make a profit. This is done by investing money in business, in trade and industry. The profits made are re-invested to make further profits. Such wealth or money is called 'capital'. Money, not the landed property, increasingly became the measure

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of man's wealth. In feudal societies, there were three classes of people: the prayers, that is, the clergy who prayed, the soldiers or the knights who fought, and workers or the peasants who worked for both the prayers and the soldiers. With the growth of trade a new class emerged - the 'middle class' - comprising mainly the merchants. Even though small in number, they began to play an important role in society because of the wealth they possessed. This early phase of capitalism is known as 'mercantile capitalism'. Thus mercantile capitalism is a system of trading for profit, typically in commodities produced by non-capitalist production methods.

Simultaneous with these developments changes took place in the system of manufacturing goods. In the early medieval period, most of the non-agricultural products required by the peasants were produced in the household of the peasant and by serfs, who were skilled craftsmen, for the lord. With the growth of towns, many of these activities shifted to towns where people skilled in particular crafts organized themselves into 'guilds'. Each craft guild had master craftsmen, journeyman and apprentices. To learn a craft, a person joined a master as an apprentice or learner. After having learned the craft, he worked as a journeyman with the master on a wage or, if he had mastered the craft, he would himself become a master craftsman. The units of production were small, consisting of three or four people, and each unit had a shop to sell its produce. There were no inequalities within a unit or between units of the same guild. The guild system, was not suited to the requirements of large scale production required by an expanding market for goods, and the system began to decline. Inequities appeared with the system, with masters refusing to let journeymen become masters and paying them low wages. With the introduction of 'the putting out system', their independence declined. The merchant, under this system, would bring the master craftsmen the raw materials, the craftsmen would work with their tools as before in their homes and the produce would be taken away by the merchant who had supplied them with raw materials. Thus, in effect, unlike before, the craftsmen did not own what they produced. They were increasingly reduced to the position of wage-earners, except that they still owned the tools used by them and worked at home.

Subsequently, this system gave way to the factory system (discussed later under 'industrial revolution') under which the production was carried out in a building owned by the capitalist with the help of machines also owned by him. The workers, owing nothing, worked only for wages. In industries, such as mining and metal-working, the new system came into being early. The period saw tremendous expansion of manufactures. This was accompanied by a growing differentiation in towns and the emergence of working class.

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As a result of these developments, the feudal system broke down. The towns which were free from the control of the lords began to undermine the stability of the feudal society. In course of time, towns became very prosperous. Kings who were quite powerless in the feudal system began to take the help and support of townsmen to increase their power and to enforce their will over the lords. The kings also started having their own armies and thus freed themselves from their earlier dependence on the lords for soldiers. This led to the emergence of strong nation-states. Thus, feudalism began to decline although it was finally ended in most countries only in the 18th and 19th centuries. In its place, a new system of society (Capitalist Society) began to emerge.

However, feudalism served its purpose of bringing a measure of orderliness, safety and security to medieval life. It allowed social and economic activity to run its normal course. But feudalism had also another side to it. It developed, and was dependent on, a rigid class system. Man was divided from man, class from class, and this stood in the way of political unity. The nobles looked down upon the common man, and their inherited authority brought with it one-man rule and oppression. The lords were often too powerful for the kings to control and fought among themselves for small selfish ends. The king had no contact with the common man, who was left entirely to the mercy of his lord, and the lord was usually irresponsible and unmindful of the welfare of common people. The feudal system also led to economic stagnation. The wealth produced by the peasants and the artisans was wastefully consumed by the feudal lords, in luxurious living and in wars. Individual enterprise and initiative were all but unknown. Further, the desire for the new lands and riches encouraged the lords and leaders of the Church to fight the 'holy wars', or the Crusades.

The medieval period, lasting roughly from fifth through the thirteenth centuries A.D. have often been called the "Dark Ages" and to some extent it was truly so. The helplessness of the common man, the arbitrary rule of the king and the barons and the absence of national unity were some of the aspects of the darker side of those times. Education was very uncommon and people led a miserable life. The prevailing European view of the "Dark Ages" was that civilization had stagnated. Not only were scientific and artistic advances rare, but much of the knowledge of the classical period was lost. Cultural activities came to an end with the arrival of invading "barbarians", and the western Roman Empire disintegrated into thousands of isolated villages where there was little interest in, or time for, study. Memory of the classical period faded except in a few sequestered monasteries, where ancient texts were stored and in the Islamic world, where scholars translated Greek texts into Arabic. During the "Dark Ages" the overwhelming majority of Europeans were crude illiterates, and even educated

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people knew less about science, medicine, and art than their counterparts in the classical period.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Please note that in the notes-making assignment you have to identify only those points which constitute the central theme of the given topic. To gain an edge over other candidates, you need to continuously enrich your notes with vital but relevant inputs. For this you may also include here some recent data, case studies or examples. For this you may refer newspapers (*The Hindu*, *The Times of India*, *The Indian Express*), magazines (*Yojana*, *Kurushetra*, *Frontline*, *The Economic and Political Weekly*, *Mainstream*) and government publications (*India Year Book*, *The Economic Survey*, *The Census of India*) etc.

Please take this exercise seriously because you would need to refer these self-made notes only just a couple of days before exam. So, be as brief and precise as possible. The first exercise is done for you to help you understand the approach as well as the methodology better.

Identify five important features of feudal society (only in the form of Pointers).

- Dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe
- Based upon a system of land tenure (King → Dukes and Earls→ Barons → Knights → Peasants)
- Characterized by estate system of stratification (Clergy, Nobility and Commoners)
- Largely subsistent economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority
- Started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres (Commercial Revolution)

2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Now, once you have made your notes on the given topic in the pointers form, it is time to practice writing short notes so as to sharpen your answer-writing skills. Dear Candidate, I repeat that no matter for how many hours or years you may have studied but ultimately it is only those 3 hours in the examination hall that would decide your fate. Hence I always suggest my students to continuously monitor their

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progress in writing-skills by regularly writing answers and getting it evaluated by me.

The first exercise is done for you.

Write a short note on feudalism. (100-120 words)

Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe. It was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies whereby one section or estate was distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. Feudal society was largely subsistent and stagnant economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority. However, feudal social order started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres in western European societies. (Total Words: 126)

3. For Interview

Questions may be asked on the following to test your conceptual clarity and grasp of the subject.

Feudalism * Estate system of stratification * Manorialism * Factors responsible for the decline of feudalism * Karl Marx on feudalism

However, fourteenth century onwards the society in Europe started changing. A number of interrelated developments took place in the period from about fourteenth to seventeenth century which marked the beginning of modern age.

Anthony Giddens also states in *The Consequences of Modernity* (1990) that modernity refers to 'modes of social life or organization which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards and which subsequently became more or less worldwide in their influence'. According to Giddens, modernity represents a sharp qualitative break from previous traditional social orders.

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Let us first understand that what were these changes which took place from about fourteenth to seventeenth century in Europe and marked the beginning of modern age? How the new social order which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards was qualitatively different from the previous traditional social orders.

Historians generally agree that from fourteenth to sixteenth centuries, Europe had been witnessing changes in its social, economic and political structures, which marked the beginning of the modern period. In the next section, we will learn about the various social, economic and political changes that Europe witnessed in the form of Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Enlightenment, Industrial Revolution, French Revolution, etc.

One of the first developments that marked the beginning of a new era was the *Renaissance*. The medieval Dark Age was followed by the Renaissance, coming in the fourteenth century and lasting to the end of the sixteenth century. The Renaissance refers, in a literal sense, to the intellectual rebirth of Europe as people tried to recapture the artistic, philosophical, scientific, and commercial glory of the 'classical period'. It is important to emphasize that the conventional nineteenth-century assessment was that the Renaissance had been a period of rediscovery. There was a great appreciation for the cultural accomplishments of the Greeks and Romans and a genuine desire to replicate those accomplishments and, hence, to recapture the cultural glory of earlier times. [Please note that the "Classical Period" of Western history, the era of Greece and, later, Rome, lasted roughly from the eighth century B.C. until the fourth century A.D. Many note-worthy scientific and artistic advances were made during that period. To name just a few: geometry was developed; money came into circulation; trade expanded; accounting practices emerged; shipbuilding improved; the Phoenician alphabet was made more precise with the inclusion of vowels; literature was born; comedies and tragedies were written; amphitheaters were constructed; great philosophical debates raged; engineers achieved wondrous feats (literally, the "wonders of the ancient world"); monuments were built; medicine advanced; libraries were constructed; elements of democratic governmental forms came into being; and education expanded. In short, civilization flowered. Advances were intermittent, to be sure, but over time the total stock of knowledge increased and diffused widely to other parts of the world. At least it was the nineteenth-century European view that the classical period of the Greeks and Romans marked such a flowering of civilization.]

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The term 'Renaissance' literally means rebirth and is, in a narrow sense, used to describe the revival of interest in the learning of the classical civilizations of Greece and Rome. This revival first began in Italy when a number of scholars from Constantinople migrated to Italy and a number of Italian scholars went to Constantinople and other cities of the old Byzantine empire in search of Greek classics. The Renaissance emerged in Italy roughly between A.D. 1300 and A.D. 1550 and then spread to northern Europe during the first half of the 16th century. The renaissance started in Italy because of several factors. First, Italy always had a cultural advantage over the rest of Europe because its geography made it the natural gateway between the East and the West. Venice, Genoa, Milan, Pisa and Florence traded uninterruptedly with the Asian countries and maintained a vibrant urban society. The Italian cities had grown up in an atmosphere of freedom from feudal control. Freedom encouraged thinking and a spirit of adventure. The rulers of the Italian states were patrons of learning and the arts.

During the 13th and the 14th centuries, mercantile cities expanded to become powerful city states dominating the political and economic life of the surrounding countryside. Italian aristocrats customarily lived in urban centres rather than in rural castles unlike their counterparts in northern Europe and consequently became fully involved in urban public affairs. The neo-rich mercantile communities which came to be known as the *bourgeoisie* tried to gain the status of aristocracy. Merchant families tried to imitate an aristocratic life-style. Their wealth and profession became an important factor for the development of education in Italy. There was not only a demand for education for the development of skills in reading and accountancy, necessary to become successful merchants, but also the richest and most prominent families looked for able teachers who would impart to their offspring the knowledge and skills necessary to argue well in the public arena. Consequently Italy produced a large number of educators, many of whom not only taught students but also demonstrated their learning in the production of political and ethical treaties and works of literature.

Another reason, why the late medieval Italy became the birthplace of an intellectual and artistic renaissance, was because it had a far greater sense of rapport with the classical past than any other region of Europe. In Italy the classical past appeared immensely relevant as ancient Roman monuments were present all over the peninsula and the ancient Latin literature referred to cities and sites that Italians recognized as their own. Further, Italian renaissance was also facilitated by the patronage that it received in abundance. The wealthy cities of Italy vied with each other to construct splendid public monuments and support writers whose role was to glorify the urban republic in their writing and speeches. As a result, hundreds of classical writings, unknown to Europeans for centuries, were circulating first in Italy and then other parts of Europe. The interest in classical

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learning and in other achievements of the civilizations of Greece and Rome deeply influenced Europeans. The Renaissance, however, was not, as mentioned earlier, a mere revival of ancient learning and knowledge of the achievements of ancient Greece and Rome. It was marked by a series of new developments in the field of art, literature, religion, philosophy, science and politics.

The early phase of Renaissance was described as a period of revival as it concentrated in reviving the old learning which was disseminated through the traditional methods. The latter phase was described as a period of innovation as much new knowledge was generated during this period, which laid the foundation for the growth of modern thought. This new knowledge was spread by a new medium, i.e print. This meant that a large number of people and countries could share the knowledge and debate the changes. Though, the study of classical and Christian antiquity existed before the renaissance, there was a significant difference between the learning of the middle age scholars and the renaissance thinkers. The renaissance thinkers recovered the works of lesser-known scholars and made them popular along side the more famous ones. The Greek scientific and the philosophical treatises were made available to the westerners in Latin translations. The renaissance thinkers used classical texts in new ways such as to reconsider their preconceived notions and alter their mode of expression.

So, rational thinking tempered with a spirit of scientific enquiry about the universe and the existence of humanity in it, became the important characteristic of the renaissance outlook. These rational ideas also helped in developing a society that was increasingly non-ecclesiastical in comparison to the culture of the Middle ages. The intellectual and cultural life of Europe for centuries had been dominated by the Catholic Church. The renaissance undermined this domination. The revival of pre-Christian classical learning and of interest in the cultural achievements of ancient Greece and Rome were, in themselves, also an important factor in undermining the domination of the Church.

The chief characteristic of the Renaissance way of thinking was *humanism*. It was the heart and soul of the Renaissance. Basically, it meant a decisive shift in concern for human as distinct from divine matters. Humanism was a system of views which extolled man, stressed his essential worth and dignity, expressed deep faith in his tremendous creative potential, and proclaimed freedom of the individual and inalienable rights of the individual. It was centered on the man of flesh and blood with all his earthly joys and sorrows, opposed to religious asceticism and defended his right to pleasure and the satisfaction of earthly desires and requirements. It meant the glorification of the human and natural as opposed to the divine and other-worldly. The humanists rejected and even ridiculed religious asceticism, mortification of the flesh and withdrawal from the world. They urged

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man to seek joy on this earth rather than in an afterlife which the Church advocated. Their works were permeated with the faith that a man with an active mind and body was capable of knowing and controlling the world, of performing miracles and fashioning his own happiness. The proper study of Mankind, it was asserted, is Man, Humanity rather than Divinity. The Renaissance men, hungered after more knowledge. They came to feel that human life is important, that man is worthy of study and respect, that there should be efforts to improve life on this earth. Because of this interest in human affairs, the study of literature and history became major areas of study. Literature and history came to be called the 'humanities' which were primarily concerned with understanding the affairs of man in his earthly life, not with life after death.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main characteristics of Renaissance. (only Pointers)

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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

'Renaissance marked a qualitative shift in the history of western European society'. Discuss. (150 words)

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3. For Interview

Renaissance	*	Factors responsible for its origin in Italy

Another development which marked the beginning of the modern age was the 'commercial revolution', fostered by a series of 'voyages of discovery'. The "Commercial revolution" refers to the expansion of trade and commerce that took place from the 15th century onwards. It was of such a large scale and organized manner that it is called a Revolution. The Commercial revolution signaled a shift from the largely subsistence and stagnant economy of medieval Europe to a more dynamic and world wide system. This expansion was as a result of the initiative taken by certain European countries to develop and consolidate their economic and political power. These countries were Portugal, Spain, Holland and England.

The same spirit of curiosity that led some of Europe's Renaissance men to effect new developments in art, literature, science, and religion led others to adventure and the discovery of new lands. The main motivation behind these adventures was the profits that trade with the East would bring. Earlier, Europe trade with the Oriental or Eastern countries like India and China was transacted by land routes. The northern Italian cities of Venice and Genoa were the major centres of trade. The result of the Italian monopoly was that the prices of goods like spices and silks imported form the East was extremely high. For example, after his first voyage to India, Vasco Da Gama found that the price of pepper in Calicut was one-

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twenty sixth of the price prevailing in Venice. The prosperity of the Italian cities that had grown rich from their trade with eastern countries aroused the envy of the other European nations; they longed to have a share in the trade.

But after 1453, the Turks cut off this trade through Asia Minor and if the Europeans were to continue to have spices, these products had to be brought by a different route. Finding new routes was a challenge to the adventurous sailors of the Renaissance. Thus, a shift from land routes to sea-routes began. Helped by some remarkable inventions, daring sailors sailed for distant lands. Invention of mariner's compass, astrolabe and newly prepared maps and guidebooks greatly facilitated these voyages. With the help of the compass, navigators determined the directions on high seas. The Astrolabe helped in determining the latitude of a particular area. These voyages were financed by rulers and merchants who sponsored the costly voyages of the sea-farers for the profits that the voyages would bring. The discoveries of the sea-farers extended the knowledge about the world and the old maps which were both inaccurate and incomplete had to be redrawn.

The voyages and discoveries of Columbus, Vasco da Gama and Magellan changed man's idea of the world, revolutionized trade and started waves of colonization that have determined the course of world history ever since. Portugal and Spain were among the first Europe countries, which financed these explorations and discoveries. Britain, France and Holland soon followed Spain and Portugal. Soon parts of Asia, Africa, Malacca, the Spice Islands, West Indies, N. America and S. America came under the control of Spain, Portugal, Britain, France and Holland. Commerce expanded into a world enterprise. The monopoly of the Italian cities was destroyed. European markets were flooded with new commodities; spice & textiles from the East, tobacco from N. America, Cocoa, Chocolate & quinine from S. America, ivory and, above all, human slaves from Africa. With the discovery of Americas, the range of trade widened. Formerly, the items sought for were spices and cloth, but later, gold and silver were added to the list. As the commercial revolution progressed, the position of Portugal and Spain declined. Britain, France and Holland came to dominate Europe and the world. This marked the early phase of capitalism known as 'mercantile capitalism'. It was characterized by growth of trade and commerce and generating profits through trade.

Subsequently, this accumulated wealth or capital was further reinvested in land & agriculture (scientific farming and sheep-rearing) to generate further profits. This led to the transformation of agriculture in Europe, called as 'agricultural revolution'. The agrarian revolution saw the transformation of a system of subsistence into a system of surplus by production of cash crops for the

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market, the surplus being made possible by reformed and mechanized cultivation. So, mercantile capitalism was followed by the capitalistic transformation of agriculture or agrarian capitalism. The first sign of capitalistic transformation of agriculture manifested itself in England in the form of land enclosures which began to occur in the rural economy as early as 1560, when landholders began to assert rights of private property over feudal land. It has been called by the historians as Enclosure Movement. Essentially, the enclosure movement can be described as a system whereby tenant holdings in feudal land and agriculture became enclosed and made available for the private use of landholder. As, a result peasant families were evicted from their holdings and in many cases thrown off the land. While many of the first enclosures were initiated by landlords in order to appropriate tenant holdings, in latter stages of change they were used to make way for sheep pastures. However, by 1710 the first Enclosure Bill appeared which legalized the enclosure of tenant holdings by Parliamentary Acts. With parliamentary approval, enclosures could proceed at a more advanced rate and eventually became commonplace by mid century as conversions became more rapid. By 1800, 4000 Parliamentary Acts had been passed and in excess of six million acres of land had been enclosed.

As the pace of economic change began to intensify, the rate of enclosures accelerated to the point where the displaced population of agricultural workers began to increase dramatically and this began to mobilize a transfer of the population to the centers of industry. As statutory enactments gave the power of eviction to landlords, legal proceedings multiplied the rate of local evictions and at the same time restricted the use of pastures from domestic animals, prohibited the use of arable land from tenant agriculture, and displaced agricultural workers and hereditary tenants. In practice, enclosures became a society-wide depopulation movement fueled by mass evictions and foreclosures which coercively separated peasants from their means of livelihood by removing them from their own agricultural holdings. As serfs were forced off the land, landlords were able to assert rights of modern private property over land to which they previously held only feudal title. This hastened the transformation of land into a commercial commodity, first by subjecting it to buying and selling, and second by extending its capacity to produce money rent. Under these circumstances, customary rights and obligations in land began to be forcibly dissolved, and with this went the bonds connecting peasants to the land through heredity tenure and leasehold. As soon as money rents replaced labour rent, peasants were forced to focus their attention on their own holdings, making money rent a precondition to economic survival. Those who were unable to pay were eventually ruined or evicted. At this point it became possible to express the value of land in money, and this led to the transformation of land into private property and eventually a commercial commodity. As land became subject to buying and selling, the economic balance between serfs and

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landlords was upset and feudal obligations in land and livelihood began to deteriorate.

As the breakdown of feudal obligations in land continued, it began to place the serf population under new forces of social differentiation and fragmentation. This put the serf population at the disposal of the new forces of production, which put into play a massive demographic transfer of the agricultural population into the industrial centers, bringing about a more complete transition to a new category of labour based on wages. At this stage, the flow of population from the old feudal economies to the new economies of industry became a more urgent fact of economic change, and this began to complete the process of transforming the agricultural worker of previous centuries into the wage labourer of the industrial economy. By 1840 the transition to an industrial economy was more or less complete. Several consequences ensued as a result of the displacement of the serf population from the rural economies. Firstly, as the transfer of the population proceeded, it brought about a massive social displacement which dispersed families, uprooted local economies and undermined regional modes of life and livelihood. Secondly, it dissolved the serf's relationship to the land and altered the system of economic livelihood, forcing serfs to sell their labour for a wage, and severing the serf's feudal relation to the agricultural means of production. Thirdly, the shift to an industrial economy meant that wage labourers were unable to employ the means of production on their own as they once did in a feudal economy, and as a result they lost control over the ability to put the means of production to work. Further, as the shift to an industrial economy became finalized, the old class structure of feudal society was replaced by the formation of a new commercial class who were at the center of power and industry. This began to bring about the transfer of the ownership of the means of production to the commercial classes and, consequently, as the means of production fell into private hands, it became the property of one class.

During much of the eighteenth century, the last remnants of the old economic order were crumbling under the impact of the industrial revolution. In historical terminology, industrial revolution means primarily the period of British History from the middle of the eighteenth century to the middle of nineteenth century. England in the 18th century was in the most favourable position for an industrial revolution. Through her overseas trade, including trade in slaves, she had accumulated vast profits which could provide the necessary capital. In the trade rivalries of European countries, she had emerged as an unrivalled power. She had acquired colonies which ensured a regular supply of raw materials. The term 'industrial revolution' was first used in the 1880s to denote the sudden acceleration of technical developments by the application of steam power to machines which replaced tools. The term got popularized when Arnold Toynbee's

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Industrial Revolution appeared in 1884. As discussed earlier, the new system of society which had been emerging in Europe from the 15th century was called *capitalism.* Under capitalism, the instruments and the means by which goods are produced are owned by private individuals and the production is carried out for making profit. The workers under this system do not own anything but work for a wage. The owners of wealth under capitalism who are called capitalists do not keep their wealth or consume it or use it for purposes of display but invest it to make profit. Goods are produced for sale in the market with a view to making profit. This system is in marked contrast with the feudal system in which goods were produced for local use and the investment of wealth for making profit did not take place. Economic life under feudalism was static as goods were produced for local consumption and there was no incentive to produce more by employing better means of producing goods for a bigger market. In contrast, the economy under capitalism was fast moving with the aim of producing more and more goods for bigger markets so that more profits could be made.

The desire to produce more goods at low cost to make higher profits led to the Industrial Revolution and further growth of capitalism. The Industrial Revolution began in England in about 1750. It was then that machines began to take over some of the works of men and animals in the production of goods and commodities. That is why we often say that the Industrial Revolution was the beginning of a 'machine age'. You have read before that the guild system had given way to the 'domestic' or the 'putting-out' system. In the 18th century, the domestic system had become obsolete. It started giving way to a new system called the 'factory system'. In place of simple tools and the use of animal and manual power, new machines and steam power came to be increasingly used. Many new cities sprang up and artisans and dispossessed peasants went there to work. Production was now carried on in a factory (in place of workshops in homes), with the help of machines (in place of simple tools). Facilities for production were owned and managed by *capitalists,* the people with money to invest in further production. Everything required for production was provided by the capitalists for the workers who were brought together under one roof. Everything belonged to the owner of the factory, including the finished product, and workers worked for wages. This system, known as the factory system, brought on the *Industrial Revolution.* This phase of capitalism is known as industrial capitalism. Industrial capitalism is capitalism's classical or stereotypical form.

The eighteenth century saw the growth of free labour and more competitive manufacturing. The cotton industry was the first to break the hold of the guilds and chartered corporations, but with each decade, other industries were subjected to the liberating effects of free labour, free trade, and free production. By the time large-scale industry emerged – first in England, then in France, and later in

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Germany – the economic reorganization of Europe had been achieved. Large-scale industry and manufacture simply accelerated the transformations in society that had been occurring for decades. These transformations involved a profound organization of society. Labour was liberated from the land; wealth and capital existed independently of the large noble estates; large-scale industry accelerated urbanization of the population; the extension of competitive industry hastened the development of new technologies; increased production encouraged the expansion of markets and world trade for securing raw resources and selling finished goods; religious organizations lost much of their authority in the face of secular economic activities; family structure was altered as people moved from rural to urban areas; law became as concerned with regularizing the new economic processes as with preserving the privilege of the nobility; and the old political regimes legitimated by "divine right" successively became less tenable.

Thus, the emergence of a capitalist economic system inexorably destroyed the last remnant of the feudal order and the transitional mercantile order of restrictive guilds and chartered corporations. Such economic changes greatly altered the way people lived, created new social classes (such as the bourgeoisie and urban proletariat), and led not only to a revolution of ideas but also to a series of political revolutions. These changes were less traumatic in England than in France, where the full brunt of these economic forces clashed with the Old Regime. It was in this volatile mixture of economic changes, coupled with the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, that political and intellectual revolutions were to be spawned. And out of these combined revolutions, sociology emerged.

The 'Renaissance' period also saw the beginning of the 'Scientific Revolution'. It is an undeniable fact that, if we want to seek out the cause of the Scientific Revolution, we must look for them among the wider changes taking place in that sea-change of European history known as the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution cannot be explained without reference to the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution, like the Protestant Reformation, can and should be seen as one of the outcomes of the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution marked an era of description and criticism in the field of science. It was a clear break from the past, a challenge to old authority. The impact of the scientific revolution was crucial not just in changing material life, but also man's ideas about Nature and Society. It is worth noting that science does not develop independent of society, rather, it develops in response to human needs. For example, various vaccines were developed out of the necessity to cure diseases. Apart from influencing the physical or material life of society, science is intimately connected with ideas. The general intellectual atmosphere existing in society influences the development of science. Similarly, new developments in science can also change the attitudes and

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beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. The emergence of sociology in Europe owes a great deal to the ideas and discoveries contributed by science.

As stated earlier, the medieval society was characterized by the feudal system. The Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. New, daring ideas could not flower in such an atmosphere. Thus the development of science was restricted mainly to improvement in the techniques of production. However, the renaissance thinkers rejected the blind acceptance of authority. They asserted that knowledge could be gained 'by going out and studying mentally and manually the Book of Nature', and not by speculation. This new outlook marked a break with the past and prepared the way for the advancement of science. It was summed up by **Francis Bacon**, an English philosopher, who said that knowledge could be gained only by observation and experimentation. According to Bacon, he who seeks knowledge should *first look at things that happen in the world around him*. He should then ask himself *what causes these things to happen* and, after he has formed a theory or belief, as to the possible cause, he should experiment. *The experiment is to test his belief* and see whether the assumed cause does, in fact, produce the result he has observed. Bacon believed that the 'true and lawful end of the sciences is that human life be enriched by new discoveries and powers.'

One of the first achievements of the Renaissance in science was in astronomy. The year 1543 marked the development of modern astronomical studies with the publication of Copernicus' *Six Books Concerning the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres*. **Copernicus** (1473-1543) was a polish scholar who lived in Italy for many years. His work in mathematics and astronomy demolished the hypothesis of the geocentric (Earth-centred) universe derived from Ptolemy and other astronomers of the past. In its place he advanced the revolutionary new hypothesis of the heliocentric (Sun-centred) universe. This meant that the earth moved round a fixed Sun and not the other way round. The Copernican hypothesis had radical implications. It destroyed the idea of the earth's uniqueness by suggesting that it acted like other heavenly bodies. More importantly, his theory contradicted the earlier notions about the centrality of the earth to the cosmic order. The very idea of an open universe of which the earth was but a small part shattered the earlier view of a closed universe created and maintained in motion by God. This was an important break with the ancient system of thought. For over a thousands years, it was believed that the earth was the centre of the universe. It was one of the basic dogmas of the philosophers of the time. Its refutation was an attack on the conception of the universe held by the Church. This was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. Copernicus' book was published in 1543, the year in

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which he died. He had hesitated from publishing it for fear of the hostility of the Church. About half a century after the publication of Copernicus' book, in 1600, Giordano Bruno was burnt at the stake on the charge of heresy. He had advocated ideas which were based on Copernicus' view of the universe.

The next major steps toward the conception of a heliocentric system were taken by the Danish astronomer **Tycho Brahe** (1546-1601) and the German astronomer **Johannes Kepler** (1571-1630). Tycho Brahe constructed the most accurate tables of astronomical observations. After his death, these observations came into the possession of Kepler, who after much work, agreed to the heliocentric theory, though he abandoned the Copernican concept of circular orbits. The mathematical relationship that emerged from a consideration of Brahe's observations suggested that the orbits of the planets were elliptical. Kepler published his findings in 1609 in a book entitled *On the Motion of Mars*. Thus, he solved the problems of planetary orbits by using the Copernican theory and Brahe's empirical data. However, in the same year when Kepler published his book, an Italian scientist **Galileo Galilei** (1564-1642), first turned a telescope invented by him on to the sky. Through this instrument he saw stars where none had been known to exist, mountains on the moon, spots moving across the sun and the moon and the orbiting Jupiter. Some of Galileo's colleagues at the University of Padua were so unnerved that they refused to look through the telescope because it revealed the heaven to be different from the teachings of the Church and the Ptolemaic theories. Galileo published his findings in numerous works, the most famous of which is his *Dialogues on the Two Chief Systems of the World* (1632). This book brought down on him the condemnation of the Roman Catholic Church. His life was spared only after he agreed to withdraw his views. He spent the rest of his life virtually under house arrest.

Isaac Newton was born in England in 1642, the year Galileo died. He solved the major remaining problems on the planetary motions and established a base for the modern physics. Much of the researches of Newton were based on the work of Galileo and other predecessors. In 1687, he published his treatise, *The Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*. In this work he proposed that the planets and, in fact, all other particles in the universe moved through the force of mutual attraction, a law which came to be known as the Law of Gravitation. In this way, Newton combined mathematics and physics for the study of astronomy. Incidentally, he was preceded in this by **Varahamihira** and **Aryabhatta** in the 5th and 6th centuries A.D. in India.

The modern age of science that began with these Renaissance scientists not only increased man's knowledge but also established a method of study that could be applied to other branches of knowledge. Significant discoveries, for example

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were made in the study of the human body and circulation of the blood which helped to fight many superstitions. In 1543, the year in which Copernicus' book was published, **Vesalius**, a Belgian, published his profusely illustrated *De Humani Corporis Fabrica*. Based on his study of the dissections of the human body, this book provided the first complete description of the anatomy of the human body. **Servetus**, a Spaniard, published a book explaining the circulation of blood. He was condemned to death for questioning the Church belief in Trinity. A completed account of the constant process of circulation of blood, from the heart to all parts of the body and back to the heart was given by Harvey, an Englishman, in about 1610. This knowledge helped to start a new approach to the study of the problems of health and disease. It is important to remember that what the Renaissance scientists began learning by questioning, observation, and experimentation is the method that scientists continue to use even today. This is scientific method. It is by applying this method that our knowledge has grown so greatly. The knowledge produced during scientific revolution deeply influenced the attitudes and beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. This is very important. Please keep this in mind when we discuss the ideas of enlightenment scholars later.

As mentioned earlier, that in medieval Europe Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. Any idea or action which challenged the authority of the Church was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. This newly emerging scientific knowledge, which was based on empirical observation and experimentation, was not only different but also contradictory to the many teachings of the Church. This stimulated the process of 'reformation' in the religious sphere of the European society. Thus, European people with new spirit of inquiry and thought started questioning the superstitious beliefs and malpractices of the Catholic Church.

The term 'Reformation' refers to two major developments in the history of Europe towards the later part of the Renaissance. The first was the Protestant reformation which resulted in a split in Christianity and the secession of a large number of countries from the Roman Catholic Church and establishment of separate Churches in those countries, generally on national lines. The second development concerned reforms within the Roman Catholic Church, generally referred to as Catholic Reformation or Counter Reformation. But Reformation was not merely a religious movement. It was intimately connected with, and was in fact a part of, the social and political movement of the period which brought about the end of the medieval period and the emergence of the modern world.

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The Catholic Church, during the early medieval period, had become a vast hierarchical organization headed by the Pope in Rome. The Pope was the supreme authority over the entire hierarchy and he exercised this authority directly. The position of the Pope is often described by the phrase 'papal monarchy'. Systematic efforts were made to extend the authority of the Church over everyone, high or low, making an oral confession of his sins to a priest at least once a year and suffering the punishment imposed was made obligatory for everyone. The people who did not follow this were excommunicated. An excommunicated person was supposed to have been temporarily consigned to hell. If he died, his body could not be buried with the prescribed rituals. Other Christians were forbidden from associating with him. An important component of the religious thinking propagated by the Church was the theory of sacraments. A sacrament was defined as an instrument by which divine grace is communicated to men. The sacraments were regarded indispensable for securing God's grace and there was no salvation without them. Another was the theory of priesthood. It was held that the priest who was ordained by a bishop (who was confirmed by the Pope) was the inheritor of a part of the authority conferred by Christ on Peter. The priest, according to this theory had the power to co-operate with God in performing certain miracles and in releasing sinner from the consequences of their sins. Besides the sacraments, various other beliefs came to be accepted.

Reformation is often described as a revolt against abuses which had grown in the Catholic Church. Some of the priests and higher-ups in the Church hierarchy received their appointments through corrupt means. Many such appointees were utterly ignorant. They led lives of luxury and immorality. Religious offices were sold to the highest bidder and those who bought positions after spending money made good by taking high fees for the services they performed. The Popes and the higher clergy lived like princes. A new abuse was the sale of letters which remitted punishments of the sinners who bought them, both in this life and after their death in purgatory. Normally, the priests imposed a penance or punishment on a person who had sinned and he was required to perform a special service or make a pilgrimage to a holy place. But increasingly sinners with enough money could be freed from doing penance for their sins by paying the clergy for a "Letter of Indulgence". The sale of indulgences which began to be considered as passports to heaven became one of the major immediate issues which caused the protestant Reformation. Besides the sale of indulgences, one could now gain salvation in exchange for fees. The priests, the bishops and the wandering monks could pronounce a marriage lawful or unlawful. By payment of fees, the problem could be solved. There were fees for every transaction in life, from birth to death, fees for the peace of the soul and fees for the souls of the people dead long ago. The wandering monks when they wanted to, heard confessions, awarded punishments for sins and remitted the punishments for fees.

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The Protestant Revolution can be said to have begun in 1517 when **Martin Luther**, a monk of the Order of St. Augustine, nailed his ninety-five theses or statements which attacked the sale of indulgences, on the door of the Church in Wittenberg in Germany. He challenged people to come and hold debates with him on his theses and sent copies of his theses to his friends in a number of cities. During the next two years Luther wrote a series of pamphlets. He knew that his doctrines could not be reconciled with those of the Catholic Church and that he had no alternative but to break with the Catholic Church. In 1520, the Pope ordered him to recant within sixty days or be condemned as a heretic. Luther burnt the proclamation of the Pope in public. During this period, he was protected by the ruler of Saxony who was his friend. Many rulers in Germany were hostile to the Church and when Luther was excommunicated, he remained unharmed. During the next 25 years, he occupied himself with the task of building an independent German Church, and in expounding his doctrine. He rejected the entire system of the hierarchy of the Catholic Church, introduced German as the language of Church services, abolished the special status of priests as representatives of God on earth, eliminated most of the sacraments, and emphasized faith rather than pilgrimages. He gave the highest priority to the supreme authority of the scriptures. Another important change was the abandonment of the view of the Catholic Church that the Church was supreme over the state. The German rulers and common people of Germany supported Luther. There were political reasons for the support of the rulers. They wanted to be free from the authority of Popes and get possession of the wealth in German monasteries for themselves. The common people liked Luther's teaching because it gave them an opportunity to demand more freedom from their rulers.

Ulrich Zwingli and **John Calvin** became the leaders of the Protestant movement in Switzerland. Under the leadership of Calvin, the Swiss cities became a refuge for Protestants fleeing to other countries in western Europe due to religious persecution. Calvin established an academy for the training of Protestant missionaries, who in return would spread the true word of God in other lands. As part of the work of propagating his version of Protestantism, Calvin composed a treatise entitled, *The Institutes of the Christian Religion*, wherein he gave a more concise and logical definition of the Protestant doctrines than what had been given by any other leader of this movement.

In England the Protestant movement was led by political leaders, particularly King Henry VIII and Queen Elizabeth I. Their reforms were not driven by the ides of religious or social reforms but by the interests of the state and more practically, the personal ambition of Henry VIII. Henry VIII sought to divorce his wife Catherine of Aragon and wanted to marry his beloved Anne Boleyn. The Pope refused to grant the divorce on the ground that Henry, before marrying Catherine,

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had asked for and had received a special Papal dispensation declaring his marriage with Catherine as valid and indissoluble. Rebuffed by the Pope, Henry promptly declared himself the "sole protector and supreme head of the Church and the Clergy of England". After that he married Anne Boleyn. From this marriage was born Elizabeth I, who later became the Queen of England. England's final break with the Pope came in 1529, when in a special session of the British Parliament a series of laws were passed to make the English Church completely free from the jurisdiction of the Pope. The King of England was also declared as the head of the English Church, which hereafter came to be known as the Anglican Church.

The Roman Catholic Church had been shaken to its very root by the movements started by Luther, Zwingli and Calvin. To counter the damage caused by the Protestant Movements, a series of reforms began within the Catholic Church, which came to be known as the 'Counter-Reformation'. During Counter-Reformation efforts were made to restore the Catholic Church's universal authority. One of these efforts took place in the Council of Trent (1545) summoned by Pope Paul III. The Council was to consider the ways and means to combat Protestantism. So it decided to settle the doctrinal disputes between the Catholics and the Protestants; clean up moral and administrative abuses within the Catholic Church and organise a new crusade against the Muslims. The next step was the organization of an order of missionaries, known as the Jesuits, with the dedicated purpose of spreading the message of Christ. The above measures adopted by the Catholic Church were not sufficient to bring the whole of Europe under the authority of the Pope. The campaign, however, did achieve a considerable measure of success in checking the further spread of Protestantism. Though much of Europe remained Protestant, new lands overseas were being won to the Catholic Church.

Reacting to economic and political changes, the concomitant reorganization of social life, much of the eighteenth century was consumed by intellectual ferment. The intellectual revolution of the eighteenth century is commonly referred to as the ***Enlightenment***. In England and Scotland, the Enlightenment was dominated by a group of thinkers who argued for a vision of human beings and society that both reflected and justified the industrial capitalism that first emerged in the British Isles. For scholars such as Adam Smith, individuals are to be free of external constraint and allowed to compete, thereby creating a better society. In France, the Enlightenment is often termed the *Age of Reason*, and it was dominated by a group of scholars known as the *philosophes*. It is out of the intellectual ferment generated by the French philosophes that sociology was born.

This section is very important, not only for your written examination but also for the interview. Please read it carefully.

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The term 'Enlightenment' is used in an academic and technical sense to indicate the intellectual movement in 18th century western and central Europe especially in England and France. Its historical significance lay in breaking the shackles of ideas imposed by tradition or authority whether of state or Church. For a long period in history up to that time, the standard method of arriving at the truth lay in an appeal to authority. It meant in practice, that truth was determined by one's superiors and one was not expected to doubt or question their wisdom. To buttress their claim, both state and Church would base their authority on supernatural sanction rather than on popular sovereignty. This had been the basis of absolutism and absolute monarchs ruled in nearly all parts of Europe. Conflicts between Church and state were not infrequent but these rarely concerned the common man in an age when communications were poor and his struggle for existence much harder.

Things in the meantime had changed fast during the 16th and 17th Centuries. Significant advances had been made in discoveries of new lands and routes; technologies as applied to agriculture and industries had increased production, and that possibly accounts for the rapid increase of population that took place both in England and France. Urban areas expanded and a middle class emerged to avail itself of the new opportunities in sectors like banking, industry, trade, journalism and above all education that served as a catalyst in the movement of ideas.

The essence of Enlightenment lay in its challenge to absolutism, the questioning of authority through a new conception of truth. In the course of Enlightenment, reason supplanted authority as the accepted method of arriving at the truth. All who look part in this movement of ideas were convinced that human understanding is capable by its own power and without recourse to supernatural assistance, of comprehending the system of the world. A new optimism was breathed about man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. The basic difference between the Absolutist view and Enlightened view centered round the individual. Under absolutism, the individual had to submit to the authority which was supposed to possess the monopoly of the truth; but under Enlightenment the individual acquired a new importance, dignity and self respect. Any man's opinion was potentially worth something. One no longer had to be a bishop or prince to claim access to truth. Enlightenment stood for the classic trilogy - Liberty, Equality, Fraternity; and as such represented the fight against oppression imposed by the old social hierarchy that had developed a vested interest in keeping people ignorant and superstitious. A challenge was thrown to religious education since it was believed that such education sapped a young person's courage and killed initiative by training him to fear and obey.

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Thus, the enlightenment was a period of remarkable intellectual development and change in the philosophical thought. A number of long-standing ideas and beliefs – many of which related to social life – were overthrown and replaced during the Enlightenment. The most prominent thinkers associated with the Enlightenment were the French philosophers **Charles Montesquieu** (1689-1755) and **Jean Jacques Rousseau** (1712-1778).

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and judicial, at one place. He believed in the theory of separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Rousseau in his book *The Social Contract* argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. For Rousseau, the social contract is the sole foundation of the political community. By virtue of this social contract, individuals lose their natural liberties (limited merely by their ability to exercise force over one another). However, man's natural liberty promoted unlimited acquisitiveness and avarice and thus encouraged individuals to destroy the freedom of others weaker than they. By submitting to a law vested in a social contract – a mandate that can be withdrawn at any time – individuals find in the laws to which they consent a pure expression of their being as civilized human entities.

Although the Enlightenment was fueled by the political, social, and economic changes of the eighteenth century, it derived considerable inspiration from the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. As noted earlier, the scientific revolution reached a symbolic peak, at least in the eye of eighteenth-century thinkers, with Newtonian physics. In the light of various revolutionary developments in science, particularly Physics, the universe (physical world) came to be viewed as orderly or patterned. It was argued that with scientific inquiry (based on empirical observation and application of reason) the underlying natural laws governing the universe can be discovered. Further, the knowledge of these laws would facilitate better prediction and greater control over the physical world. Thus, Physics was to become the vision of how scientific inquiry and theory should be conducted. And the individual and society were increasingly drawn into the orbit of the new view of science. This gradual inclusion of the individual and society into the realm of science represented a startling break with the past, because heretofore these phenomena had been considered the domain of morals, ethics, and religion.

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So, the enlightenment thinkers argued that just as the physical world was governed by the natural laws, it was likely that social world was, too. Thus it was up to the philosopher, using reason and research, to discover these social laws. And once such social laws are discovered, then with the knowledge of those laws we can control and create a better society (social engineering).

It is important to note that almost all enlightenment thinkers also shared 'a vision of human progress.' Humanity was seen to be marching in a direction and was considered to be governed by a "law of progress" that was as fundamental as the law of gravitation in the physical world. For example, with economic modernization and advancement of technology agricultural and industrial revolution took place leading phenomenal increase in the agricultural and industrial outputs. With commercial revolution (trade and commerce), unprecedented wealth or capital was generated. Further, scientific revolution demolished the traditionally held superstitious beliefs (sanctified by Church) and ushered in the age of reason. With its emphasis on empirical observation and application of reason, it significantly changed the social outlook of man and brought about social modernization.

At psychological level, modernity was reflected in terms of reflexivity. Reflexivity refers to the reflexive monitoring of action: that is, the way in which humans think about and reflect upon what they are doing in order to consider acting differently in future. Humans have always been reflexive up to a point, but in pre-industrial societies the importance of tradition limited reflexivity. Humans would do some things simply because they were the traditional things to do. However, with modernity, tradition loses much of its importance and reflexivity becomes the norm (psychological modernization). Social reflexivity implies that social practices are constantly examined and reformed in the light of incoming information about those very practices, thus continuously altering their character.

Further, with the rise various social and political movements, demands for greater individual freedom and democratization were being made. For the first time in human history, the idea of fundamental rights of the individuals was being entertained in the public discourse. Traditional authoritarian and autocratic systems of governance were being challenged. The enlightenment scholars argued that all humans had certain inalienable "natural rights" which must be respected such as right to freedom of speech and expression, right of participation in the decision-making process, etc. This marked a significant step towards political modernization.

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Thus, the enlightenment scholars saw these developments as the sign of progress and the enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main features of Enlightenment period.

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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Write a short note on 'Enlightenment'. (100-120 words)

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3. For Interview

Enlightenment Philosophy * Major Enlightenment Philosophers

Now let us briefly discuss the developments taking place in France, the birthplace of Sociology. In the years preceding the revolution, France retained the political and economic characteristics of a feudal society: rigid social hierarchy, social and economic inequality, monarchy, etc. The French society was divided into feudal **'estates'**. The structure of the feudal French society comprised the 'Three Estates'. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. **The First Estate** (the Church) consisted of the clergy, which was stratified into higher clergy, such as the cardinal, the archbishops, the bishops and the abbots. They lived a life of luxury and gave very little attention to religion. In fact, some of them preferred the life of politics to religion. They spent much of their time in wasteful activities like drinking, gambling, etc. The Church owned one-fifth of the cultivated lands in France and enjoyed great influence with the Government. Like the nobles, the higher clergy was also exempt from paying most of the taxes. With the nobles they supported absolute monarchy. The Church collected tithe, a tax from the people for providing community services. It also maintained institutions of learning. In comparison to the higher clergy, the lower parish priests were over worked and poverty-stricken.

The Second Estate consisted of the nobility. There were two kinds of nobles, the nobles of the sword and the nobles of the robe. The nobles of the sword were big landlords. They were the protectors of the people in principle but in reality they led a life of a parasite, living off the hard work of the peasants. They led the life of pomp and show and were nothing more than 'high born wastrels'; that is, they spent extravagantly and did not work themselves. They can be compared to the erstwhile zamindars in India. The nobles of the robe were nobles not by birth but by title. They were the magistrates and judges. Among these nobles, some were very progressive and liberal as they had moved in their positions from common citizens who belonged to the third estate. However, these noble families continued to enjoy all the privileges such as non-payment of most of the taxes, avenues to higher positions in the French administration, and income from various feudal dues of the peasants.

The Third Estate comprised the rest of the society and included the peasants, the merchants, the artisans, and others. There was a vast difference between the condition of the peasants and that of the clergy and the nobility. The

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peasants worked day and night but were overloaded with so many taxes that they lived a hand to mouth existence. They produced the food on which the whole society depended. Yet they could barely survive due to failure of any kind of protection from the government. The King, in order to maintain the good will of the other two estates, the clergy and the nobility, continued to exploit the poor. The poor peasants had no power against him. While the clergy and the nobility kept on pampering and flattering the King.

As compared to the peasants, the condition of the middle classes, also known as the **bourgeoisie** comprising the merchants, bankers, lawyers, manufacturers, etc. was much better. These classes too belonged to the third estate. But the poverty of the state, which led to a price rise during 1720-1789, instead of adversely affecting them, helped them. They derived profit from this rise and the fact that French trade had improved enormously also helped the commercial classes to a great extent. Thus, this class was rich and secure. But it had no social prestige as compared with the high prestige of the members of the first and the second estates. In spite of controlling trade, industries, banking etc. the bourgeoisie had no power to influence the court or administration. They were looked down upon by the other two estates and the King paid very little attention to them. Thus, gaining political power became a necessity for them.

The clergy and the nobility both constituted only two per cent of the population but they owned about 35 per cent of the land. The peasants who formed 80 per cent of the population owned only 30 per cent of the land. The first two estates paid almost no taxes to the government. The peasantry, on the other hand, was burdened with taxes of various kinds. It paid taxes to the Church, the feudal lord, taxed in the form of income tax, poll tax, and land tax to the state. Thus, you can see how much burdened and poverty stricken the peasants had become at this time. They were virtually carrying the burden of the first two estates on their shoulders. On top of it all the prices had generally risen by about 65 per cent during the period 1720-1789. The French system of taxation was both unjust and unfair.

Like in all absolute monarchies, the theory of the Divine Right of King was followed in France too. For about 200 years the Kings of the Bourbon dynasty ruled France. Under the rule of the King, the ordinary people had no personal rights. They only served the King and his nobles in various capacities. The King's word was law and no trials were required to arrest a person on the King's orders. Laws too were different in different regions giving rise to confusion and arbitrariness. There was no distinction between the income of the state and the income of the King. The kings of France, from Louis XIV onwards, fought costly wars, which ruined the country, and when Louis XIV died in 1715, France had

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become bankrupt. Louis XV instead of recovering from this ruin kept on borrowing money from bankers. His famous sentence, "After me the deluge" describes the kind of financial crisis that France was facing. Louis XVI, a very weak and ineffective king, inherited the ruin of a bankrupt government. His wife, Queen Marie Antoinette, known for her expensive habits, is famous for her reply, which she gave to the poor, hungry people of France who came to her asking for bread. She told the people that, 'if you don't have bread, eat cake'.

Now let us examine the intellectual developments in France, which proved to be the igniting force in bringing about the French revolution. France, like some other European countries during the eighteenth century, had entered the age of reason and rationalism. Some of the major philosophers, whose ideas influenced the French people, were rationalists who believed that all true things could be proved by reason. Some of these thinkers were Locke (1632-1704), Montesquieu (1689-1755), Voltaire (1694-1778), and Rousseau (1712-1778).

Locke, an Englishman, advocated that every individual has certain rights, which cannot be taken by any authority. These rights were (i) right to live, (ii) right to property, and (iii) the right to personal freedom. He also believed that any ruler who took away these rights from his people should be removed from the seat of power and replaced by another ruler who is able to protect these rights.

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law,* held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and juridical, at one place. He believed in the theory of the separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Voltaire became internationally famous as a great writer and critic whose style and pungent criticism were inimitable. It was through his plays and writings that he launched his bitter attacks against the existing institutions like the church and the state. He made fun of the eccentricities of the nobles. He advocated religious toleration and freedom of speech. He also stood for the rights of individuals, for freedom of speech and expression.

Probably the greatest French philosopher of the age was **Jean Jacques Rousseau**. In his book *The Social Contract*, he argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. He further explained that the king and his subjects are parties to a contract, and therefore if the king does not rule the people according to their general will, he loses their loyalty. Rousseau was advocating popular sovereignty

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theory. His writings cast such a spell on his admirers that they were ready to revolt against the oppressive monarchy.

The major ideas of these and several other intellectuals struck the imagination of the French people. Also some of them who had served in the French army, which was sent to assist the Americans in their War of Independence from British imperialism, came back with the ideas of equality of individuals and their right to choose their own government. The French middle class was deeply affected by these ideas of liberty and equality. So far you have leant about the basic picture of the French society just before the Revolution. Now let us discuss some of the major events that took place during the Revolution.

It is worth noting that when the American colonists revolted against the oppressive rule of the mother country and won a resounding victory at Saratoga, the French government decided to help them with men, money and materials. It caused a serious strain on the finances of the country and cast a heavy burden on the poor peasants. Turgot was appointed as the Minister of Finance to suggest remedies. He advised the king to tax the privileged class. He was summarily dismissed at the instance of the queen. Unfortunately, France witnessed near-famine conditions in 1788 with the result that there was a serious food shortage. It was at this critical juncture that the king was advised by his courtiers to summon the Estates-General (French Parliament) to get approval for further dose of taxation.

When the Estates-General was summoned, the king ignored the importance of the Third Estate (600 representatives elected by the common people) and tried to consult the representatives of the three estates separately. The representatives of the third estate advised the king to bring together the representatives of all the three estates at one place for discussion of state problems. The king discarded their advice. Subsequently, it led to a quarrel between the king and the representatives of the third estate. This led to the formation of the National Assembly. The meeting of the National Assembly led by middle class leaders and some liberal minded nobles was met with stiff resistance. On 20th June 1789 when a meeting was to be held in the Hall at Versailles near Paris, the members found that it was closed and guarded by the King's men. Therefore, the National Assembly members led by their leader Bailey went to the next building which was an indoor tennis court. It was here that they took an Oath to draw a new constitution for France. This Oath, which marks the beginning of the French Revolution, is popularly known as the Oath of the Tennis Court.

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Next, on July 14th, 1789 took place one of the most important events of the French Revolution. It was the storming of the Bastille, an ancient royal prison that stood as a symbol of oppression. On this date the mobs of Paris, led by some middle class leaders, broke open this prison and set its inmates free. The causes for this event were the shortage of food, on the one hand, and the dismissal of a very popular minister called Necker, on the other. The mobs of Paris rebelled against the ruling class, especially the King. This day is celebrated in France as its Independence Day.

Shortly after these events, the National Assembly drafted the 'Declaration of the Rights of Man,' which was a central political document defining human rights and setting out demands for reform. The political rights and freedoms proclaimed by the 'Declaration' were so wide-ranging in their human emancipation that it set the standard for social and political thinking, and formed the central rallying point of the revolution. The 'Declaration' stated at the outset that all human beings were born free and equal in their political rights, regardless of their class position, and this proceeded to set up a system of constitutional principles based on liberty, security and resistance to oppression. With philosophical authority, the 'Declaration' proclaimed that all individuals had the prerogative to exercise their 'natural right' and that the law rather than the monarch was the expression of the common interest. This led to the elimination of all social distinctions on the one hand, and the right to resist oppression on the other. Thus, the ideas of Liberty, Equality and Fraternity were enshrined in this declaration. Liberty and equality put an end to the age of serfdom, despotism and hereditary privileges found in the old feudal society.

By August the National Assembly began to deal directly with political and legal reforms, first by eliminating feudal dues and then by abolishing selfdom. Second, by compelling the church to give up the right to tithes, the National Assembly altered the authority and class position of the clergy. Third, in declaring that 'all citizens, without distinction, can be admitted to ecclesiastical, civil and military posts and dignities,' it proclaimed an end to all feudal social distinctions.

As the criticism of social and political inequalities spread throughout society, there was a widespread critique of economic inequality altogether and this led to putting into question all other forms of subordination. With this came the idea that human beings, without distinctions, were the bearers of natural rights – a concept which had a corrosive effect on all other forms of inequality. Finally, from the assertions inherent in the 'Declarations of Rights,' a new category of social person came into being which came fundamentally to rest in the concept of the 'citizen,' whose social and political rights were brought within the framework of the state.

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As the political changes began to take effect, there were abrupt social changes in the form of altered politics and in the form of the political reorganization of the feudal way of life. This brought with it two central historical shifts. First, it transformed the existing class structure of feudal society and led to the decline of class privilege and a change in the relations of subordination which had existed up until that time. Second, it set loose political and legal reforms which brought about a change from a political aristocracy based on sovereign authority to a democratic republic based on the rights of the citizen. Thus French Revolution of 1789 marked the phase of political modernization.

Now let us once again return to our discussion of enlightenment. As we had discussed earlier, the enlightenment scholars saw these socio-economic and political developments as the sign of progress. The enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. So, enlightenment thinkers represented intellectual modernity. But there were also some scholars who viewed these changes otherwise. These scholars were not only skeptic about these changes taking place in European society but even condemned these changes. We call these scholars as Counter–Enlightenment scholars and their views as a Conservative Reaction to enlightenment (anti–modernity). The most extreme form of opposition to Enlightenment ideas was French Catholic counterrevolutionary philosophy, as represented by the ideas of **Louis de Bonald** (1754-1840) and **Joseph de Maistre** (1753-1821). These men were reacting against not only the Enlightenment but also the French Revolution, which they saw partly as a product of the kind of thinking characteristic of the Enlightenment. De Bonald, for example, was disturbed by the revolutionary changes and yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages.

In general, these scholars deplored the disruption of socio-economic and political fabric of the traditional medieval society caused by Industrial Revolution and French Revolution. As mentioned earlier that there was massive dislocation of rural population due to enclosure movement. The newly emerging social life in towns and cities was bereft of close-knit community and kinship bonds, we-feeling, stability and harmonic social order. Since these cities had emerged spontaneously, without any proper planning, they lacked even the basic amenities such as proper sewage and sanitation. As a result, due such unhygienic living conditions, epidemics were a common phenomenon. Further, these newly emerging industrial cities were marked by gross socio-economic disparities. Workers, including women and children, were forced to work for long hours in the factories marked by inhuman working conditions. In this new mode of production, worker had lost control over both, the process of production as well as his product. He was simply reduced to a wage-labourer. In Marxist terms, the worker became alienated from the product of his labour.

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Further, demand for political rights fuelled by the writings of enlightenment scholars, often led to civil wars leading to political anomie. Furthermore, religion too, which until now regulated the social order started declining. Religion, as the source of solace and meaning of life, started losing its appeal with the advances in science. So, Conservatives saw these changes, i.e. decline of family & community life, decline of religion, economic exploitation of workers in factories, rising socio-economic disparities and political turmoil as a sign of social decay and not as progress. Hence, they were preoccupied with their concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society.

So, while enlightenment scholars glorified change, conservatives deplored such changes and emphasized on stability, peace and harmony. However, the idea that there must be peace and harmony in social life came to be generally accepted by scholars of both the traditions.

Thus, the social conditions prevalent in Europe in 18th and 19th centuries, generated by social changes such as Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Counter-Reformation, Industrial Revolution and French Revolution created the need for a distinct discipline to understand and analyze these changes. As we know that the existing knowledge that was prevalent during those times was largely religious in nature. Traditionally, the only source of knowledge was religion, propagated by the Church. But, the then existing body of religious knowledge had no answer to these challenges. Further, with the growth of science, religion itself was under attack and religious ideas were loosing their plausibility. So, there was a need for a new body of knowledge. A new body of knowledge was needed to understand what was happening and also help people to find solutions to the newly emerging problems.

That is how, the social changes created by modernity in Europe in the late 18th and early 19th century created the need for new knowledge.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

How?

As the early social theorists were largely preoccupied with understanding the puzzle of social change unfolding in Europe and to create a harmonic social order, hence, we can say that the goals of sociology were dictated by the conservative reaction. As we had already discussed that how the Conservative scholars were

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preoccupied with concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society. Therefore, sometimes it is also said that the early sociology developed as a reaction to the Enlightenment.

But, as far as the methodology or means to understand and study these social changes was concerned, it was largely influenced by the intellectual contributions of the Enlightenment scholars. Unlike conservatives, who yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages, early social theorists emphasized on the need for scientific study of society based on empirical observation and reason (an idea of Enlightenment scholars) to be the basis of this new knowledge. They argued that through scientific study of society, social scientists can discover social laws that govern social order and thus, through corrective social legislation, can create a harmonic society. So, that is how the intellectual conditions helped in creating a new discipline which would use scientific method to study society, discover the laws that govern society and use that knowledge of laws to create a peaceful and harmonic society.

So, social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology and that is how modernity and social change in Europe led to the emergence of sociology.

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A. 250 - 300 Marks
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Test Yourself

Q1. Write a note on 'Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of Sociology'. (300-350 words/ 30 marks)

Dear Candidate, before I give you a model answer for this question, I wish to discuss with you the correct strategy of writing an answer. I call this '**Dialectical Approach**', a term borrowed from Hegel. But before you apply the dialectical approach to a question make sure that you have read that question at least three times and understood it. It is a very common error on the part of the candidates to write in the examination 'what they know' rather 'what has been asked by the examiner.' Hence, the key to score well in this examination is to read the mind of the examiner and accordingly answer the question, meeting the expectations of the examiner. If you do this, you would get marks as per your expectations too.

All you have to do for this is to follow a very simple process. Firstly, read the question carefully and underline the keywords. Secondly, try to understand from which dimension the question has been framed on the topic. This is very important because questions can be framed from multiple dimensions or angles on the same topic. You would have no problem doing this if you sincerely follow the theme-based approach. Thirdly, divide the question into 3-4 logical sub-questions. When you do this it will not only keep you focused on the main theme but also help you complete the paper in time.

Now, let me share with you something about the structure of your answer. Your answer must be divided in four sections, viz. **introduction**, **thesis**, **anti-thesis** and **synthesis**. The Introduction section is the most important section of your answer as it introduces yourself as a candidate to the examiner. The examiner forms an image about you and your understanding of the concept just by reading the introduction. Hence, you must start by directly addressing the question, without beating the bush. By this I mean that given the limitations of Time and Word Limit, please avoid developing the background and glorifying the thinkers. In the introduction, briefly explain the key concept asked in the question. The introduction section should constitute nearly 20 % of the total length of your answer.

The next section is Thesis. In this section, you need to identify the main arguments in favour of the given concept or statement. Here, you must enrich your answer by highlighting the works of the scholars and case studies in support of

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your argument. In the Anti-Thesis section, you must write a critique of the concept or statement. This would balance your answer. Both, Thesis and Anti-Thesis should constitute nearly 30% each of the total length of your answer. Last, but not the least, is the Synthesis section. You may also call it as concluding remarks. Please remember that the concluding remarks reflect your overall understanding of the subject to the examiner. Your concluding remarks are not supposed to be your personal opinion about the ideas or concepts asked in the question. Rather, your concluding remarks must reflect the insight that you have gained as a student of Sociology. Thus, when write synthesis, make sure it is an academic conclusion rather than personal opinion.

Structure of the Model Answer:

Introduction: Briefly discuss the concept of modernity and the process of social change in Europe that brought about modernity

Thesis: Arguments in favour of the modernization process, viz. the ideas of Enlightenment scholars, with examples

Anti-thesis: Conservative reaction to Enlightenment

Synthesis: Emergence of Sociology as a by-product of the confluence of the two intellectual currents – Enlightenment and Conservatives

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Model Answer

Modernity refers to the rational transformation of social, psychological, economic and political aspects of society. In this sense, the process of modernization could be said to have begun in the late 18th and early 19th century in Western Europe. During that period, the entire social structure and the economic and political institutions were undergoing transition, particularly in the backdrop of Renaissance and Enlightenment movement. With industrial revolution, traditional feudal agrarian society was in decline and a new capitalist industrial society was emerging. The commercial and scientific revolutions which marked the period laid the foundations for the transformation of a predominant rural, agricultural and manual way of life to an urban industrial and mechanized pattern of living.

These extensive changes integral to the process of industrialization however, involved a major paradox. They brought a new society with great productive potential and more sophisticated and complex ways of living while at the same time generating extensive disruptions in traditional patterns of life and relationship. Thus, creating new problems of overcrowding, unhygienic urban conditions, poverty and unemployment. Demand for greater political rights gave rise to social and political movements, such as French Revolution, often leading to civil wars.

However, the early scholars who were carefully observing the changes in the patterns of social life with the rise of industrial society were divided in their opinion with regard to the nature, impact and direction of such changes. Enlightenment scholars like Rousseau, Montesquieu, Adam Smith, Saint Simon and Augusts Comte had a positive view of the newly emerging social order. They considered such changes as progressive and hence desirable. They favoured modern scientific knowledge, advanced technology, individualism and political ideas of justice and liberty. They encouraged the forces of liberalization and industrialization. Whereas, the Conservatives like Louis de Bonald, Joseph de Maistre and other such scholars had a rather skeptic view of these profound and far reaching institutional changes that were taking place in society. They were preoccupied with the concern for social stability and order in the society as the new social order was marked by violent political revolutions, class wars, extreme economic inequalities and widespread misery and poverty.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

Total Words: 355

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Dear Candidate, after completing a given topic and preparing your notes in pointer form, you must attempt questions asked so far in previous years and get them evaluated. As I have discussed before, what really counts here is how you are articulating the learned knowledge in the given Time and Word Limit. Always remember that Civil Services Examination is not about information, it is more about analysis. So, you must practice by writing more and more answers and getting them periodically evaluated.

All the best

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Science, scientific method and critique

Science refers to the application of objective methods of investigation, reasoning and logic to develop a body of knowledge about given phenomena. There are three goals of science. The first is to explain why something happens. The second is to make generalizations, that is, to go beyond the individual cases and make statements that apply to a collectivity. The third is to predict, to specify, what will happen in future, in the light of the available stock of knowledge.

Thus, science refers to a systematic body of certified and changing knowledge which is based upon observable and verifiable facts and the methods used to acquire this knowledge. So, the term science is used both for the knowledge as well the methods that are used to acquire this knowledge.

Like all scientists, sociologists must study the specific in order to understand the general. The true concern of the geologist is not the peculiarity of the rock he holds in his hand, the concern of the botanist is not the fate of the flower he finds in the field, the concern of the sociologist is not the specific event he observes and records. All science is concerned with the order and pattern of its subject matter – what it is that rocks or flowers or persons or societies have in common. One of the ways scientists move from the specific to the general is through statistical averaging. A chemist who observes the reactions of millions of atoms cannot predict with certainty the behaviour of any single hydrogen atom, but he can say with assurance that most hydrogen atoms behave in a certain way. Similarly, although a sociologist can never predict the political opinion of any particular blue-collar worker, he can say that most members of a given socio-economic class have political opinions of a certain kind.

Sociology is a scientific discipline. It is a science in the sense that it involves objective and systematic methods of investigation and evaluation of social reality in the light of empirical evidence and interpretation. But, it cannot be directly modeled on the patterns of natural sciences, because human behaviour is different from the world of nature. Among other differences, the subject matter of natural sciences is relatively static and unchanging whereas human behaviour as the subject matter of sociology is flexible and dynamic. Whereas, the natural phenomena can be put under controlled observation, it may not be possible to do the same regarding the subject matter of sociology. This is because all social phenomena and social institutions like family, marriage, caste, etc. are constantly changing even while they are being studied. In sociological research, it is difficult to be completely value-free. Moreover, the research situation itself becomes a social situation where the researcher confronts another human being and gets involved in a process of interaction. This makes it difficult to be objective. Good

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social scientists keep these limitations in mind and try to be as objective as possible. For that purpose, different research tools are used, and data are checked and crosschecked.

To sum up, it may be said that any discipline is considered to be scientific when it is empirical, theoretical, cumulative and value-neutral. Against this yardstick, let us examine the status of sociology as a science:

(a) Sociology is empirical: It is based on observation and reasoning, not on supernatural/ speculative revelations, and its results are not speculative. In the early stages of their creative work, all scientists speculate, of course, but ideally at least, they submit their speculations to the test of fact before announcing them as scientific discovers. All aspects of sociological knowledge are subject to evaluation made about social behaviour or can be put to test for empirical evidence.

(b) Sociology is theoretical: It attempts to summarize complex observations in abstract logically related propositions which purport to explain causal relationships in the subject matter. Its main aim is to interpret and to inter-relate sociological data in order to explain the nature of social phenomena and to produce hypotheses whose final validity can be cheeked by further empirical research.

(c) Sociology is cumulative: Sociological theories are built upon one another, extending and refining the older ones and producing the new ones. As such, theoretical integration becomes a goal in the construction of sociological formulations. Thus, sociology is cumulative.

(d) Sociology is non-ethical: Sociologists do not ask whether particular social actions are good or bad; they seek merely to explain them. It addresses issues. Study of human relations is the prime consideration in sociology. In this context, Morris Ginsberg observes that ethical problems should be dealt with neutrality. Objectivity and rationality based on a thorough knowledge of a situation alone can ensure scientific status to the discipline of sociology.

In all these respects, sociology is far from having reached perfection; but is being steadily made. Hence, sociology can at best be described as a social science.

As discussed earlier, science is a body of verified knowledge about physical or social reality. The method used to acquire this kind of knowledge is called **scientific method**. The general guideline for all scientific research is the scientific

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method. Although it is possible to outline the series of steps that comprise this method, its real importance is not as a body of rules but as an attitude toward the work of observation and generalization. It has often been said that many scientific discoveries are due to a lucky accident; Galvani, for example, discovered that nerves transmit electrical impulses when one of his assistants left a freshly dissected frog on the lab table near an unrelated experiment in electrical conduction. But it is not the element of chance that should be stressed in such an occurrence, the key element was Galvani's trained powers of observation, his ability to derive a possible explanation for what he saw, his knowledge of the way to test that explanation. While Galvani's assistant, who also observed this lucky accident, dismissed it as a curious coincidence, Galvani the scientist saw the implications of the coincidence.

How can one learn to observe and generalize in a scientific manner? The following steps serve as general guidelines when applying the scientific method in sociological research.

First, make a careful statement of the problem to be investigated and frame a hypothesis. A sociologist begins by defining precisely what it is he wants to know. He generally states the problem so that it fits into existing theoretical frameworks and is related to the relevant findings of previous research. Stating the problem in this manner insures that knowledge will be cumulative and that one researcher's findings can be easily utilized by others. The problem must also be formulated as a verifiable **hypothesis**, one that can be tested before it is accepted or rejected. Many provocative hypotheses can never be tested. For example, one might hypothesize that God exists, but no one has found a way to test this hypothesis. Scientists must modify the original hypothesis to one they can test, such as: the majority of adult Americans believe that God exists. Please note that a hypothesis is nothing but a tentative statement asserting a relationship between certain facts (or variables). You will learn more about hypothesis in our later discussion.

In sociological research the application of this first step in the scientific method can be illustrated by the case of a researcher who suspects an association between urban residence and mental illness. The researcher would begin by identifying certain defining qualities of a city: How big is it? What are its social characteristics? How does it differ from a nearby suburb? With a definition in mind, he looks for the aspects of a city that might be associated with mental illness: population size and density, quality of housing, prevalence of low-income groups, availability of recreational facilities. After examining existing theories and research findings in this area, he would frame a hypothesis stating a suspected or tentative relationship between some specific urban characteristic and mental

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illness. For example, he might hypothesize that the incidence of mental illness increases in proportion to the size of the city, with the largest cities having the highest rates of mental illness.

In the search for ways that these **variables** (characteristics that are present in varying amounts or degrees) could be measured, the hypothesis might be further refined. The researcher might choose to limit his study to those patients actually hospitalized with a diagnosis of mental illness, thus eliminating all those mentally ill urban residents who have not been diagnosed and are not being treated. Although this refinement makes the hypothesis easier to test, it also introduces an additional problem: the number of institutions that can diagnose and treat mental illness. Thus, the rates of mental illness might appear higher in some cities simply because they have more facilities to treat the mentally ill, whereas in other cities a large percentage of the mentally ill population go untreated. Each choice of a specific measure brings with it new possibilities of error and bias, yet the general hypothesis must be reduced to specifics if it is to be tested at all.

Second, develop a research design. A **research design** is a plan for the collection, analysis, and evaluation of data; it involves deciding how facts are to be selected, how they are to be evaluated and classified, and how they are to be analyzed to uncover relationships and patterns that bear on the original hypothesis. The major goal of the research design is to insure that the evidence gathered to test a hypothesis will be trustworthy, and that extraneous factors that might falsify the results will be controlled. Please note that **extraneous variables** are undesirable variables that influence the relationship between the variables that an experimenter is examining. In other words, extraneous variables are the variables which though not a part of the study yet are capable enough to influence the outcome of the study. These variables are undesirable because they add error to an experiment. A major goal in research design is to decrease or control the influence of extraneous variables as much as possible. The classic **controlled experiment** in a laboratory is the ideal scientific research design. It is an experiment designed in advance and conducted under conditions in which it is possible to control all relevant factors while measuring the effect on an experimentally induced variable. In a controlled experiment the subjects are divided into two groups. The variable whose effect is to be tested, or the **independent variable**, is then introduced into one group, called the **experimental group**, while it is withheld from the other group, called the **control group**. The two groups are subsequently compared to determine whether there are any significant differences between them regarding the variable that is expected to change, or the **dependent variable**. On the basis of this comparison, the original hypothesis, which proposes a specific relationship between the independent and dependent variables, can be confirmed or rejected.

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The use of the controlled experiment can best be illustrated by cancer research. Suppose one wishes to test the hypothesis that nicotine causes cancer in mice. A number of mice can be randomly assigned to experimental and control groups. Those in the experimental group are then given a dose of nicotine (the independent variable) while those in the control group are not. Everything else about the two groups is held constant. If the incidence of cancer (the dependent variable) is subsequently found to be higher in the experimental than in the control group, a cause-and-effect relationship between nicotine and cancer in mice may be assumed. It is seldom possible to test sociological hypotheses under controlled laboratory conditions. The typical social research design is therefore developed with this limitation in mind.

Third, collect data in accordance with the research design. One way for obtaining information about human behaviour and social life is to observe the way people actually behave: how they act in a given situation, what they do on a daily and regular basis. This constitutes the *objective reality*. Accurate and objective observation by trained observers is a fundamental distinguishing feature of all the sciences. Another way is to ask people about their actions, attitudes, and beliefs. Their answers help to reveal the *subjective reality* – the meanings and thoughts, or "reasons," that lie behind a person's behaviour. Subjective reality distinguishes the social sciences from the natural sciences, which deal only with objective reality, that which can be seen to happen.

Some sociologists, however, question whether subjective reality can be accurately analyzed scientifically and prefer to concentrate exclusively on the observation of objective reality. They maintain that the only valid evidence for scientific purposes is what they can observe about human behaviour, not what people tell them. Such scholars are called as ***'positivists'***. In sociology, positivism is generally associated with the view that there is an objective world which is capable of being understood in objective and scientific terms. The founders of sociology, be it Comte, Spencer or Durkheim, all advocated positivist approach to study social life. Though, this approach had its own limitations and was later criticized by the scholars belonging to the anti-positivist tradition. You will read about this in more detail in our subsequent discussion on 'Positivism and its critique'.

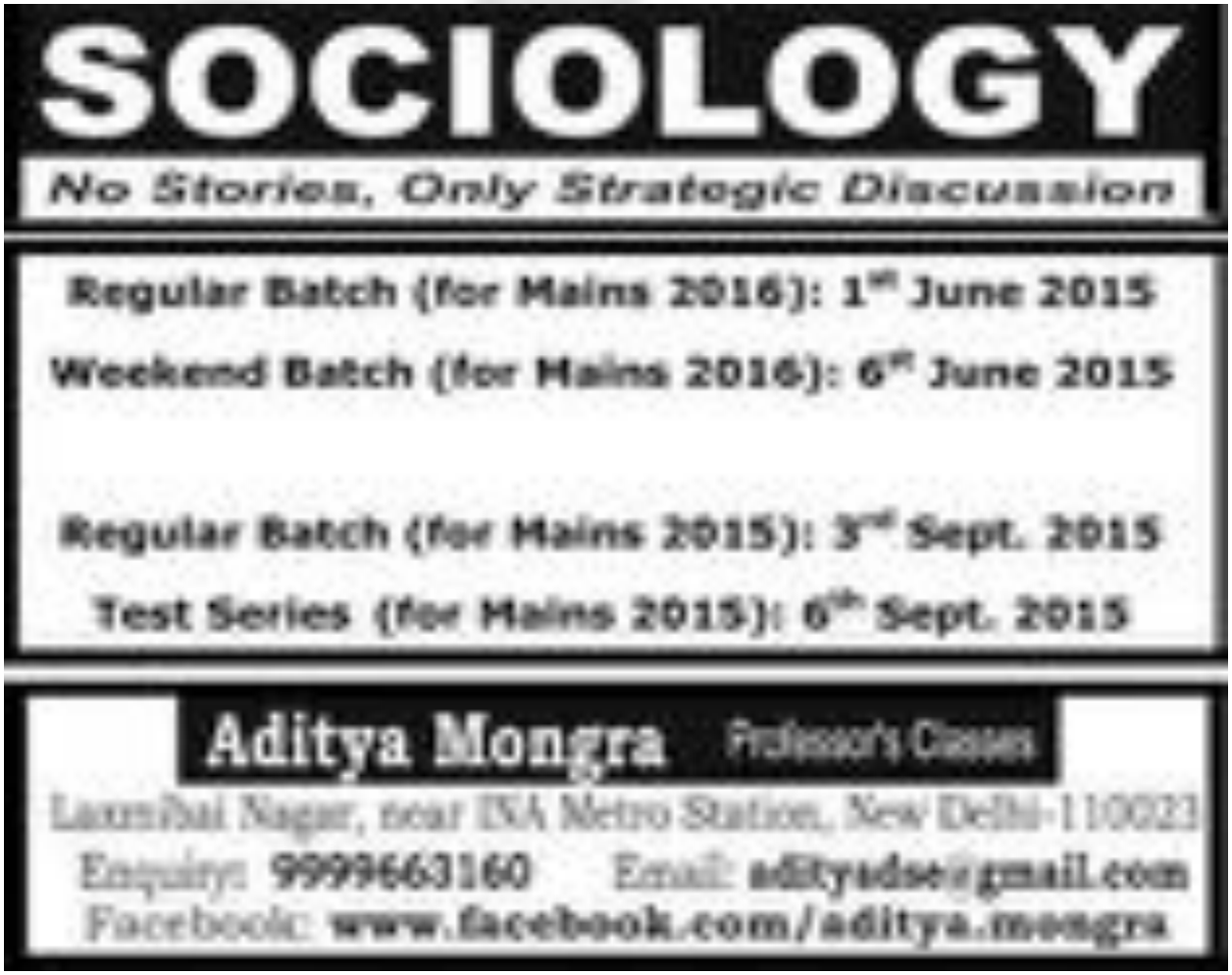
The fourth step in the scientific method is to analyze the data and draw conclusions. It is at this step that the initial hypothesis is accepted or rejected and the conclusions of the research are related to the existing body of theory, perhaps modifying it to take account of the new findings. The findings are usually presented as articles in scholarly journals, monographs, or books. The accuracy and significance of scientific findings are assessed in terms of their validity and

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reliability. **Validity** refers to the correspondence between what a scientific investigation or technique purports to measure and what it actually measures. An example of this kind of assessment is the current challenge by many social scientists of the validity of IQ tests. These scientists question whether the tests really measure innate human intelligence or something else. **Reliability** refers to the degree to which a scientific test or measurement is consistent and accurate. There is less doubt about the reliability of IQ tests; although they may not measure intelligence, they seem to measure some particular characteristic consistently. To determine reliability, replication, the repetition of an experiment a number of times, is done to see if the same results are obtained.

By no means do all, or even most, sociological research investigations closely follow this outline of the scientific method. Many sociologists are simply interested in accurate descriptions, others do not develop precise hypotheses or elaborate research designs, and most do not formally go through the step of either accepting or rejecting a hypothesis. Nevertheless, this model of the scientific method is highly influential as a guideline for both planning research and evaluating research findings. It represents the ideal that all scientists seek to attain.



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Major theoretical strands of research methodology

Positivism and its critique

Non-positivist methodologies

(Dear Candidate, since the above mentioned topics are conceptually interrelated, we have discussed these topics in an interlinked argument. This discussion would also help you to understand the underlying theme of ***methodological debate*** running through these topics and write an analytical answer.)

(Dear Candidate, this is the most important section in sociology. Kindly read it thoroughly. Read it as many times as possible. I guarantee that if you understand this section, you will play with sociology as most of the debates in sociological theory center around the arguments discussed in this section.)

Sociologists approach the study of human society in different ways. They can look at the "big picture" of society to see how it operates. This is a macro view focusing on the large social phenomena of society such as social institutions and inequality. Sociologists can also take a micro view, zeroing in on the immediate social situations in which people interact with one another. From these two views, sociologists have developed various theoretical perspectives, each a set of general assumptions about the nature of society.

To help understand the beginners, these major theoretical strands could broadly be classified into two major approaches in sociology. These are the **Structural approach** (also called as macro sociology) and the **Social Action approach** (also called as the interpretive, phenomenological, anti/non-positive or micro sociology). Structural and social action approaches to the study and research of society exhibit two major differences. One involves how they conceive of society, the social world itself. In other words, they completely disagree on the question of what society is. The second question follows from the first. It concerns the question of how we are to conduct our research into the social world. That is, because structural and social action sociology have very different ideas of what society in fact is, they also have very different ideas about research method which are most appropriate to the conduct of research into social life. This is why we can say that how we conceive of society cannot be separated from the question of how we should proceed in our study of it. (You must understand this point very clearly

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because this links the theoretical perspectives with the research methodology. It will become more clear as we proceed with our discussion.)

Let us now discuss these two major theoretical strands, and the various sociological perspectives and approaches that fall under their respective domain.

Structural approach is a macro-sociological analysis, with a broad focus on social structures that shape society as a whole. Structural approach analyses the way society as a whole fits together. Structural theory sees society as a system of relationships that creates the structure of the society in which we live. It is this structure that determines our lives and characters. Structured sets of social relationships are the 'reality' that lie below the appearance of 'the free individual'.

Important: Social structure refers to the pattern of interrelations between individuals. Every society has a social structure, a complex of major institutions, groups, and arrangements, relating to status and power. In a society individuals interact with one another for the fulfilment of their needs. In this process, they occupy certain status and roles in social life with accompanying rights and obligations. Their social behaviour is patterned and gets associated with certain norms and values which provide them guidance in social interaction. There emerge various social units, such as groups, community, association and institutions in society as a product of social intercourse in human life. In this scenario, social structure is conceived as the pattern of inter-related statuses and roles found in a society, constituting a relatively stable set of social relations. It is the organized pattern of the inter-related rights and obligations of persons and groups in a system of interaction.

In order to systematically understand the structure of a society, let us first assume the structure of a building. The structure of a human society is similar to the structure of a building. The structure of any given building primarily has three components viz. (i) the building material such as bricks, mortars, beams and pillars, (ii) all these are arranged in a definite order and are placed in relationship to one another, and (iii) all these put together make a building one unit. The same three sets of features can be used to describe the structure of a society as well. A human society also consists of (i) males and females, adults and children, various occupational and religious groups and so on, (ii) the interrelationship between various parts (such as relationship between husband and wife, between parents and children and between various groups), and (iii) all the parts of the society are put together to work as a unit.

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Philip Jones in his *Theory and Method in Sociology* (1987) argues that the structuralist sociologists look at society as 'a structure of (cultural) rules', guiding our behaviour and telling us how to behave appropriately in any given situation and what to expect in terms of the behaviour of others. Thus, the structural sociology is based on the premise that society comes before individuals. This general idea – that sociologists should study the way society impacts on individual behaviour – represents the main way structuralist sociologists differ from social action sociologists. Further, with these assumptions about the social reality, the structural theorists argue that there can be a sociology which is a science. In other words, sociology can be a science of society just as, for example, nuclear physics is the science of the structure of matter –of atoms, neutrons, electrons, and so on. Structural theorists conceive society as an objective phenomenon, a 'thing'. In other words, just as natural sciences study the structure and composition of matter, sociology too can identify and objectively study the social structure and its various constituents such as shared norms, values, attitudes and beliefs, etc. Hence the structural theorists argue that the study of the social world can be modeled on the study of natural phenomena and the scientific methodology of natural sciences can be adopted to study the social phenomena. Thus, we can conclude that structural approaches are **positivist** in nature. Before moving further, let us discuss the concept of Positivism and the positivist approach in sociology.

Many of the founding fathers of sociology believed that it would be possible to create a science of society such as chemistry and biology. This approach is known as positivism. Auguste Comte (1798-1857), who is credited with inventing the term sociology and regarded as one of the founders of the discipline, maintained that the application of the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences would produce a 'positive science of society'. He believed that this would reveal that the evolution of society followed 'invariable laws'. It would show that the behaviour of man was governed by principles of cause and effect which were just as invariable as the behaviour of matter, the subject of the natural sciences. In terms of sociology, the positive approach makes the following assumptions. The behaviour of man, like the behaviour of matter, can be objectively measured. Just as the behaviour of matter can be quantified by measures such as weight, temperature and pressure, methods of objective measurement can be devised for human behaviour. Observations of behaviour based on objective measurement will make it possible to produce statements of cause and effect. Theories may then be devised to explain observed behaviour. This emphasis on the objective measurement of human social behaviour forces the positivist scholars to rely more on the **quantitative methods** while conducting research. You will read more on 'Quantitative methods' in our subsequent discussion on Research Methods and Analysis.

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The positivist approach in sociology places particular emphasis on behaviour that can be directly observed. It argues that factors which are not directly observable, such as meanings, feelings and purposes, are not particularly important and can be misleading. The positivists' emphasis on observable 'facts' is due largely to the belief that human behaviour can be explained in much the same way as the behaviour of matter. Natural scientists do not inquire into the meanings and purposes of matter for the obvious reason of their absence. Atoms and molecules do not act in terms of meanings, they simply react to external stimuli. Thus if heat, an external stimulus, is applied to matter, that matter will react. The job of the natural scientist is to observe, measure, and then explain that reaction. The positivist approach to human behaviour applies a similar logic. Men react to external stimuli and their behaviour can be explained in terms of this reaction. For example they enter into marriage and produce children in response to the demands of society. Society requires such behaviour for its survival and its members simply respond to this requirement. The meanings and purposes they attach to this behaviour are largely inconsequential.

Thus, it has often been argued that the structural theory (also called systems theory) in sociology adopts a positivist approach. Once behaviour is seen as a response to some external stimulus, such as economic forces or the requirements of the social system, the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences appear appropriate to the study of man. Marxism has often been regarded as a positivist approach since it can be argued that it sees human behaviour as a reaction to the stimulus of the economic infrastructure. Functionalism has been viewed in a similar light. The behaviour of members of society can be seen as a response to the functional prerequisites of the social system. These views of the structural (or systems) theory represent a considerable oversimplification of complex theories; however, it is probably fair to say that they are closer to a positivist approach.

In sociology, there are two main structural approaches:

i. Consensus theory (Functionalism)
ii. Conflict theory (Marxism)

Functionalism: The consensus approach

Functional analysis also known as functionalism and structural functionalism is rooted in the origin of sociology. It is prominent in the work of Auguste Comte (1798-1857) and Herbert Spencer (1820-1903), two of the founding fathers of the discipline. It was developed by Emile Durkheim (1858-1917) and refined by Talcott Parsons (1902-79).

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Functionalism was the dominant theoretical perspective in sociology during the 1940s and 1950s. From the mid 1960s onwards, its popularity steadily declined due partly to damaging criticism and partly to competing perspectives which appeared to provide superior explanations.

The key points of the functionalist perspective may be summarized by a comparison drawn from biology. If a biologist wanted to know how an organism such as the human body worked, he might begin by examining the various parts such as the brain, lungs, heart and liver. However, if he simply analysed the parts in isolation from each other, he would be unable to explain how life was maintained. To do this, he would have to examine the parts in relation to each other since they work together to maintain the organism. Thus he would analyze the relationship between the heart, lungs, brain and so on to understand how they operated and appreciate their importance. From this viewpoint, any part of the organism must be seen in terms of the organism as a whole. Functionalism adopts a similar perspective. The various parts of society are seen to be interrelated and taken together, they form a complete system. To understand any part of society, such as the family or religion, the part must be seen in relation to society as a whole. Thus where a biologist will examine a part of the body, such as the heart, in terms of its contribution to the maintenance of the human organism, the functionalist will examine a part of society, such as the family, in terms of its contribution to the maintenance of the social system.

Functionalism begins with the observation that behaviour in society is structured. This means that relationships between members of society are organized in terms of rules. Social relationships are therefore patterned and recurrent. Values provide general guidelines for behaviour and they are translated into more specific directives in terms of roles and norms. The structure of society can be seen as the sum total of normative behaviour – the sum total of social relationships which are governed by norms. The main parts of society, its institutions, such as the family, the economy, the educational and political systems are major aspects of the social structure. Thus an institution can be seen as a structure made up of interconnected roles or interrelated norms. For example, the family is made up of the interconnected roles of husband, father, wife, mother, son and daughter. Social relationships within the family are structured in terms of a set of related norms.

Having established the existence of a social structure, functionalist analysis turns to a consideration of how that structure functions. This involves an examination of the relationship between the different parts of the structure and their relationship to society as a whole. From this examination, the functions of institutions are discovered. At its simplest, function means effect. Thus the

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function of the family is the effect it has on other parts of the social structure and on society as a whole. In practice the term function is usually used to indicate the contribution an institution makes to the maintenance and survival of the social system. Thus a major function of the family is the socialization of new members of society. This represents an important contribution to the maintenance of society since order, stability and cooperation largely depend on learned, shared norms and values.

In determining the function of various parts of the social structure, functionalists are guided by the following ideas. Societies have certain basic needs or requirements which must be met if they are to survive. These requirements are sometimes known as **functional prerequisites**. For example, a means of producing food and shelter may be seen as a functional prerequisite since without them members of society could not survive. A system for socializing new members of society may also be regarded as a functional prerequisite since without culture social life would not be possible. Having assumed a number of basic requirements for the survival of society, the next step is to look at the parts of the social structure to see how they meet such functional prerequisites. Thus a major function of the economic system is the production of food and shelter. An important function of the family is the socialization of new members of society.

From a functionalist perspective, society is regarded as a system. A system is an entity made up of interconnected and interrelated parts. From this viewpoint, it follows that each part will in some way affect every other part and the system as a whole. It also follows that if the system is to survive, its various parts must have some degree of fit or compatibility. Thus a functional prerequisite of society involves a minimal degree of integration between the parts. Many functionalists argue that this integration is based largely on **'value consensus'**, that is on agreement about values by members of society. Thus if the major values of society are expressed in the various parts of the social structure, those parts will be integrated. For example, it can be argued that the value of materialism integrates many parts of the social structure in Western industrial society. The economic system produces a large range of goods and ever increasing productivity is regarded as an important goal. The educational system is partly concerned with producing the skills and expertise to expand production and increase it efficiency. The family is an important unit of consumption with its steadily increasing demand for consumer durables such as washing machines, televisions and three-piece suits. The political system is partly concerned with improving material living standards and raising productivity. To the extent that these parts of the social structure are based on the same value, they may be said to be integrated.

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One of the main concerns of functionalist theory is to explain how social life is possible. The theory assumes that a certain degree of order and stability are essential for the survival of social systems. Functionalism is therefore concerned with society. Many functionalists see shared values as the key to this explanation. **Thus value consensus integrates the various parts of society.** It forms the basis of social unity or social solidarity since individuals will tend to identify and feel kinship with those who share the same values as themselves. Value consensus provides the foundation for cooperation since common values produce common goals. Members of society will tend to cooperate in pursuit of goals which they share. Having attributed such importance to value consensus, many functionalists then focus on the question of how this consensus is maintained. Indeed the American sociologist Talcott Parsons has stated that the main task of sociology is to examine 'the institutionalization of patterns of value orientation in the social system'. Emphasis is therefore placed on the process of socialization whereby values are internalized and transmitted from one generation to the next. In this respect, the family is regarded as a vital part of the social structure. Once learned, values must be maintained. In particular those who deviate from society's values must be brought back into line. Thus the mechanisms of social control are seen as essential to the maintenance of social order.

In summary, society, from a functionalist perspective, is a system made up of interrelated parts. The social system has certain basic needs which must be met if it is to survive. These needs are known as functional prerequisites. The function of any part of society is its contribution to maintenance of society. The major functions of social institutions are those which help to meet the functional prerequisites of society. Since society is a system, there must be some degree of integration between its parts. A minimal degree of integration is therefore a functional prerequisite of society. Many functionalists maintain that the order and stability they see as essential for the maintenance of the social system are largely provided by value consensus. An investigation of the source of value consensus is therefore a major concern of functionalist analysis.

However, with their concern for investigating how functional prerequisites are met, functionalists have concentrated on functions rather than dysfunctions. This emphasis has resulted in many institutions being seen as beneficial and useful to society. Indeed some institutions, such as the family, religion, and social stratification, have been seen as not only beneficial but indispensable. This view has led critics to argue that **functionalism has a built in conservative bias** which supports the status quo. The argument that certain social arrangements are beneficial or indispensable provides support for their retention and rejects proposals for radical change.

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Marxism: The conflict approach

The conflict perspective produces a portrait of society strikingly different from that offered by functionalism. Whereas functionalism emphasizes society's stability, the conflict perspective portrays society as always changing and always marked by conflict. Functionalists tend to focus on social order, to view social change as harmful, and to assume that the social order is based largely on people's willing cooperation. In contrast, proponents of the conflict perspective are inclined to concentrate on social conflict, to see social change as beneficial, and to assume that the social order is forcibly imposed by the powerful on the weak. They criticize the status quo.

The conflict theorists stress inequalities and regard society as a system made of individual and groups which are competing for scarce resources. These groups may form alliances or co-operate with one another, but underneath the surface harmony lies a basic competitive struggle to gain control over scarce resources. Conflict theorists also focus on macro level. In modern society, Karl Marx (1818-83) focused on struggle between the bourgeoisie (owners of production) and proletariat (those who worked for the owners), but today's conflict theorists have expanded this perspective to include smaller groups and even basic relationships.

The conflict perspective originated largely from Karl Marx's writings on class conflict between capitalists and the proletariat. For decades, U.S. sociologists tended to ignore Marx and the conflict perspective because the functionalist perspective dominated their view of society. Since the turbulent 1960s, however, the conflict perspective has gained popularity. Generally, conflict is now defined more broadly. Whereas Marx believed that conflict between *economic* classes was the key force in society, conflict theorists today define social conflict to mean conflict between any *unequal* groups or societies. Thus, they examine conflict between whites and blacks, men and women, one religious group and another, one society and another, and so on. They emphasize that groups or societies have conflicting interests and values and complete with each other for scarce resources. The more powerful groups gain more than the less powerful, but the former continue to seek more wealth and power, while the latter continue to struggle for more resources. Because of this perpetual competition, society or the world is always changing.

The conflict perspective leads sociologists to ask such questions as: which groups are more powerful and which are more weak? How do powerful group benefit from the existing social order, and how are weaker groups hurt? Consider, for example, how the conflict perspective can shed light on prostitution. According to this perspective, prostitution reflects the unequal social positions of men and

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women. In prostitution, members of a dominant group, men, benefit from the exploitation of a weaker group, women. This exploitation is made possible by the existence of a social order in which women are subordinate to men. If the sexes were treated equally – with women having full access to and being equally paid for more respectable types of work as men – women would be unlikely to become prostitutes. Prostitution further reinforces the general dominance of men over women because it helps perpetuate the sexist idea that women are inferior beings who can be used as mere objects for pleasure. In short, prostitution reflects and reinforces the power of one group over another. (You will read more on Marx and his ideas in our discussion on Sociological Thinkers.)

Until now we have discussed the Structural approach, one of the two major strands in sociological theory. While discussing structural approach, we have discussed two main structural approaches in sociology, viz. Consensus theory (Functionalism) and Conflict theory (Marxism). We have also discussed that how these structural approaches are largely positivist in nature. Now, let us discuss the other major strand in sociological theory, that is, the Social Action approach.

As a student of sociology, you must remember that not all sociological perspectives base their analysis upon an examination of the structure of society as a whole. Rather than seeing human behaviour as being largely determined by society, they see society as being the product of human activity. They stress the meaningfulness of human behaviour, denying that it is primarily determined by the structure of society. These approaches are known as social action theory. Max Weber was the first sociologist to advocate a social action approach. In contemporary sociology there are two main varieties of this type of sociology. These are **Symbolic Interactionism** and **Ethnomethodology**. However, before we discuss these approaches in detail, let us first try to understand the general assumptions about social reality that underlie the social action approach.

Social action approach (also called as the phenomenological, interpretive, anti/non-positive or micro sociology) in sociology rejects many of the assumptions of positivism. Social action theorists argue that the subject matter of the social and natural sciences is fundamentally different. As a result the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences are inappropriate to the study of man. The natural sciences deal with matter. To understand and explain the behaviour of matter it is sufficient to observe it from the outside. Atoms and molecules do not have consciousness. They do not have meanings and purposes which direct their behaviour. Matter simply reacts 'unconsciously' to external stimuli; in scientific language it behaves. As a result the natural scientist is able to observe, measure, and impose an external logic on that behaviour in order to explain it. He has no

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need to explore the internal logic of the consciousness of matter simply because it does not exist.

Unlike matter, man has consciousness – thoughts, feelings, meanings, intentions and an awareness of being. Because of this, his actions are meaningful, he defines situations and gives meaning to his actions and those of others. As a result, he does not merely react to external stimuli, he does not simply behave, he acts. Imagine the response of early man to fire caused by volcanoes or spontaneous combustion. He did not simply react in a uniform manner to the experience of heat. He attached a range of meanings to it and these meanings directed his actions. For example he defined fire as a means of warmth and used it to ward off wild animals; and as a means of transforming substance and employed it for cooking and hardening the points of wooden spears. Man does not just react to fire, he acts upon it in terms of the meanings he gives to it. If actions stems from subjective meanings, it follows that the sociologist must discover those meanings in order to understand action. He cannot simply observe action from the outside and impose an external logic upon it. He must interpret the internal logic which directs the actions of the actor.

Max Weber (1864-1920) was one of the first sociologists to outline this perspective in detail. He argued that sociological explanations of actions should begin with 'the observation and theoretical interpretation of the subjective "states of minds" of actors'. Interactionism adopts a similar approach with particular emphasis on the process of interaction. Where positivists emphasize facts and cause and effect relationships, interactionists emphasize insight and understanding. Since it is not possible to get inside the heads of actors, the discovery of meaning must be based on interpretation and intuition. For this reason objective measurement is not possible and the exactitude of the natural science cannot be duplicated. Since meanings are constantly negotiated in ongoing interaction process it is not possible to establish simple cause and effect relationships. Thus some sociologists argue that sociology is limited to an interpretation of social action and hence the social action approaches are also sometimes referred to as 'interpretive sociology'.

A number of sociologists have argued that the positivist approach has produced a distorted picture of social life. They see it as tending to portray man as a passive responder to external stimuli rather than an active creator of his own society. Man is pictured as reacting to various forces and pressures, to economic infrastructures and the requirements of social systems. Peter Berger argues that society has often been viewed as a puppet theatre with its members portrayed as 'little puppets jumping about on the ends of their invisible strings, cheerfully acting out the parts that have been assigned to them'. Society instills values, norms and

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roles, and men dutifully respond like puppets on a string. However, from a social action perspective, man does not merely react and respond to an external society, he is not simply acted upon, he acts. In his interaction with others he creates his own meanings and constructs his own reality and therefore directs his own actions.

The distinction between positivist and anti-positivist (or phenomenological) approaches is not as clear cut as this section has implied. There is considerable debate over whether or not a particular theory should be labeled positivist or anti-positivist (or phenomenological). Often it is a matter of degree since many theories lie somewhere between the two extremes.

Let us now discuss symbolic interactionism and ethnomethodology, the two major social action approaches in detail.

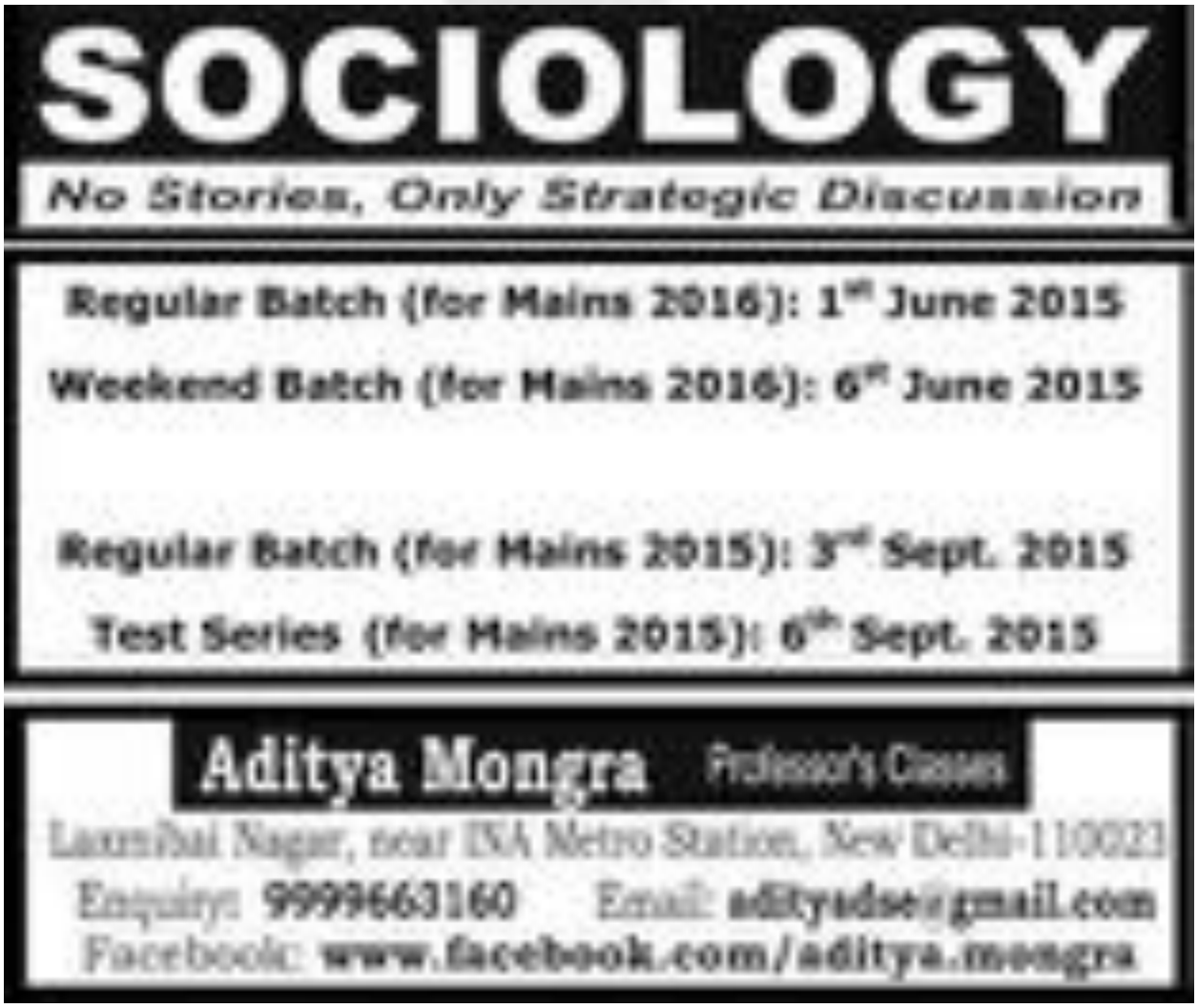
As discussed earlier, both functionalist and conflict perspectives focus on larger social forces of order and conflict, forces that simultaneously affect huge numbers of people across the country. In contract, the symbolic interactionist perspective directs our attention to the details of a specific situation and the interaction between individuals in that situation. The combination of these countless interactions in various situations is seen to constitute society. We can trace the origins of symbolic interactionism to Max Weber's argument that people act according to their interpretation of the meaning of their social world. But it was **George Herbert Mead** (1863-1931), an American philosopher, who introduced symbolic interactionism to sociology in the 1920s.

According to symbolic interactionism, people assign meanings to each other's words and actions. Our response to a person's action is therefore determined not by that person's action in itself but by our *subjective interpretation* of the action. When we speak to a friend, an observer can easily give an objective report of the words we have said. But friend's response will depend not on the words we spoke but on his or her interpretation of the entire interaction; at the same time, out friend's response is influencing what we are saying. If our friend perceives by the way we speak that we are intelligent, this interpretation may make our friend respect and admire us and, perhaps, respond more positively to what we are saying. If we, in turn, catch this interpretation, we may feel proud and speak more confidently. In other words, the exchange is a *symbolic interaction*. It is an interaction between individuals that is governed by their interpretation of the meaning of symbols. In this case, the symbols are primarily spoken words. But a symbol can be anything – an object, a sound, a gesture – that points to something beyond itself. The marks on this paper are symbols because they point to things – they have meanings – beyond black squiggles.

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The symbolic interactionist perspective suggests two things. First, people do not respond directly to physical things. Rather, they respond to their own interpretations of them. Second, because people constantly impose interpretations – on the world in general, on other people, themselves, and even their own interpretations – and then act accordingly, human behaviour is fluid, always changing. How we act is constantly being altered by how we interpret other people's actions and their reactions to our own behaviour. Human behaviour is thus not real in itself but becomes real only after it has been subjected to *reality construction*, the process by which we interpret what a given action means and respond to it in accordance with the interpretation. The symbolic interactionist perspective has been criticized, however, for ignoring the larger issues of national and international order and change. It has also been faulted for ignoring the influence of larger social forces, such as social institutions, groups, cultures, and societies, on individual interactions.



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Ethnomethodology is the most recent of all the theoretical perspectives discussed so far. The term was coined by the American sociologist Harold Garfinkel who is generally regarded as its founder. Garfinkel's book, *Studies in Ethnomethodology*, which provided the initial framework for the perspective was published in 1967. Roughly translated ethnomethodology means the study of the methods used by people. It is concerned with examining the methods and procedures employed by members of society to construct, account for and give meaning to their social world. Ethnomethodologists draw heavily on the European tradition of phenomenological philosophy and in particular acknowledge a debt to the ideas of the philosopher–sociologist Alfred Schutz (1899-1959). Many ethnomethodologists begin with the assumption that society exists only in so far as members perceive its existence. (The term member replaces the interactionist term actor.) With this emphasis on members' views of social reality, ethnomethodology is generally regarded as a phenomenological approach. Ethnomethodology is a developing perspective which contains a diversity of viewpoints. The following account provides a brief and partial introduction.

One of the major concerns of sociology is the explanation of social order. From the results of numerous investigations it appears that social life is ordered and regular and that social action is systematic and patterned. Typically the sociologist has assumed that social order has an objective reality. His research has apparently indicated that it actually exists. He then goes on to explain its origin, to provide causal explanations for its presence. Thus from a functionalist perspective, perspective, social order derives ultimately from the functional prerequisites of social systems which require its presence as a necessary condition of their existence. Social action assumes its systematic and regular nature from the fact that it is governed by values and norms which guide and direct behaviour. From a Marxian perspective social order is seen as precarious but its existence is recognized. It results from the constraints imposed on members of society by their position in the relations of production and from the reinforcement of these constraints by the superstructure. From an interactionist perspective, social order results from interpretive procedures employed by actors in interactions. It is a 'negotiated order' in that it derives from meanings which are negotiated in the process of interaction and involves the mutual adjustment of the actors concerned. The net result is the establishment of social order, of an orderly, regular and patterned process of interaction. Although the above perspectives provide very different explanations for social order, they nevertheless agree that some form of order actually exists and that it therefore has an objective reality.

Ethnomethodologists either suspend or abandon the belief that an actual or objective social order exists. Instead they proceed from the assumption that social life appears orderly to members of society. Thus in the eyes of members their

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everyday activities seem ordered and systematic but this order is not necessarily due to the intrinsic nature or inherent qualities of the social world. In other words it may not actually exist. Rather it may simply appear to exist because of the way members perceive and interpret social reality. Social order therefore becomes a convenient fiction, an appearance of order constructed by members of society. This appearance allows the social world to be described and explained and so made knowable, reasonable, understandable and 'accountable' to its members. The methods and accounting procedures used by members for creating a sense of order form the subject matter of ethnomethodological enquiry. Zimmerman and Wieder state that the ethnomethodologist is concerned with how members of society go about the task of *seeing*, *describing*, and *explaining* order in the world in which they live.

Garfinkel argues that members employ the 'documentary method' to make sense and account for the social world and to give it an appearance of order. This method consists of selecting certain aspects of the infinite number of features contained in any situation or context, of defining them in a particular way and seeing them as evidence of an underlying pattern. The process is then reversed and particular instances of the underlying pattern are then used as evidence for the existence of the pattern. Ethnomethodologists are highly critical of other branches of sociology. They argue that 'conventional' sociologists have misunderstood the nature of social reality. They have treated the social world as if it had an objective reality which is independent of members' accounts and interpretations. By contrast, ethnomethodologists argue that the social world consists of nothing more than the constructs, interpretations and accounts of its members. The job of the sociologist is therefore to explain the methods and accounting procedures which members employ to construct their social world. According to ethnomethodologists, this is the very job that mainstream sociology has failed to do.

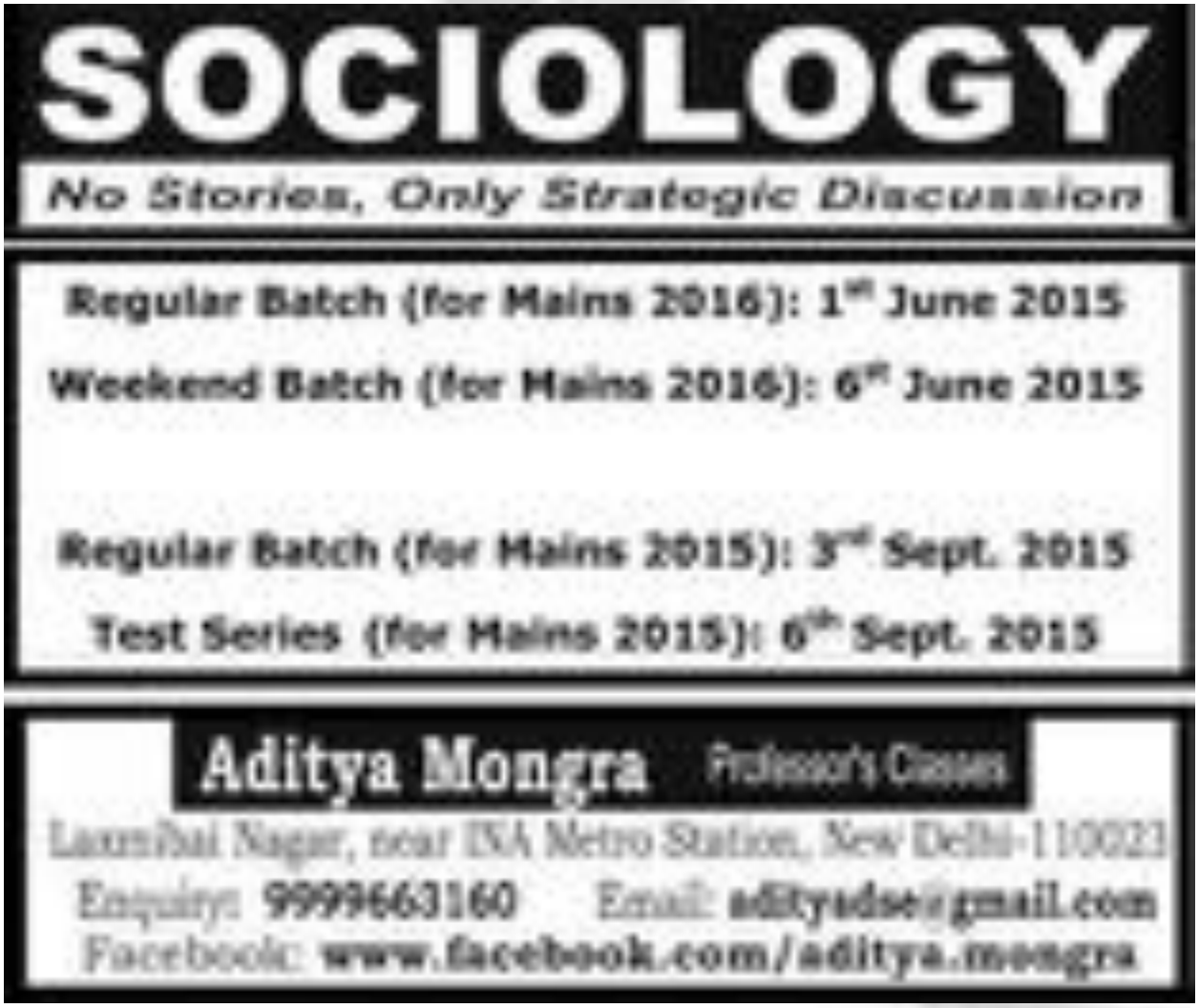
Important: Dear students, after reading about these different perspectives, you may ask: Which one is right? The answer can be found in the following story from sociologist Elliot Liebow (1993):

Mr. Shapiro and Mr. Goldberg had an argument they were unable to resolve.
It was agreed that Mr. Shapiro would present the case to a rabbi.
The rabbi said to Mr. Shapiro, "You are right."
When Mr. Goldberg learned of this, he ran to the rabbi with his version of the argument. The rabbi said to him, "You are right."
Then the rabbi's wife said to the rabbi, "You told Mr. Shapiro he was right and you told Mr. Goldberg he was right. They can't both be right!"
The rabbi said to his wife, "You are right too."

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As the rabbi would say, each of the three perspectives in sociology is right in its own way. Each shows what our world looks like, but only when viewed from a certain angle. Although different, the three perspectives are not really incompatible. To some extent, they are like different perspectives on a house. Looked at from the front, the house has a door, windows, and a chimney on top. From the back, it has a door and a chimney on top but probably fewer windows and may be a porch. From the top, it has no doors or windows, but it has a chimney in the middle. It is the same house, but it looks very different, depending on perspective. Similarly, whether we see functions, conflict, or interaction depends on the position from which we are looking. Each perspective is useful because we cannot take everything about the complex social world into account at once. We need some vantage point. Each perspective tells us what to look for, and each brings some aspect of society and human behaviour into sharper focus. Brought together, these diverse perspectives can enrich our sociological knowledge of the world.



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Reflexive Sociology

Dear Candidate, ***reflexive sociology*** in the newly emerging perspective in sociology. Though it is not explicitly mentioned in the syllabus but a short or long question can anytime be asked in the examination. So, it would be wise here to discuss some of the central arguments of reflexive sociology.

Reflexivity refers to the 'reflexive monitoring of action', that is, the way in which humans think about and reflect upon what they are doing in order to consider acting differently in future. Humans have always been reflexive up to a point, but in pre-industrial societies the importance of tradition limited reflexivity. Humans would do some things simply because they were the traditional things to do. However, with modernity, tradition loses much of its importance and reflexivity becomes the norm. Social reflexivity implies that social practices are constantly examined and reformed in the light of incoming information about those very practices, thus continuously altering their character.

Alvin W. Gouldner (1920-1980), an American sociologist, in his most influential work *The Coming Crisis of Western Sociology* offered a substantial and exhaustive argument for 'reflexive sociology'. Against the view that science in general and sociology in particular is concerned with producing objective truths, Gouldner argued that knowledge is not independent of the knower and that sociology is intimately bound up with the socio-economic and political context in which it exists.

Gouldner advocated 'reflexive sociology' in response to **Methodological Dualism** which was the dominant methodological assumption in early 20th century in American sociology. Methodological dualism was based on the elementary distinction of *subject* and *object*. Natural sciences in general were based on this premise. Since the subject matter of natural sciences was physical reality or matter, their prime concern was to discover the underlying pattern in nature and arrive at certain universal laws which can help in predicting and controlling natural phenomenon. In sociology, methodological dualism was emphasized by scholars belonging to the positivist tradition in France and America. They argued that like natural sciences, social sciences can also study social reality in an objective manner and information thus arrived could be used to predict and control man's social behaviour and social change. Methodological dualism in sociology implied a clear distinction between the *inquiring subject* (social scientist) and the *studied object* (the social group whom he observes). Methodological dualism enjoins the sociologist to be detached from the world he studies. It sees his involvement with his object of study primarily from the standpoint of its contaminating effect upon the information system.

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Gouldner rejects the assumption of methodological dualism in sociology. He argues that positivists who emphasize on methodological dualism in sociology do so primarily because they conceive of knowledge only as information. But, according to Gouldner, the ultimate goal of sociology is not to seek neutral information about social reality but rather such knowledge which facilitates a better understanding of social reality in terms of men's changing interests, expectations, values, etc. In this regard, Gouldner cites the example of Weber's *Verstehen* method. In contrast to positivists, Weber had emphasized the need for the interpretative understanding of social action. He argued that in order to have a better understanding of social action, it is necessary to take into account the unique meanings and motives that underlie such action. Weber suggests that this can be done by the sociologist by establishing empathetic liaison with the actor. In other words, it implies that the sociologist should imaginatively place himself in the actor's position and then try to understand the motives of the actor which guided his action.

Gouldner further extends this argument of Weber and argues that the knowledge of the world cannot be advanced apart from the sociologist's knowledge of himself and his position in the social world. He argues that to know others, a sociologist cannot simply study them but must also listen to and confront himself. Awareness of the self is seen as an indispensable avenue to awareness of the social world. Reflexive sociology aims at transforming the sociologist's relation to his work. It is characterized by the relationship it establishes between being a sociologist and being a person, between the role and the man performing it.

Reflexive sociology rejects the subject-object dichotomy, that is, sociologist who studies and those whom he studies or observes. Rather, the historical mission of sociology, according to Gouldner is to raise the sociologist's awareness of himself and his position in the social world. Thus, a reflexive sociologist must become aware of himself as both *knower* and as *agent of change*. He cannot know others unless he also knows his intentions toward and his effects upon them. He cannot know others without knowing himself, his place in the social world, and the forces – in society and in himself – to which he is subjected.

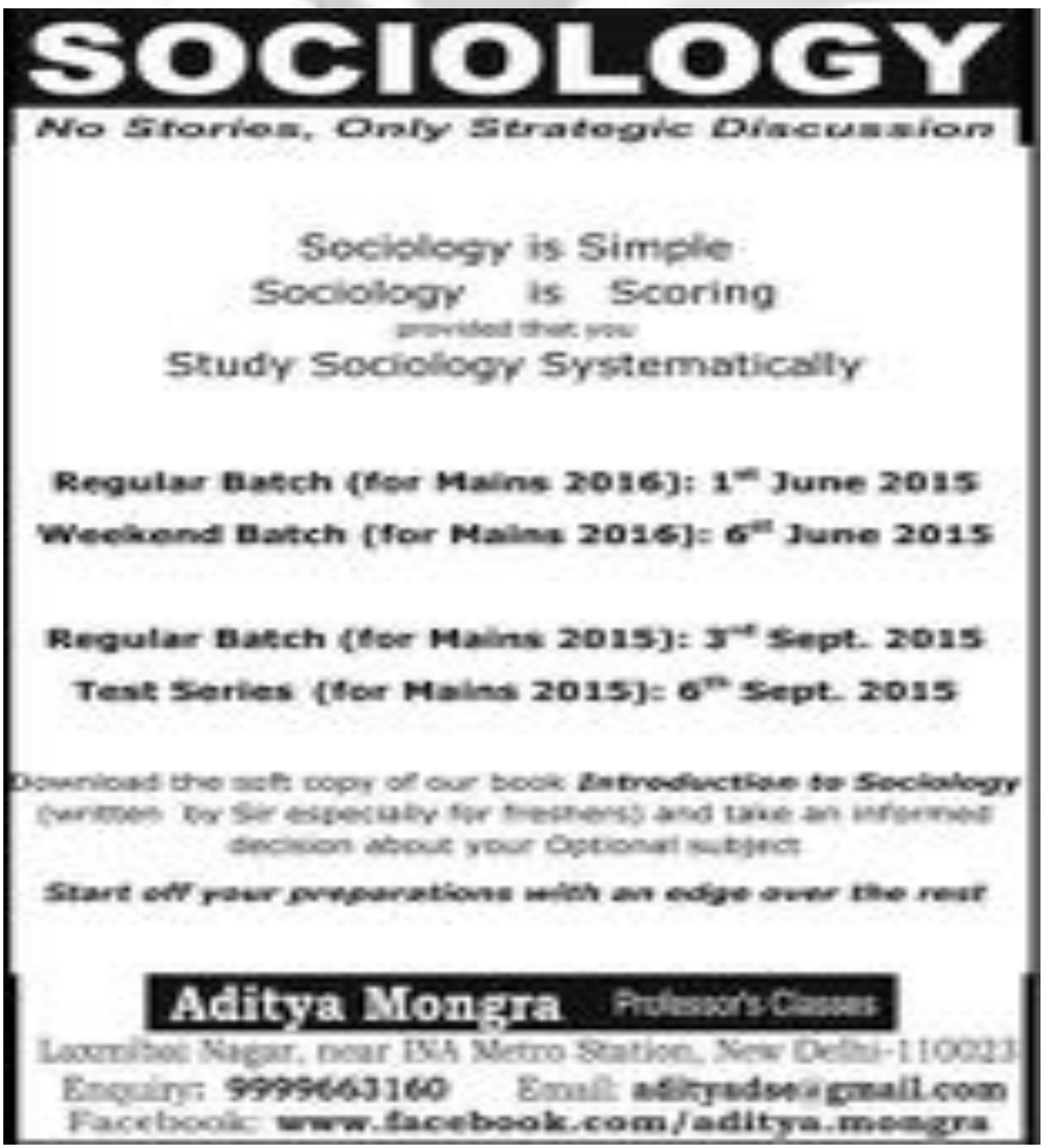
Gouldner argues that reflexive sociology is radical sociology. It is radical because in contrast to positivism, it rejects the assumption of methodological dualism i.e. subject-object dichotomy. It is radical because it is a historically sensitive sociology as it seeks to deepen the awareness of sociologists about themselves, of their own historically evolving character and of their place in a historically evolving society. It is radical because it embodies and advances certain specific values. As a work ethic, it affirms the creative potential of the sociologist and encourages him to take an independent stand of his own and resist the

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demands for conformity by the established authorities and institutions. Hence, according to Gouldner, a reflexive sociology would be a moral sociology.

Dear Candidate, the long question on reflexivity can also be asked in context of its comparison with positivist tradition, which I think you would be able to answer. But, the examiner may also ask a question on reflexivity in context of its implications on the changing landscape of 'field' and the practices of fieldwork in social anthropological research. This I will discuss in detail in the topic 'field' in our next section on *Research Methods and Analysis*.



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Fact, Value and Objectivity

The word **fact** derives from the Latin *factum*. A fact is something that has really occurred or is actually the case. The usual test for a statement of fact is its verifiability, that is, whether it can be proven to correspond to experience. Scientific facts are verified by repeatable experiments. Thus, a fact is regarded as an empirically verifiable observation. A **theory**, on the other hand, is a set of ideas which provides an explanation for something. It is an abstract and generalized statement which tends to establish a logical interrelationship between facts (concepts or variables). Theories involve constructing abstract interpretations that can be used to explain a wide variety of empirical situations.

Thus, in sociology, we can say that a sociological theory is a set of ideas which provides an explanation for human society. As discussed earlier, sociology is a scientific study of society and as we know that scientific research is a guided search for facts based on the formulated hypothesis. A hypothesis is a tentative statement asserting a relationship between certain facts. It is the hypothesis that guides the researcher what data to look for. A social scientist or researcher conducts a field research and collects data (facts) in order to test the hypothesis. After data collection, data is processed. Thereafter, the researcher tests the hypothesis against the processed data. If the hypothesis is proved (i.e. supported by data) then it becomes **thesis** – if it is repeatedly proved, it becomes a **theory** and if it is almost universally true, then if becomes the **law**.

Thesis → Theory → Law

Thesis, Theory and Law, they all are generalizations. They represent different degrees of generalizations. In natural sciences, we hear about several laws but in social sciences we only have theories. Social sciences study social behaviour of man which is guided by unique meanings and motives, values and beliefs, etc. Hence, given the diversity and dynamism of human society in general, it is nearly impossible to arrive at a universally valid generalization or law of human society.

Let us now discuss the interrelationship of theory and facts (empirical research). Robert K. Merton, the American sociologist, has elaborated on this aspect in detail in his essays. In his essay '*The bearing of sociological theory on empirical research*' he argues that without a theoretical approach, we would not know what facts to look for in beginning a study or in interpreting the results of research. Often, existing theories serve as a source for hypothesis formulation and thus stimulate and guide further research resulting in discovery of new facts. For example, Marxian theory suggests that increasing economic inequalities are the primary cause of alienation and class conflict in modern capitalist societies. This

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theory can serve as a source for our hypothesis to understand the rising discontentment among masses in the contemporary Indian society. Thus you may start exploring that to what extent economic inequality is a factor in the rise of Naxalism or caste conflicts in rural India, etc. Thus theory helps to define which kinds of facts are relevant. Secondly, theory establishes a rational link between two or more variables and thus can act as a tool for prediction and control. For example, various theories have highlighted female education as a critical factor in the overall social development. Thus, in order to improve their ranking on the social development index, countries with low female education can initiate female education programmes at national level because we now know that female education has direct bearing on the social development of a society. Thirdly, as stated earlier, theory is an abstract and generalized statement which tends to establish a logical interrelationship between facts (concepts or variables). Theories involve constructing abstract interpretations and thus make the knowledge cross-culturally useful. For example, Weber's ideal type of bureaucracy is nothing but an abstraction which can serve as tool for a comparative study of bureaucratic models across societies.

Merton in his another essay '*The bearing of empirical research on sociological theory*' argues that empirical research is generally assigned a rather passive role: the testing or verification of hypotheses. Merton argues that empirical research goes far beyond the passive role of verifying and testing theory: it does more than confirm or refute hypotheses. According to Merton, research plays an active role: it performs at least four major functions which help shape the development of theory. It *initiates*, it *reformulates*, it *deflects* and it *clarifies* theory. Merton explain in his essay that how under certain conditions, a research finding gives rise to social theory. He calls it **'*serendipity pattern*'**. Merton argues that fruitful empirical research not only tests theoretically derived hypothesis, it also originates new hypothesis. This might be termed the 'serendipity' component of research, *i.e.*, the discovery, by chance or sagacity, of valid results which were not sought for. In simpler words, it implies that during the course of research some unanticipated but strategic data may come to light, which may initiate a new theory altogether. For example, Elton Mayo, a professor at the Harvard Business School, in his investigation at the Hawthorne plant of Western Electric Company in Chicago, conducted a series of experiments designed to investigate the relationship between working conditions and productivity. Mayo began with the assumptions of scientific management believing that the physical conditions of the work environment, the aptitude of the worker and the financial incentives were the main determinants of productivity. However, during the course of his research Mayo struck upon the role of informal groups and group norms in determining the productivity. From the Hawthorne studies, developed the human relations school, which challenged and led to the reformulation of the conventional scientific

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management approach. It stated that scientific management provided too narrow a view of man and that financial incentives alone were insufficient to motivate workers and ensure their cooperation. The Hawthorne studies moved the emphasis from the individual worker to the worker as a member of a social group. The behaviour of the worker was seen as a response to group norms rather than simply being directed by economic incentives and management designed work schemes. It was found that the informal work groups develop their own norms and values which are enforced by the application of group sanctions. The power of such sanctions derives from the dependence of the individual upon the group. He has a basic need to belong, to feel part of a social group. He needs approval, recognition and status, needs which cannot be satisfied if he fails to conform to group norms.

Thus there is an intricate relation between theory and fact. Facts (empirical research) and theory are inherently dependent on each other. Factual research and theories can never completely be separated. We can only develop valid theoretical approaches if we are able to test them out by means of factual research.

Important: Dear candidate, since the topic mentioned in the syllabus is '*Fact, Value and Objectivity*', I wish to give you a few hints in case the examiner asks you the role or significance of facts and values in sociology. As you know that a fact is an empirically verifiable observation. It is objective in nature. A value, on the other hand, is subjective in nature. Values are socially accepted standards of desirability. In other words, a value is a belief that something is good and desirable. It defines what is important and worthwhile. Values differ from society to society and culture to culture.

The significance of facts was asserted by the early founding fathers of sociology, be it Comte, Spencer or Durkheim. Remember? We had discussed earlier that how these scholars advocated a positivist approach to study society i.e. they emphasised on the study of only those aspects of social reality which could be empirically observed and hence quantified. Anti-positivist scholars, on the other hand, argued that the subject matter of sociology is the study of human behaviour in society and all human behaviour is guided by values. Hence, these scholars, be it Max Weber, Mead, etc. suggested social action approach to study society.

In this manner, with the limited content, you can easily formulate a good analytical answer. But you must support all your arguments with suitable examples to score better than the others.

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Now we will discuss the role of values in sociological enquiry and associated with it is the problem of objectivity.

As stated earlier, the subject matter of sociology is the study of human behaviour in society. All human behaviour is guided by values. Moreover, social research is in itself a type of social behaviour guided by the value of 'search for true knowledge.' Values are socially accepted standards of desirability. In other words, a value is a belief that something is good and desirable. It defines what is important and worthwhile. Values differ from society to society and culture to culture. For example, in West, the dominant values are individualism and materialism which are this-wordly in nature. While in India, *moksha* had been a long cherished goal of human life which is other-wordly in nature.

In order to have a complete understanding of man's social behaviour it is not only important but also necessary to take into account the unique meanings, motives and values that underlie such behaviour. Initially this view was advocated by anti-positivists scholars (also known as neo-Kantian scholars in Germany) like Wilhelm Dilthey (1833-1911), Wilhelm Windelband (1848-1915) and Heinrich Rikert (1863-1936). Later, Weber also argued that behaviour of man in society is qualitatively different from that of physical objects and biological organisms. He argued that unlike matter, man has consciousness – thoughts, feelings, meanings, intentions and an awareness of being. Because of this, his actions are meaningful. He defines situations and gives meaning to his actions and those of others. As a result, he does not merely react to external stimuli, he does not simply behave, he acts. Thus, if action stems from subjective meanings, it follows that the sociologist must discover those meanings in order to understand action. He cannot simply observe action from the outside and impose an external logic upon it. He must interpret the internal logic which directs the actions of the actor.

However, the views mentioned above are quite antithetical to the propositions of positivist tradition in sociology. Auguste Comte, who is credited with inventing the term sociology and regarded as one of the founders of the discipline, maintained that the application of the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences would produce a 'positive science of society'. In terms of sociology, the positivist approach makes the following assumptions. The behaviour of man, like the behaviour of matter, can be objectively measured. Just as the behaviour of matter can be quantified by measures such as weight, temperature and pressure, methods of objective measurement can also be devised for human behaviour. The positivist approach in sociology places particular emphasis on behaviour that can be directly observed. It argues that factors which are not directly observable such as meanings, feelings, motives, etc. are not particularly important and can be misleading. This is best manifested in the works of

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Durkheim. Durkheim in his *"Rules of Sociological Method"* states that social facts must be treated as 'things' and all the preconceived notions about the social facts must be abandoned.

On the basis of the above discussed ideas of both positivist and anti-positivist scholars, one thing is clear that without taking into account the values that underlie human behaviour, a comprehensive understanding of man's social behaviour would not be possible. Our reliance on positivist approach alone would produce a partial picture of social reality. But if we undertake study of values as well in the course of sociological research then the problem of objectivity raises its head (because we know that values are subjective). Let us now discuss what does objectivity means and how different scholars have tried to address the problem of objectivity in sociology.

Objectivity is a 'frame of mind' so that the personal prejudices or preferences of the social scientists do not contaminate the collection and analysis of data. Objectivity is the goal of scientific investigation. Sociology also being a science aspires for the goal of objectivity. Thus, scientific investigations should be free from the prejudices of race, colour, religion, sex or ideological biases. The need of objectivity in sociological research has been emphasized by all important sociologists. For example, Durkheim, in this '*Rules of the Sociological Method*' stated that 'social facts' must be treated as 'things' and all preconceived notions about the social facts must be abandoned. Even Max Weber emphasized the need of objectivity when he said that sociology must be value-free. According to Radcliffe-Brown, the social scientist must abandon or transcend his ethnocentric and egocentric biases while carrying out researches. Similarly, Malinowski advocated 'cultural relativism' while conducting anthropological field work in order to ensure objectivity.

However, objectivity continues to be an elusive goal at the practical level. In fact, one school of thought represented by Gunnar Myrdal states that complete objectivity in social sciences is a myth. Gunnar Myrdal in his book 'Objectivity in Social Research' argues that total objectivity is an illusion which can never be achieved. Because all research is always guided by certain viewpoints and viewpoints involve subjectivity. Myrdal argues that subjectivity creeps in at various stages in the course of sociological research. For example, the very choice of topic of research is influenced by personal preferences and ideological biases of the researcher. How personal preferences influence the choice of topic of research can be illustrated from a study made by Prof. Schwab. In his study he analyzed 4000 scientific papers produced over a span of centuries. He found that the choice made by scientists in pursuing their research was based on their personal preferences as determined by personality factors and social circumstances.

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Besides personal preferences, the ideological biases, acquired in the course of education and training also have a bearing on the choice of the topic of research. The impact of ideological biases on social research can be very far reaching as can be seen from the study of Tepostalan village in Mexico. Robert Redfield studied it with a functionalist perspective and concluded that there exists total harmony between various groups in the village while Oscar Lewis studied this village at almost the same time from Marxist perspective, and found that the society was conflict ridden. Here we can see that how the differences of ideological perspectives had a bearing on the research findings even though the society studied was the same.

Subjectivity can also creep in at the time of formulation of hypothesis. Normally hypotheses are deducted from existing body of theory. Now all sociological theories are produced by and limited to particular groups whose view points and interests they represent. Thus formulation of hypotheses will automatically introduce a bias in the sociological research.

The fourth stage at which subjectivity creeps in the course of research is that of collection of empirical data. No technique of data collection is perfect. Each technique may lead to subjectivity in one way or the other. For example, in case of participant observation, the observer as a result of *'nativisation'* acquires a bias in favour of the group he is studying. While in non-participant observation, the sociologist belongs to a different group than that under study. He is likely to impose his values and prejudices. In all societies there are certain prejudices. For e.g., in America, people have prejudices against the Blacks and in India, people have prejudices against untouchables or women. Such prejudices of the observer may influence his observation. Further, in case of interview as a technique of data collection, the data may be influenced by (i) context of the interview; (ii) interaction of the participants; (iii) participants' definition of the situation; (iv) and if adequate rapport does not extend between them there might be communication barriers. Thus, according to P.V. Young, interview sometimes carries a double dose of subjectivity.

Finally subjectivity can also creep in due to field limitations as was found in case of Andre Beteille's study of Sripuram village in Tanjore where the Brahmins did not allow him to visit the untouchable locality and study their point of view.

Thus complete objectivity continues to be an elusive goal. Myrdal argues that sociology at best could aspire for the goal of value-neutrality on the part of the researcher. This could be attained by either of the following ways:

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i. The researcher should exclude all ideological or non-scientific assumptions from his research;

ii. The researcher should make his value-preference clear in the research monograph. As Weber has also stated that the researcher should be value-frank;

iii. The researcher should not make any evaluative judgement about empirical evidence;

iv. The researcher should remain indifferent to the moral implication of his research;

v. Highly trained and skilled research workers should be employed.

vi. Various methods of data collection should be used and the result obtained from one should be cross checked with those from the other.

vii. Field limitations must be clearly stated in the research monograph.

Eminent sociologist T. K. Oommen in his book *Knowledge and Society* emphasizes the importance of 'contextualization' in sociological enquiry. Oommen argues that while objectivity in natural sciences is *generalizing objectivity*, in social sciences it is *particularizing objectivity*. He suggests that objectivity in social sciences has to be *contextual objectivity*. Contextual objectivity, according to Oommen, can be determined by intra-subjectivity and inter-subjectivity. Intra-subjectivity is one where the same researcher (with his given value orientation) studies the same object (the social group) at two different points of time and arrives at the similar conclusions. Inter-subjectivity, on the other hand, is one when two researchers (with similar value orientations) study the same object at the same time and arrive at similar conclusions.

Of late, a group of American sociologists who have come to be known as 'radical sociologists', have advocated that total value-neutrality is not desirable. Commitment to total political neutrality reduces the sociologist to the status of a mere spectator and sociologists can play no creative role in the society. After all the basic purpose of sociological knowledge is social welfare. But, given such excessive preoccupation with value-neutrality, the role of sociologists has been like, to use W.H. Auden's phrase, "Lecturing on navigation while the ship is going down." C. Wright Mills has also complained that sociology has lost its 'reforming push'. Alvin W. Gouldner, most remembered for his work *The Coming Crisis of Western Sociology* (1970), argued that sociology must turn away from producing

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objective truths and understand the subjective nature of sociology and knowledge in general and how it is bound up with the context of the times. He called for a *reflexive sociology* in which there would be no forgetting of the idea that the sociologist was part of society and played a social role. As the commonplace has it, sociology cannot be practiced outside its historical and social context. Thus, according to C. Wright Mills, Alvin W. Gouldner and others, sociology must have commitment to certain basic human values and sociologists should be ready to defend human freedom and the pursuit of reason.



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Quantitative and qualitative methods

(including Field: Issues and Context)

Dear Candidate, before proceeding with our discussion on quantitative and qualitative research methods, I would like you to recall our discussion on 'Major theoretical strands of research methodology'. There I had mentioned that broadly we can identify two major traditions in sociological theory. They are the positivist and anti-positivist traditions. I had also discussed the various sociological perspectives that fall under each category. Most importantly, I had also cautioned you that how we conceive of society cannot be separated from the question of how we should proceed in our study of it. In other words, what methodology a researcher would adopt in carrying out his research would largely be determined by the perspective or orientation that he has towards social reality. In our discussion, I had made it clear that the emphasis on the objective measurement of human social behaviour forces the positivist scholars to rely more on the quantitative methods while conducting research. While on the other hand, anti-positivist scholars who emphasise on the interpretative understanding of the social behaviour rely more on qualitative methods.

However, whatsoever be the perspective and methodology of the researcher, ultimately he has to carry out his research in the field. The topic 'field' has not been explicitly mentioned in the syllabus but the theme based approach suggests that any discussion on research methodology would be futile without understanding field and issues associated with it. So let's first understand what 'field' implies in a sociological enquiry and what are the problems or challenges associated with the field-work.

In the context of sociological research, the term 'field' refers to the members of a social group which is the prime object of study for a social scientist. In its early phase, Malinowski and Radcliffe-Brown laid the foundations of intensive fieldwork among anthropologists in Britain. However, in Indian context, it was M.N. Srinivas who strongly advocated for the 'field-view' of Indian society in place of the 'book-view'. Book-view of Indian society was largely championed by the Indologists like B.K. Sarkar, G.S. Ghurey, Radhakamal Mukerjee, Irawati Karve. Indologists claimed that Indian society could be understood only through the concepts, theories and frameworks of Indian civilization. They believed that an examination of the classical texts, manuscripts, archaeological artefacts, etc. should be the starting point for the study of the present.

Srinivas was critical of the 'book-view' of Indian society. He argued that the book-view gave a distorted picture of society by dwelling on the ideals of the past

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from which the present reality departed considerably. The book-view of Indian society presented an idealized picture of its institutions – marriage, family, kinship, caste and religion – dwelling more on what they were supposed to be than how they actually worked. For example, the book-view had represented caste in terms of the invariant and immutable scheme of the four *varnas*. Field studies shifted attention away from the four-fold scheme of *varnas* to the operative units of the system which were the innumerable *jatis*. They also drew attention to the ambiguities of caste ranking and the very distinctive process of caste mobility. Thus, the field-view revealed the gap everywhere between ideal and the actual. By bringing to attention ambiguities, contradictions and conflicts, it paved the way for a better understanding of the dynamics of social change. Thus, the idea of an unchanging and immutable society began to give way, and the field-view changed not only the perception of India's present, but to some extent also the perception of its past.

However, like every other method, field-work too is marked by its own set of challenges and problems in conducting a genuine sociological research. Firstly and foremostly, the researcher faces the problem of the choice of the 'field' to carry out his field-work as no typical field exists in reality. As stated earlier, unlike natural sciences, sociology cannot study any particular social phenomena in a laboratory by the experimental method due to certain moral and ethical reasons. As a result, social research takes place in the open, where, unlike a scientific experiment, it is extremely difficult to control the extraneous variables. Hence, it becomes increasingly challenging for the social scientist to establish a cause-effect relationship between the variables stated under hypothesis. After having identified the field for his research, the researcher faces the challenge of entry into the field. This implies that unless the researcher is able to establish a good rapport with the natives, he would find it hard to carry out his research. Thus, in order to seek the cooperation of the native population for his data collection, the researcher must gain their acceptability. In this, the social background of the researcher also plays an important role.

Further, since the researcher can only carry out a limited study of any given social phenomenon, the problem of holism looms large. Since holistic study appears impractical in study of complex societies, the researcher should keep in mind that the segment he is studying is the part of a larger and complex whole and should look for interrelationships. Researcher may also face problem in the formulation of hypothesis and might have to reformulate or modify his hypothesis because hypotheses cannot be formulated in the vacuum, without the knowledge of the field. Further, the issues of objectivity and ethical-neutrality also need to be addressed. The researcher should be aware of his biases and prejudices and try to make certain that they do not influence his collection and interpretation of data.

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Though some of these challenges are endemic to any social science enquiry, yet they can be dealt with a cautious and informed approach on the part of the researcher. Since the field-work basically involves dealing with people, the researcher must be empathetic and flexible in his approach and employ the services of well trained field workers.

In the ultimate analysis, it may be argued that in any field research, the sociologist is an integral part of the research process. The data so collected has no existence independent of him. His data are 'constructions, not reflections of facts or relationships alone. In the process of knowing, external facts are sensorily perceived and transformed into conceptual knowledge. Thus, the sociologist as a researcher in an active factor in the creation of knowledge and not just a mere passive recipient. The importance of his perception makes a sociologist as integral a part of the research process as the data he observes.

Dear Candidates, I had mentioned in our earlier discussion on reflexivity that a long question on reflexivity may be asked in reference to its contribution in reconstituting the 'field' and the practices of fieldwork in social anthropological research. Let us try to understand it.

As you now know that reflexivity offers an alternate perspective to study social reality. Reflexivity in social anthropological research implies that the ideas about 'field' and 'practices' of field-work are constantly examined and reformed in the light of new developments, thus continuously altering their character. Reflexivity challenges the conventional notions of anthropological research with regard to field and practices of field-work. Early social anthropological research was largely concerned with the study of small scale societies in their natural state or surroundings. Hence the term 'field' came to denote a distinct social group which was to be studied in its unique socio-cultural and geographical setting. Early anthropological research was largely based on the dichotomy of subject and object. In other words, it was based on the separation of the social scientist (subject) from those 'others' whom he observes (object). It was based on the assumption that over involvement of the social scientist with his object of study (social group) may contaminate the research findings. The idea about 'otherness' remained remarkably central to the fieldwork practices of Malinowski, A.R. Radcliffe-Brown, etc.

Amory shows how these ideas about 'otherness' and taking for granted of a white subject have shaped the field of African studies in the United States. She shows that African American scholars were discouraged from working in Africa, on the grounds that they were "too close" and would not manage to be "objective", while white scholars were judged to have the appropriate distance from the black "other". This helps to explain that why the contemporary field of African studies

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contains remarkably few black American scholars. Kath Weston too in her study of gay and lesbian communities in United States arrived at a similar conclusion. She argued that her position as a native ethnographer itself blurs the subject-object distinction on which ethnography is conventionally founded. She calls native ethnographer as a 'virtual anthropologist'.

Akhil Gupta and James Ferguson also question the conventional notion of field and argue that in the light of new developments there is a need for reconstruction of field and field-work practices. They argue that processes such decolonization and globalization, accompanied by processes of diffusion and acculturation, have challenged the traditional definition of field and the very idea of a clearly demarcated space of 'otherness'. They argue that the conventional notion about the 'field' in terms of a homogenous social group with its unique culture and geographical surroundings has come to be questioned in the wake of globalization. Social groups are no longer tightly territorialized or spatially bounded. Further, the process of diffusion and acculturation, have significantly altered the homogenous character of social groups and today cultural heterogeneity is more common.

Gupta and Ferguson further question the 'field-home dichotomy' in social anthropological research. They question the traditional notion of field which rested on the idea that different cultures exist in discrete and separate places. They argued that the 'location' of the field should not merely be seen in geographical sense alone. They advocated retheorizing of fieldwork from spatial sites to social and political locations in terms of unequal power relations. For example, subaltern approach in sociology has significantly contributed towards a better understanding of various socio-economic and political processes in India, which were until now largely studied from an elitist perspective. Gupta and Ferguson argue that with decolonization, there is proliferation of domestic research led by the natives. As a result, today, the very idea of 'otherness', which was central to the early anthropological fieldwork, is subjected to review. Hence, there is a need to modify the practices of fieldwork accordingly.

Further, Gupta and Ferguson also question the fundamental premise of early anthropological field-work practices that only professionally trained observers could be trusted to collect ethnographic data. As Paul Radin in his study found that his untrained native research assistants proved to be better than the academically and professionally qualified observers in terms of gathering valuable data. This is because, as Radin argues that such professionals are socially separated from those whom they study by their very training. The training of the professional observers erects an undesirable barrier between themselves and the persons to be interrogated. It may lead to a difficulty in establishing direct and immediate contact

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and building rapport with their sources of information. While on the other hand, the native research assistants or local intellectuals are better positioned at least for certain sorts of data collection.

Thus, reflexivity has significantly contributed in reconstruction of the ideas about field and field-work practices in social anthropology. Such a rethinking of the idea of the 'field' coupled with an explicit attentiveness to 'location' might open the way for a different kind of anthropological knowledge and a different kind of anthropological subject.



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Let us now discuss now discuss some of the fundamental characteristics of quantitative as well as qualitative research methods.

As you know that sociology first developed in Europe in the nineteenth century when industrialization resulted in massive social changes. Accompanying these social changes were intellectual changes during which science started to enjoy a higher reputation than ever before. Science appeared to be capable of producing objective knowledge that could be used to solve human problems and increase human productive capacity in an unprecedented way. It was not surprising therefore, that many early sociologists chose to turn to science for a methodology on which to base their subject. However, not all sociologists have agreed that it is appropriate to adopt the methodology of the natural sciences. For these sociologists, studying human behaviour is fundamentally different from studying the natural world. Unlike the subject matter of, for example, chemistry or physics, people possess consciousness, which means that sociology requires a different type of methodology from science. Thus on the basis of the above discussion, two broad traditions within sociology could be identified.

1. Those who advocated the use of scientific and usually quantitative methods. (Positivists)
2. Those who supported the use of more humanistic and qualitative methods. (Anti-Positivists)

Though in recent years, some sociologists have questioned the need for such a rigid division between quantitative and qualitative methodology, and have advocated combining the two approaches.

Quantitative Research Methods:

Quantitative research in sociology is largely associated with the 'positivist tradition'. Early sociologists belonging to the positivist tradition such as Comte, Spencer, Durkheim, etc. believed that the methods and procedures of natural sciences could be adopted in sociology as well. Quantitative research is associated with a number of techniques of data collection such as survey, questionnaire, structured interview and secondary sources of data, etc. Some of the features of quantitative research in sociology are discussed below:

1. **Social facts:** As a positivist, Comte believed that the scientific study of society should be confined to collecting information about phenomena that can be objectively observed and classified. Comte argued that sociologists should not be concerned with the internal meanings, motives, feelings and emotions of individuals. Since these mental states exist only in the person's

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consciousness, they cannot be observed and so they cannot be measured in any objective way. Similarly, Durkheim also argued that social facts should be treated as *'things'*. This means that the belief systems, customs and institutions of society – the facts of the social world – should be considered as things in the same way as the objects and events of the natural world.

2. **Statistical data:** The second aspect of quantitative approach as advocated by positivists is the use of statistical data. Positivists believed it was possible to classify the social world in an objective way. Using these classifications it was then possible to count sets of observable social facts and so produce statistics. For example, Durkheim collected data on social facts such as the suicide-rate and membership of different religions.

3. **Correlation:** The third aspect of positivist methodology entails looking for correlations between different social facts. In his study of suicide, Durkheim found an apparent correlation between a particular religion, Protestantism, and a high suicide rate.

4. **Causation:** The fourth aspect of positivist methodology involves a search for causal connections. The quantitative research is highly preoccupied with establishing the causal relationship between variables. If there is a strong correlation between two or more types of social phenomena, then a positivist sociologist might suspect that one of these phenomena was causing the other to take place. For example, Durkheim in his study of suicide had explained that low solidarity among the Protestants was the causal factor for high suicide rate amongst them.

5. **Generalization and Replicability:** The quantitative researcher is invariably concerned to establish that his result of a particular investigation can be generalized to the larger population. Positivists like Comte and Durkheim, believed that just as natural sciences could arrive at universal laws with regard to matter, similarly, laws of human behaviour can also be discovered in social sciences. They believed that laws of human behaviour can be discovered by the collection of objective facts about the social world, by the

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careful analysis of these facts and by repeated checking of the findings in a series of contexts (replication).

Positivism is based upon an understanding of science that sees science as using a mainly inductive methodology. An inductive methodology starts by collecting the data. The data are then analysed, and out of this analysis theories are developed. Once the theory has been developed it can then be tested against other sets of data to see if it is confirmed or not. If it is repeatedly confirmed (replicated), then positivists like Comte, Durkheim, etc. assume that they have discovered a law of human behaviour.

Qualitative Research Methods:

A significant number of sociologists choose not to use the more scientific approaches to the study of human behaviour. They prefer to sacrifice a certain precision of measurement and objectivity in order to get closer to their subjects, to examine the social world through the perspective of the people they are investigating. These sociologists sometimes refer to quantitative researchers as those who "measure everything and understand nothing." Qualitative research fundamentally refers to that approach to the study of the social world which seeks to describe and analyse the culture and behaviour of humans and their groups from the point of view of those being studied. As we have discussed earlier that quantitative data are data in a numerical form: for example, official statistics on crime, suicide and divorce rates. By comparison, qualitative data are usually presented in words. These may be a description of a group of people living in poverty, providing a full and in-depth account of their way of life, or a transcript of an interview in which people describe and explain their attitude towards and experience of religion. Compared to quantitative data, qualitative data are usually seen as richer, more vital, as having greater depth and as more likely to present a true picture of a way of life, of people's experiences, attitudes and beliefs. Participant observation, unstructured interview, focus group discussion, life-history or case study method are some of the major methods or techniques of data collection in qualitative research. The main intellectual undercurrents which tend to be viewed as providing qualitative research with their distinct methodology are phenomenology, symbolic interactionism, *verstehen*, ethnomethodology, etc. Some of the features of qualitative research in sociology are discussed below:

1. **Empathetic description of social reality:** The most fundamental characteristic of qualitative research is its express commitment to viewing events, actions, norms, values, etc. from the perspective of the people who are being studied.

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2. **Contextualism:** Qualitative research exhibits a preference for contextualism in its commitment to understanding events, behaviour, etc. in their respective context. It is almost inseparable from another theme in qualitative research, namely 'holism' which entails an undertaking to examine social entities – schools, tribes, firms, slums, delinquent groups, communities, or whatever – as wholes to be explicated and understood in their entirety.

3. **Emphasis on processual dimension:** Qualitative research views social life in processual, rather than static terms. The emphasis on process can be seen as a response to the qualitative researcher's concern to reflect the reality of everyday life which, they tend to argue, takes the form of streams of interconnecting events. The general image that qualitative research conveys about the social order is one of interconnection and change.

4. **Flexibility:** Qualitative researchers tend to favour a research strategy which is relatively open and unstructured. Such strategy allows them access to unexpectedly important topics which may not have been visible to them had they foreclosed the domain of study by a structured, and hence potentially rigid strategy.

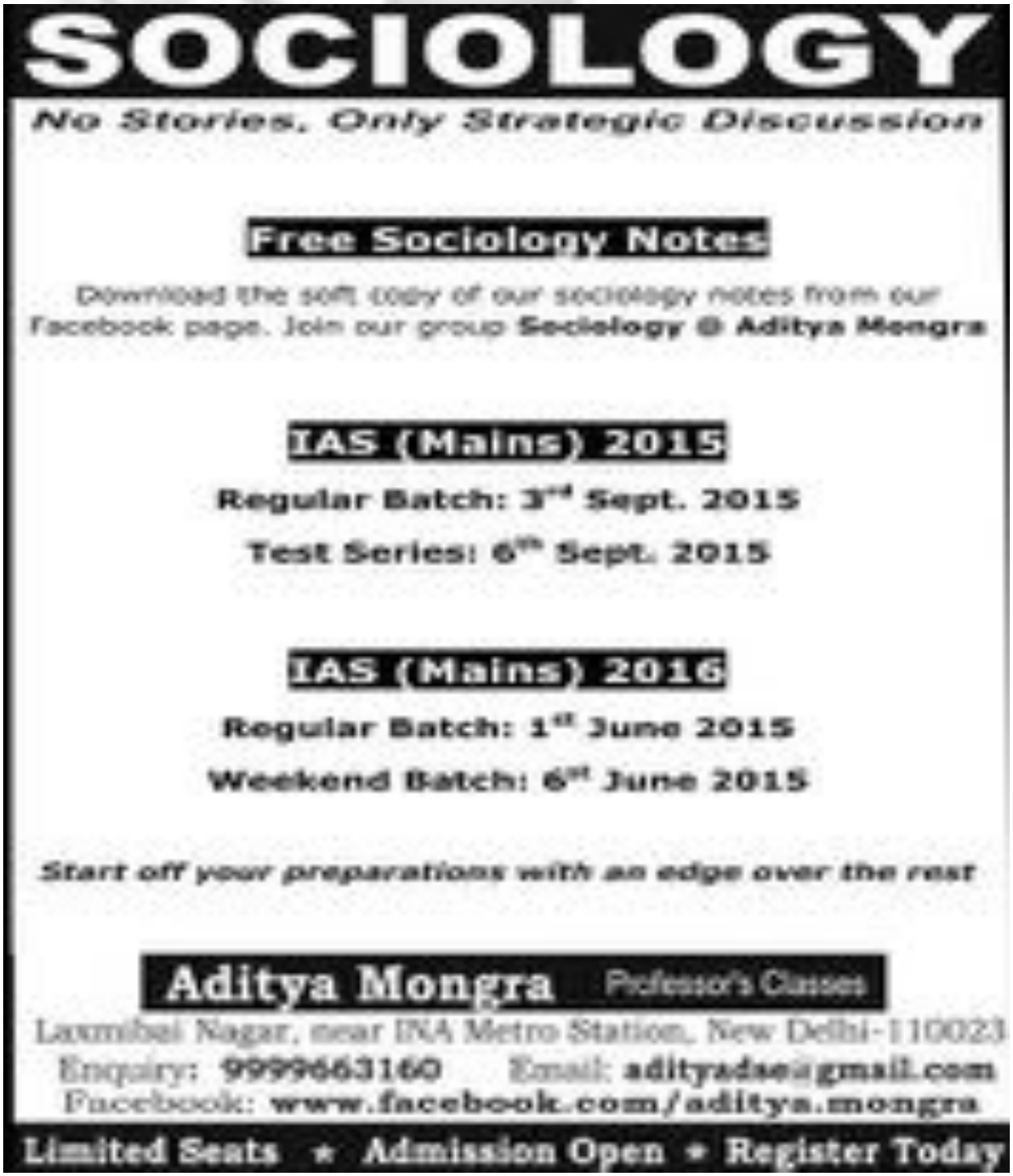
Some sociologists, in recent years, have questioned the need for such a rigid division between quantitative and qualitative methodology and have advocated combining the two approaches. Alan Bryman has suggested a number of ways in which a plurality of methods – a practice known as *triangulation* – can be useful.

1. Quantitative and qualitative data can be used to check on the accuracy of the conclusions reached on the basis of each.
2. Qualitative research can be used to produce hypotheses which can then be checked using quantitative methods.
3. The two approaches can be used together so that a more complete picture of the social group being studied is produced.
4. Qualitative research may be used to illuminate why certain variables are statistically correlated. For example, Durkheim concluded in his study on suicide that the rate of suicide varies from religion to religion because of their varying degree of solidarity.

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Bryman believes that both quantitative and qualitative research have their own advantages. Neither can produce totally valid and completely reliable data, but both can provide useful insights into social life. He argues that each has its own place and they can be most usefully combined. Generally, quantitative data tends to produce rather static pictures, but it can allow researchers to examine and discover overall patterns and structures in society as a whole. Qualitative data is less useful for discovering overall patterns and structures, but it does allow a richer and deeper understanding of the process of change in social life.



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Techniques of data collection

(including Sampling, Reliability and Validity)

Dear Candidate, in the previous section, we had discussed some of the fundamental characteristics of quantitative (positivist) and qualitative (anti-positivist) research methodologies. However, in practice, the distinctions between positivist and anti-positivist research methodologies are not as clear cut as the previous sections have implied. They have been placed at opposite ends of the spectrum for purposes of emphasis and illustration. A large body of sociological research falls somewhere between the two extremes. In the same way, the methods of data collection discussed in the following sections cannot be neatly categorized as aspects of positivist or anti-positivist methodologies. However, certain methods are regarded as more appropriate by supporters of one or other of these perspectives.

Let us now discuss some of the important techniques employed by the social scientists for collecting data from the field. The need for adequate and reliable data is ever increasing for taking policy decisions in different fields of human activity. There are two ways in which the required information may be obtained:

1. Complete enumeration survey (also known as the census method).
2. Sampling technique.

Under complete enumeration survey method, data are collected for each and every unit (person, household, field, shop, factory etc., as the case may be) belonging to the population or universe which is the complete set of items which are of interest in any particular situation. The advantage of this type of survey will be that no unit is left out and hence greater accuracy may be ensured. However, the effort, money and time required for carrying out complete enumeration will generally be extremely large and in many cases cost may be so prohibitive that the very idea of collecting information may be dropped. Hence in modern times very little use is made of complete enumeration survey. How to collect the data then? It is through the adoption of *sampling technique* that a large mass of data pertaining to different aspects of human activity are collected these days.

Sampling:

In the sampling technique instead of every unit of the universe only a part of the universe is studied and the conclusions are drawn on that basis for the entire universe. A sample is not studied for its own sake. The basic objective of the sample study is to draw inference about the entire population which it claims to

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represent. In other words, sampling is only a tool which helps to know the characteristics of the universe or population by examining only a small part of it.

There are basically two types of sampling: **probability sampling** and **non-probability sampling**. *Probability sampling* is one in which every unit of the population has an equal probability of being selected for the sample. It offers a high degree of representativeness. However, this method is expensive, time-consuming and relatively complicated since it requires a large sample size and the units selected are usually widely scattered. *Non-probability sampling* makes no claim for representativeness, as every unit does not get the chance of being selected. It is the researcher who decides which sample units should be chosen.

Probability sampling today remains the primary method for selecting large, representative samples for social science and business researches. Some of the important sampling designs or methods under this category are simple random sampling, stratified random sampling, systematic (or interval) sampling, cluster sampling, and multi-stage sampling.

i. Simple Random Sampling:

Random sampling refers to the sampling technique in which each and every item of the population is given an equal chance of being included in the sample. The selection is thus free form personal bias because the investigator does not exercise his discretion or preference in the choice of items. Since selection of items in the sample depends entirely on chance this method is also known as the method of chance selection. Some people believe that randomness of selection can be achieved by unsystematic and haphazard procedures. But this is quite wrong. However, the point to be emphasized is that unless precaution is taken to avoid bias and a conscious effort is made to ensure the operation of chance factors, the resulting sample shall not be a random sample. Random sampling is sometimes referred to as 'representative sampling'. If the sample is chosen at random and if the size of the sample is sufficiently large, it will represent all groups in the universe. A random sample is also known as a 'probability sample' because every item of the universe has an equal opportunity of being selected in the sample. To ensure randomness of selection one may adopt any of the following methods:

a) Lottery Method: This is a very popular method of taking a random sample. Under this method, all items of the universe are numbered on separate slips of paper of identical size and shape. These slips are then folded and mixed up in a container or drum. A blindfold selection is then made of the number of slips required to constitute the desired sample size. The selection of items thus depends entirely on chance.

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b) Table of Random Numbers: The lottery method discussed above becomes quite cumbersome to use as the size of population increases. An alternative method of random selection is that of using the table of random numbers. Three such tables are available, namely (i) Tippett's table of random numbers, (ii) Fisher and Yate's numbers, and (iii) Kendall and Babington Smith numbers.

The merits of random sampling lies in the fact that since the selection of items in the sample depends entirely on chance there is no possibility of personal bias affecting the results. Further, as the size of the sample increases, it becomes increasingly representative of the population. However, the use of random sampling necessitates a completely catalogued universe from which to draw the sample. But it is often difficult for the investigator to have up-to-date lists of all the items of the population to be sampled. This restricts the use of random sampling method.

ii. Stratified Random Sampling:

In this sampling method, the population is divided into various stratas or classes and a sample is drawn from each stratum at random. For example, if we are interested in studying the consumption pattern of the people of Delhi, the city of Delhi may be divided into various parts or zones and from each part a sample may be taken at random. However, the selection of cases from each stratum must be done with great care and in accordance with a carefully designed plan as otherwise random selection from the various strata may not be accomplished.

Stratified sampling may be either *proportional* or *disproportional*. In proportional stratified sampling, the cases are drawn from each stratum in the same proportion as they occur in the universe. For example, if we divide the city of Delhi into four zones A, B, C, and D with 40%, 30%, 20% and 10% of the total population respectively and if the sample size is one thousand then we should draw 400, 300, 200 and 100 cases respectively from zones A, B, C and D, *i.e.*, sample is proportional to the size in the universe. In disproportional stratified sampling, an equal number of cases is taken from each stratum, regardless of how the stratum is represented in the universe. Thus, in the above example, an equal number of items from each zone may be drawn, that is, 250. This approach is obviously inferior to the proportional stratified sampling.

The most important merit of the stratified random sampling is that it is more representative. Since the population is first divided into various stratas and then a sample is drawn from each stratum, there is little possibility of any essential group of the population being completely excluded. A more representative sample is thus

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secured. Stratified sampling is frequently regarded as the most efficient system of sampling. However, utmost care must be exercised in dividing the population into various stratas. Each stratum must contain, as far as possible, homogenous items as otherwise the results may not be reliable. However, this is a very difficult task and may involve considerable time and expense.

iii. Systematic or Interval Sampling:

This method is popularly used in those cases where a complete list of the population from which sample is to be drawn is available. It involves obtaining a sample of items by drawing every n^{th} item from a predetermined list of items. In simple words, it involves randomly selecting the first respondent and then every n^{th} person after that; '*n*' is the sampling interval. For example, if a complete list of 1000 students of a college is available and if we want to draw a sample of 200 this means we must take every fifth item (*i.e.*, $n = 5$). The first item between one and five shall be selected at random. Suppose it comes out to be three. Now we shall go on adding five and obtain numbers of the desired sample. Thus, the second item would be the 8th student, the third, 13th student and so on.

Systematic sampling differs from simple random sampling in that in the latter, the selections are independent of each other; in the former the selection of sample units is dependent on the selection of a previous one. The systematic sampling is more convenient to adopt than the random sampling or the stratified sampling method. The time and work involved in sampling by this method are relatively smaller. It is a rapid method and eliminates several steps otherwise taken in probability sampling. However, critics of this method argue that it ignore all persons between two n^{th} numbers with the result that the possibility of over representation and under representation of several groups is greater.

iv. Cluster Sampling:

This sampling implies dividing population into clusters and drawing random sample either from all clusters or selected clusters. This method is used when (a) cluster criteria are significant for the study, and (b) economic considerations are significant. In cluster sampling, initial clusters are called *primary* sampling units; clusters within the primary clusters are called *secondary* sampling units; and clusters within the secondary clusters are called *multi-stage* clusters. When clusters are geographic units, it is called *area sampling*. For example, dividing one city into various wards, each ward into areas, each area into neighbourhoods and each neighbourhood into lanes. We can take an example of a hospital. The issue is to ascertain the problems faced by doctors, patients and visitors in different units and to introduce some reformative programmes. Administratively, it will not be viable to call all doctors from all units nor a large number of patients admitted in different

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units like cardiology, neurology, orthopaedic, gynaecology, and so on. Treating each unit as a cluster, randomly selected doctors and patients – say two doctors and three patients or about 50 people all together – from all units may be invited for discussions. Arriving at a consensus for immediate reforms needed, a plan can be chalked out for seeking grant from the government.

The advantages of cluster sampling are that it is much easier to apply this sampling design when large populations are studied or when large geographical area is studied. Further, the cost involved in this method is much less than in other methods of sampling. The disadvantages of this sampling method are that each cluster may not be of equal size and hence the comparison so done would not be on equal basis. The chances of sampling error are greater as there could be homogeneity in one cluster but heterogeneity in other.

v. Multi-Stage Sampling:

As the name implies this method refers to a sampling procedure which is carried out in several stages, but only the last sample of subjects is studied. Suppose, it is decided to take a sample of 5,000 households from the State of Uttar Pradesh. At the first stage, the State may be divided into number of districts and a few districts selected at random. At the second stage, each district may be sub-divided into a number of villages and a sample of villages may be taken at random. At the third stage, a number of households may be selected from each of the villages selected at the second stage. In this way, at each stage the sample size becomes smaller and smaller. The merit of multi-stage sampling is that it introduces flexibility in the sampling method which is lacking in the other methods. It enables existing divisions and sub-divisions of the population to be used as units at various stages, and permits the field work so be concentrated and yet large area to be covered. Another important advantage in this sampling design is that is more representative. Further, in all cases, complete listing of population is not necessary. This saves cost. However, a multi-stage sample is in general less accurate than a sample containing the same number of final stage units which have been selected by some suitable single stages process.

Let's now discuss about the non-probability sampling. In many research situations, particularly those where there is no list of persons to be studied (e.g., widows, alcoholics, migrant workers, etc.) probability sampling is difficult and inappropriate to use. In such research, non-probability sampling is the most appropriate one. Non-probability sampling procedures do not employ the rules of probability theory, do not claim representativeness, and are usually used for qualitative exploratory analysis. Some of the important sampling designs under this category are convenience sampling, purposive or judgement sampling, quota sampling, snowball sampling and volunteer sampling.

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i. Convenience Sampling:

This is also known an 'accidental' or 'haphazard' sampling. In this sampling, the researcher studies all those persons who are most conveniently available or who accidentally come in his contact during a certain period of time in the research. For example, the researcher engaged in the study of university students might visit the university canteen, library, some departments, play-grounds, verandahs and interview certain number of students. Another example is of election study. During election times, media personnel often present man-on-the-street interviews that are presumed to reflect public opinion. In such sampling, representativeness is not significant. The most obvious advantages of convenience sample is that it is quick and economical. But it may be a very biased sample. The possible sources of bias could be: (i) the respondents may have a vested interest to serve in cooperating with the interviewer, and (ii) the respondents may be those who are vocal and/or want to brag. Convenience samples are best utilised for exploratory research when additional research will subsequently be conducted with a probability sample.

ii. Purposive Sampling:

Purposive sampling is also known as judgement sampling. In this, the choice of sample items depends exclusively on the discretion of the investigator. In other words, the investigator exercises his judgement in the choice and includes those items in the sample which he thinks are most typical of the universe with regard to the characteristics under investigation. For example, if a sample of ten students is to be selected from a class of sixty for analysing the spending habits of students, the investigator would select 10 students who, in his opinion, are representative of the class. This method, though simple, is not scientific because there is a big possibility of the results being affected by the personal prejudice or bias of the investigator. Thus judgement sampling involves the risk that the investigator may establish foregone conclusions by including those items in the sample which conform to his preconceived notions. For example, if an investigator holds the view that the wages of workers in a certain establishment are very low, and if he adopts the judgment sampling method, he may include only those workers in the sample whose wages are low and thereby establish his point of view which may be far from the truth. Since an element of subjectiveness is possible, this method cannot be recommended for general use. (Please remember this argument. You would need it as one of the criticisms against Karl Marx.) However, because of simplicity and easy adaptability this method is quite often used by businessmen in the solution of everyday problems. Indeed, if applied with skill and care, the judgement method can be of great help to businessmen. At least, it helps deriving somewhat better solutions to the problems than could be obtained without it.

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iii. Quota Sampling:

Quota sampling is a type of judgement sampling. In a quota sample, quotas are set up according to given criteria but, within the quotas, the selection of sample items depends on personal judgement. For example, in a radio listening survey, the interviewers may be told to interview 500 people living in a certain area and that out of every 100 persons interviewed 60 are to be housewives, 25 farmers, and 15 children. Within these quotas the interviewer is to free to select the people to be interviewed. The cost per person interviewed may be relatively small for a quota sample but there are numerous opportunities for bias which may invalidate results. Because of the risk of personal prejudice and bias entering the process of selection, the quota sampling is rarely used in practical work.

iv. Snowball Sampling:

In this technique, the researcher begins the research with the few respondents who are known and available to him. Subsequently, these respondents give other names who meet the criteria of research, who in turn give more new names. This process is continued until 'adequate' number of persons are interviewed or until no more respondents are discovered. For instance, in studying wife battering, the researcher may first interview those cases whom he knows, who may later on give additional names, and who in turn may give still new names. This method is employed when the target population is unknown or when it is difficult to approach the respondents in any other way. Reduced sample sizes and costs are a clear advantage of snowball sampling. Bias enters because a person known to someone (also in the sample) has a higher probability of being similar to the first person. If there are major differences between those who are widely known by others and those who are not, there may be serious problems with snowball sampling.

v. Volunteer Sampling:

This is the technique in which the respondent himself volunteers to give information he holds. The success of the research is dependent on the 'rich' information given by the respondents. However, there is a possibility that the informants may not truly represent the population, i.e., they may not have the aggregate characteristics of the population. Further, the personal leanings of the researcher of being prejudiced against certain types of persons, say, untouchables or religious minorities, may also affect the validity of the findings.

On a review of the pros and cons of the various methods of sampling, it is clear that stratified sampling and systematic sampling methods based on random

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principle are more reliable, and hence these methods are more widely used than others.

Let's now briefly discuss the merits of the sampling procedure in general. The sampling technique has the following merits over the complete enumeration survey:

1. Less time: Since sampling is a study of a part of the population, considerable time and labour are saved when a sample survey is carried out. Time is saved not only in collecting data but also in processing it. For these reasons a sample often provides more timely data in practice than a census.

2. Less cost: Sampling also edges out other techniques of data collection in terms of the cost involved. This is a great advantage particularly in an underdeveloped economy where much of the information would be difficult to collect by the census method for lack of adequate resources.

3. More reliable results: Although the sampling technique involves certain inaccuracies owing to sampling errors, the result obtained is generally more reliable than that obtained from a complete count. This is because more effective precautions can be taken in a sample survey to ensure that the information is accurate and complete. Moreover, it is possible to avail of the services of experts and to impart thorough training to the investigators in a sample survey which further reduces the possibility of errors. Follow-up work can also be undertaken much more effectively in the sampling method.

4. More detailed information: Since the sampling technique saves time and money, it is possible to collect more detailed information in a sample survey. For example, if the population consists of 1,000 persons in a survey of the consumption pattern of the people, the two alternative techniques available are as follows:

   (a) We may collect the necessary data from each one of the 1,000 people through a questionnaire containing, say, 10 questions (census method),

   Or

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(b) We may take a sample of 100 persons (i.e. 10% of population and prepare a questionnaire containing as many as 100 questions. The expenses involved in the latter case almost be the same as in the former but it will enable nine times more information to be obtained.

However, despite the various advantages of sampling, it is not altogether free from limitations. Some of the difficulties involved in sampling are stated below:

1. A sample survey must be carefully planned and executed otherwise the results obtained may be inaccurate and misleading.
2. Sampling generally requires the services of experts for the proper planning and execution of the survey. In the absence of qualified and experienced persons, the information obtained from sample surveys cannot be relied upon.
3. If the information is required for each and every unit in the domain of study, sample method cannot be adopted.

Dear Candidate, it would be useful here to discuss the various types of errors that often are committed while collecting the data. Though it is less likely that a question would be asked on this but given the unpredictability of UPSC, I would suggest you to just glance through it.

To appreciate the need for sample surveys, it is necessary to understand clearly the role of ***sampling*** and ***non-sampling errors*** in complete enumeration and sample surveys. The errors arising due to drawing inferences about the population on the basis of few observations (sample) is termed as *sampling errors*. Clearly, the sampling error, in this sense is non-existent in a complete enumeration survey, since the whole population is surveyed. However, the errors mainly arising at the stages of ascertainment and processing of data which are termed *non-sampling errors* are common both in complete enumeration and sample surveys.

Sampling Errors:

Even if utmost care has been taken in selecting a sample, the results derived from the sample may not be representative of the population from which it is drawn, because samples are seldom, if ever, perfect miniatures of the population. This gives rise to sampling errors. Sampling errors are thus due to the fact that samples are used and to the particular method used in selecting the items from the

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population. Sampling errors are of two types – biased and unbiased. Biased errors are those which arise from any kind of bias in selection, estimation, etc. Bias may arise either due to a faulty process of selection or faulty method of analysis. Unbiased errors, on the other hand, arise due to chance differences between the members of population included in the sample and those not included. The simplest and the only certain way of avoiding bias in the selection process is for the sample to be drawn either entirely at random or at random, subject to restrictions, which, while improving the accuracy, are of such a nature that they do not introduce bias in the results.

Non-sampling Errors:

When a complete enumeration of units in the universe is made one would expect that it would give rise to data free from errors. However, in practice it is not so. For example, it is difficult to completely avoid errors of observation or ascertainment. So also in the processing of data tabulation errors may be committed affecting the final results. Errors arising in this manner are termed non-sampling errors, as they are due to factors other than the inductive process of inferring about the population from a sample. Thus, the data obtained in a census by complete enumeration, although free from sampling errors, would still be subject to non-sampling errors, whereas the results of a sample survey would be subject to sampling errors as well as non-sampling errors.

Non-sampling errors can occur at every stage of planning and execution of the census or survey. Such errors can arise due to a number of causes such as defective methods of data collection and tabulation, faulty definitions, incomplete coverage of the population or sample, etc. More specifically, non-sampling errors may arise from one or more of the following factors:

1. Data specification being inadequate and inconsistent with respect to the objectives of the census or sample survey.
2. Inappropriate statistical unit.
3. Inaccurate or inappropriate methods of interviews, observation or measurement with inadequate or ambiguous schedules, definitions or instructions.
4. Lack of trained and experienced investigators.
5. Lack of adequate inspection and supervision of primary staff.
6. Errors due to non-response, *i.e.*, incomplete coverage in respect of units.
7. Errors in data processing operations such as coding, punching, verification, tabulation, etc.
8. Errors committed during presentation and printing of tabulated results.

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These sources are not exhaustive, but are given to indicate some of the possible sources of error. In some situations the non-sampling errors may be large and deserve greater attention than the sampling error. While, in general, sampling error decreases with increase in sample size, non-sampling error tends to increase with the sample size. In the case of complete enumeration, non-sampling error and in the case of sample surveys both sampling and non-sampling errors require to be controlled and reduced to a level at which their presence does not vitiate the use of final results.



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Survey:

The most common type of empirical, or quantitative, research in sociology is the survey, which consists of systematically questioning people about their opinions, attitudes, or behaviour. Questionnaires and structured interviews are the usual methods employed to gather data for a research design known as the 'social survey'.

Social surveys may be roughly divided into two categories, 'descriptive' and 'analytical'. A descriptive survey, as its name suggests, is concerned with description rather than explanation. It aims to provide an accurate measurement of the distribution of certain characteristics in a given population. For example, a survey may be conducted in a city or town to measure the extent of poverty in the given population. Here the researcher and his team would be interested in collecting the data on average per capita income of the working class stratum or population below poverty line, etc. In other words, they aim to measure the extent of poverty in a given population rather than to explain the causes of poverty. Analytic surveys, on the other hand, are concerned with explanation. They are designed to test hypotheses about the relationships between a number of factors or variables. Thus an analytic survey may seek to discover possible relationships between social class and religious behaviour, ethnicity and mental health, family size and educational attainment or age and voting behaviour. Analytic surveys are not simply concerned with discovering relationship but also with explaining them.

Analytic surveys are usually designed to test the effects of a number of variables or factors on some other variable. The researcher often begins with a hypothesis which postulates a relationship between variables and the direction of cause and effect. For example, he may suggest that social class differences in some way cause or determine variations in mental health. There may be other factors affecting mental health, however, and these must also be considered if the influence of social class is to be accurately assessed. For example, variables such as age, ethnicity and gender may account for some variation in mental health. As a result researchers usually gather data on a range of factors which might influence the variable in question. The method used to analyse relationships between variables is known as 'multivariate' or 'variable analysis'. With the aid of various statistical techniques, the analyst attempts to measure the effects of a number of variables upon another. This method was pioneered in sociology by Durkheim in his study of suicide. Official statistics revealed significant variations in suicide rate between European societies. Durkheim's research indicated that predominantly Protestant societies had a higher rate of suicide than societies in which Catholicism was the majority faith. But before a causal relationship could be claimed between religion and suicide rates, it was necessary to eliminate other possibilities. For

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example, could variations in suicide rates be the result of differences in national cultures? To test this possibility, Durkheim held the variable of national culture constant by examining differences in suicide rates between Catholics and Protestants within the same society. The relationship still held. Within the same society Protestants had higher suicide rates than Catholics.

Durkheim then went a step further and examined the possibility that regional differences rather than religion might account for variations in suicide rates. He found, for example, that Bavaria had the lowest suicide rate of all the states in Germany and it also had the highest proportion of Catholics. Yet might the suicide rate be due to the peculiarities of Bavaria as a region rather than its predominantly Catholic population? To test this possibility Durkheim compared the suicide rates and the religious composition of the various provinces within Bavaria. He found that the higher the proportion of Protestants in each province, the higher the suicide rate. Again the relationship between religion and rates of suicide was confirmed. By eliminating variables such as national culture and region, Durkheim was able to strengthen the relationship between religion and suicide rates and provide increasing support for his claim that the relationship is a causal one.

A social survey involves the collection of standardized information from a sample selected as being representative of a particular group or population. The group from which the sample is drawn may be the population as whole, a particular class, ethnic, gender or age group, or individuals with certain characteristics in common such as married or divorced persons, manual workers or professionals. The group selected for study will, of course, depend on what the researcher wishes to investigate. Standardized information is obtained by asking the same set of questions to all members of the sample.

Let's briefly discuss some of the major steps normally involved in survey research.

Firstly, before a survey is begun, the issues to be explored must be clearly defined. At the same time, the target population to be interviewed is selected. The target population might be identified on the basis of the characteristics that the researcher is interested in examining. It could either be a particular gender or age group, or any specific socio-economic section of the society, etc. This first step is crucial, for if the population is not correctly specified, the results of the survey may be meaningless. For example, if the aim of the research is to predict the results of an election, it is very important that the population chosen consist only of those persons who will actually vote in that election.

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Secondly, if the population is large, time and cost will almost always make it impractical to interview the entire population. So, the second step in surveying is to pick an appropriate sample of the population to interview. A sample is a limited number of selected cases drawn from a large group. Careful procedures have been established for selecting samples. The better the sampling procedure, the more closely the sample will resemble the entire population and the more accurate will be the generalizations or predictions. In other words, if generalizations are to be made from the findings of a social survey, it is essential that the sample is representative. This is often accomplished by means of a 'random sample'. We have already discussed the various types of sampling techniques and their merits and limitations. Once the researcher is satisfied that he has obtained a representative sample, he can begin the survey proper and feel some justification in generalizing from its findings.

Once the sample is selected, the third step in survey research is to interview or administer the questionnaire to the selected people and to collect the data. At this point a major consideration is the precision of the questions. Do the questions really pinpoint the issue concerned? Are they phrased in such a way that they will be interpreted correctly and similarly by each person interviewed *i.e.*, the respondents. In addition to being precise and unambiguous in meaning, a survey question must also be neutrally stated.

Please note that for the most accurate results, the entire sample must be interviewed, particularly if the sample is small. If some people refuse to answer or are unavailable for interviewing, the sample is no longer representative and, consequently, the accuracy of the data may be reduced. Non-response is frequently a serious problem when questionnaires are sent by mail, for refusals to respond to mailed questionnaires tend to be high. Replies often come only from those who have some interest in the particular issue, thus introducing a bias into the survey findings. To assure maximum response, most major attitude surveys and public opinion polls are conducted through personal interviews. These interviews range from the highly structured to be highly unstructured. A structured interview consists of a set of questions and answers are always stated in the same way and in the same sequence. The answers are thus easily compiled and generalized. Most public opinion polls use structured interviews. For other research purposes, where more extensive information about individual attitudes or behaviour is desired, the unstructured interview has many advantages. An unstructured interview may consist of open ended questions (How do you feel about the inter-caste marriages or caste-based reservations?) or even just a list of topics to be discussed. It is possible for the interviewer to introduce bias into the survey. He may, for example, use expressions or make comments that encourage the respondent to answer in a certain way. In an unstructured interview he may influence the answers by the way

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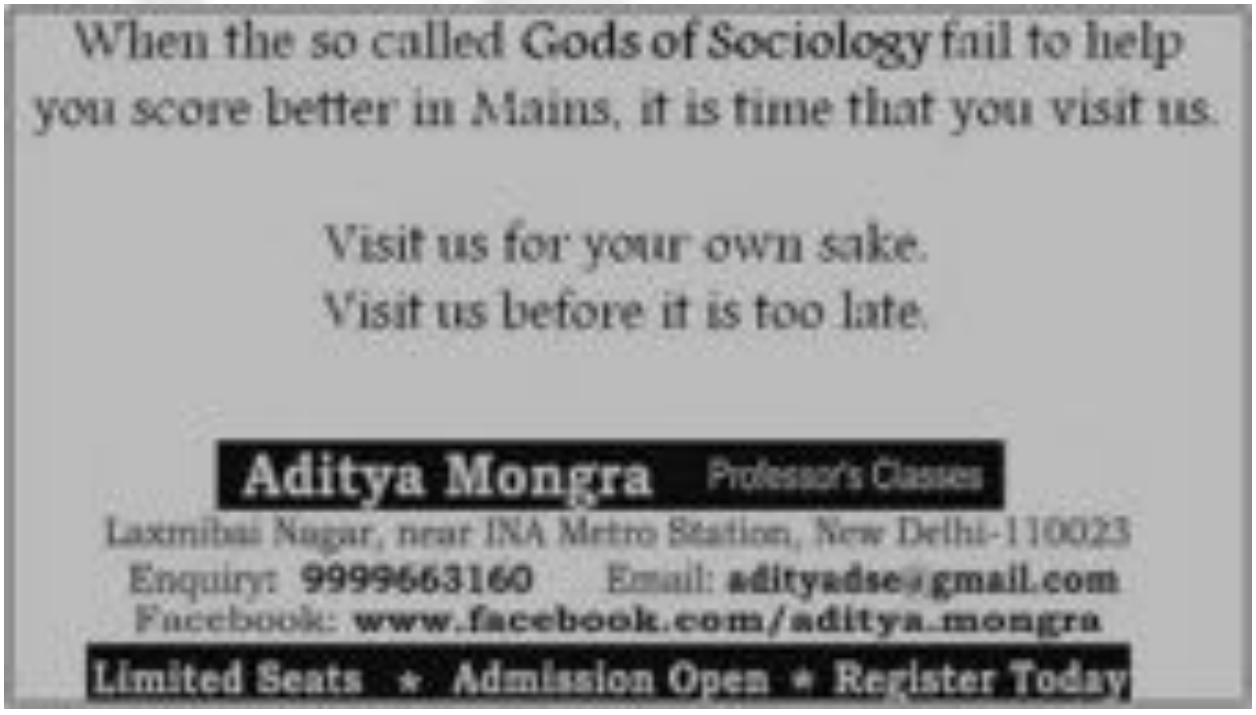
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he phrases the questions. It is important that interviewers be suited to their task and that they be well trained in the techniques of interviewing.

The final step in survey research is the tabulation, analysis, and interpretation of the data. In all but the smallest surveys, this step normally involves the use of computers.

There are several possible sources of error in survey results. Sampling error is the degree to which the selected sample misrepresents the population as a whole. Other major sources of error arise from problems in observation and measurement, processing the data, and analyzing the findings. A basic problem, with all surveys is that what people say may not always agree with how they act. People sometimes conceal their attitude purposely. An individual prejudiced against lower castes in India, for example, may act in a discriminatory fashion toward them, but because he knows that this prejudice is socially disapproved of, he will not admit it to an interviewer. Research that is well designed and carried out can help to overcome these difficulties, but the sociologist must be constantly aware that attitudes expressed in interviews are not always perfect expressions of underlying values, and that actions do not always reflect stated attitudes.

The success of any survey is, however, ultimately dependent on the quality of its data. At the end of the day a social survey stands or falls on the validity of its data.



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Case Study:

Case study method is an ideal methodology when a holistic, in-depth investigation is needed. Frederic Le Play is reputed to have introduced the *case study* method into social science. He used it as a handmaiden to statistics in his studies of family budgets. Herbert Spencer was one of the first sociologists to use case materials in his ethnographic studies.

Case study is an intensive study of a case which may be an individual, an institution, a system, a community, an organisation, an event, or even the entire culture. Robert K. Yin has defined case study as "an empirical inquiry that investigates a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life context, when the boundaries between phenomenon and context are not clearly evident, and in which multiple sources of evidence are used". It is, thus, a kind of research design which usually involves the qualitative method of selecting the sources of data. It presents the holistic account that offers insights into the case under study. Please note that while a case study can either be quantitative or qualitative, or even both, but most case studies lie within the realm of qualitative methodology. It is the preferred strategy when "how, who, why and what" questions are being asked or when the focus is on a contemporary phenomenon within a real-life context.

Case studies have been used in varied social investigations, particularly, in sociological studies, and are designed to bring out the details from the viewpoint of the participants by using multiple sources of data. It is, therefore, an approach to explore and analyze the life of social unit, be it a person, a family, an institution, a culture group or even an entire community. Its aim is to determine the factors that account for the complex behaviour patterns of the unit and the relationships of the unit to its surroundings. Case-data may be gathered, exhaustively, on the entire life cycle or on a definite section of the cycle of a unit but always with a view to ascertain the natural history of social unit and its relationship to the social factors and forces involved in its environment. In other words, through case study, researchers attempt to see the variety of factors within a social unit as an integrated whole. When attention is focussed on the development of the case, it is called 'case history'. For example, how a particular boy became a juvenile delinquent because of lack of parental control, impact of peers, lack of attention by teachers, and money earned through cheap means, and then became an adolescent thief and a sex criminal and ultimately a professional pickpocket is tracing criminality through case history method.

Data, for case studies, can be collected by primary as well as secondary sources. Two main sources of primary data collection are interviews and observation. Interviews may be structured or unstructured. Most commonly, it is

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the unstructured interview which is used by the investigators. The observation method used could either be participant or non-participant. While the secondary data can be collected through a variety of sources like reports, records, newspapers, magazines, books, files, diaries, etc.

Sjoberg has identified some essential characteristics of case study method which are as follows:

- The case study 'strives towards a holistic understanding of cultural systems of action'. Cultural systems of action refer to sets of inter-related activities engaged in by the actors in a social situation.
- Case study research is not sampling research. However, selection of the items or sources must be done so as to maximize what can be learned, in the limited period of time available for the study.
- Because they are intensive in nature, case studies tend to be selective, focusing on one or two issues that are fundamental to understanding the system being examined.
- 'Case studies are multi-perspectival analyses.' This means that the researcher considers not just the voice and perspective of the actors but also of the relevant groups of actors and the interaction between them.

According to Black and Champion, some of the advantages of case study design are:

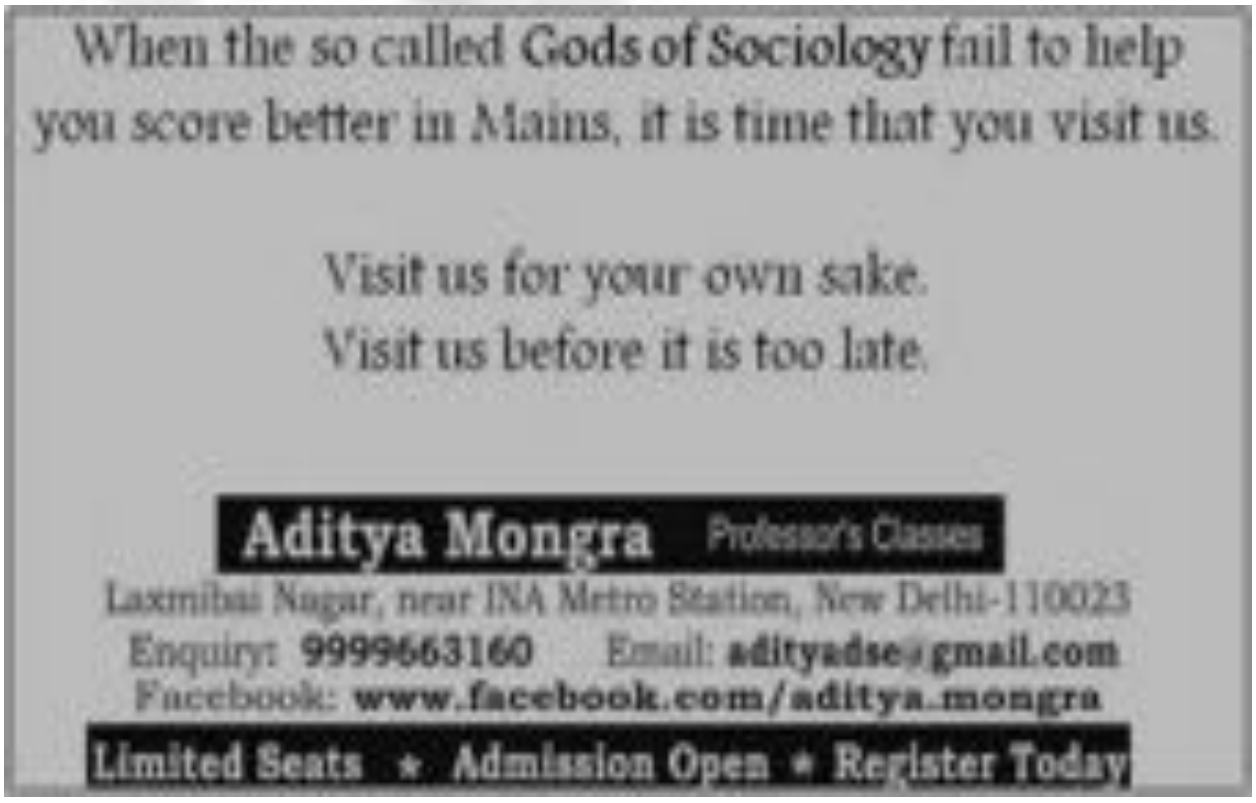
- Case study makes holistic and in-depth study of the phenomenon possible.
- It offers flexibility with respect to using methods for collecting data, e.g., questionnaire, interview, observation, etc.
- It could be used for studying any specific dimension of the topic in detail.
- It can be conducted in practically any kind of social setting.
- Case studies are relatively inexpensive.

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However, practically, the case study method is very time consuming and very demanding of the researcher. The possibility of becoming involved emotionally is much greater than in survey research, thus, making detached and objective observation difficult and sometimes, impossible. Another problem in the use of case study method is that, since, only one example of a social situation or group is being studied the results may not be representative of all groups or situations in the category. In other words, the particular mental hospital ward, slum, or suburb may not be typical of all mental hospital wards, slums or suburbs. Critics of the case study method believe that the study of a small number of cases can offer no grounds for establishing reliability or generality of findings. Some dismiss case study research as useful only as an exploratory tool. Yet, researchers continue to use the case study research method with success in carefully planned and crafted studies of real life situations, issues and problems.

Please note that in comparison to survey, case study method is more intensive while survey research is more extensive in nature. In other words, surveys are usually conducted on a fairly large scale as contrasted with case studies which tend to be more intensive but on a smaller scale. Case study is done in terms of limited space and broader time, whereas survey is done in terms of limited time with broader space. Case study is inward looking while survey method is outward looking.



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Interviews:

Interviews are one of the most widely used methods of gathering data in sociology. They consist of the researcher asking the interviewee or respondent a series of questions. Interviews can be classified as '***structured***' or '***unstructured***' though many fall somewhere between these two extremes. In a structured interview, the wording of the questions and the order in which they are asked remains the same in every case. The result is a fairly formal question and answer session. Unstructured interviews are more like an informal conversation. The interviewer usually has particular topics in mind to cover but few if any preset questions. He has the freedom to phrase questions as he likes, ask the respondent to develop his answers and probe responses which might be unclear and ambiguous. This freedom is often extended to the respondent who may be allowed to direct the interview into areas which interest him.

Data from structured interviews are generally regarded as more reliable. Since the order and wording of questions are the same for all respondents, it is more likely that they will be responding to the same stimuli. Thus different answers to the same set of questions will indicate real differences between the respondents. Different answers will not therefore simply reflect differences in the way questions are phrased. Thus the more structured or standardized an interview, the more easily its results can be tested by researchers investigating other groups. By comparison data from unstructured interviews are seen as less reliable. Questions are phrased in a variety of ways and the relationship between interviewer and respondent is likely to be more intimate. It is unclear to what degree answers are influenced by these factors. Differences between respondents may simply reflect differences in the nature of the interviews. It is therefore more difficult to replicate an unstructured interview but the greater flexibility of unstructured interviews may strengthen the validity of the data. They provide more opportunity to discover what the respondent 'really means'. Ambiguities in questions and answers can be clarified and the interviewers can probe for shades of meaning. In general, structured interviews are regarded as appropriate for obtaining answers to questions of 'fact' such as the age, sex and job of the respondent. Unstructured interviews after seen as more appropriate for eliciting attitudes and opinions. Interview data are often taken as indications of respondents' attitudes and behaviour in everyday life although what a person says in an interview may have little to do with his normal routines. Even if the respondent does his best to provide honest answers, he may be unaware of the taken-for-granted assumptions which he employs in everyday life.

Various studies have suggested, though, that interviews pose serious problems of reliability and validity. This is partly due to the fact that interviews are

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interaction situations. Thus the results of an interview will depend in part on the way the participants define the situation, their perceptions of each other and so on. Most studies have been concerned about the effects of interviewers on respondents. The significance of what has come to be known as '*interviewer bias*' can be seen from research conducted by J. Allan Williams Jr. He suggests that the greater the status differences between interviewer and respondent, the less likely the respondent will be to express his true feelings. To test this proposition, Williams organized a series of interviews with 840 Blacks in North Carolina during the early 1960s. All the interviewers were female, thirteen were Black and nine White. Important differences were revealed between the results obtained by Black and White interviewers. For example, a significantly higher proportion of those interviewed by Black said they approved of civil rights demonstrations and school desegregation. In addition more respondents refused to give any answers to these questions when faced with a White interviewer. Williams argues that Blacks often tended to give the answers they felt that White interviewers wanted to hear. He sees this as due to the nature of the power structure in the American South at the time of the research. Williams's findings suggest that when status differences are wide, as is often the case with middle-class sociologists interviewing members of the lower working class, interview data should be regarded with caution.

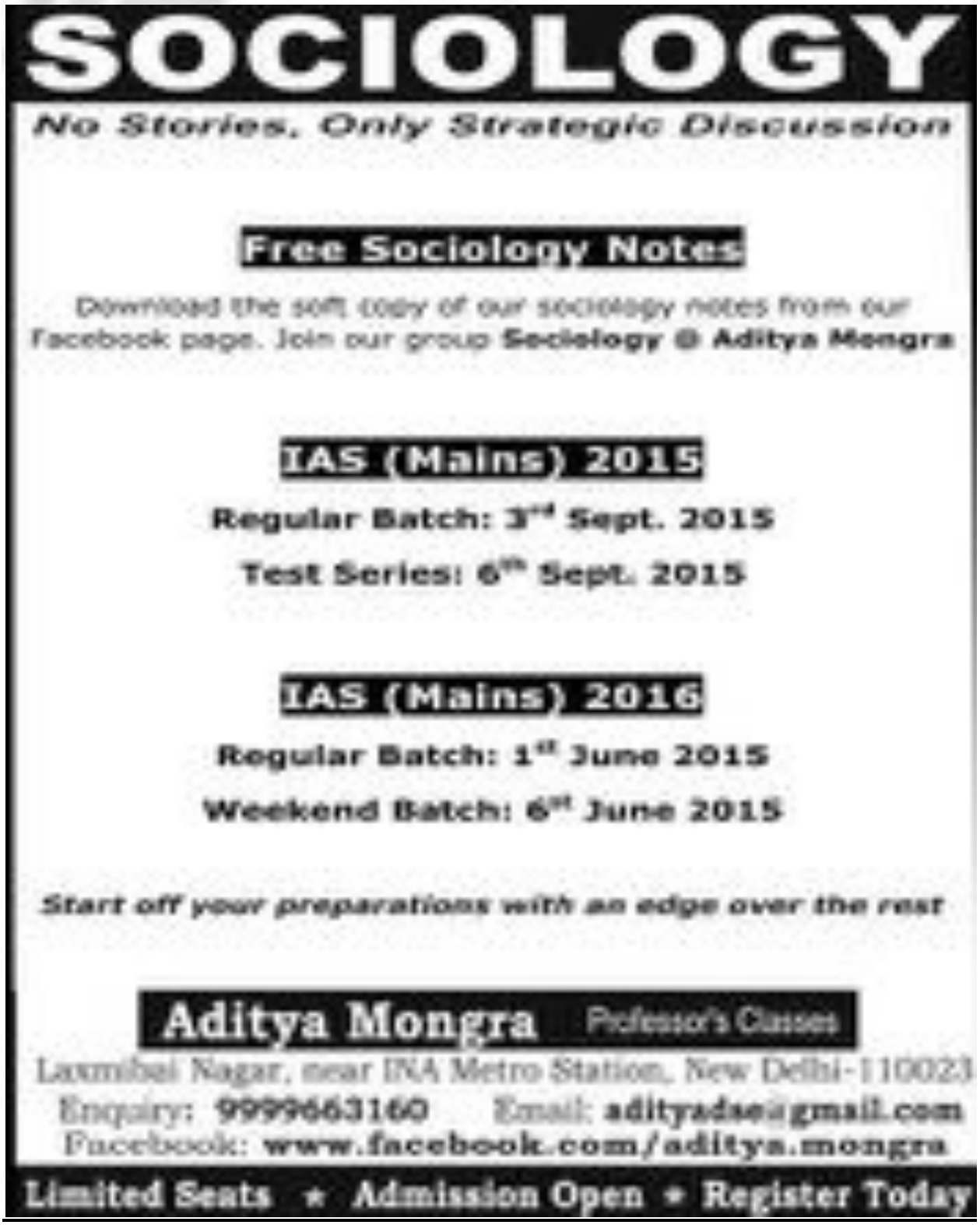
Interviewers, like everybody else, have values, attitudes and expectations. However much the interviewer tries to disguise his views they may well be communicated to the respondent. This is particularly likely in the more informal situation of the unstructured interview. As a result the interviewer may 'lead' the respondent whose answer will then reflect something of the interviewer's attitudes and expectations. This can be seen from a study conducted by Stuart A. Rice in 1914. Two thousand destitute men were asked, among other things, to explain their situation. There was a strong tendency for those interviewed by a supporter of prohibition to blame their demise on alcohol but those interviewed by a committed socialist were much more likely to explain their plight in terms of the industrial situation. To counter this problem, interviewers are often advised to be 'non-directive', to refrain from offering opinions, to avoid expressions of approval and disapproval. It is suggested they establish 'rapport' with their respondents, that is a warm, friendly relationship which implies sympathy and understanding, while at the same time guard against communicating their own attitudes and expectations.

However, despite these limitations, interviews do have certain advantages. They are less costly and time consuming and can cover much larger samples. Interviews can fill in the picture by providing data on the respondent's past and his activities in a range of contexts. Further, the response rate of the interview method is high, particularly when compared to mailed questionnaires. Most importantly, the validity of the information can be checked. Since the respondent's confidence

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can be sought through personal rapport, in-depth probing is possible. Interviewer can explain difficult terms and remove confusion and misunderstandings. Interviewer gets opportunity to observe the non-verbal behaviour of the respondent and hence enables him to record the responses in the right perspective.



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Questionnaires:

A questionnaire consists of a list of preset questions to which respondents are asked to supply answers. Questionnaire poses a structured and standardized set of questions, either to one person or to a small population, or most commonly to respondents in a sample survey. Structure here refers to questions appearing in a consistent, predetermined sequence and form. Researcher who use questionnaires regard them as a comparatively cheap, fast and efficient method for obtaining large amounts of quantifiable data on relatively large numbers of people.

Questionnaires may either be distributed by mail or by hand, through arrangements such as the 'drop-off', where a fieldworker leaves the questionnaire for respondents to complete by themselves, with provision either for mailing the complete form back to the research office, or for a return call by the fieldworker to collect the questionnaire. A questionnaire administered in a face-to-face interview, or over the telephone (growing in popularity among researchers) is generally termed a 'schedule'. In deciding upon one of these methods, researcher balances the cost, probable response rate and the nature of the questions to be posed.

Please note that the set of structured questions in which answers are recorded by the interviewer himself is called ***interview schedule*** or simply the ***schedule***. It is distinguished from the questionnaire in the sense that in the later (questionnaire) the answers are filled in by the respondent himself or herself. Though the questionnaire is used when the respondents are educated, schedule can be used both for the illiterate and the educated respondents. The questionnaire is especially useful when the respondents are scattered in a large geographical area but the schedule is used when the respondents are located in a small area so that they can be personally contacted. The wording of the questions in the questionnaire has to be simple. Since the interviewer is not present to explain the meaning and importance of the question to the respondent. In the schedule, the investigator gets the opportunity to explain whatever the respondent needs to know.

Questionnaires could broadly be classified into three types, *standardized questionnaire*, *open-ended questionnaire* and *close-ended questionnaire*. Standardized questionnaires are those in which there are definite, concrete and pre-ordained questions with additional questions limited to those necessary to clarify inadequate answers or to elicit more detailed responses. The questions are presented with exactly the same wording and in the same order to all the respondents. The reason for standardized questions is to ensure that all the respondents are replying to the same set of questions. Here the respondents or the researcher mark certain categories of reply to the questions asked for instance, 'yes/no/don't know' or 'very likely/likely/unlikely/very unlikely'. Standardized

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questionnaires have the advantage that responses are easy to compare and tabulate, since only a small number of categories are involved. On the other hand, because the standardized questions do not allow for subtleties of opinion or verbal expressions, the information they yield is likely to be restricted in scope.

Open-ended questions allow the respondent to compose his own answer rather than choosing between a number of given answers. For example, 'What's your view on the reservation policy in India?' Open-ended questionnaires are designed to permit a free response from the subject rather than one limited to certain alternatives. This may provide more valid data since he can say what he means in his own words. However, this kind of response may be difficult to classify and quantify. Answers must be carefully interpreted before the researcher is able to arrive at certain conclusion.

Close-ended or fixed-choice questions, on the other hand require the respondent to make a choice between a number of given answers. For example, 'Do you agree with the reservation policy in India?' The answer choices given are, 'yes', 'no', 'partly'. From the point of view of the interpretation of questionnaires the closed question is preferable. The results are unambiguous and comparable. With an open question, the heterogeneous answers must first be ordered into classes (codified) before they can be interpreted. Constructing classes in this way is sometimes very laborious and a challenging task. From the point of view of the reliability of interview-data also the closed question is preferable. This is because that the response to an open-ended question is subjected to the perception and linguistic ability of the respondent and under certain circumstances this can produce serious distortions.

Please note that questionnaires may be administered in a number of ways. Often they are given to individuals by interviewers, in which case they take the form of structured interviews. This method was used by Goldthorpe and Lockwood in the affluent worker study and by Young and Willmott in their survey of family life in London conducted in 1970.

Although the content of questionnaires is governed by the purpose of the study, many problems of communication may still arise on all surveys regardless of content. Much careful attention and experimentation are needed to produce effectively worded questions. The language should be concise and directed toward producing uniformity of understanding among the respondents. Great care is therefore need in the design of a questionnaire. Sometimes the main survey is preceded by a 'pilot study' which involves giving the questionnaire to a group similar to the population to be surveyed. This helps to clear up any ambiguity in the wording of questions and to ensure their relevance to future respondents.

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Ideally the questions should mean the same thing to all respondents. As earlier discussed, this is extremely difficult to ensure, particularly if respondents are drawn from different social classes and ethnic groups. In addition, the researcher must be aware of the meaning respondents give to the question. He cannot simply assume that they will share his interpretation.

More importantly, questions must not only elicit stable or reliable answers but they must also provide the kind of information, which the researcher wants. More often, the problem of truth is a much more complex one. A good questionnaire will contain some 'check questions' on crucial issues, variously placed within the document, designed to parallel or confirm each other. Sometimes, these will explore other facets of the same behaviour. Usually, the cross-check question is a kind of *specification*. That is, a general question is checked by specific reference.

Questionnaires provide data which can be easily quantified. They are largely designed for this purpose. Those who adopt a positivist approach insist that this kind of measurement is essential if sociology is to progress. They argue that only when the social world is expressed in numerical terms can precise relationships be established between its parts. Only when data are quantified by means of reliable measuring instruments can the results of different studies be directly compared. Without quantification sociology will remain on the level of impressionistic guesswork and unsupported insight. It will therefore be impossible to replicate studies, establish causal relationships and support generalizations. The questionnaire is one of the main tools of measurement in positivist sociology.

Please note that in the construction of a questionnaire concepts are operationalized. This means they are put into a form which can be measured. Sociologists classify the social world in terms of a variety of concepts. For example, social class, power, family, religion, alienation and anomie are concepts used to identify and categorize social relationships, beliefs, attitudes and experiences which are seen to have certain characteristics in common. In order to transpose these rather vague concepts into measuring instruments, a number of steps are taken. Firstly, an operational definition is established. This involves breaking the concept down into various 'components' or 'dimensions' in order to specify exactly what is to be measured. Thus when Robert Blauner attempted to operationalize the concept of alienation, he divided it into four components – powerlessness, meaninglessness, isolation and self-estrangement. Once the concept has been operationally defined in terms of a number of components, the next step involves the selection of 'indicators' for each component. Thus an indicator of Blauner's component of powerlessness might be an absence of opportunities for workers to make decisions about the organization of work tasks. Finally, indicators

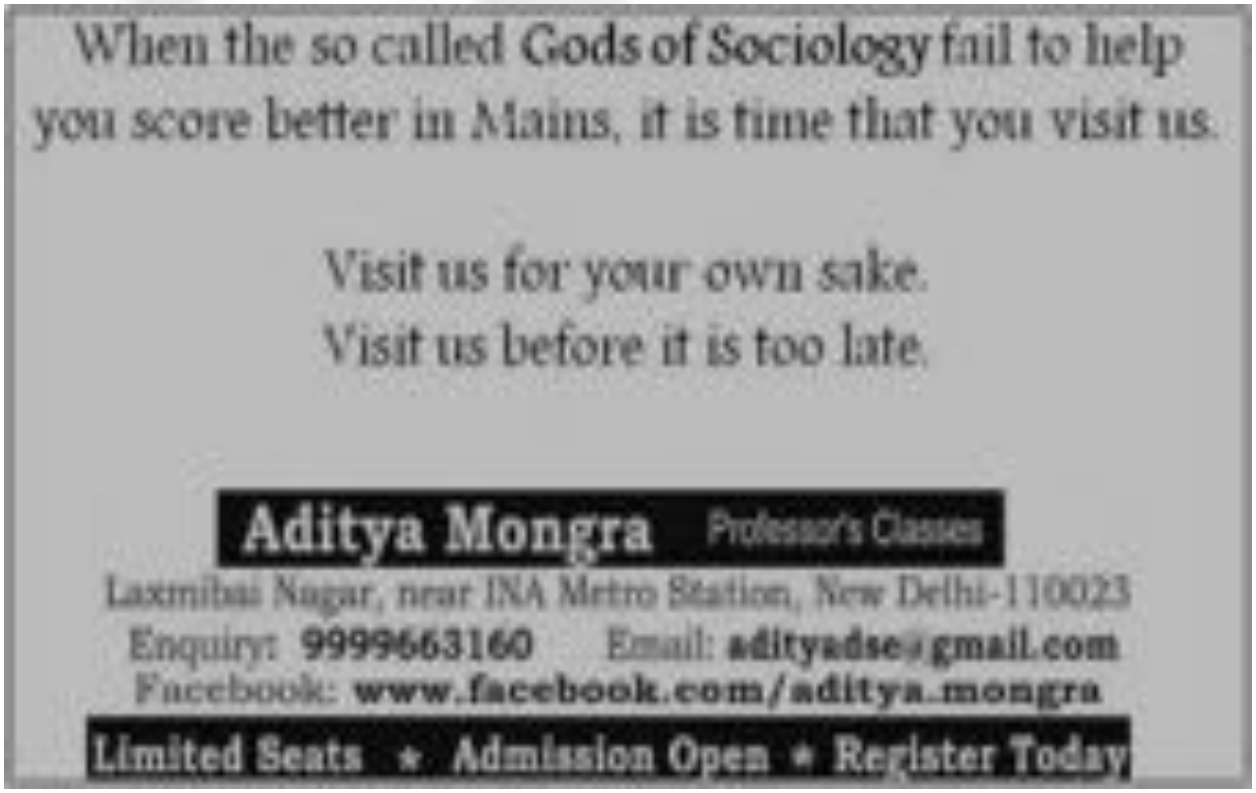
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of each dimension are put into the form of a series of questions, which will provide quantifiable data for measuring each dimension.

However, whether such procedures succeed in producing valid measurements of human behaviour is open to question. Those who adopt phenomenological perspectives often reject the entire procedure of operational definitions, selecting indicators, constructing questionnaires and quantifying the results. They argue that rather than providing a valid picture of the social world, such operations merely serve to distort it. Since the social world is constructed by its members, the job of the sociologist is to investigate members' constructs. Positivist research procedures merely impose sociological constructs, categories and logic on that world.

There is little doubt that questionnaires are rather inexpensive and for that reason quite attractive. This is not merely a question of saving money but also of saving administrative time and talent, e.g. by using the mail system instead of a costly *ad hoc* staff of interviewers. One special advantage lies in the simultaneity of access. If it is important to reach all respondents at the same time, this is probably easier by means of questionnaires than interviews.



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Observation

Observation is a method that employs vision as its main means of data collection. It implies the use of eyes rather than of ears and the voice. It is accurate watching and noting of phenomena as they occur with regard to the cause and effect or mutual relations. It is watching other persons' behaviour as it actually happens without controlling it. For example, observing the life of street-children or a religious ceremony in any community.

Lindzey Gardner has defined observation as "selection, provocation, recording and encoding of that set of behaviours and settings concerning organisms '*in situ*' (naturalistic settings) which are consistent with empirical aims". In this definition, *selection* means that there is a focus in observation and also editing before, during and after the observations are made. *Provocation* means that though observers do not destroy natural settings but they can make subtle changes in natural settings which increase clarity. *Recording* means that observed incidents/events are recorded for subsequent analysis. *Encoding* involves simplification of records.

According to Black and Champion, the major purpose of observation is to capture human conduct as it actually happens. In other methods, we get a static comprehension of people's activity. In actual situation, they sometimes modify their views, sometimes contradict themselves, and sometimes are so swayed by the situation that they react differently altogether. They further argue that observation can be used as a tool of collecting information in situations where methods other than observation cannot prove to be useful, e.g., voter's behaviour during election time or worker's behaviour during strike.

A significant number of sociologists choose not to use the more scientific approaches to the study of human behaviour. They prefer to sacrifice a certain precision of measurement and objectivity in order to get closer to their subjects, to examine the social world through the perspective of the people they are investigating. These sociologists sometimes refer to quantitative researchers as those who "measure everything and understand nothing."

By far the most important of the so-called qualitative methodologies is **participant observation**, in which the researcher participates in the daily life of the population under study, observing things that happen, listening to conversations, informally questioning people. This may be done covertly, as when a sociologist becomes a prison inmate in order to study the effectiveness of rehabilitation programs. It may also be done openly, by joining a group in the formal role of observer.

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In simple words, participant observation is a method in which the investigator becomes a part of the situation he is studying. He involves himself in the setting and group life of the research subjects. He shares the activities of the community observing what is going on around him, supplementing this by conversations and interview. One of the pioneering uses of participant observation by sociologists in a modern setting is recorded in William Foote Whyte's *Street Corner Society: The Social Structure of an Italian Slum*.

Street Corner Society by William Foote Whyte is a study of an Italian American streetcorner gang in a low-income district of south Boston. Whyte spent three and a half years living in the area as a participant observer. Whyte studied lower class "slum" street-corner groups by joining and talking informally with the members. He gained access to the first group through a social worker, became friendly with the group's leader, was introduced to other groups, and finally was accepted as "one of them" although he did not have to "play their game all the way." By "hanging out" on the street corner for a period of time, Whyte gained much valuable information about the group's goals and structure and the motivations of its members.

Supporters of participants observation have argued that, compared to other research techniques, it is least likely to lead to the sociologist imposing his reality on the social world he seeks to understand. It therefore provides the best means of obtaining a valid picture of social reality. With a structured interview – a predetermined set of questions which the interviewee is requested to answer – or a questionnaire – a set of printed questions to which the respondent is asked to provide written answer – the sociologist has already decided what is important. With preset questions he imposes his framework and priorities on those he wishes to study. By assuming the questions are relevant to his respondents he has already made many assumptions about their social world. Although the participant observer begins his work with some preconceived ideas, for example he will usually have studied the existing literature on the topic he is to investigate, he at least has the opportunity to directly observe the social world.

However, the success of participant observation depends initially upon the acceptance of the observer by the group he wishes to study. Once accepted, the participant observer must gain the trust of those he observes to be successful. Further, there are also the challenges of objectivity and value-neutrality. Since the observer participates in the events, sometimes he becomes so involved that he loses objectivity in observation. He may start interpreting events subjectively. Further, his presence may sensitise the subjects that they do not act in a natural way. In other words, his presence will to some degree influence the actions of those he

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observes. In this way he may modify or change the social world he wishes to investigate.

Those who argue that research methods in sociology should be drawn from the natural sciences (positivists) are often highly critical of participant observation. In particular they argue that the data obtained from participant observation lack 'reliability'. In the natural sciences data are seen to be reliable, if other researchers using the same methods of investigation on the same material produce the same results. By replicating an experiment it is possible to check for errors in observation and measurement. Once reliable data have been obtained, generalizations can then be made about the behaviour observed. No sociologist would claim that the social sciences can attain the standards of reliability employed in the natural sciences. Many would argue, however, that sociological data can attain a certain standard of reliability. They criticize participant observation for its failure to approach this standard. The data obtained by participant observation are seen to be unreliable because, as a method, its procedures are not made explicit, its observations are unsystematic and its results are rarely quantified. Thus there is no way of replicating a study and checking the reliability of its findings. Since participant observation relies heavily on the sensitivity, interpretive skills and personality of the observer, precise replication of studies using this method are difficult if not impossible. As a result it is not possible to generalize from such studies. Their value is seen to lie in providing useful insights which can then be tested on larger samples using more rigorous and systematic methods.

The above criticisms derive mainly from those who adopt a strongly positivist approach. Others would argue that what the findings of participant observation lack in reliability, they often more than make up for in validity. By coming face to face with social reality, the participant observer at least has the opportunity to make valid observations. Many would argue that the systematic questionnaire surveys favoured by many positivists have little or no chance of tapping the real social world.

Please note that in non-participant observation, the observer remains detached and does not participate or intervene in the activities of those who are being observed. He merely observes their behaviour. Sometimes, this places the persons being observed in an awkward position and their conduct becomes unnatural. But some say that though initially the observer's behaviour may affect the behaviour of the observed but after a little while, less and less attention is paid to his presence. This type of observation is more useful as a tool of data collection because the observer can choose the situations to be observed and can record the data freely. This is because the observer is not required to participate actively in the social processes at work in the social field he is observing. Since, he is not

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himself immediately affected by the demands of the situation, he can concentrate his whole attention more easily on systematic observation of the situation and what is happening in it.



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Focus Group

Focus group is a qualitative research method of data collection in social sciences. Over the past decade, focus groups and group interviews have emerged as popular techniques for gathering qualitative data, both among sociologists and across a wide range of academic and applied research areas.

David L. Morgan has defined focus groups as 'a research technique that collects data through group interaction on a topic determined by the researcher'. This definition has three essential components. First, it clearly states that focus groups are a research method devoted to data collection. Second, it locates the interaction in a group discussion as the source of the data. Third, it acknowledges the researcher's active role in creating the group discussion for data collection purposes.

Thus, on the basis of this definition, focus groups should be distinguished from groups whose primary purpose is something other than research, for example, therapy, education, decision-making, etc. Further, it is useful to distinguish focus groups from procedures that utilize multiple participants but do not allow interactive discussions, such as nominal groups and Delphi groups. Finally, focus groups should be distinguished from methods that collect data from naturally occurring group discussions where no one acts as an interviewer. However, there is a difference of opinion among scholars on the issue whether focus groups should be distinguished from other types of group interviews. On one hand are the scholars who use an inclusive approach and treat most forms of group interviews as variants of focus groups. On the other hand, there are scholars who use an exclusive approach and treat focus group as a distinct technique which should not be confused with other types of group interviews. In this regard, Frey and Fontana argue that group interviews can be distinguished from focus groups on the basis of three features.

- Firstly, group interviews are conducted in informal settings;
- Secondly, group interviews use non-directive interviewing, and
- Thirdly, group interviews use unstructured question formats.

Similarly, Stewart and Shamdasani associate focus groups with more or less directive interviewing styles and structured question formats.

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However, applied demographers such as John Knodel, who have held focus group interviews throughout the world, concluded that focus groups can be adapted to a wide variety of settings and culture practices. Hence, in actual practice, it would be quite difficult to apply the above mentioned classification as the methodology of focus groups or group interviews is largely dependent on the purpose of a particular project as well as the socio-cultural context.

Today focus groups, like other qualitative methods, are being used across a wide variety of research areas including education, public health, marketing research, etc. In recent years, two specific areas where the applied use of focus groups has had a major and continuing link to sociology are family planning and HIV/AIDS. Studies conducted in these areas suggest that the use of focus groups facilitated better understanding of knowledge, attitudes, and practices with regard to contraception in the Third World countries. Further, an important aspect of focus group method is that it facilitates participatory research. Various studies have suggested that use of focus group method in HIV/AIDS research has not only facilitated a better understanding of the problems being faced by at-risk groups but it also serves to "give a voice" to such marginalized groups.

Uses of Focus Groups in combination with other methods:

Focus groups can be used as both either independently or in combination with other methods such as individual interviews, surveys, etc.

Focus Groups and Individual Interviews:

Focus groups and individual interviews, both are qualitative techniques of data collection. But while focus groups and group interviews provide greater breath to the research, individual interviews on the other hand provide greater depth.

Various researchers have often used in-depth individual interviews as a follow up to focus group studies in order to ascertain the degree of consistency or discrepancy in the responses of the participants.

Focus Groups and Surveys:

Morgan has described four ways of combining quantitative and qualitative methods using survey and focus groups as example. The four ways of combining the methods are based on, 'which method received the primary attention and whether the secondary method served as a preliminary or follow-up study'?

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First combination: *Survey as the primary method and focus group for preliminary study.*

The first combination contains studies in which surveys are the primary method and focus groups serve in a preliminary capacity. Survey researchers typically use this design to develop the context of their questionnaires. Because surveys are inherently limited by the questions they ask, it is increasingly common to use focus groups to provide data on how the respondents themselves talk about the topics of the survey.

For example, in order to carry out a survey on the factors that influence the voting behaviour of people in rural areas, a preliminary focus group study may be undertaken to list various important factors and issues that people take into account when voting such as caste, religion, socio-economic status of the contestants, etc. The data thus collected from this preliminary focus group study may be used to design the questionnaire for the survey study.

Second combination: *Focus groups as the primary method and survey for preliminary study.*

In the second combination, focus groups are the primary method while surveys provide preliminary inputs. Studies following this research design make use of the data obtained from survey in selecting samples for focus groups to carry out a detailed analysis.

For example, a preliminary survey study may be carried out to know about the opinion of students regarding implementation of semester system. After determining the general opinion of the students either for or against the semester system, a more intense and detailed focus group study may be carried out to find out the reasons that students give for their respective opinion.

Third combination: *Survey as the primary method and focus group as a follow up.*

The third combination uses survey as the primary method and focus group as a follow up study. This type of research design is increasingly being used for interpreting the survey results and in determining the degree to which the results of both methods are in conformity or at variance with each other. For example, if a survey study finds out that people in rural areas give high priority to caste factor during voting, it may be cross-checked by a follow-up focus group study.

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Fourth combination: *Focus group as the primary method and survey as a follow up.*

The fourth combination uses focus group as the primary method and survey as a follow up. For example, if a focus group study suggests caste factor as the most important factor determining the voting behaviour of people rural India, it may be cross checked by a follow up survey.

Survey Vs Focus Group:

Survey offers more breadth to research both in terms of coverage of area as well as coverage of issues. Focus Group offers more depth to research by means of in-depth and detailed investigation over a topic.

Strength and Weakness of Focus Groups:

Morgan and Krueger argue that compared to other methods the real strength of focus groups is not simply in exploring what people have to say, but in providing insights into the sources of complex behaviors and motivations. They view this advantage of focus groups as a direct outcome of the interaction in focus groups. What makes the discussion in focus groups more than the sum of separate individual interviews is the fact that the participants both query each other and explain themselves to each other. Morgan & Krueger argue that such interaction offers valuable data on the extent of consensus and diversity among the participants. This ability to observe the extent and nature of interviewees' agreement and disagreement is a unique strength of focus groups.

The weaknesses of focus groups, like their strengths, are linked to the process of producing focused interactions, raising issues about both the role of the moderator in generating the data and the impact of the group itself on the data. Agar and MacDonald, and Saferstein from their respective studies have concluded that the behaviour of the moderator has consequences for the nature of group interviews.

Sussman et al. in their study administered questionnaires before and after focus group discussion to find out if the focus group discussion changed the participants' attitudes. They found that the attitudes became more extreme after the group discussion. In other words, after the focus group discussion, there was a polarization effect on the attitudes of the participants. Thus it could be concluded that 'group effect' also influences the response of participants in a focus group.

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Further, critics argue that only a limited range of topics can be researched effectively in groups. It is argued that some sensitive issues may be unacceptable for discussion among some categories of research participants. However, this assumption is being questioned in the light of widespread use of group interviews to study various sensitive issues like sexual behaviour, etc.

Dear Candidate, many of the debates about the merits of particular research methods focus on questions of 'reliability' and 'validity'. In the natural sciences, data are seen to be 'reliable' if other researchers using the same methods of investigation on the same material produce the same results. By replicating an experiment it is possible to check for errors in observation and measurement. Once reliable data have been obtained, generalizations can then be made about the behaviour observed. No sociologist would claim that the social sciences can attain the standards of reliability employed in the natural sciences. Many would argue, however, that sociological data can attain a certain standard of reliability. Generally speaking, quantitative methods are seen to provide greater reliability. They usually produce standardized data in a statistical form: the research can be repeated and the results checked. Qualitative methods are often criticized for failing to meet the same standards of reliability. Such methods may be seen as unreliable because the procedures used to collect data can be unsystematic, the results are rarely quantified, and there is no way of replicating a qualitative study and checking the reliability of its findings.

Further, data are considered 'valid' if they provide a true picture of what is being studied. A valid statement gives a true measurement or description of what it claims to measure or describe. It is an accurate reflection of social reality. Data can be reliable without being valid. Studies can be replicated and produce the same results but those results may not be a valid measure of what the researcher intends to measure. For instance, statistics on church attendance may be reliable but they do not necessarily give a true picture of religious commitment.

Supporters of qualitative methods often argue that quantitative methods lack validity. Statistical research methods may be easy to replicate but they may not provide a true picture of social reality. They are seen to lack the depth to describe accurately the meanings and motives that form the basis of social action. They use categories imposed on the social world by sociologists, categories that may have little meaning or relevance to other members of society. To many interpretive sociologists, only qualitative methods can overcome these problems and provide a valid picture of social reality.

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Researchers are sometimes attracted to quantitative methods because of their practicality. Quantitative methods are generally less time-consuming and require less personal commitment. It is usually possible to study larger and more representative samples which can provide an overall picture of society. Qualitative research often has to be confined to the study of small numbers because of practical limitations. It is more suited to providing an in-depth insight into a smaller sample of people.



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Variables (Concepts) and Hypothesis

Dear Candidate, in our discussion on 'scientific method', we have learned that a social scientist starts his research by defining precisely what it is he wants to know. This he does by formulating a clear and verifiable hypothesis. Let us now discuss hypothesis and its relevance in sociological enquiry in detail.

According to Theodorson and Theodorson, a **hypothesis** is a tentative statement asserting a relationship between certain facts. Bailey has also said that a hypothesis is a proposition stated in a testable form which predicts a particular relationship between two or more variables. Since statements in hypothesis have to be put to empirical investigation, the definition of hypothesis excludes all such statements which are merely opinions or value judgements, for example, *'All politicians are corrupt'*. In other words, a hypothesis carries clear implications for testing the stated relationship, that is, it contains variables that are measurable and also specifies how they are related. A statement that lacks variables or that does not explain how the variables are related to each other is no hypothesis in scientific sense. **Variables** are measurable phenomena whose values can change. In social sciences, variables may be understood as the social characteristics that can be converted into measurable forms and analyzed. This point will be more clear in our subsequent discussion on operationalisation of concepts.

In social sciences, the social scientists tend to study and explore the various aspects of social reality and interrelationship among them. Since social reality is infinite, social scientists make sense of this infinite social reality through logical abstractions. These logical abstractions or mental constructs are nothing but the 'concepts'. Hence, when a social scientist is carrying out a research to test his hypothesis, he is actually exploring the relationship between the two concepts. Thus, in general, variables in social sciences are nothing but the concepts which are the part of the research. However, in particular, variables are described as the specific characteristics or attributes of the more general concepts. As you will learn soon that in order to carry out a research, the variables or the concepts used in hypothesis should be clearly defined and operationalised. This point will be discussed in detail with examples in our subsequent discussion on operationalisation of concepts. Further, the terms 'independent variable', 'dependent variable' and 'extraneous variable' used commonly in research have already been discussed in our earlier discussion on the 'scientific method.'

A few examples of hypothesis are cited below:

- Suicide rates vary inversely with social integration.
- Urbanisation leads to proliferation of nuclear families.

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- Literacy rate is directly related to average marital age.
- Children from broken homes more likely tend to be delinquents.

Hypothesis formulation is of fundamental importance in any research. A hypothesis looks forward. It provides direction to research. Without it, research is unfocussed and may be reduced to a random empirical wandering. Results of such an unguided research would be of little use. The hypothesis is the necessary link between theory and the investigation which leads to the discovery of additions to knowledge.

Goode and Hatt argue that the theory and hypothesis are very closely interrelated. Hypotheses are the deduced propositions from the existing theory. These hypotheses, when tested, by means of empirical investigations, are either proved or disproved. Hence, in turn, hypothesis testing leads to either revalidation or reformulation of the theory.

Let us now discuss a few essential characteristics of a good hypothesis. The most fundamental of them all is that a hypothesis must be conceptually clear. This means that the variables or the concepts used in hypothesis should be clearly defined and operationalised. **Operationalisation of concepts** refers to the process of defining concepts in terms of those attributes which could be empirically observed during research. In other words, operationalisation refers to the process of converting concepts in their empirical measurements. For example, the concept of anomie, in general terms, is defined as a 'state of normlessness' in society. Now, anomie could be observed in social, economic and political systems of a given society. For instance, the concept of anomie in social sphere may be operationalised by identifying the quantifiable attributes such as incidence of suicide, crime, honour killings, etc. on which empirical data can be collected. Similarly, in political sphere, the concept of anomie may be operationalised when it is explained in terms of the attributes like stability of the government, corruption in the government, people's perception about the government, etc. In economic sphere, the concept of anomie may be operationalised when it is defined in terms of attributes like economic inequality, poverty, unemployment, etc.

Secondly, the variables or the concepts used in hypothesis should be commonly accepted and communicable. In simpler words, it implies that there should be uniformity in the definition and meaning of the concepts used in hypothesis. Once the concepts have been clearly defined and operationalised by

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means of their empirical referents, a hypothesis must also specify the relationship between the variables. A hypothesis that does not explain how the concepts are related to each other is no hypothesis in scientific sense. For example, suicide rates *vary inversely* with social integration.

Another important characteristic of a good hypothesis is that it should be related to the available techniques of data collection and interpretation. In other words, a hypothesis must be so formulated keeping in mind the availability as well as applicability of the techniques of data collection in the respective field (socio-geographical area identified to carry out the research). Further, a good hypothesis must be related to a body of theory. As stated earlier that one of the key feature of any scientific discipline is its cumulative nature. Likewise, sociological theories are built upon one another, extending and refining the older ones and producing the new ones. This would be possible only if the hypotheses are related to a body of theory.

Dear Candidate, so far we have discussed the meaning of hypothesis, its relevance in sociological enquiry and some characteristics of a good hypothesis. We have discussed that a hypothesis is a tentative statement asserting a relationship between two or more concepts or variables. What do you understand by concept? What is the relevance of concepts in sociology? What are the problems associated in defining the concepts in sociology? Let us now try to understand and answer these questions. Though this topic has not been explicitly mentioned in the syllabus but it is a very important dimension of hypothesis formulation and theory building.

Concepts are the logical abstractions or mental constructs created from sense impressions, percepts or experiences. Concept formation is an essential step in the process of sociological reasoning. Concepts are the tools with which we think, criticise, argue, explain and analyse. We build up our knowledge of the social world not simply by looking at it but through developing and refining concepts which will help us make sense of it. Concepts, in that sense, are the building blocks of human knowledge. Concepts help in comprehending the reality that a science is engaged in studying. Concepts act as mediums of short-cut communication among those associated with the enquiry (social scientists).

Concepts and hypotheses are the core of social research. For any social research to be fruitful, it is important that the concepts or variables mentioned in the hypothesis are operationalised. As discussed earlier, operationalisation of

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concepts refers to the process of defining concepts in terms of those attributes which could be empirically observed during research. In other words, operationalisation refers to the process of converting concepts in their empirical measurements. For example, the concept of alienation is generally explained in terms of powerlessness, meaninglessness, normlessness, social isolation and self-estrangement. Now, in a given workplace, powerlessness could be empirically measured in terms of the indicators such as participation in the administration, degree of control over decision-making process, grievance redressal mechanism, etc.

Let us now discuss the various problems in defining concepts in sociology.

Social reality is dynamic in character and so are the concepts in sociology. Sociology being a relatively young discipline relies more and more on empirical research for verification and validation of the existing theories and concepts. Hence new findings lead to modification of the established concepts and theories. In other words, it leads to re-conceptualization or re-specification of a concept. For example, earlier the personality differences between men and women were explained in biological terms. However later day research by anthropologists like Margaret Mead who in her study "Sex and temperament in three primitive tribes" studied three tribes namely Arapesh, Mundugumor and Tchambuli (in the western Pacific) and concluded that personality patterns were culturally determined rather than biologically. In brief, her comparative study revealed a full range of contrasting gender roles. Among the Arapesh, both men and women were peaceful in temperament and neither men nor women made war. Among the Mundugumor, the opposite was true: both men and women were warlike in temperament. Among the Tchambuli, gender role reversal was found. While the men 'primped' and spent their time decorating themselves, the women worked and were the practical ones. Similarly, you can also discuss here that how the concepts of class, caste (jati), etc. have undergone changes with new findings put forward by later day researches.

Secondly, sociology as a discipline is rapidly attaining maturity with the contributions of several established and highly reputed schools like British school, American school, French school and German school, etc. But the contributions from diverse school of thoughts give rise to the problem of ensuring uniformity in the definition and meaning of the concepts. Concepts develop from a shared experience. Since each school of sociological thought puts forward its own set of concepts and defines the concept in the context of its unique social setting, it gives rise to the problem of communication. For example, the concepts of *Gemeinschaft* and *Gesellschaft*, which were coined by the German sociologist Ferdinand

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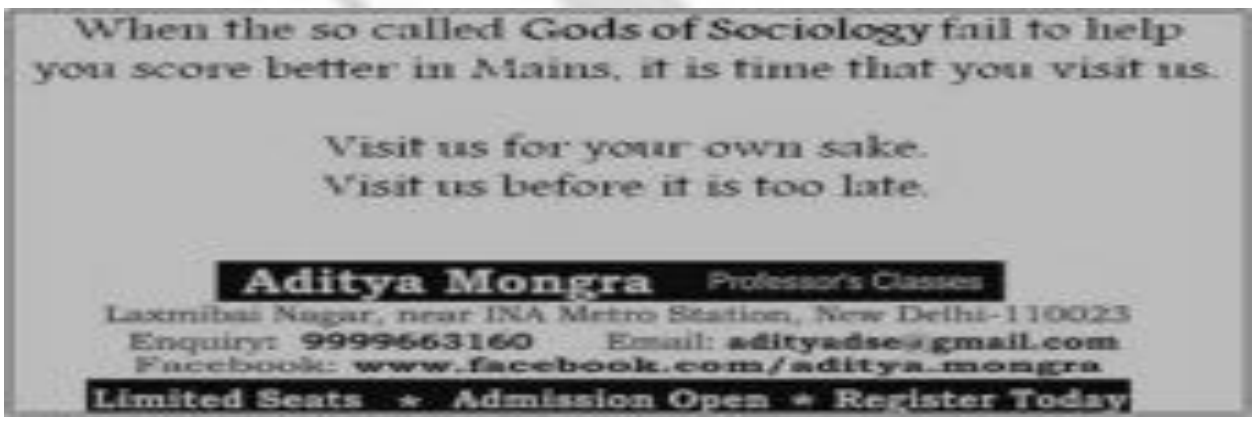
Tonnies, have no English equivalent. The terms *Community* and *Association* which are English translations of these words, do not convey the particular sociological meaning of these two German words.

Thirdly, due to the very subject matter of sociology, the terms used to denote scientific concepts may also have meanings in other frames of reference. For instance, the term 'bureaucracy' which implies a particular type of social structure may either be seen as a rationally designed authority structure or as an administrative institution characterised by red-tapism, corruption and official disregard for the public interest.

Another problem associated with defining the concepts in social sciences is that the same term may refer to different phenomena. For example, the term 'function' in one sense may be used to denote the contributions which a given practice or belief makes toward the continued existence of society. However, the term function may also be used to denote the causal relationship between two variables. For example, in determining that to what extent one variable (proliferation of nuclear families) is the function of another variable (industrialisation).

Further, in social sciences, different terms or concepts may be used to refer to the same or similar phenomena. For example, the terms like formal-informal, organic-mechanistic, primary-secondary, community-association, etc. overlap to a great degree in their meaning. Another problem with regard to concepts in social sciences is that a given concept may have no immediate empirical referent. For example, the concepts like social system, social structure, etc. have no immediate empirical referents or quantifiable attributes. At best they can be studied by observing the patterns of relations among the members of a given society.

Thus, a social scientist must define the concepts as precisely as possible and operationalise the concepts in order to conduct a meaningful and result-oriented research.



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Comparative Method

Dear Candidate, I would also like to discuss a few other topics which though not mentioned in the syllabus but are integral components of the topic 'Research Methods and Analysis' and hence very important. These topics are comparative method and historical method.

Comparative Method:

Comparative method refers to the study of different types of groups and societies in order to determine analytically the factors that lead to similarities and differences in specified patterns of behaviour.

Comparative method is an integral component of the positivist tradition in sociology. The founding fathers of sociology like Auguste Comte, Herbert Spencer and Emile Durkheim laid great emphasis on the use of 'comparative method' in any sociological enquiry. In the 19th century, when sociology as a discipline was still in its infancy stage, the principle attraction of the comparative method lay in the belief that it could be used for discovering scientific laws about human society and culture. The strong advocates of the comparative method believed in the possibility of a natural science of society that would establish regularities of coexistence and succession among the forms of social life by means of systematic comparisons. Unlike natural sciences, sociology cannot make proper use of experimental method in the study of any particular social phenomena in a laboratory due to certain moral and ethical reasons. But a sociologist can surely experiment in the laboratory of the world by employing the comparative method.

Not only was the early use of the comparative method tied to the idea of a natural science of society, it was, more specifically, tied to the theory of evolution. A large part of nineteenth-century anthropology was concerned with the origins of phenomena and the reconstruction of the stages through which they had evolved from simplest to their most complex forms. The classification and comparison of the forms of social life became an indispensable part of this process of reconstruction.

The central place assigned to comparison was signalled by Durkheim when he wrote: 'Comparative sociology is not a special branch of sociology; it is sociology itself'. Durkheim regarded the comparative method as the counterpart in the social sciences of the experimental method pursued in natural sciences. He recognized that social fact could only be observed, not artificially produced under experimental conditions. Therefore, Durkheim favoured a comparative-historical

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approach because sociologists could not carry out experiments and had to rely on the method of indirect experiment, that is, the comparison of similar cases in a systematic way. In this regard it is important to note that Durkheim, following J.S. Mill's *System of Logic*, refers appreciatively to the 'method of concomitant variations' as the procedure of the comparative method. He calls it 'instrument par excellence of sociological research'. Please note that concomitant variation simply refers to the method of establishing statistical correlation between two variables. For example, Durkheim in his study of suicide found that Germany, a Protestant-dominated country, reported high suicide rate whereas Spain, a Catholic-dominated country reported low suicide rate. Hence, he arrived at a conclusion that the rate of suicide is correlated with the religious faith in a society.

However, in this regard, S.F. Nadel in his work '*The Foundations of Social Anthropology*' argues that the notion of concomitant variations do not mean the same thing in J.S. Mill's *System of Logic* and in Durkheim's sociological treatise. Nadel argues that while for Mill, concomitant variations imply quantitative correlation, but Durkheim makes as well as advocates the use of comparative method with concomitant variations to arrive at qualitative correlations. For instance, after having arrived at a statistical correlation between the suicide rate and a particular religion, he further explores what makes people of a particular religious faith more or less prone to suicide. The answer he arrived was solidarity. The lower degree of solidarity or social integration among the Protestants prone them to greater suicidal tendencies while higher solidarity among the Catholics, affirmed by the age old institution of Church, resulted in relatively fewer suicides. Hence, Durkheim concluded that '*the rate of suicide is inversely proportional to the degree of solidarity*'.

A.R. Radcliffe-Brown (1881-1955), in Britain, was another strong advocate of the comparative method. Radcliffe-Brown borrowed a great deal from Durkheim, including the idea that societies were governed by laws that could be discovered by the application of the proper method. That method was the comparative method based on observation, description and comparison of societies as they actually existed. He often used the term 'comparative sociology' as a synonym for social anthropology. He argued that in comparative sociology or social anthropology, the purpose of comparison is to explore the varieties of forms of social life as a basis for the theoretical study of human social phenomena.

In his essay, '*The Comparative Method in Social Anthropology*', Radcliffe-Brown further extended the argument of Durkheim to explain why a particular totem is chosen by a society or group as its totem. In a comparative analysis of various tribes of Australia and north-west America, he found various instances whereby a tribe was divided into two exogamous moieties and each moiety

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represented by particular natural specie as its totem. For example, in case of Australian aborigines in New South Wales, the two moieties were represented by eaglehawk and crow. On the basis of his comparative study, he concluded that the selection of a particular set of natural species as the totem by the two exogamous moieties of a tribe is also associated with their inter-group social relations. He found it common that natural species were placed in pairs of opposites, with certain degree of resemblances as well as differences. He interpreted the resemblances and differences of animal species in terms of social relationships of friendship and antagonism in human society.

Thus on the basis of his comparative study he arrived at a higher order generalization that relationships of mutual alliance and antagonism are universal to human society. However, the manner in which these relationships of alliance and opposition get reflected may vary from society to society. For example, in his comparative study of the institution of marriage, he found that the expression of relationships of alliance and opposition may take the form of joking and avoidance relationship. In joking relationship, members of opposite divisions are permitted or expected to indulge in teasing each other, in verbal abuse or in exchange of insults. Joking relationships serve to protect the delicate relationships between persons who are bound together in one set of ties and yet separated by other ties. For example, the members of different lineages are socially separated from each other, but, if they marry each other, they are also allied. Joking, thus, is one way of defusing the tensions of certain delicate relationships. Another response is avoidance or extreme respect. It prevents conflict that might arise through divergence of interest. In many societies, a man is required to avoid any close social contact with the mother of his wife, etc.

However, Andre Beteille in his essay '*Some Observations on the Comparative Method*' argues that the great wave of enthusiasm for the comparative method belongs to the past, and today there are probably more sceptics than enthusiasts. Among the sceptics, Franz Boas, Goldenweiser and Evans-Pritchard are some of the important names. For example, Franz Boas objected to the sweeping generalizations made through the use of comparative method, and recommended studies on a more limited geographical scale. He clearly stated his preference for 'historical method' over and above the comparative method. Similarly, Evans-Pritchard recommended intensive comparative investigation in a limited area rather than going for universal generalisations. Similarly, scholars belonging to the phenomenological tradition argue that the application of this method is not as simple as it may appear because social units have different meanings in different societies. For instance, the institution of marriage among Hindus is regarded as an indissoluble and sacred bond between husband and wife. But, Muslim marriage, on the other hand, is not a

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religious sacrament but a secular bond. It is a social or civil contract, which can be terminated.

However, despite these criticisms and limitations of comparative method, its significance in sociology cannot be undermined. For example, Durkheim and Weber, in their respective works have clearly highlighted the importance of comparative method as a scientific for sociological enquiry for a comprehensive understanding of social reality.

Historical method:

As discussed earlier, inquiries in social sciences could be classified in two categories, the nomothetic and the ideographic. According to this classification, the ideographic sciences are those which study unique and unrepeatable events, while the nomothetic sciences attempt to make generalizations. We can, thus, call sociology as a nomothetic science and history as an ideographic science. Historians try to increase our accurate knowledge of unique phenomena of the past, whereas sociologists try to seek information about certain uniformities in social behaviour under specific conditions. This, in principle, is the difference between the two modes of inquiry. However, the data of history are also widely used now by sociologists. On the other hand, historians have also started using data generated by sociologists for their own writings.

Historical method is one of the important methods to analyse the process of social change that occurred in past. It involves the study of origins, development and transformation of social institutions over a period of time. The historical method in sociology has taken two principal forms. The first is that of early sociologists, initially influenced by the philosophy of history and later by biological theory of evolution. It concentrates upon the origin, development and transformation of social institutions, societies and civilizations. It is concerned with the whole span of human history with all the major institutions of society, as in the works of Comte, Spencer, Hobhouse, etc. It was also employed by Karl Marx in conjunction with dialectical materialism in understanding the human societies. Marx talked of dialectical materialism to explain change as a historical phenomenon. According to Marx, the history of all the hitherto societies is the history of class struggle. He classified the evolution of human society in terms the following stages, viz. primitive communism, ancient society, feudal society, capitalist society and communism.

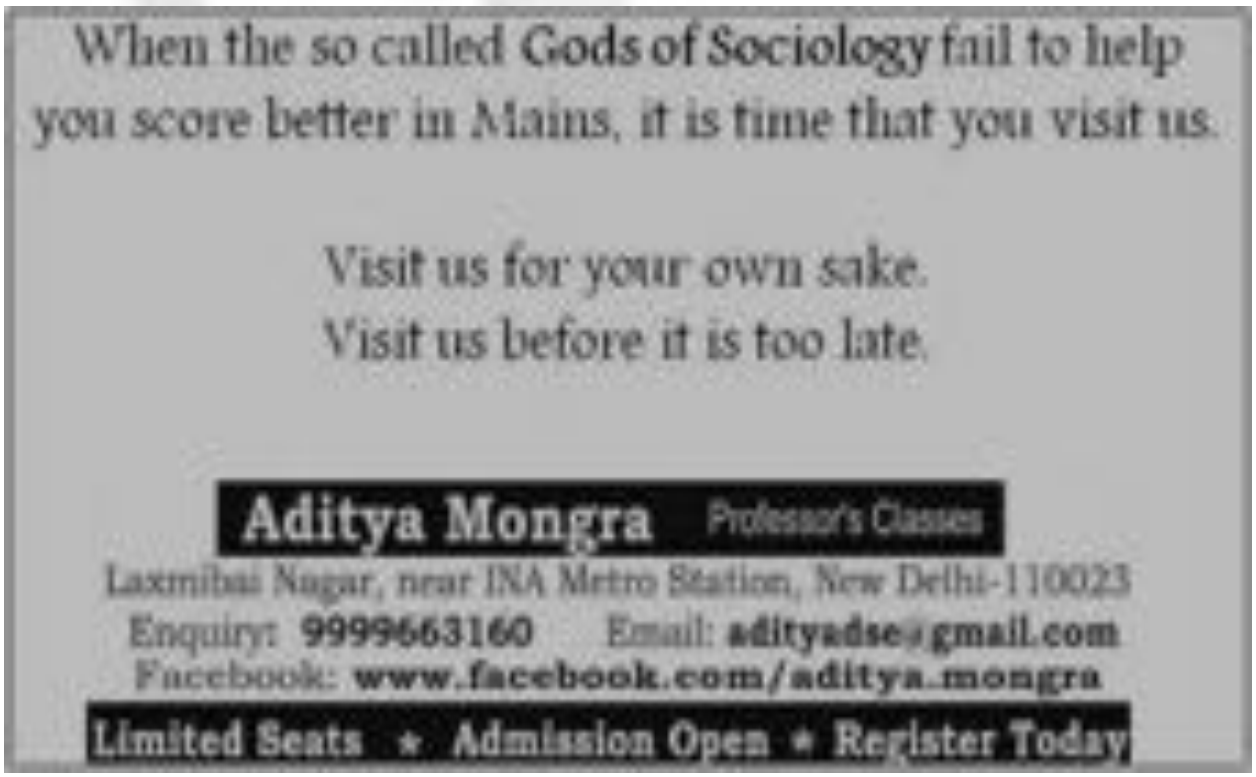
Yet another form of historical method is characteristic of the works of Max Weber. This is exemplified, especially, in his studies of the origins of capitalism,

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the development of modern bureaucracy, and the economic influence of the world religions. The main methodological features of these studies are that particular historical changes of social structures and types of society are investigated; and are compared in certain respects with changes in other societies. In this manner, both causal explanation and historical interpretations find a place in the social explanation. A very convincing illustration of this approach of Weber is to be found in his treatment of the growth of capitalism in Europe, as he brings out in his book, *Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*.

P.V. Young, in her book *Scientific Social Surveys and Research*, describes sources of historical data highlighting both the adequacy and limitations of historical data. The social scientists generally confine themselves to three major sources of historical information, (i) Documents and various historical sources to which historians themselves have access, (ii) materials of cultural history and of analytical history, (iii) personal sources of authentic observers and witnesses. When, how and under what circumstances these sources are to be used depends upon the discretion of the researcher's interest, the scope of the study and the availability of the sources. Historical data have some limitations, which arise mainly because historians cannot describe all the happenings in time and space available at the time of writing history. Personal biases and private interpretations, often, enter unconsciously, even when, honest attempts are made to select and interpret pertinent facts.



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Content Analysis

Bernard Berelson defined content analysis as "a research technique for the objective, systematic, and quantitative description of manifest content of communications." Content analysis is a research tool focused on the actual content and internal features of media. It is used to determine the presence of certain words, concepts, themes, phrases, characters, or sentences within texts or sets of texts and to quantify this presence in an objective manner.

Content analysis or textual analysis is a methodology in the social sciences for studying the content of communication. Earl Babbie defines it as "the study of recorded human communications, such as books, websites, paintings and laws". Harold Lasswell formulated the core questions of content analysis: "Who says what, to whom, why, to what extent and with what effect?" Ole Holsti offers a broad definition of content analysis as "any technique for making inferences by objectively and systematically identifying specified characteristics of messages."

In simple words, content analysis is a research tool used to determine the presence of certain words or concepts within texts or sets of texts. Researchers quantify and analyze the presence, meanings and relationships of such words and concepts, then make inferences about the messages within the texts, the writer(s), the audience, and even the culture and time of which these are a part. Texts can be defined broadly as books, book chapters, essays, interviews, discussions, newspaper headlines and articles, historical documents, speeches, conversations, advertising, theatre, informal conversation, or really any occurrence of communicative language. To conduct a content analysis on any such text, the text is coded, or broken down, into manageable categories on a variety of levels – word, word sense, phrase, sentence, or theme – and then examined using one of content analysis' basic methods: conceptual analysis or relational analysis. Conceptual analysis can be thought of as establishing the existence and frequency of concepts in a text. Relational analysis builds on conceptual analysis by examining the relationships among concepts in a text.

Content analysis is a product of the electronic age. Though content analysis was regularly performed in the 1940s, it became a more credible and frequently used research method since the mid-1950s, as researchers started to focus on concepts rather than simply words, and on semantic relationships rather than just presence. While both traditions still continue today, content analysis now is also utilized to explore mental models, and their linguistic, affective, cognitive, social, cultural and historical significance. Due to the fact that it can be applied to examine any piece of writing or occurrence of recorded communication, content

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analysis is used in large number of fields, ranging from marketing and media studies, to literature and rhetoric, ethnography and cultural studies, gender and age issues, sociology and political science, psychology and cognitive science, as well as other fields of inquiry.

For example, in a research project on gender issues, the content of the text books (particularly the stories) was analysed and it was found that how gender relations prevailing in our society manifested themselves as well as got reinforced by the gender roles described in the various stories. The girl child often was depicted as an obedient child, helping the mother in the household chores. On the other hand, the boy was often portrayed as school going, naughty, and aiming high in life. Similarly, the content analysis of the local newspapers in rural hinterland could throw light on the prevailing caste relations and the nature of the caste conflict.

Bernard Berelson has identified the various uses of content analysis. Some of them are listed below:

- Reveal international differences in communication content
- Detect the existence of propaganda
- Identify the intentions, focus or communication trends of an individual, group or institution
- Describe attitudinal and behavioural responses to communications
- Determine psychological or emotional state of persons or groups

Content analysis offers several advantages to researchers who consider using it. In particular, content analysis:

- is an unobtrusive means of analyzing interactions. One of the significant advantages of content analysis is that it is an *unobtrusive* method, *i.e.*, it has no effect on the subject being studied. In other methods (like interview, observation, experiment, etc.), the researcher is directly involved with persons. Content analysis eliminates the source of 'response bias' that threatens research whenever the respondents are directly questioned or observed.
- looks directly at communication via texts or transcripts, and hence gets at the central aspect of social interaction

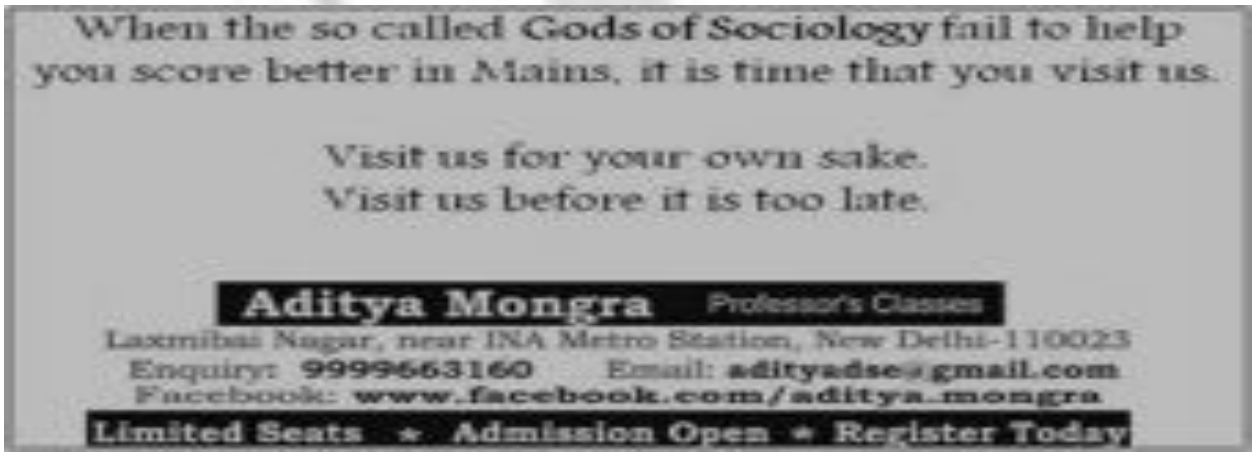
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- can allow for both quantitative and qualitative operations
- can provide valuable historical/cultural insights over time through analysis of texts
- makes possible a variety of cross cultural studies that would likely be unfeasible using other methods.
- provides insight into complex models of human thought and language use

Content analysis suffers from several disadvantages, both theoretical and procedural. In particular, content analysis:

- Since content analysis is a heavily planned method, it lacks the spontaneity often required in the field research
- can be extremely time consuming
- is subject to increased error, particularly when relational analysis is used to attain a higher level of interpretation
- is often devoid of theoretical base, or attempts too liberally to draw meaningful inferences about the relationships and impacts implied in a study
- often disregards the context that produced the text, as well as the state of things after the text is produced
- Some required documents may not be available to the researcher which may affect the conclusions.
- It is susceptible to coder's bias.



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Dear Candidate, now just to clarify some of your queries that might have arised after reading this note on content analysis, I would like to throw some light on the debates with regard to the use of content analysis. This is not very important from the examination point of view and it will also not be possible for you to incorporate all such details in a short note given the time and word limit.

One of the leading debates among the users of content analysis is whether analysis should be quantitative or qualitative. Berelson, for example, suggests that content analysis is "objective, systematic, and quantitative." Similarly, Silverman dismisses content analysis from his discussion of qualitative data analysis "because it is a quantitative method." Selltiz et al. however, state that concerns over quantification in content analysis tend to emphasize "the procedures of analysis," rather than the "character of the data available." Selltiz et al. suggest also that heavy quantitative content analysis results in a somewhat arbitrary limitation in the field by excluding all accounts of communication that are not in the form of numbers as well as those that may lose meaning if reduced to a numeric form (definitions, symbols, detailed explanations, photographs, and so forth). Other proponents of the content analysis, notably Smith, suggest that some blend of both quantitative and qualitative analysis should be used. Smith explains that he has taken this position "because qualitative analysis deals with the forms and antecedent-consequent patterns of form, while quantitative analysis deals with duration and frequency of form." Abrahamson suggests that "content analysis can be fruitfully employed to examine virtually any type of communication." As a consequence, content analysis may focus on either quantitative or qualitative aspects of communication messages.

Another controversy concerning the use of content analysis is whether the analysis should be limited to *manifest content* (those elements that are physically present and countable) or extended to more *latent content*. In the latter case, the analysis is extended to an interpretive reading of the symbolism underlying the physical data. For example, an entire speech may be assessed for how radical it was, or a novel could be considered in terms of how violent the entire text was. Stated in different words, manifest content is comparable to the *surface structure* present in the message, and latent content is the *deep structural* meaning conveyed by the message. Holsti has tried to resolve this debate: "It is true that only the manifest attributes of text may be coded, but this limitation is already implied by the requirement of objectivity. Inferences about latent meanings of messages are therefore permitted but....they require corroboration by independent evidence." One reasonable interpretation of this passage, and a similar statement made by Berelson, suggests that although there are some dangers in directly inferring from latent symbolism, it is nonetheless possible to use it. To accomplish this sort of "deciphering" of latent symbolic meaning, researchers must first incorporate

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independent corroborative techniques (for example, agreement between independent coders concerning latent content or some noncontent analytic source). Finally, and especially when latent symbolism may be discussed, researchers should offer detailed excerpts from relevant statements (messages) that serve to document the researchers' interpretations.



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Karl Marx (1818-1883)

Karl Marx was born in 1818 in Trier in Germany into a prosperous middle-class family. His parents were Jewish but his father converted to Protestantism so that he could retain his job as a senior lawyer in the Court of Appeal. This was due to the increased pressure and persecution of the Jews under the newly established Prussian regime following the fall of the more lenient Napoleonic government. Born in a bourgeois household and brought up by a highly educated lawyer, Marx naturally thought of pursuing an advanced university education upon completing his early studies at the Trier gymnasium. At age 17, in 1835, Karl Marx entered the University of Bonn to study law. The following year, unlike most German students who attend several universities before sitting for the university degree examinations, he journeyed to Berlin to study on the university faculty. Though Hegel had died in 1831, the university was still very much under the spell of his theory of history. Quickly succumbing to Hegelianism, he joined a rather loosely knit band of young radicals marginally affiliated with the university, who called themselves unabashedly the Doktorklub. Law was abandoned, and joining these Young Hegelians, Marx took up the study of philosophy.

Finally, in 1841 at the age of twenty-three, he received the doctorate degree from the University of Jena for his thesis on Greek natural philosophy. Having destroyed his chances at a university teaching career due to his radical and outspoken views, shortly after completing his studies, he began writing for a radical left-wing paper in Cologne, *Rheinische Zeitung*, and became its editor in 1842. Following the forced closure of the paper by the government because of a series of radically controversial articles by Marx on social conditions, Marx and his fiancée, Jenny, married and moved to Paris in 1843. The move to Paris was crucial for Marx for two reasons. First, still aged only 26, he wrote his most important philosophical work known as the 1844 *Paris Manuscripts*. Although these were not published until 1930 (and were not widely read until the 1950s), it is here that he introduced the concept of alienation, and laid the philosophical foundations for much of his later work. The second important event was meeting his lifelong friend Friedrich Engels (1820-1895). Despite being heir to flourishing textiles business with factories in Germany and a mill in Manchester, Engels had developed a reputation as a forthright critic of capitalist industry in his book, published in 1845, *The Condition of the Working Class in England*. Sharing many ideas with Marx, and certainly also favouring a socialist political outlook, Marx and Engels began a 40 year collaboration that lasted until Marx's death in 1883.

But, as in Germany two years before, the governmental authorities, this time of Guizot in Paris, expelled Marx and many of his associates. In 1845 Marx and his family were forced to leave Paris by the authorities there and they spent the next

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three years in Brussels. Moving to Brussels, he re-established contact with like-minded German refugees there, especially a socialist organization called the German Workers' Educational Association. This organization interestingly had headquarters in London and was federated with the Communist League of Europe. With a draft from Engels, and under commission from the G.W.E.A., Marx wrote *The Communist Manifesto* which was sent on to London headquarters in 1848. Just prior to that, he had published *The Holy Family* (1845) and *The Poverty of Philosophy* (1847). Another book, *The German Ideology*, was written in 1845-6, but was not published until 1932.

Under what appeared to be favourable but later proved unfavourable circumstances, Marx and Engels returned to Paris in 1848 following the outbreak of revolution in Germany, assuming the editorship of the radical paper, *Neue Rheinische Zeitung*. Failing to work out a working-class/bourgeoisie alliance against the feudal government, Marx was presented an ultimatum by the government in August 1849, of retiring to the French hinterlands or leaving the country. Opting for the latter, Marx migrated to London where he established permanent residence. The first few years in London proved productive, intellectually and literally, producing such works as *The Class Struggles in France* (1850) and *The 18th Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852). During these years, Marx also spent a great deal of time researching for his major work, the three-volume *Das Kapital* (or simply *Capital*). The first volume was published in 1867 and volumes two and three, edited by Engels after Marx's death, in 1885 and 1894. Also important from the period around 1859 is his *Contributions to a Critique of Political Economy* and a collection of 'fragments' or 'notes', which he wrote as a "preliminary work" to *Capital*, were eventually published in 1953 as *Grundrisse*.

Arriving in London in 1849 at the age of thirty one, Marx's life was just half over-a refugee thrice, twice exiled as an editor of a radical political paper, and once as the author of *The Communist Manifesto*, it would appear he had much to live and hope for. But in London, he withdrew with Engels into a close-knit circle composed of his family and a select few devoted disciples. This self-enforced isolation continued throughout the remainder of his life. After securing an admission card to the British Museum's reading room, much of the remainder of his active life centered around the analysis and the criticism of the industrial capitalism of the day. During this period, he was desperately impoverished, and save for the loyal assistance of Engels, all might have been lost. Three children died in the Marx household owing to malnutrition and impoverishment during the time he was completing the first volume of *Das Kapital* (or simply *Capital*). Except for the one pound sterling he received for each article he wrote for the New York Daily Tribune, he had nothing. For a brief time, Marx came out of seclusion and was saved from continued poverty due to the appearance of and subsequent

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leadership offered by him to *The International*, an international federation of European and English workers committed to altering the present economic system. From 1864 to 1872 Marx worked with the First International, which was filled with strife and in which various anarchists, in particular, were opposed to Marx. Marx quit the organization after writing *The Paris Commune*, following the fall of the Paris Commune in 1871. Marx, now wrecked by illness and broken health due to early poverty, and unfulfilled dreams, produced little during his last remaining years. Though a little comfortable towards the end of his life financially, and a distinct celebrity, for socialist leaders from all over the world came to visit him in London, he sustained two blows – the deaths of his eldest daughter and wife – from which he never recovered. Marx died on March 14, 1883.

As is the case with all philosophers and social theorists, Marx's social theory was a critical response to the leading theories and intellectual traditions of the day. His approach was to become fully engaged with a particular set of issues, reach conclusions about them and then fashion his own variations. In many ways, Marx's impact on social theory comes from the fact that his theory does not simply amount to a moderate reworking of what went before, a slight modification here and a bit of tinkering there, but is instead a complete transformation of it. It is this radical intellectual technique that makes Marx a *revolutionary thinker* rather just than somebody who writes *about* revolution in capitalist society. A common thread that runs throughout is Marx's preoccupation with conflict in society. One could say that, whether as a philosophy, an approach to social theory or as a political strategy, Marxist social theory specialises in the analysis of social conflict. This contrasts with the emphasis on social order in the work of Durkheim.

Dear Candidate, before I proceed further, I would like to throw some light on the social and intellectual background of Karl Marx.

Karl Marx's life coincided with the beginning of a change in the European countries from agrarian to industrial societies. It was in England, particularly, in the late eighteenth century that the Industrial Revolution began a concentration of the new working class into factories and housing areas; and Marx obtained most of his basic empirical data for his theory of the development of capitalism from England. Just as important to Marx's theory, however, was the French Revolution of 1789 with its abolition of feudal conditions, the growth of a bourgeois society, and appearance of an anti-bourgeois socialist left.

When Marx appeared on the scene, Germany, compared to England and France, was still a feudal country that was not united until 1871. The direct intellectual background for Marx's theories involved Germany's chances of catching up with more developed countries, and this debate was carried on by the

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radical successors of the philosopher G. W. F. Hegel (1770-1831). With his grand philosophical system, Hegel had attempted to show that human history had a goal, the most salient features of which were the creation of a reasonable state and the realization of the concept of freedom. Since Hegel believed that the Prussian state of his time had made the greatest advances toward realizing freedom and reason, as a professor in Berlin he became somewhat of a "state philosopher" for Prussia. The radicals among Hegel's followers, the young Hegelians objected to this and criticized the dominant position of religion in Prussia. Marx belonged to the young Hegelian movement for a time, but he soon came to criticize its belief that philosophical analysis would lead to change in and liberation of Germany. Instead, he was more influenced by Hegel's historical method in which development and change through *dialectic contradictions* are the primary components, although he rejected Hegel's emphasis on spiritual forces in history. In contrast, Marx stressed human social conditions, particularly their material production, as crucial to historical development.

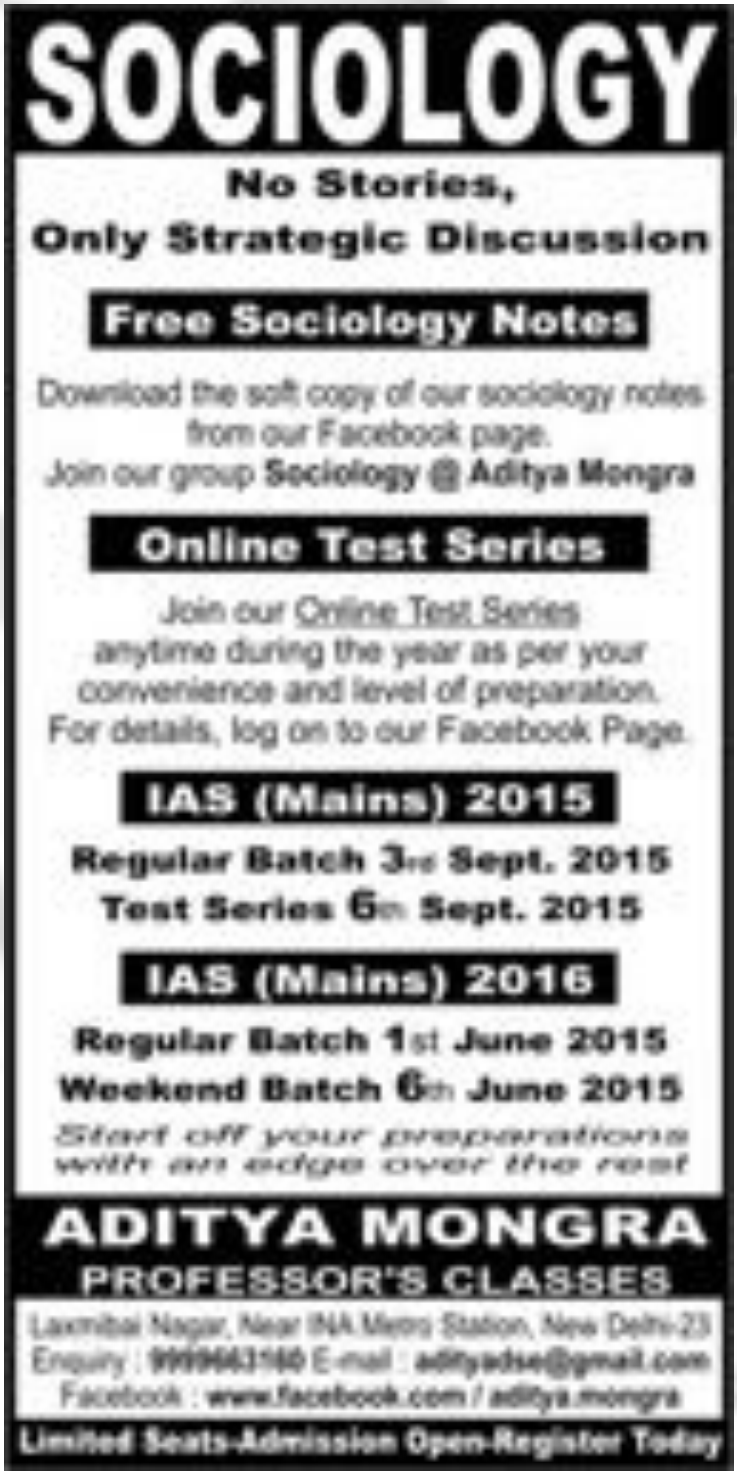
Another important source of inspiration for Marx was the French Socialist tradition that arose during the French Revolution of 1789 and continued through the revolutions of 1830 and 1848. The most important aspect of this tradition was the idea and goal of a new and more radical revolution than that of 1789. In the coming revolution the new class, the industrial workers or proletariat, would take power and abolish all classes. Beside these revolutionaries who were oriented toward class struggle, these were more reform oriented socialists such as the "utopian socialists," Claude Henri Saint-Simon (1760-1825) and Charles Fourier (1772-1837). Like the Englishman, Robert Owen (1771-1858), they wanted to build a socialist society through state reforms or by creating small local societies in which the division of labour was abolished and people lived in harmony with one another and with nature. Although Marx was critical of these socialists and based his thinking more on the "theory of class struggle," he incorporated some of their criticism of the modern capitalist industrial society into his own theories.

A third tradition of importance in Marx's scientific work was British political economy, with names such as Adam Smith (1723-90) and David Ricardo (1772-1823). They had analyzed the new capitalist market economy and Marx continued their analyses, although to a great extent he reached different conclusions. Of particular importance was the fact the Marx took up their *labour theory of value*, the idea that the value of commodity in determined by the quantity of work put into it. Other socialists also took up this tradition, particularly the so-called *Ricardian socialists*, who tried to demonstrate the injustice of a system in which the workers created all value but received only part of it for themselves. Marx objected to their moral criticism of the distribution of value and in his own theory of surplus value he tried to explain why the workers received only a part of the value they created. These three traditions – German philosophy and Hegel in

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particular, French socialism, and British political economy – form the most important intellectual background for the theories of Marx. Which of them is most important depends on what perspective one has on Marx whether we see him primarily as a philosopher, a revolutionary, or a scientist. Whatever the case, we may say that all three traditions are present in Marx's lifework and that this work is characterized by the special way in which he synthesized these (and other) traditions.



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Hegal: Idealism

When Marx entered university in the 1830s the German intellectual world was dominated by the work of the German idealist philosopher G.W.F. Hegal (1770-1831). In his key works, *The Phenomenology of Mind* (1807) and *The Philosophy of Right* (1821), Hegal developed a very ambitious philosophical system based on the premise that the ultimate purpose of human existence was to express the highest form of what he called the human Geist or 'Spirit'. This Spirit was not a physical or material entity but an abstract expression of the moral and ethical qualities and capacities, the highest cultural ideals, which, he argued, were the ultimate expression of what it is to be a human being. For Hegel, material life was the practical means through which this quest for the ultimate realisation of human consciousness, the search for a really truthful awareness of reality, could be expressed. Material life, and this included such things as the economy, the political institutions of the state and other social organisations in civil society, are a means to this higher end and not an end in themselves.

In saying all this Hegel was building on the philosophical system of his great German predecessor Immanuel Kant (1724-1804). Kant was a rationalist philosopher believing that the human mind is uniquely equipped with the capacity to understand the exterior physical world *before* we encounter it. This understanding is generally well organised and sensible, and thus 'rational'. It is well-established, for example, that all humans are born with the capacity to learn language. We learn the words and grammar of a language through experience but *the capacity* to do so in an orderly fashion comes before the learning process, or is *a priori*, which would in fact not be possible without it. We do not learn the capacity to learn, this is something that we already have. For rationalists, and especially rationalist idealists, human knowledge and understanding are more about what goes on inside our minds than outside of them. Real reality, or the most significant version of reality, is not the physical stuff that surrounds us, but the reflection of it we hold or create in our minds. For Hegel, then, reason and thought are not simply part of reality *they are reality*. It follows from this that the laws and principles that govern human thought must also be the laws and principles that govern the whole of reality.

Combining a strongly rationalist position with his own idealist system based on the idea of Spirit as the search for a really truthful understanding of human consciousness and its real relation with material or objective reality, Hegel goes beyond Kant by suggesting that, because the minds of all human beings are essentially the same (physiologically and in terms wired-in capacities for interpreting the exterior world), we are all part of *the same* overarching consciousness. My consciousness of the highest human ideals and my desire to

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find the most truthful ways of expressing them are essentially the same as yours because my consciousness works in the same way as yours does. If Hegel is correct in arguing that thought and reality are one and the same thing, and that the laws that govern human thought are therefore also the laws that govern reality, then in a sense all of humanity will eventually have the same thoughts. Differences between social actors in terms of their thoughts are to do with differences in their stages of development, how far they have progressed in the capacity for reason, not with differences in how they think.

According to Hegel, the process by which this quest for the ultimate truth is carried on involves a *dialectical* process in which one state of awareness about the nature of reality (thesis) is shown to be false by a further and higher state of awareness (antithesis) and is finally resolved in a final and true state of awareness (synthesis). The idea of the dialectic comes from Ancient Greek philosophy and describes a situation in which truth is arrived at through a process of debate or conversation. A particular point of view is stated, this is challenged by an alternative view and eventually a third view emerges, which is superior to them both. Hegel refines the term to refer to the pattern or logic that human thought must follow. The dialectic is his explanation of the intellectual and philosophical process, inherent within and throughout human consciousness, by which social actors finally come to realise the truth of the idea that thought is reality. Hegel uses the same triadic approach in suggesting that the contradictions or imperfections of the family and of civil society (corresponding with thesis and antithesis) are finally resolved by the institutions of the state, which correspond with the new ethical synthesis. The state thus provides the practical means of expressing the universal Spirit.

A further important analytical device used by Hegel is the idea of *sublation*. He uses this term to describe the need social actors have to feel at ease with their understanding of reality and how they fit into it. Lack of sublation shows itself as a feeling of **estrangement**, of not fitting in, of being at odds with the world and being confused about the nature of reality. Moving away from home for the first time, starting an unfamiliar job or being let down by a friend are all situations where, in Hegel's terms, the social actors experience a sense of estrangement and insecurity, a lack of sublation. Hegel felt that at its root, estrangement arose because uncertainty about the nature of reality 'out there' caused us to be uncertain about reality 'in here'. The extent to which we do not fully understand the objective world around us is also the extent to which we are ignorant about our own subjective inner nature. However much we live inside our heads and build up versions of reality there (and it is very difficult to see where else consciousness could come from), we are ourselves also physical objects that are a part of the

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exterior world we are trying to understand. We are both subjects (things that do things) and objects (things that have things done to them) at one and the same time. Hegel believed that his system of idealist rationality offered a solution to this fundamental dilemma and that his ideas presented the highest synthesis of philosophical thought so far achieved. The fact that he had discovered the underlying principle of the dialectic process as it applies to the development of true human awareness of the nature of reality made Hegel even more convinced of the value of his contribution. The Spirit had become self-aware in terms of understanding the mechanism of its own creation.

Although Hegel's work was extremely popular in Germany in the 1830s, not least because it led people to believe that the German state of the time represented the most advanced and civilized kind of society yet achieved, it was eventually challenged by a new generation of intellectuals who proposed a counter-thesis of their own. The Young Hegelians as they were known applied the triadic apparatus of thesis, antithesis and synthesis to Hegel's own philosophical system. The most influential of this group was **Ludwig Feuerbach** (1804-72), who argued that by subordinating the material world to the realm of consciousness and ideas, Hegel's obsession with the coming of the great universal Spirit, was not in the least bit rational or objective in the scientific sense and was in fact nothing more than a form of religious mysticism. Rather than describing how social actors might overcome their sense of estrangement from material reality, Hegel simply made matters worse by suggesting that it was not objective reality that was the problem but simply the inadequacy of social actors' understanding of it. As Marx puts it: 'Feuerbach's great achievement is to have shown that philosophy is nothing more than religion brought into thought and developed in thought, and that it is equally to be condemned as another form….of the estrangement of man's nature.'

At university Marx soon became interested in the ideas of the counter thesis group and of Feuerbach in particular and eventually rejected much of the Hegelian thesis. Crucial to his own development, however, Marx retained key elements and adapted them for his own use. While giving Hegel, 'that mighty thinker', credit for developing a number of very important insights, Marx argued that he had applied them incorrectly, and had thus reached incomplete conclusions about true nature of real reality. Marx's social theory can be thought of as the new synthesis that emerged out of the collision of Hegel's thesis and the Young Hegelians' antithesis. The key to Marx's critique of Hegel is very simple; he takes a number of his most useful conceptual tools and uses them the other way around.

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Marx: Historical Materialism or Dialectical Materialism

For Marx, it is quite inadequate to regard human history, the development of society itself, as merely a by-product of the quest for ultimate knowledge in the abstract realm of human consciousness. So Marx reverses Hegel's approach by arguing that the quest for knowledge should not begin with abstract conceptions in the realm of ideas, but with a positive analysis of actually existing material things in the real physical world. While Hegel, in common with all idealist thinkers, argues that the most truthful version of the world is the one that we hold in our consciousness, Marx proposed the opposite or **materialist view**, which is that the most real version must be the one we can actually touch and feel. For materialist thinkers, the really real world is not the one we create in our minds but the untidy, crowded, noisy physical matter that surrounds us. If we want to know about real reality, and provide a truthful account of it, social theory must begin with an analysis of real things and not become preoccupied with their 'ideal' representation in our thoughts. Even the most perfectly polished mirror needs something to reflect or it has no purpose at all. Worse still, it might be used to project a completely false image or ideology.

Let us now try to understand the underlying assumptions of this materialist view of Marx. In Marx's view man is essentially a social being. Marx regards man as both the producer and the product of society. Man makes society and himself by his own actions. History is therefore the process of man's self-creation. Yet man is also a product of society. He is shaped by the social relationships and systems of thought which he creates. An understanding of human history therefore involves an examination of these relationships, the most important of which are the relations of production. A society forms a totality and can only be understood as such. The various parts of society are interconnected and influence each other. Thus economic, political, legal and religious institutions can only be understood in terms of their mutual effect. Economic factors, however, exert the primary influence and largely shape other aspects of society. The history of human society is a process of tension and conflict. According to Marx, apart from the communities based on primitive communism at the dawn of history, all societies are divided into social groups known as classes. The relationship between classes is one of antagonism and conflict. Class conflict forms the basis of the dialectic of social change. Social change is not a smooth, orderly progression which gradually unfolds in harmonious evolution. Instead it proceeds from contradictions built into society which are a source of tension and ultimately the source of open conflict and radical change. In Marx's view, '*The history of al hitherto existing society is the history of the class struggle*'.

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It is often argued that Marx's view of history is based on the idea of the dialectic. From this viewpoint any process of change involves tension between incompatible forces. Dialectical movement therefore represents a struggle of opposites, a conflict of contradictions. Conflict provides the dynamic principle, the source of change. The struggle between incompatible forces grows in intensity until there is a final collision. The result is a sudden leap forward which creates a new set of forces on a higher level of development. The dialectical process then begins again as the contradictions between this new set of forces interact and conflict, and propel change. As stated earlier, the idea of dialectical change was developed by the German philosopher Hegel. He applied it to the history of human society and in particular to the realm of ideas. Hegel saw historical change as a dialectical movement of men's ideas and thoughts. He believed that society is essentially an expression of these thoughts. Thus in terms of the dialectic, conflict between incompatible ideas produces new concepts which provide the basis for social change. Marx rejects the priority Hegel gives to thoughts and ideas. He argues that the source of change lies in contradictions in the economic system in particular and in society in general. As a result of the priority he gives to economic factors, to 'material life', Marx's view of history is often referred to as 'dialectical materialism'. Since men's ideas are primarily a reflection of the social relationships of economic production, they do not provide the main source of change. It is in contradictions and conflict in the economic system that the major dynamic for social change lies. Since all parts of society are interconnected, however, it is only through a process of interplay between these parts that change occurs.

History begins when men actually produce their means of subsistence, when they begin to control nature. At a minimum this involves the production of food and shelter. Marx argues that, 'The first historical act is, therefore, the production of material life'. Production is a social enterprise since it requires cooperation. Men must work together to produce the goods and services necessary for life. From the social relationships involved in production develops a 'mode of life' which can be seen as an expression of these relationships. This mode of life shapes man's nature. In Marx's words, 'As individuals express their life so they are. What they are, therefore, coincides with their production, with what they produce and how they produce it'. Thus the nature of man and the nature of society as a whole derive primarily from the production of material life.

Thus, according to Marx, the major contradictions which propel change are found in the economic infrastructure of society. At the dawn of human history, when man supposedly lived in a state of primitive communism, those contradictions did not exist. The forces of production and the products of labour were communally owned. Since each member of society produced both for himself

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and for society as a whole, there were no conflicts of interest between individuals and groups. However, with the emergence of private property, and in particular, private ownership of the forces of production, the fundamental contradiction of human society was created. Through its ownership of the forces of production, a minority is able to control, command and enjoy the fruits of the labour of the majority. Since one group gains at the expense of the other, a conflict of interest exists between the minority who own the forces of production and the majority who perform productive labour. The tension and conflict generated by this contradiction is the major dynamic of social change.

For long periods of history, men are largely unaware of the contradictions which beset their societies. This is because man's consciousness, his view of reality, is largely shaped by the social relationships involved in the process of production. Marx maintains that, '*it is not the consciousness of men that determines their being, but, on the contrary, their social being determines their consciousnesses*'. The primary aspect of man's social being is the social relationships he enters into for the production of material life. Since these relationships are largely reproduced in terms of ideas, concepts, laws and religious beliefs, they are seen as normal and natural. Thus when the law legitimizes the rights of private property, when religious beliefs justify economic arrangements and the dominant concepts of the age define them as natural and inevitable, men will be largely unaware of the contradictions they contain. In this way the contradictions within the economic infrastructure are compounded by the contradiction between man's consciousness and objective reality. This consciousness is false. It presents a distorted picture of reality since it fails to reveal the basic conflicts of interest which exist in the world which man has created. For long periods of time man is at most vaguely aware of these contradictions, yet even a vague awareness produces tension. This tension will ultimately find full expression and be resolved in the process of dialectical change.

To conclude it may be argued that historical materialism is a methodological approach to the study of society, first articulated by Karl Marx. Marx himself never used the term but referred to his approach as "the materialist conception of history," which was later referred to as "historical materialism" by Engels.

Marx drew heavily from Hegel in terms of his "manner of approach" to social phenomena and his analysis of it. However, Hegel was an idealist who asserted the primacy of "mind" or "ideas", whereas Marx was "materialist" who asserted the primacy of "matter." Marx was not satisfied with Hegelian idealism but Hegel's use of the dialectical methodology did grab Marx's imagination. By turning from idealism to materialism (i.e., inverting Hegel), Marx was able to make good use of the dialectic in what came to be called "historical materialism"

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or "dialectical materialism." Please note that it was Georgi Plekhanov, the father of Russian Marxism, who later introduced the term *dialectical materialism* to Marxist literature.

According to Friedrich Engels, historical materialism "designates that view of the course of history, which seeks the ultimate causes and the great moving power of all important historic events in the economic development of society, in the changes in the modes of production and exchange, with the consequent division of society into distinct classes and the struggles of these classes."

Historical materialism is thus both, a perspective as well as the methodology. As a perspective, it looks for the causes of development and change in human society in the material conditions or the economic structure of society. As a methodology, it seeks to examine the social structure and explain social change in terms of the dialectical movement of forces of production and relations of production in the mode of production of a given society.

Although Marx did not consistently argue for a crude economic determinism, he left no doubt that he considered the economy to be the foundation of the whole socio-cultural system. Throughout their study, Marx and Engels emphasized the primacy of economics in human relationship and the centrality of the economic dimension in political structures. The economic system of production and distribution, or the means and relations of production in the Marxian sense, constitute the basic structure of society on which are built all other social institutions, particularly the state and legal system. According to Engels, "... the production of immediate material means of subsistence, and consequently, the degree of economic development attained by a given people or during a given epoch, form the foundation upon which the state institutions, the legal conceptions, the ideas on art, and even on religion, of the people concerned have been evolved."

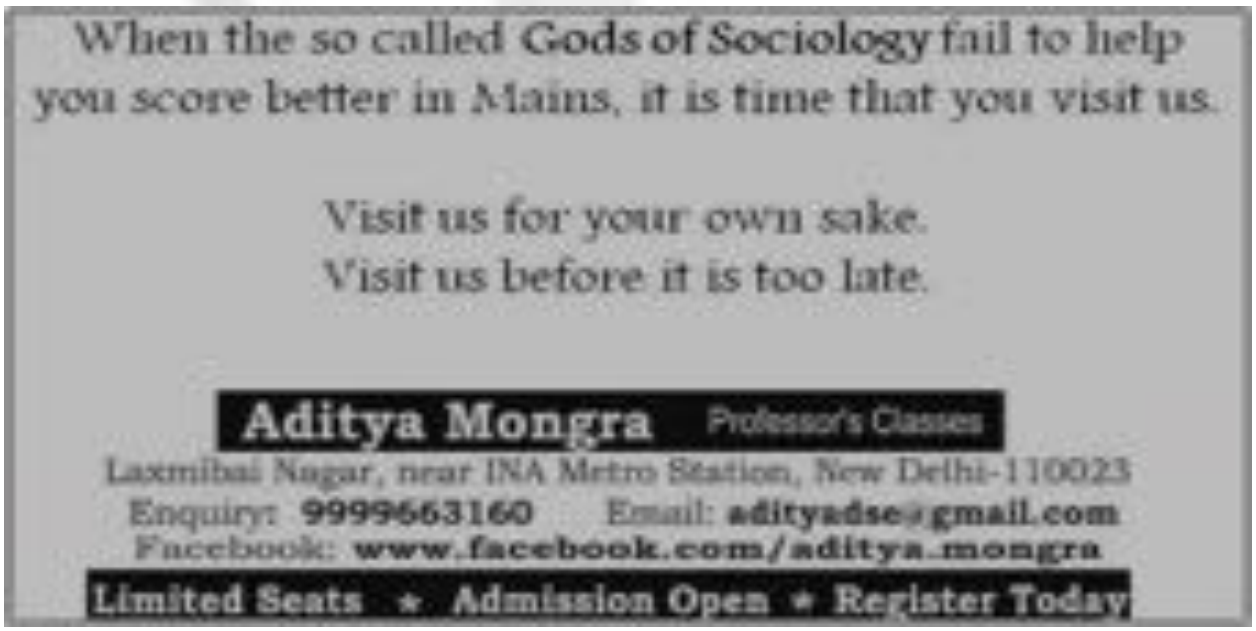
All other factors in the human experience of social relations were subservient and dependent upon the economic factor in the Marxian theory of social relationships. "The political, legal, philosophical, literary, and artistic development," Marx wrote, "rests on the economic. But they all react upon one another and upon the economic base. It is not that the economic situation is the sole active cause and that everything else is merely a passive effect, there is, rather a reciprocity within a field of economic necessity which in the last instance always asserts itself". He would argue, even, that human thought, human awareness, and human consciousness, were not self-originating but were derivatives of the economic principle. Consistent with his economic interpretation of history, Marx developed a variant of the sociology of knowledge which stressed the primacy of the economic principle in the evolution of ideologies, philosophical systems,

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politics, ethics and religion. The central thesis of Marx is this: "It is not the unfolding of ideas that explains the historical development of society (as Hegel and Comte would have argued), but the development of the social structure in response to changing material conditions that explains the emergence of new ideas."

According to Marx, ideas belong to the realm of the superstructure and are determined by the economic infrastructure. He believed that the ideologies prevailing at any particular point in time reflect the worldview of the dominant class. In other words, ideas depend on the social positions – particularly on the class positions of their proponents. These views, moreover, tend either to enhance or undermine the power and control of whatever class happens to be dominant at the time. If generated from the dominant class, they tend to be supportive and reinforce the predominance of the social structure. "The ideas of the ruling class", Marx pointed out "are, in every age, the ruling ideas: i.e., the class which is the dominant *material* force in society is at the same time its dominant *intellectual* force. The class which has the means of material production at its disposal, has control at the same time over the means of mental production." Marx warned that we will fail to understand the historical process "if...we detach the ideas of the ruling class from the ruling class itself and attribute to them an independent existence, if we confine ourselves to saying that in a particular age these or those ideas were dominant, without paying attention to the conditions of production and the producers of these ideas, and if we thus ignore the individuals and the world conditions which are the source of these ideas." Thus Marx sought to trace the evolution of ideas to the life conditions in general, and the forces and relations of production in particular. As it is with conservative ideas, so it is with revolutionary ideas: the former originate in the worldview of the ruling class and the latter in the material conditions of the revolutionary class.



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Dear Candidate, it would be wise at this point of our discussion to briefly examine what many see as the central issue of Marxism, the question of 'economic determinism'. Critics have often rejected Marxism on this basis though they admit that the charge of economic determination is more applicable to certain of Marx's followers than to Marx himself. It is possible to select numerous quotations from Marx's writings which support the views of his critics. In terms of these quotations, history can be presented as a mechanical process directed by economic forces which follow 'iron laws'. Man is compelled to act in terms of the constraints imposed by the economy and passively responds to impersonal forces rather than actively constructing his own history. Thus the proletariat is 'compelled' by its economic situation to overthrow the bourgeoisie. The contradictions in the capitalist infrastructure will inevitably result in its destruction. The superstructure is 'determined' by the infrastructure and man's consciousness is shaped by economic forces independent of his will and beyond his control. In this way Marx can be presented as a crude positivist who sees causation solely in terms of economic forces.

On closer examination, however, Marx's writings prove more subtle and less dogmatic than many of his critics have suggested. Marx rejects a simplistic, one-directional view of causation. Although he gives priority to economic factors, they form only one aspect of the dialectic of history. From this perspective the economy is the primary but not the sole determinant of social change. The idea of the dialectic involves an interplay between the various parts of society. It rejects the view of unidirectional causation proceeding solely form economic factors. Instead it argues that the various parts of society are interrelated in terms of their mutual effect. Marx described the economic infrastructure as the 'ultimately determinant element in history'. Yet he added that, 'if somebody twists this into saying that the economic element is the *only* determining one, he transforms that proposition into a meaningless, abstract and senseless phrase. The economic situation is the basis, but the various elements of the superstructure . . . also exert their influence upon the course of the historical struggle and in many cases preponderate in determining their *form*'. Thus the various aspects of the superstructure have a certain degree of autonomy and a part to play in influencing the course of history. They are not automatically and mechanically determined by the infrastructure.

Marx consistently argued that 'man makes his own history'. The history of human society is not the product of impersonal forces, it is the result of man's purposive activity. In Marx's view, 'It is not "history" which uses men as a means of achieving – as if were an individual person – *its* own ends. History is *nothing* but the activity of men in pursuit of their ends'. Since men make society only men can change society. Radical change results from a combination of consciousness of reality and direct action. Thus members of the proletariat must be fully aware of

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their situation and take active steps in order to change it. Although a successful revolution depends ultimately on the economic situation, it requires human initiative. Men must make their own utopia.

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Marx: Class, Class Struggle and Social Change

Let us now try to understand this in simpler terms. Marxian theory begins with the simple observation that in order to survive, man must produce food and material objects. In doing so he enters into social relationships with other men. From the simple hunting band to the complex industrial state, production is a social enterprise. Production also involves a technical component known as the **forces of production** which includes the technology, raw materials and scientific knowledge employed in the process of production. Each major stage in the development of forces of production will correspond with a particular form of the **social relationships of production**. Thus the forces of production in a hunting economy will correspond with a particular set of social relationships. Taken together, the forces of production and the social relationships of production form the economic base or infrastructure of society (**mode of production**). The other aspects of society, known as the superstructure, are largely shaped by the infrastructure. Thus the political, legal and educational institutions and the belief and value system are primarily determined by economic factors. A major change in the infrastructure will therefore produce a corresponding change in the superstructure. Marx maintained that, with the possible exception of the societies of prehistory, all historical societies contain basic contradictions which mean that they cannot survive forever in their existing form. These contradictions involve the exploitation of one social group by another, for example in feudal society, lords exploit their serfs, in capitalist society, employers exploit their employees. This creates a fundamental conflict of interest between social groups since one gains at the expense of another. This conflict of interest must ultimately be resolved since a social system containing such contradictions cannot survive unchanged.

Thus, according to Marx, the major contradictions in society are between the forces and relations of production. The **forces of production** include land, raw materials, tools and machinery, the technical and scientific knowledge used in production, the technical organization of the production process and the labor power of the workers. The **relations of production** are the social relationships which men enter into in order to produce goods. Thus in feudal society they included the relationship between the lord and vassal and the set of right, duties and obligations which make up that relationship. In capitalist industrial society they included the relationship between employer and employee and the various rights of the two parties. The relations of production involve the relationship of social groups to the forces of production. Thus in feudal society, land, the major

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force of production, is owned by the lord whereas the serf has the right to use land in return for services or payment to the lord. In Western industrial society the forces of production are owned by the capitalist whereas the worker owns only his labor which he hires to the employer in return for wages.

The idea of contradiction between the forces and relations of production may be illustrated in terms of the infrastructure of the capitalist industrial society. Marx maintained that only labour produces wealth. Thus wealth in capitalist society is produced by the labour power of the workers. However, much of this wealth is appropriated in the form profits by the capitalists, the owners of the forces of production. The wages of the workers are well below the value of the wealth they produce. There is thus a contradiction between the forces of production, in particular the labour power of the workers which produce wealth, and the relations of production which involve the appropriation of much of that wealth by the capitalists. A related contradiction involves the technical organization of labour and the nature of ownership. In capitalist society, the forces of production include the collective production of goods by large numbers of workers in factories. Yet the forces of production are privately owned, the profits are appropriated by individuals. The contradiction between the forces and relations of production lies in the social and collective nature of production and the private and individual nature of ownership. Marx believed that these and other contradictions would eventually lead to the downfall of the capitalist system. He maintained that by its very nature, capitalism involves the exploitation and oppression of the worker. He believed that the conflict of interest between capital and labour, which involves one group gaining at the expense of the other, could not be resolved within the framework of a capitalist economy.

Marx saw history as divided into a number of time periods, each being characterized by a particular mode of production. Marx believed that Western society had developed through four main epochs: primitive communism, ancient society, feudal society and capitalist society. Major changes in history are the result of new forces of production. For example, the change from feudal to capitalist society stemmed from the emergence, during the feudal epoch, of the forces of production of industrial society. This resulted in a contradiction between the new forces of production and the old feudal relations of productions. Capitalist industrial society required relations of production based on wage labour, rather than the traditional ties of lord and vassal. When they reach a certain point in their development, the new forces of production lead to the creation of a new set of

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relations of production. Then, a new epoch of history is born which sweeps away the social relationships of the old order. However, the final epoch of history, the **communist** or **socialist society** which Marx believe would eventually supplant capitalism, will not result from a new force of production. Rather, it will develop from a resolution of the contradictions contained within the capitalist system. Collective production will remain but the relations of production will be transformed. Ownership of the forces of production will be collective rather than individual and members of society will share the wealth that their labour produces. No longer will one social group exploit and oppress another. This will produce an infrastructure without contradiction and conflict. In Marx's view this would mean the end of history since communist society would no longer contain the contradictions which generate change.

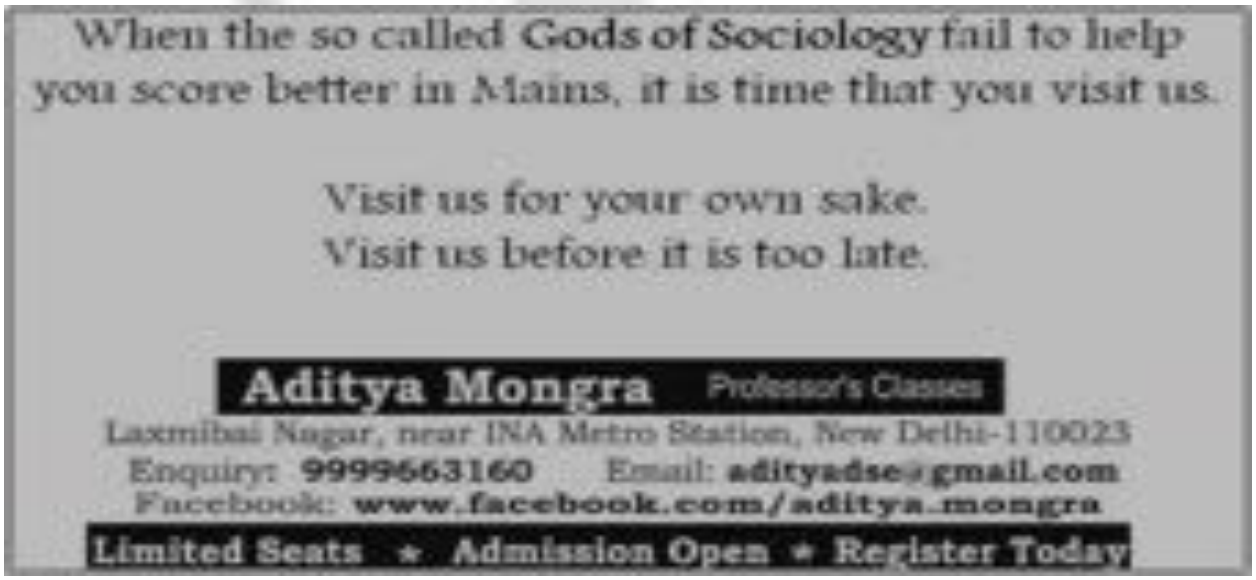
Note: In view of the contradictions which beset historical societies, it appears difficult to explain their survival. Despite its internal contradictions, capitalism has continued in the West for over 200 years. This continuity can be explained in large part by the nature of the superstructure. In all societies the superstructure is largely shaped by the infrastructure. In particular, the relations of productions are reflected and reproduced in the various institutions, values and beliefs that make up the superstructure. Thus the relationships of domination and subordination found in the infrastructure will also be found in social institutions. In Marx's words, 'The existing relations of production between individuals must necessarily express themselves also as political and legal relations'. The dominant social group or ruling class, that is the group which owns and controls the forces of production, will largely monopolize political power and its position will be supported by laws which are framed to protect and further its interests. In the same way, beliefs and values will reflect and legitimate the relations of productions. Members of the ruling class 'rule also as thinkers, as producers of ideas'. These ideas justify their power and privilege and conceal from all members of society the basis of exploitation and oppression on which their dominance rests. Thus under feudalism honour and loyalty were 'dominant concepts' of the age. Vassals owed loyalty to their lords and were bound by an oath of allegiance which encouraged the acceptance of their status. In terms of the dominant concept of the age, feudalism appeared as the natural order of things. Under Capitalism, exploitation is disguised by the ideas of equality and freedom. The relationship between capitalist and wage laborer is defined as an equal exchange. The capitalist buy the labour power which the worker offers for hire. The worker is defined as a free agent since he has the

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freedom to choose his employer. In reality, equality and freedom are illusions. The employer-employee relationship is not equal. It is an exploitive relationship. The worker is not free since he is forced to work for the capitalist in order to survive. All he can do is exchange one form of 'wage slavery' for another. Marx refers to the dominant ideas of each epoch as '**ruling class ideology**'. Such ideology is a distortion of reality, a false picture of society. It blinds members of society to the contradictions and conflict of interest which are built into their relationships. As a result they tend to accept their situation as normal and natural, right and proper. In this way a 'false consciousness' of reality is produced which helps to maintain the system. However, Marx believed that ruling class ideology could only slow down the disintegration of the system. The contradictions embedded in the structure of society must eventually find expression.

In summary, the key to understanding society from a Marxian perspective involves an analysis of the infrastructure. In all historical societies there are basic contradictions between the forces and relations of production and there are fundamental conflicts of interest between the social groups involved in the production process. In particular, the relationship between the major social groups is one of exploitation and oppression. The superstructure derives largely from the infrastructure and therefore reproduces the social relationships of production. It will thus reflect the interests of the dominate group in the relations of production. Ruling class ideology distorts the true nature of society and serves to legitimate and justify the status quo. However the contradictions in the infrastructure will eventually lead to a disintegration of the system and the creation of a new society.



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According to Karl Marx, in all stratified societies, there are two major social groups; a **ruling class** and a **subject class**. The power of the ruling class derives from its ownership and control of the forces of production. The ruling class exploits and oppresses the subject class. As a result, there is a basic conflict of interest between the two classes. The various institutions of society such as the legal and political systems are instruments of ruling class domination and serve to further its interests. Only when the forces of production are communally owned will classes disappear, thereby bringing an end to the exploitation and oppression of some by others.

From a Marxian perspective, systems of stratification derive from the relationships of social groups to the forces of production. Marx used the term **class** to refer to the main strata in all stratification systems, though most modern sociologists would reserve the term for strata in capitalist society. **From a Marxian view, a class is a social group whose members share the same relationship to the forces of production.** Thus during the feudal epoch, there are two main classes distinguished by their relationship to land, the major force of production. They are the feudal nobility who own the land and the landless serfs who work the land. Similarly, in the capitalist era, there are two main classes, the bourgeoisie or capitalist class which owns the forces of production and the proletariat or working class whose members own only their labour which they hire to the bourgeoisie in return for wages.

Marx believed that Western society had developed through four main epochs; **primitive communism**, **ancient society**, **feudal society** and **capitalist society**. Primitive communism is represented by the societies of prehistory and provides the only example of a classless society. From then on, all societies are divided into two major classes: masters and slaves in ancient society, lords and serfs in feudal society and capitalists and wage labourers in capitalist society. During each historical epoch, the labour power required for production was supplied by the subject class, that is by slaves, serfs and wage labourers respectively. The subject class is made up of the majority of the population whereas the ruling or dominant class forms a minority. The relationship between the two major classes will be discussed shortly.

Classes did not exist during the era of primitive communism when societies were based on a socialist mode of production. In hunting and gathering band, the earliest form of human society, the land and its products were communally owned.

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The men hunted and the woman gathered plant food, and the produce was shared by members of the band. Classes did not exist since all members of society shared the same relationship to the forces of production. Every member was both producer and owner, all provided labour power and shared the products of their labour. Hunting and gathering is a subsistence economy which means that production only meets basic survival needs.

Classes emerge when the productive capacity of society expands beyond the level required for subsistence. This occurs when agriculture becomes the dominant mode of production. In an agricultural economy, only a section of society is needed to produce the food requirements of the whole society. Thus many individuals are freed from food production and are able to specialize in other tasks. The rudimentary **division of labour** of the hunting and gathering band was replaced by an increasingly more complex and specialized division. For example, in the early agricultural villages, some individuals became full-time producers of pottery, clothing and agricultural implements. As agriculture developed, surplus wealth, that is goods above the basic subsistence needs of the community, was produced. This led to an exchange of goods and trading developed rapidly both within and between communities. This was accompanied by the development of a system of **private property**. Goods were increasingly seen as commodities or articles of trade to which the individual rather than the community had right of ownership. **Private property and the accumulation of surplus wealth form the basis for the development of class societies**. **In particular, they provide the preconditions for the emergence of a class of producers and a class of non-producers**. Some are able to acquire the forces of production and others are therefore obliged to work for them. The result is a class of non-producers which owns the forces of production and a class of producers which owns only its labour power.

From a Marxian perspective, the relationship between the major social classes is one of mutual dependence and conflict. Thus in capitalist society, the bourgeoisie and proletariat are dependent upon each other. The wage labourer must sell his labour power in order to survive since he does not own a part of the forces of production and lacks the means to produce goods independently. He is therefore dependent for his livelihood on the capitalists and the wages they offer. The capitalists, as non-producers, are dependent on the labour power of the wage labourers, since without it, there would be no production. However, the mutual dependency of the two classes is not a relationship of equal or symmetrical

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reciprocity. Instead, it is a relationship of exploiter and exploited, oppressor and oppressed. In particular, the ruling class gains at the expense of the subject class and there is therefore a conflict of interest between them. This may be illustrated by Marx's view of the nature of ownership and production in capitalist society.

The basic characteristics of a capitalist economy may be summarized as follows. **Capital** may be defined as money used to finance the production, of commodities for private gain. In a capitalist economy goods, and the labour power, raw materials and machinery used to produce them, are given a monetary value. The capitalist invests his capital in the production of goods. Capital is accumulated by selling those goods at a value greater than their cost of production. **Capitalism therefore involves the investment of capital in the production of commodities with the aim of maximizing profit**. Capital is privately owned by a minority, the capitalist class. However, in Marx's view, it is gained from the exploitation of the mass of the population, the working class. Marx argued that capital, as such, produces nothing. Only labour produces wealth. Yet the wages paid to the workers for their labour are well below the value of the goods they produce. The difference between the value of wages and commodities is known as '**surplus value**'. This surplus value is appropriated in the form of profit by the capitalists. Since they are non-producers, the bourgeoisie are therefore exploiting the proletariat, the real producers of wealth. Marx maintained that in all class societies, the ruling class exploits and oppresses the subject class.

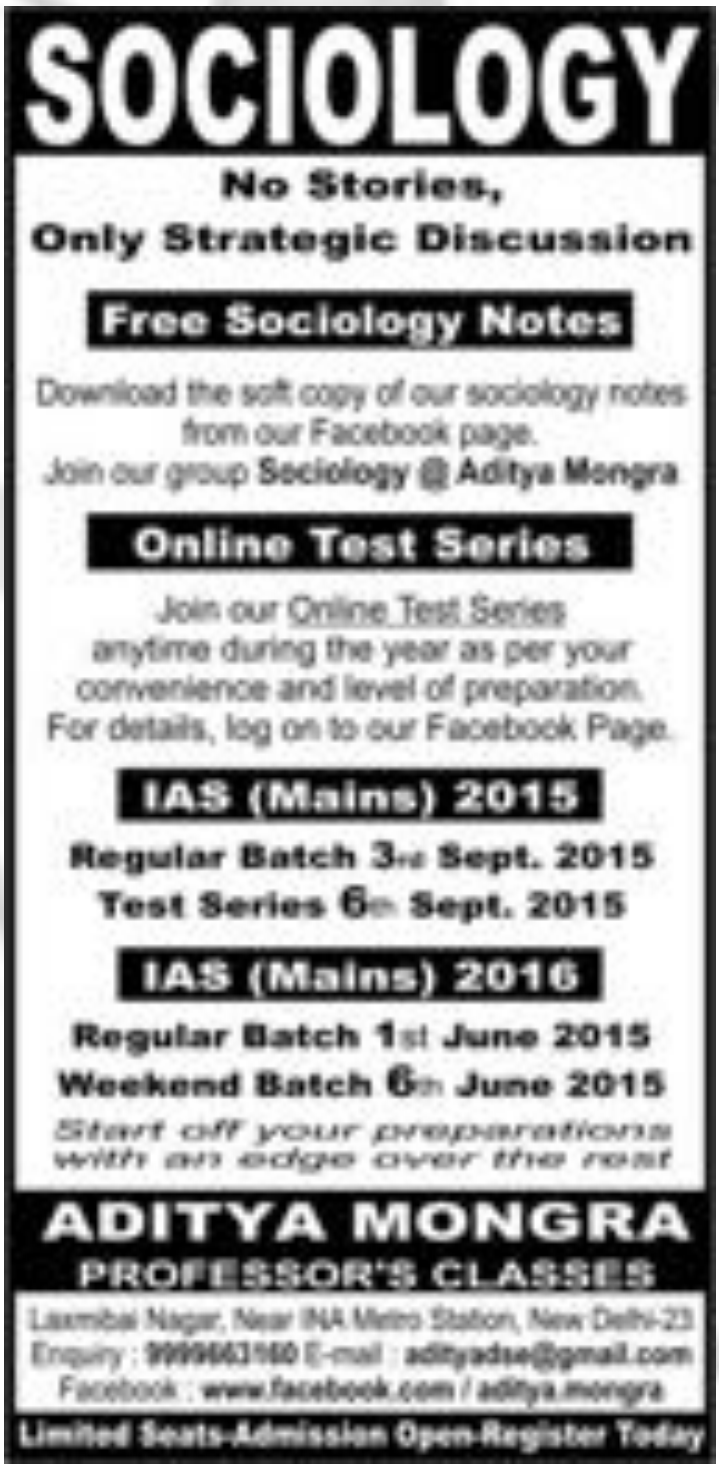
In simpler words, Marx argues that class divisions result from the differing relationships of members of society to the forces of production. The structure of all societies may be represented in terms of a simplified two class model consisting of ruling and subject class. The ruling class owes its dominance and power to its ownership and control of the forces of production. The subjection and relative powerlessness of the subject class is due to its lack of ownership and therefore lack of control of the forces of production. The conflict of interest between the two classes stems from the fact that productive labour is performed by the subject class yet a large part of the wealth so produced is appropriated by the ruling class. Since one class gains at the expense of another, the interests of their members are incompatible. The classes stand opposed as exploiter and exploited, oppressor and oppressed.

The labour of the subject class takes on the character of 'forced labour'. Since its members lack the necessary means to produce for themselves they are

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forced to work for others. Thus during the feudal era, landless serfs were forced to work for the landowning nobility in order to gain a livelihood. In the capitalist era, the means necessary to produce goods – tools, machinery, raw materials and so on – are owned by the capitalist class. In order to exist, members of the proletariat are forced to sell their labour power in return for wages. Ownership of the forces of production therefore provides the basis for ruling class dominance and control of labour.



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From a Marxian perspective political power derives from economic power. The power of the ruling class therefore stems from its ownership and control of the forces of production. Since the superstructure of society – the major institutions, values and belief systems – is seen to be largely shaped by the economic infrastructure, the relations of production will be reproduced in the superstructure. Thus the dominance of the ruling class in the relations of production will be reflected in the superstructure. In particular, the political and legal systems will reflect ruling class interests since, in Marx's words, 'The existing relations of production between individuals must necessarily express themselves also as political and legal relations'. For example, the various ownership rights of the capitalist class will be enshrined in and protected by the laws of the land. Thus the various parts of the superstructure can be seen as instruments of ruling class domination and as mechanisms for the oppression of the subject class. In the same way, the position of the dominant class is supported by beliefs and values which are systematically generated by the infrastructure. Marx refers to the dominant concepts of class societies as **ruling class ideology** since they justify and legitimate ruling class domination and project a distorted picture of reality. For example, the emphasis on freedom in capitalist society, illustrated by phrases such as 'the free market', 'free democratic societies' and the free world', is an illusion which disguises the wage slavery of the proletariat. Ruling class ideology produces '**false class consciousness**', a false picture of the nature of the relationship between social classes. Members of both classes tend to accept the status quo as normal and natural and are largely unaware of the true nature of exploitation and oppression. In other words, members of both social classes are largely unaware of the true nature of their situation, of the reality of the relationship between ruling and subject classes. Members of the ruling class assume that their particular interests are those of society as a whole, members of the subject class accept this view of reality and regard their situation as a part of the natural order of things. This false consciousness is due to the fact that the relationships of dominance and subordination in the economic infrastructure are largely reproduced in the superstructure of society. In Marx's words, the relations of production constitute 'the real foundation on which rise legal and political superstructures and to which correspond definite forms of social consciousness. The mode of production in material life determines the general character of the social, political and spiritual processes of life'. Ruling class dominance is confirmed and legitimated in legal statues, religious proscriptions and political legislation. The consciousness of all members of society is infused with ruling

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class ideology which proclaims the essential rightness, normality and inevitability of the status quo. In this way the conflict of interest between the classes is disguised and a degree of social stability produced but the basic contradictions and conflicts of class societies remain unresolved.

Marx believed that the class struggle was the driving force of social change. He states that, '**The history of all societies up to the present is the history of the class struggle**'. A new historical epoch is created by the development of superior forces of production by new social group. These developments take place within the framework of the previous era. For example, the merchants and industrialists who spearheaded the rise of capitalism emerged during the feudal era. They accumulated capital, laid the foundations for industrial manufacturers, factory production and the system of wage labour, all of which were essential components of capitalism. The superiority of the capitalist mode of production led to a rapid transformation of the structure of society. The capitalist class became dominant, and although the feudal aristocracy maintained aspects of its power well into the nineteenth century, it was fighting a losing battle.

The class struggles of history have been between minorities. For example, capitalism developed from the struggle between the feudal aristocracy and the emerging capitalist class, both groups in numerical terms forming a minority of the population. Major changes in history have involved the replacement of one form of private property by another and of one type of production technique by another. For example, capitalism involved the replacement of privately owned land and an agricultural economy by privately owned capital and an industrial economy. Marx believed that the class struggle which would transform capitalist society would involve none of these processes. The protagonists would be the bourgeoisie and the proletariat, a minority versus a majority. Private property would be replaced by communally owned property. Industrial manufacture would remain as the basic technique of production in the society which would replace capitalism.

Marx believed that the basic contradictions contained in a capitalist economic system would lead to its eventual destruction. The proletariat would overthrow the bourgeoisie and seize the forces of production, the source of power. Property would be communally owned and, since all members of society would now share the same relationship to the forces of production, a classless society would result. Since history is the history of the class struggle, history would now end. The communist society which replaces capitalism will contain no

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contradictions, no conflicts of interest and therefore be unchanging. However, before the dawning of this utopia, certain changes must occur.

Marx distinguished between a **'class in itself'** and a **'class for itself'**. **A class in itself is simply a social group whose members share the same relationship to the forces of production.** Marx argues that a social group only fully becomes a class when it becomes a class for itself. At this stage its members have class consciousness and class solidarity. Class consciousness means that false class consciousness has been replaced by a full awareness of the true situation, by a realization of the nature of exploitation. Members of a class develop a common identity, recognize their shared interests and unite, so producing class solidarity. The final stage of class consciousness and class solidarity is reached when members realize that only by collective action can they overthrow the ruling class and when they take positive steps to do so.

Marx believed that the following aspects of capitalist society would eventually lead to the proletariat developing into a class for itself. Firstly capitalist society is by its very nature unstable. It is based on contradictions and antagonisms which can be resolved by its transformation. In particular, the conflict of interest between the bourgeoisie and proletariat cannot be resolved within the framework of a capitalist economy. The basic conflict of interest involves the exploitation of workers by the capitalists. Marx believed that this contradiction would be highlighted by a second, the contradiction between social production and individual ownership. As capitalism developed, the workforce was increasingly concentrated in the large factories where production was a social enterprise. Social production juxtaposed with individual ownership illuminates the exploitation of the proletariat. Social production also makes it easier for workers to organize themselves against the capitalists. It facilitates communication and encourages recognition of common circumstances and interest.

Apart from the basic contradictions of capitalist society, Marx believed that certain factors in the natural development of a capitalist economy will hasten its downfall. These factors will result in the polarization of the two main classes. Firstly the increasing use of machinery will result in a **homogeneous working class**. Since 'machinery obliterates the differences in labour' members of the proletariat will become increasingly similar. The differences between skilled, semi-skilled and unskilled workers will tend to disappear as machines remove the skill required in the production of commodities. Secondly, the difference in wealth

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between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat will increase as the accumulation of capital proceeds. Even though the real wages and living standards of the proletariat may rise, its members will become poorer in relation to the bourgeoisie. This process is known as **pauperization**. Thirdly, the competitive nature of capitalism means that only the largest and most wealthy companies will survive and prosper. Competition will depress the immediate strata, those groups lying between the two main classes, into the proletariat. Thus the 'petty bourgeoisie', the owners of small businesses, will 'sink into the proletariat'. At the same time the surviving companies will grow larger and capital will be concentrated into fewer hands. These three processes - the obliteration of the differences in labour, the pauperization of the working class and the depression of the intermediate strata into the proletariat - will result in the **polarization** of the two major classes. Marx believed he could observe the process of polarization in nineteenth-century Britain when he wrote, 'Society as a whole is more and more splitting into two great hostile camps..... bourgeoisie and proletariat'. Now the battle lines were clearly drawn, Marx hoped that the proletarian revolution would shortly follow and the communist utopia of his dreams would finally become a reality.

Marx argued that while the superstructure may stabilize society and contain its contradictions over long periods of time, this situation cannot be permanent. The fundamental contradictions of class societies will eventually find expression and will finally be resolved by the dialectic of historical change. A radical change in the structure of society occurs when a class is transformed from a 'class in itself' to a 'class for itself'. A class in itself refers to members of society who share the same objective relationships to the forces of production. Thus, as wage labourers, members of the proletariat form a class in itself. However, a class only becomes a class for itself when its members are fully conscious of the true nature of their situation, when they are fully aware of their common interests and common enemy, when they realize that only by concerted action can they overthrow their oppressors, and when they unite and take positive, practical steps to do so. When a class becomes a class for itself, the contradiction between the consciousness of its members and the reality of their situation is ended.

A class becomes a class for itself when the forces of production have developed to the point where they cannot be contained within the exiting relations of production. In Marx's words, 'For an oppressed class to be able to emancipate itself, it is essential that the existing forces of production and the existing social relations should be incapable of standing side by side'. Revolutionary change

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requires that the forces of production on which the new order will be based have developed in the old society. Therefore the 'new higher relations of production never appear before the material conditions of their existence have matured in the womb of the old society'. This process may be illustrated by the transition from feudal to capitalist society. Industrial capitalism gradually developed within the framework of feudal society. In order to develop fully, it required, 'the free wage labourer who sells his labour-power to capital'. This provides a mobile labour force which can be hired and fired at will and so efficiently utilized as a commodity in the service of capital. However, the feudal relations of production, which involved 'landed property with serf labour chained to it', tended to prevent the development of wage labourers. Eventually the forces of production of capitalism gained sufficient strength and impetus to lead to the destruction of the feudal system. At this point the rising class, the bourgeoisie, became a class for itself and its members united to overthrow the feudal relations of production. When they succeeded the contradiction between the new forces of production and the old relations of production was resolved.

Marx further argued that once a new economic order is established, the superstructure of the previous era is rapidly transformed. The contradiction between the new infrastructure and the old superstructure is now ended. Thus the political dominance of the feudal aristocracy was replaced by the power to the newly enfranchised bourgeoisie. The dominant concepts of feudalism such as loyalty and honour were replaced by the new concepts of freedom and equality. In terms of the new ideology the wage labourer of capitalist society is free to sell his labour power to the highest bidder. The relationship between employer and employee is defined as a relationship between equals, the exchange of labour for wages as an exchange of equivalents. But the resolution of old contradictions does not necessarily mean an end to contradictions in society. As in previous eras, the transition from feudalism to capitalism merely results in the replacement of an old set of contradictions by a new.

The predicted rise of the proletariat is not strictly analogous with the rise of the bourgeoisie. The bourgeoisie formed a privileged minority of industrialists, merchants and financiers who forged new forces of production within feudal society. The proletariat forms an unprivileged majority which does not create new forces of production within capitalist society. Marx believed, however, that the contradictions of capitalism were sufficient to transform the proletariat into a class for itself and bring about the downfall of the bourgeoisie. He saw the magnitude of

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these contradictions and the intensity of class conflict steadily increasing as capitalism developed. Thus there is a steady polarization of the two major classes as the intermediate strata are submerged into the proletariat. As capital accumulates, it is concentrated more and more into fewer hands, a process accompanied by the relative pauperization of the proletariat. Production assumes an increasingly social and cooperative character as larger and larger groups of workers are concentrated in factories. At the same time the wealth produced by labour is appropriated by fewer and fewer individuals as greater competition drives all but the larger companies out of business. Such processes magnify and illuminate the contradictions of capitalism and increase the intensity of conflict. It is only a matter of time before members of the proletariat recognize that the reality of their situation is the alienation of labour. This awareness will lead the proletariat to 'a revolt to which it is forced by the contradiction between its *humanity* and its situation, which is an open, clear and absolute negation of its humanity'.

The **communist society** which Marx predicted would arise from the ruins of capitalism will begin with a transitional phase, '**the dictatorship of the proletariat**'. Once the communist system has been fully established, the reason for being of the dictatorship and therefore its existence will end. The communist society of the new era is without classes, without contradictions. The dialectical principle now ceases to operate. The contradictions of human history have now been negated in a final harmonious synthesis.

Judging from the constant reinterpretations, impassioned defences and vehement criticisms of Marx's work, his ideas are as alive and relevant today as they ever were. Many of his critics have argued that history has failed to substantiate Marx's views on the direction of social change. Thus they claim that class conflict, far from growing in intensity, has become institutionalized in advanced capitalist society. They see little indication of the proletariat becoming a class for itself. Rather than a polarization of classes, they argue that the class structure of capitalist society has become increasingly complex and differentiated. In particular, a steadily growing middle class has emerged between the proletariat and bourgeoisie. Turning to communist society, critics have argued that history has not borne out the promise of communism contained in Marx's writings. Significant social inequalities are present in communist regimes and there are few, if any, signs of a movement towards equality. The dictatorship of the proletariat clings stubbornly to power and there is little indication of its eventual disappearance. Particular criticism has been directed towards the priority that Marx assigns to

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economic factors in his explanation of social structure and social change. Max Weber's study of ascetic Protestantism argued that religious beliefs provided the ethics, attitudes and motivations for the development of capitalism. Since ascetic Protestantism preceded the advent of capitalism, Weber maintained that at certain times and places aspects of the superstructure can play a primary role in directing change. The priority given to economic factors has also been criticized by elite theorists who have argued that control of the machinery of government rather than ownership of the forces of production provides the basis for power. They point to the example of communist societies where, despite the fact that the forces of production are communally owned, power is largely monopolized by a political and bureaucratic elite.



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Important: The German sociologist **Ralf Dahrendorf** claims that the social structure of advanced societies has undergone some very significant changes since Marx's time. These changes have resulted in a "transformed" capitalism, and the modern industrial societies are organized in terms of "**imperatively coordinated associations**," i.e. associations of people controlled by a hierarchy of authority and power. According to Dahrendorf, some of the key features of advance industrial societies are:

- **Decomposition of capital** (stock holders and managers): This implies the separation of ownership and control over large corporations such as joint stock companies where the ownership (in the form of equity) lies with the public at large while the control is exercised by the management, professionals, technocrats and other experts.

- **Decomposition of labour** (from homogeneous group of equally unskilled and impoverished people, to differentiated occupational groups, with differentiated attributes and status (prestige, responsibility, authority)): Dahrendorf believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegrating of the manual working class. Contrary to Marx's prediction, the manual working class has become increasingly heterogeneous or dissimilar by the emergence of new differentiations of skill. He sees this resulting from changes in technology arguing that 'increasingly complex machines require increasingly qualified designers, builders, maintenance and repair men and even minders'. Dahrendorf claims that the working class is now divided into three distinct levels: unskilled, semi-skilled and skilled manual workers. Differences in economic and prestige rewards are linked to this hierarchy of skill. In view of the differences in skill, economic and status rewards and interests within the ranks of manual workers, Dahrendorf claims that 'it has become doubtful whether speaking of the working class still makes much sense'. He believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegration of the manual working class.

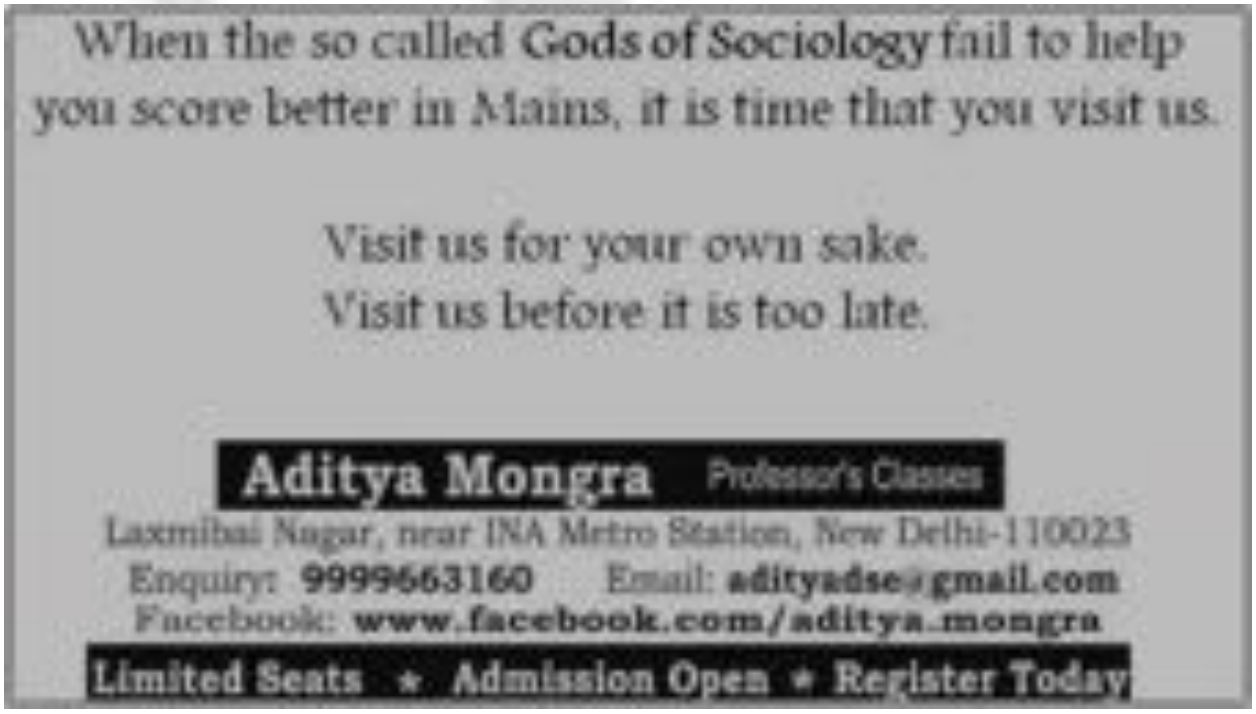
- **Institutionalisation of class conflict (**industrial bargaining): According to Dahrendorf, the tension between labour and capital is recognized as a principle of the structure of the labour market and has become a legal institution of society. As workers have become increasingly skilled, educated and better paid, they have become more integrated into the middle layers of society. The traditional sources of discontent and labour militancy have been dissolved. The basis for class struggle is gone. Conflicts now develop within imperatively coordinated associations (institutional structures

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such as business organizations, unions and so forth) and are resolved rationally and fairly through mediation, arbitration or adjudication.

However, despite criticisms, Marx's work on class has been examined in detail for the following reasons. Firstly, many sociologists claim that his theory still provides the best explanation of the nature of class in capitalist society. Secondly, much of the research on class has been inspired by ideas and questions raised by Marx. Thirdly, many of the concepts of class analysis introduced by Marx have proved useful to Marxists and non-Marxists alike. And, as T.B. Bottomore writing in 1965 notes, 'For the past eighty years Marx's theory has been the object of unrelenting criticism and tenacious defence'. This observation remains true today.



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Dear Candidate, until now we have discussed some of the key ideas of Marx. We have discussed historical materialism as a perspective as well as a method. We have also seen that how Marx applied the historical materialism methodology in explaining class conflict and social change in society. We have also discussed the concept of mode of production and its centrality in Marxian theory. However, when we come to the discussion of Paper II, you will also learn that how an Indian Marxist sociologist A.R. Desai has applied this methodology to explain the rise of Indian nationalism in his book '*Social Background of Indian Nationalism*.'

Let us now briefly discuss the various stages of human society which Marx talked about, each being characterized by a particular mode of production. Marx believed that Western society had developed through four main epochs: *primitive communism*, *ancient society*, *feudal society* and *capitalist society*.

Primitive communism is represented by the societies of pre-history and provides the only example of a classless society according to Marx. Primitive communism represents the earliest stage where forces of production were extremely simple and were commonly owned. For example, in a hunting and gathering band, the earliest form of human society, the land and its products were communally owned. The men hunted and the woman gathered plant food, and the produce was shared by members of the band. Classes did not exist since all members of society shared the same relationship to the forces of production. Every member was both producer and owner, all provided labour power and shared the products of their labour. Hunting and gathering is a subsistence economy which means that production only meets basic survival needs. Classes emerge when the productive capacity of society expands beyond the level required for subsistence. This occurs when agriculture becomes the dominant mode of production.

Next stage was represented by ancient Greece and Rome where the society was divided into masters, those who owned the forces of production, and slaves, who were themselves owned by the masters. In other words, slavery is the very essence of the ancient mode of production. In this system of production the master has the right of ownership over the slave and appropriates the products of the slave's labour. So much so, that the slave is not even allowed to reproduce. The slave is deprived of his own means of reproduction. The ruling classes in these societies acquired their wealth from slave labour. In Roman Italy, slavery on the land (agricultural slavery) assumed an importance beyond anything experienced

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before. In the western half of the Roman Empire, the ancient mode of production gradually transformed into the feudal mode of production.

As discussed earlier, society of medieval Europe (before fourteenth century) was largely feudal in character. Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Western Europe from tenth to fifteenth century. It had emerged on account of downfall and decentralization of Roman Empire and absence of any central authority. The word 'feudal' comes from *feud* which originally meant a *fief* or land held on condition or service. In a feudal society, land was the source of the power. Thus, feudal system was based on allocation of land in return for service. Feudal society was essentially an agrarian society consisting of land owning nobility and the landless serfs who enjoyed the right to work in the lord's land.

Finally, capitalist society emerged fully with the growth of industrial mode of production and consisted of bourgeoisie who owned the forces of production and the proletariat who contributed their labour. According to Marx, capitalist society was inherently unstable and would eventually transform into a communist society.

Please note that when Marx worked on Asian countries, he used the term *Asiatic mode of production* for the primitive communism stage. The theory of the Asiatic mode of production was devised by Karl Marx around the early 1850s. It is concluded that Marx at first regarded Asian society as a special society which was stagnant and devoid of history, but that at length he overcame this view, considered that the Asiatic mode of production was begotten out of the dissolution of primitive society and was the earliest form of class society and the specific mode of production preceding the ancient mode of production, and placed this mode of production in the series of historical stages of development.

The essence of the theory has been described as "*[the] suggestion ... that Asiatic societies were held in thrall by a despotic ruling clique, residing in central cities and directly expropriating surplus from largely autarkic and generally undifferentiated village communities*". The Asiatic mode of production is characteristic of primitive communities in which ownership of land is communal. These communities are still partly organized on the basis of kinship relations. State controls the use of essential economic resources, and directly appropriates part of the labour and production of the community.

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Sometimes, Marx and Engels stressed the dominant role the state played in Asiatic societies because of either its monopoly of land ownership, its control over irrigation systems, or its sheer political and military power. At other times, they suggested that it was the communal nature of landholding that isolated the inhabitants of different villages from one another and so made them prey to state domination.

The Asiatic mode of production does not seem to be distinguished by the subordination of slaves or serfs, but by the subordination of all workers to the State. The Asiatic mode of production constitutes one of the possible forms of transition from classless to class societies; it is also perhaps the most ancient form of this transition. It contains the contradiction of this transition, i.e. the combination of communal relations of production with emerging forms of the exploiting classes and of the State. Marx did not leave behind any systematic presentation of the history of India. He set down his observations on certain current Indian questions which attracted public attention, or drew materials from India's past and contemporary conditions of his times to illustrate parts of his more general arguments. The concept of Asiatic mode of production is therefore inadequate for an understanding of Indian history and society.

The Asiatic mode of production is a notion that has been the subject of much deliberation on the part of Marxist and non-Marxist commentators alike. The Asiatic mode of production has endured much controversy and contest from many scholars and is the most disputed mode of production outlined in the works of Marx and Engels. Questions regarding the validity of the concept of the Asiatic mode of production were raised in terms of whether or not it corresponds to the reality of certain given societies. Some have rejected the whole concept on the grounds that the socio-economic formations of pre-capitalist Asia did not differ enough from those of feudal Europe to warrant special designation. Some argue that the Asiatic mode of production is not compatible with archaeological evidence.



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Let us now discuss another important concept of Marx, **alienation**.

The term alienation has had long and varied use in many fields besides sociology, including philosophy, theology, law, and psychiatry. Alienation is a socio-psychological condition which denotes a state of 'estrangement' of individuals from themselves or from others, or from a specific situation or process. This concept gained currency in the writings of Hegel and was later developed by Feuerbach before Marx adopted it in his early writings.

According to Hegel, the noted German idealist philosopher, the ultimate purpose of human existence was to express the highest form of what he called the human Geist or 'Spirit'. This Spirit was not a physical or material entity but an abstract expression of the moral and ethical qualities and capacities, the highest cultural ideals, which, he argued, were the ultimate expression of what it is to be a human being. For Hegel, material life was the practical means through which this quest for the ultimate realisation of human consciousness, the search for a really truthful awareness of reality, could be expressed. Material life, and this included such things as the economy, the political institutions of the state and other social organisations in civil society, are a means to this higher end and not an end in themselves.

As discussed earlier, Hegel uses the concepts of sublation and estrangement to describe the sense of insecurity or unease that people might experience at moments when they recognize the shortcomings of their mental understanding of reality. For Hegel, estrangement was a cognitive or psychological state of being whose resolution depends on acquiring a more thorough understanding of what reality is and how individual consciousness comes to terms with its place within it. Hegel links the term alienation to the terms estrangement and objectification in his theory of development of the human mind. In labour, man is alienated from his humanity and becomes an object for himself. Thus, he becomes estranged from the social world he has created. At the same time, however, this estrangement and objectification are necessary element for the mind to learn to know itself by becoming something else, and man can abolish this alienation if the sees himself in his own objectification. Thus for Hegel, as Marx puts it, 'all estrangement of human nature is therefore nothing but estrangement of self-consciousness.'

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Several years before Marx wrote about alienated labour, Ludwig Feuerbach published *The Essence of Christianity* (1841). In this book Feuerbach not only criticized religion (as did most of the young Hegelians, including Marx and Engels), but he went a step further and tried to explain why it exists. Feuerbach bases religion in man's worldly existence and believes that, in religion, man expresses his dream of a different and better world. It is not God who has created man, as religion teaches, but it is man who has created (the concepts of) God. Man has objectified his own being in God and then provided his creation with a creative force of his own. In this way the object, the concept of God which is created by man, has become the subject and the true subject, man, has made himself an object. In this way, man has become estranged – alienated – from himself and, according to Feuerbach, religion expresses this alienation of man from himself.

For Hegal, alienation was a meta-physical concept. Marx transformed it in to a sociological one in his *The Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts* (1844). Here, in his analysis of alienation, Marx takes up Hegel's theory of the importance of human labour, but he rejects the idea of the existence of a superhuman spirit and the process of its development.

According to Marx, the course of human history involves a progressive development of the forces of production, a steady increase in man's control over nature. This is paralleled by a corresponding increase in man's alienation, an increase which reaches its height in capitalist society. Alienation is a situation in which the creations of man appear to him as alien objects. They are seen as independent from their creator and invested with the power to control him. Man creates his own society but will remain alienated until he recognizes himself within his creation. Until that time he will assign an independent existence to objects, ideas and institutions and be controlled by them. In the process he loses himself, he becomes a stranger in the world he has created, he becomes alienated. Religion provides an example of men's alienation. In Marx's view, 'Man makes religion, religion does not make man'. However, members of society fail to recognize that religion is of their own making. They assign to the gods an independent power, a power to direct their actions and shape their destiny. The more man invests in religion, the more he loses himself. In Marx's words, 'The more man puts into God, the less he retains of himself'. In assigning his own powers to supernatural beings, man becomes alienated from himself. Religion appears as an external force controlling man's destiny whereas, in reality, it is man-made. Religion, though, is a reflection of a more fundamental source of alienation. It is essentially a projection

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of the social relationships involved in the process of production. If man is to find himself and abolish the illusions of religion, he must 'abandon a condition which requires illusions'. He must therefore eradicate the source of alienation in the economic infrastructure.

In Marx's view, productive labour is the primary, most vital human activity. History begins when men actually produce their means of subsistence, when they begin to control nature. At a minimum this involves the production of food and shelter. Marx argues that, 'The first historical act is, therefore, the production of material life'. Production is a social enterprise since it requires cooperation. Men must work together to produce the goods and services necessary for life. From the social relationships involved in production develops a 'mode of life' which can be seen as an expression of these relationships. This mode of life shapes man's nature. In Marx's words, 'As individuals express their life so they are. What they are, therefore, coincides with their production, with what they produce and how they produce it'. Thus the nature of man and the nature of society as a whole derive primarily from the production of material life.

In Marx's view, productive labour is the primary, most vital human activity. According to Marx, man is essentially a creative being who realizes his essence and affirms himself in labour or production, a creative activity carried out in cooperation with other and by which the external world is transformed. The process of production involves transformation of human power into material objects or 'objectification' of human creative power. In other words, in the production of objects man 'objectifies' himself, he expresses and externalizes his being. However, if the objects of man's creation come to control his being, then man loses himself in the object. The act of production then results in man's alienation. This occurs when man regards the products of his labour as commodities, as articles for sale in the market place. The objects of his creation are then seen to control his existence. They are seen to be subject to impersonal forces, such as the law of supply and demand, over which man has little or no control. In Marx's words, 'the object that labour produces, its product, confronts it as an alien being, as a power independent of the producer'. In this way man is estranged from the object he produces, he becomes alienated form the most vital human activity, productive labour.

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Marx saw into important characteristics of industrial society – the mechanization of production and a further specialization of the division of labour – as contributing to the alienation of the work-force. However, he stressed that the capitalist economic system, rather than industrialization as such, is the primary source of alienation. In the capitalist society, division of labour and the institution of private property develop to their highest level and relations become contractual, consequently alienation also reaches the highest level. According to Marx, alienation reaches its height in capitalist society where labour is dominated by the requirements of capital, the most important of which is the demand for profit. These requirements determine levels of employment and wages, the nature and quantity of goods produced and their method of manufacture. The worker sees himself as a prisoner of market forces over which he has no control. He is subject to the impersonal mechanisms of the law of supply and demand. He is at the mercy of the periodic booms and slumps which characterize capitalist economies. The worker therefore loses control over the objects he produces and becomes alienated from his product and the act of production. His work becomes a means to an end, a means of obtaining money to buy the goods and services necessary for his existence. Unable to fulfill his being in the products of his labour, the worker becomes alienated from himself in the act of production. Therefore the more the worker produces, the more he loses himself. In Marx's words, 'the greater this product the less he is himself'.

According to Marx, alienation manifests itself in four ways:

Firstly, the worker is alienated from the product of his labour, since what he produces is appropriated by the capitalist and the worker has no control over it.

Secondly, the worker is alienated from the act of production itself because all decisions as to how production is to be organized are taken by the capitalist. For the worker, labour ceases to offer an intrinsic satisfaction and instead becomes only a means for survival. It becomes a compulsion forced from without and is no more an end in itself. In fact, work becomes a commodity to be sold and its only value to the worker is its saleability. The labour therefore is not voluntary but forced, it is *forced* labour.

Thirdly, in addition to the fact that wage labour alienates man from his product and his productive activity, which distinguishes him from animals, he also becomes alienated from his species. After all, according to Marx (and Hegel) his "species-being" is determined by his conscious productive activity, which is also a

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goal in itself. Under conditions of wage labour, however, labour is not a goal in itself, but only a means of maintaining life. This too means that what distinguishes man from animals, the free, conscious activity of life, disappears. In other words, according to Marx, man is distinguished from the animal by his creative ability to do labour but due to above mentioned aspects of alienation, man looses his distinctly human quality and gets alienated from his real human nature or his "species-being." The capitalist system stratifies man, destroys the human qualities and renders man to a state worse than animal. No animal has to work for its survival at other's bidding while man has to do that in a capitalist system.

Fourthly, the form of wage labour prevalent in the capitalist society also leads to social alienation. Consequently, man ultimately becomes alienated from that which is a product of his actions: society, as in the case of Feuerbach's concept of God, society becomes estranged from the individual and directed against him. "Society" then becomes a force that lives its own life over which no one has control. In other words, the worker in a capitalist system is also socially alienated, because social relations became market relations, in which each man is judged by his position in the market, rather than his human qualities. Capital accumulation generates its own norms which reduces people to the level of commodities. Workers become merely factors in the operation of capital and their activities are dominated by the requirements of profitability rather than by their human needs.

In Marx's view, the market forces which are seen to control production are not impersonal mechanisms beyond the control of man, they are man-made. Alienation is therefore the result of human activity rather than external forces with an existence independent of man. If the products of labour are alien to the worker, they must therefore belong to somebody. Thus Marx argues that, 'The alien being to whom the labour and the product of the labour belongs, whom the labour serves and who enjoys its product, can only be man himself. If the product of labour does not belong to the worker but stands over against him as an alien power, this is only possible in that it belongs to another man apart from the worker'. This man is the capitalist who owns and controls the forces of production and the products of labour, who appropriates for himself the wealth that labour produces. Alienation therefore springs not from impersonal market forces but from relationships between men. An end to alienation thus involves a radical change in the pattern of these relationships. This will come when the contradiction between man's consciousness and objective reality is resolved. Then man will realize that the

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situation in which he finds himself is man-made and therefore subject to change by human action.

Given the priority Marx assigns to economic factors, an end to alienation involves a radical change in the economic infrastructure. In particular, it requires the abolition of private property and its replacement by communal ownership of the forces of production, that is the replacement of capitalism by communism. In communist society conflicts of interest will disappear and antagonistic groups such as capitalists and workers will be a thing of the past. The products of labour will no longer be appropriated by some at the expense of others. With divisions in society eradicated, man will be at one with his fellows, a truly social being. As such he will not lose himself in the products of his labour. He will produce both for himself and others at one and the same time. In this situation 'each of us would have doubly affirmed himself and his fellow man'. Since he is at one with his fellows, the products of man's labour in which he objectifies himself will not result in the loss of self. In productive labour each member of society contributes to the well-being of all and so expresses both his individual and social being. The objects which he produces are owned and controlled at once by himself and his fellow man.

The critique of capitalism developed by the American economists Samuel Bowles and Herbert Gintis is strongly influenced by Marx's views. Like Marx they see capitalism as a repressive and exploitive system concerned with the maximization of profit rather than the satisfaction of human need. Following Marx, they argue that an understanding of the nature of work in capitalist society is only possible by seeing it in relation to the economic and social system in which it is set. Thus, what goes on in the workplace, the social organization of work, can only be explained by reference to the structure of class and power relationships in society as a whole. Bowles and Gintis's major contribution is their rejection of the view that the nature of work in capitalist society is shaped by the demands of efficiency and the requirements of technology. They claim that 'the alienated character of work as a social activity cannot be ascribed to the nature of "modern technology", but is, rather, a product of the class and power relations of economic life'.

Please note that the theory of alienation was unknown until the 1930s but, particularly since the 1960s, it has become extremely important and much discussed and used in so-called humanistic Marxism. It was used to criticize the

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"affluent society' of the Western world, but it was also used by many opposition figures in Western Europe who analyzed and criticized "actually existing socialism." Since Marx, 'alienation' has undergone a lot of change of meaning. It has become one of the important concepts in mainstream sociology, especially in the writings of the American sociologists of 50's and 60's. Let us now discuss the view of other scholars on alienation.



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Max Weber disagreed with Marx regarding the factors leading to alienation and believed that alienation was an inevitable feature of modern industrial society irrespective of whether the means of production are owned privately or collectively. For Weber the cause of alienation lies in the rationalization of social life and predominance of bureaucratic organizations in modern industrial societies. The compulsive conformity to impersonal rules in bureaucratic organizations renders people into mere cogs in giant machines and destroys their human qualities.

The American sociologist C. Wright Mills, in a study of the American middle classes entitled *White Collar*, applies Marx's concept of alienation to non-manual (white-collar) workers. Mills states that the expansion of the tertiary sector of the economy in advanced capitalist societies has led to a 'shift from skills with things to skills with persons'. Just as manual workers become like commodities by selling their 'skills with things', a similar process occurs when non-manual workers sell their 'skills with persons' on the open market. Mills refers to this sector of the economy as the 'personality market'. A market value is attached to personality characteristics and as a result people sell pieces of their personality. Therefore managers and executives are employed not simply because of their academic qualifications and experience but for their ability to get on with people. The salesman is given a job for his apparent warmth, friendliness and sincerity. However, because aspects of personality are bought and sold like any other commodity, individuals are alienated from their true selves. Their expression of personality at work is false and insincere. Mills gives the example of a girl working in a department store, smiling, concerned and attentive to the whims of the customer. He states, 'in the course of her work, because her personality becomes, the instrument of an alien purpose, the salesgirl becomes self-alienated'. At work she is not herself. In the salesroom, in the boardroom, in the staffroom, in the conference room, men and women are prostituting their personalities in pursuit of personal gain. Mills regards American society as a 'great salesroom' filled with hypocrisy, deceit insincerity. Rather than expressing their true personalities and feelings, people assume masks of friendliness, concern and interest in order to manipulate others to earn a living.

Similarly, the French sociologist and journalist Andre Gorz argues that alienation at work leads the worker to seek fulfillment in leisure. However, just as the capitalist system shapes his working day, it also shapes his leisure activities. It creates the passive consumer who finds satisfaction in the consumption of the

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product of the manufacturing and entertainment industries. Leisure simply provides a 'means of escape and oblivion', a means of living with the problem rather than an active solution to it. Thus in capitalist society, man is alienated from both work and leisure. The two spheres of life reinforce each other.

A similar picture is painted by Herbert Marcuse in *One Dimensional Man*, though his remarks apply to both capitalist and East European communist societies. Marcuse sees the potential for personal development crushed in advanced industrial society. Work is 'exhausting, stupefying, inhuman slavery'. Leisure simply involves 'modes of relaxation which soothe and prolong this stupefaction'. It is based on and directed by 'false needs' which are largely imposed by a mass media controlled by the establishment. Needs are false if they do not result in true self-fulfillment and real satisfaction. Marcuse claims that, 'Most of the prevailing needs to relax, to have fun, to behave and consume in accordance with the advertisements, to love and hate what others love and hate belong to this category of false needs'. Members of society no longer seek fulfillment in themselves and in their relationships with others. Instead, 'The people recognize themselves in their commodities; they find their soul in their automobile, hi-fi set, split-level home, kitchen equipment'. The circle is now complete: industrial man is alienated from every sphere of his life.

Marxian perspectives on the nature of work and leisure are open to a number of criticisms. Firstly, they are based partly on a rather vague picture of what man could and ought to be. It can be argued that this view says more about the values of particular sociologists than it does about man's essential being. Secondly, they tend to ignore the meanings held by members of society. If people claim fulfillment in work and/or leisure, there is a tendency to dismiss their views as a product of false class consciousness. Thirdly, Marxian perspectives are very general. As Alasdair Clayre notes, they tend to lump together diverse occupations and leisure activities and create a simple model of 'man in industrial society'.

Where Marx was pessimistic about the division of labour in society, Emile Durkheim (a functionalist) was cautiously optimistic. Marx saw the specialized division of labour trapping the worker in his occupational role and dividing society into antagonistic social classes. Durkheim saw a number of problems arising from specialization of industrial society but believed the promise of the division of labour outweighed the problems. Whereas Marx's solution to the problem of alienation was radical – the abolition of capitalism and its replacement by

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socialism – Durkheim believed that the solution to anomie can be provided within the existing framework of industrial society. He outlined his views in *The Division of Labour in Society,* first published in 1893. Durkheim saw alienation as a consequence of the condition of *anomie*, which refers to the breakdown of norms in society leading to experienced normlessness. You will learn about it more when we'll discuss the ideas of Emile Durkheim.

Another sociologist Melvin Seeman used the insights of Marx, Emile Durkheim and others to construct what is often considered a model to recognize the five prominent features of alienation: powerlessness, meaninglessness, normlessness, isolation and self-estrangement. However, Seeman simply treats them as subjective dispositions which can be measured with the help of attitude scales. Seeman later added a sixth element (cultural estrangement), although this element does not feature prominently in later discussions of his work. Seeman was part of a surge in alienation research during the mid-20th century when he published his paper, "*On the Meaning of Alienation*", in 1959.

An American sociologist, Robert Blauner, in his famous study entitled *Alienation and Freedom,* examines the behaviour and attitudes of manual workers in the printing, textile, automobile and chemical industries. He sees production technology as the major factor influencing the degree of alienation that workers experience. Blauner defines alienation as 'a general syndrome made up of different objective conditions and subjective feelings and states which emerge from certain relationships between workers and socio-technical settings of employment'. 'Objective conditions' refer mainly to the technology employed in particular industries. Blauner argues that technology largely determines the amount of judgement and initiative required from workers and the degree of control they have over their work. From an analysis of various forms of technology, he assesses the degree of alienation they produce. 'Subjective feelings and states' refer to the attitudes and feeling that workers have towards their work. This information is obtained from questionnaires.

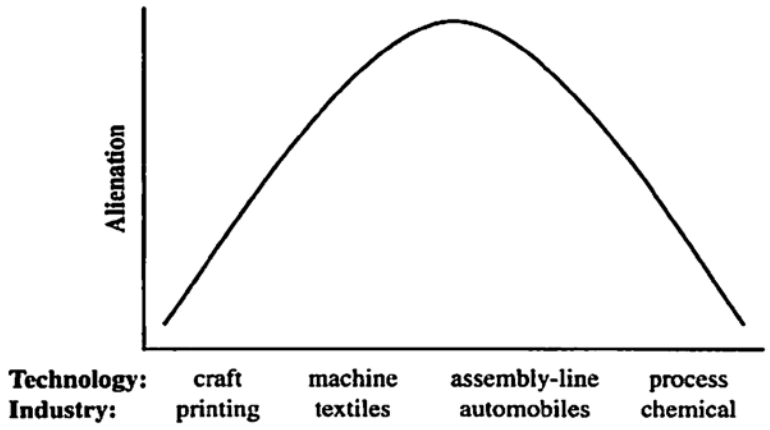
Blauner considers workers' attitudes as a valid measure of their level of alienation. Thus if workers express satisfaction with their work, they are not alienated. He thus rejects Marxian views which argue that workers in capitalist society are automatically alienated because of their objective position in the relations of production. From a Marxian perspective, if workers express satisfaction with their jobs, this is an indication of false consciousness. Blauner

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divides the concept of alienation into four dimensions: the degree of control workers have over their work; the degree of meaning and sense of purpose they find in work; the degree to which they are socially integrated into their work; and the degree to which they are involved in their work. In terms of these four dimensions, the alienated worker has a sense of powerlessness, meaninglessness, isolation and self estrangement.

Robert Blauner, on the basis of his findings, presented the relationship between technology and alienation in the form of an **inverted U-curve**. According to him, level of alienation is low in craft industries like printing but it increases in the machine-based textile industry. Blauner saw alienation reaching its height with mass production industry based on mechanized assembly line technology like automobile industry but in process industries with high degree of automation, alienation tends to decline because workers feel more involved and responsible.



Blauner's Model of Alienation

Please note that Blauner believes that automation reverses the 'historic trend' towards increasing alienation in manufacturing industry. It restores control, meaning, integration and involvement to the worker. Blauner examines work in the chemical industry which involves the most recent development in production technology. The oil and chemical industries employ automated continuous process technology whereby the raw materials enter the production process, the various stages of manufacture are automatically controlled and conducted by machinery, and the finished product emerges 'untouched by human hand'. Although the product is manufactured automatically, the worker has considerable control over and responsibility for production. Work in chemical plants involves monitoring and checking control dials which measure factors such as temperature and pressure. Readings indicate whether or not adjustments must be made to the

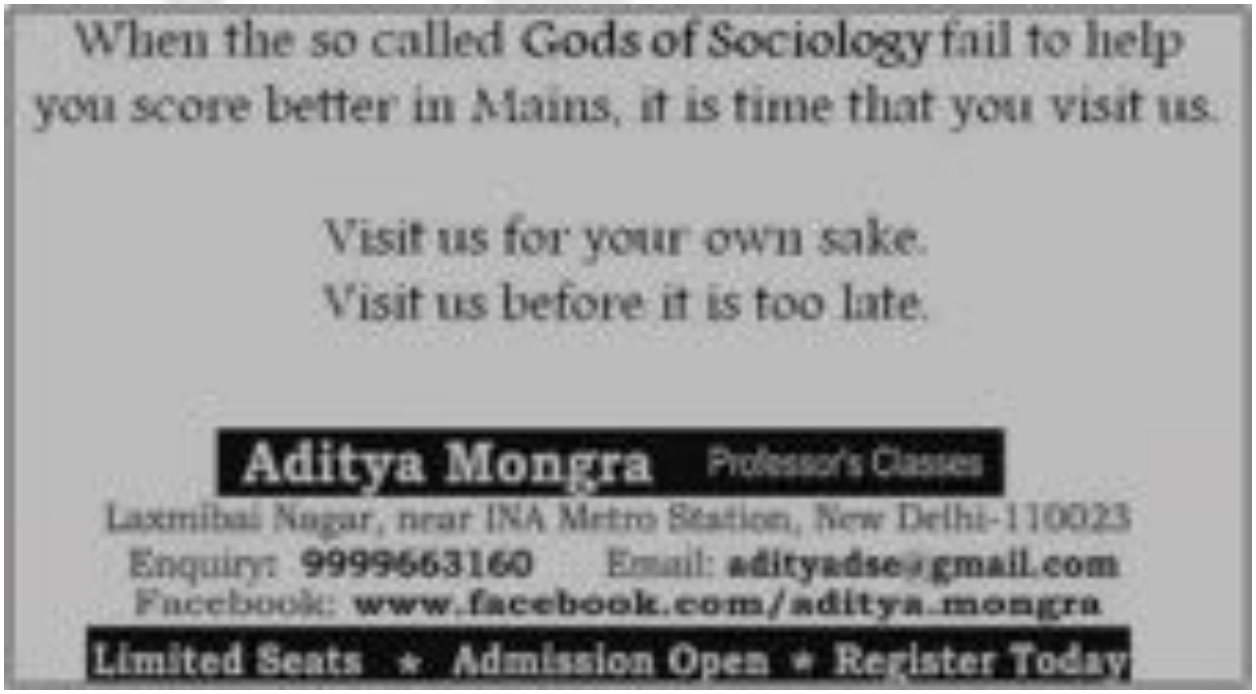
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process. Blauner states that these decisions require 'considerable discretion and initiative'. Work also involves the maintenance and repair of expensive and complicated machinery. Skilled technicians range freely over the factory floor; there is considerable variety in their work compared to the routine machine minding and assembly line production. In direct contrast to assembly line workers, none of the process workers felt they were controlled or dominated by their technology.

Compared to craft work, Blauner argues that in continuous process technology, 'the dominant job requirement is no longer manual skill but responsibility'. This emphasis on responsibility restores meaning and purpose to work; it is an 'important source of satisfaction and accomplishment'. Process technology halts the increasingly specialized division of labour. It integrates the entire production process and since workers are responsible for the overall process, they can see and appreciate their contribution to the finished product. Their sense of purpose is increased by the fact that process workers operate in teams with collective responsibility for the smooth running of the machinery. Again, this encourages the individual worker to feel a part of the overall production process.

However, as can be seen from the discussion above the latter-day meaning of alienation has undergone change. It is no longer based upon objective conditions alone rather it has come to be identified with subjective dispositions.



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Marx: An Assessment

We conclude our discussion by making some observations about the impact of Marx's ideas on social theory and on the social theorists who came after him. As we know that Karl Marx never saw himself in the role of a sociologist, his prime concern being to bring about a revolutionary transformation in the then contemporary European society. Nevertheless, ideas of Karl Marx have greatly contributed to the development of modern sociology. In fact, he is the founder of the 'conflict tradition' in modern sociology and his ideas have stimulated a lively debate which has further enriched the discipline.

Firstly, Marx contributed a new perspective and a new methodology to study the social phenomena. He highlighted the role of economic factors in shaping various institutions of society. This has been accepted as an academic methodology in social sciences. The long-lasting significance of Marx's theory of historical materialism is that he goes far beyond the point of just adopting a materialist orientation in philosophical terms, but puts this approach to work in developing a detailed theory about the emergence of modern capitalist society. To the extent that Marx's theory accounts successfully for the emergence of capitalist society during the 19th century, this reinforces the general reliability, not only of his own theory of historical change, but of the materialist and realist approaches in social theory as a whole.

However, particular criticism has been directed towards the priority that Marx assigns to economic factors in his explanation of social structure and social change. Max Weber's study of ascetic Protestantism argued that religious beliefs provided the ethics, attitudes and motivations for the development of capitalism. Since ascetic Protestantism preceded the advent of capitalism, Weber maintained that at certain times and places aspects of the superstructure can play a primary role in directing change. The priority given to economic factors has also been criticized by elite theorists who have argued that control of the machinery of government rather than ownership of the forces of production provides the basis for power. They point to the example of communist societies where, despite the fact that the forces of production are communally owned, power is largely monopolized by a political and bureaucratic elite.

Secondly, having produced a painstaking account of how societies move on under pressure from developments in the means of production combined with changes in the nature of property relations, the simple message that Marx and Engels want to get across in *The Communist Manifesto* is that, as surely as night follows day, the capitalist mode of production is about to be replaced by a socialist or communist mode of production. The only remaining question was exactly *when*

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this might happen and whether some kind of intervention might be required to make sure it did. Marx and Engels certainly felt that by forming the Communist Party, and by spelling out the principles of historical change according to their own theory in the *Manifesto*, they could, as it were, give history a bit of a push in the right direction. The working class, it seemed, could not be relied upon to make history happen as it should, but would need the help of 'fresh elements of enlightenment and progress' supplied even by the bourgeoisie to show them the way. There are strong hints, at least in sections of the *Manifesto* drafted by Engels, that the overthrow of capitalism was unlikely to be a peaceful affair: the Communists 'openly declare that their ends can be attained only by the forcible overthrow of all existing social conditions. Let the ruling classes tremble at a Communist revolution. The proletarians have nothing to lose but their chains. They have a world to win'.

Equally certain, however, is the fact that the validity of Marx and Engel's theory would have been considerably strengthened if a revolution *had* occurred in modern society during the latter part of the 19th century. The fact that this has not yet happened rather suggests either that the theory was not complete or that they had a poor sense of timing. Critics argue that Marx's predictions about the downfall of capitalism have not come true. Contrary to his belief, socialism has triumphed in predominantly peasant societies whereas capitalist societies show no signs of destructive class war. And Marx's classless and stateless society is an utopia; there can be no society without an authority structure or a regulatory mechanism which inevitably leads to a crystallization of social relations between the rulers and the ruled, with inherent possibilities of internal contradiction and conflict. His theory of class conflict, even though no longer relevant to a present day society, has been an immensely valuable contribution. It has stimulated further debate and research which enriched sociology as a discipline.

Turning to his idea of '**communist society**', critics have argued that history has not borne out the promise of communism contained in Marx's writings. Socialist or communist societies are societies in which the forces of production are communally owned. Marx believed that public ownership of the forces of production is the first and fundamental step towards the creation of an egalitarian society. This would abolish at a stroke the antagonistic classes of capitalist society. Classes, defined in terms of the relationship of social groups to the forces of production, would now share the same relationship-that of ownership-to the forces of production. Social inequality would not, however, disappear overnight. There would be a period of transition during which the structures of inequality produced by capitalism would be dismantled. Marx was rather vague about the exact nature of the communist utopia which should eventually emerge from the abolition of private property. He believed that the state would eventually 'wither away' and

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that the consumption of goods and services would be based on the principle of 'to each according to his needs'. Whether he envisaged a disappearance of all forms of social inequality, such as prestige and power differentials, is not entirely clear. One thing that is clear, though, is that the reality of contemporary communism is a long way from Marx's dreams. Significant social inequalities are present in communist regimes and there are few, if any, signs of a movement towards equality. The dictatorship of the proletariat clings stubbornly to power and there is little indication of its eventual disappearance.

Eastern European communism has not resulted in the abolition of social stratification. Identifiable strata, which can be distinguished in terms of differential economic rewards, occupational prestige and power, are present in all socialist states. Frank Parkin identifies the following strata in East European communist societies: White-collar intelligentsia (professional, managerial and administrative positions), Skilled manual positions, Lower or unqualified white-collar positions, and Unskilled manual positions. Although income inequalities are not as great as in capitalist societies, they are still significant.

Milovan Djilas, a Yugoslavian writer, argues that those in positions of authority in communist societies use power to further their own interests. He claims that the bourgeoisie of the West have been replaced by a new ruling class in the East. This 'new class' is made up of 'political bureaucrats', many of whom are high ranking officials of the Communist Party. Although in legal terms, the forces of production are communally owned, Djilas argues that in practice they are controlled by the new class for its own benefit. Political bureaucrats direct and control the economy and monopolize decisions about the distribution of income and wealth. If anything, Djilas sees the new class as more exploitive than the bourgeoisie. Its power is even greater because it is unchecked by political parties. Djilas claims that in a single party state political bureaucrats monopolize power. In explaining the source of their power, Djilas maintains the Marxian emphasis on the forces of production. He argues that the new class owes its power to the fact it controls the forces of production. Others have reversed this argument claiming that in communist societies economic power derives from political power. Thus T.B. Bottomore argues that the new class 'controls the means of production because it has political power'.

The German sociologist Ralf Dahrendorf has modified the Marxian theory of class and class struggle to make it applicable to contemporary industrial societies. He examined the nature of conflict in industry with particular reference to the role of trade unions. He argues that by the latter half of 20th century trade unions were generally accepted as legitimate by employers and the state.

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Dahrendorf regards this as the major step towards industrial democracy and the institutionalization of industrial conflict.

Trade unions form the major groups representing the interests of employees in general and the manual working class in particular. A number of sociologists have argued that largely through trade unionism, the working class has been integrated into capitalist society. Conflict between employers and employees has been institutionalized in terms of an agreed upon set of rules and procedures. The net result is increasing stability in industrial society. No longer is the working class seen as a threat to social order a Marx believed; there is less and less chance of the kind of class conflict which Marx predicted.

Dahrendorf argues that the voice of the working class is growing louder through its formal associations. He sees a trend towards a more equal balance of power between employers and employees and the development of what he terms, 'industrial democracy'. He argues that with the formation of workers' interest groups a number of processes occurred which furthered the integration of the working class into the structure of capitalist society. Firstly, negotiating bodies were set up for formal negotiation between representatives of employer and workers. Such negotiation take place within a framework of agreed upon rules and procedures. Conflict is largely contained and resolved within this framework. Secondly, should negotiations break down, a machinery of arbitration has been institutionalized in terms of which outside bodies mediate between the parties in dispute. Thirdly, within each company workers are formally represented, for example by shop stewards, who represent their interest on a day-to-day basis. Finally, there is a tendency 'towards an institutionalization of workers participation in industrial management'.

The American sociologist Seymour M. Lipset has also argued that trade unions 'serve to integrate their members in the larger body politic and give them a basis for loyalty to the system'. Via trade unions, the interests of the working class are represented at the highest level and in this way the working class as a whole is integrated into 'the larger body politic'. The picture which emerges from this discussion is one of fully-fledged interest groups – trade unions – effectively representing workers' interests. Industrial conflict has been institutionalized and the working class has been integrated into both the capitalist enterprise and society as a whole.

However, although Marx's predictions regarding the future of capitalist societies have been largely disproved by the developments of history in 20th century, yet Marx's concepts of historical materialism, class and class conflict and his theory of social change (if shorn of the prophetic elements) remains a valuable

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contribution to social sciences in understanding the social structure and change in the society.

Thirdly, Marx's concept of alienation is another important contribution to sociology. The concept of alienation was further developed by other sociologists like C.Wright Mills, Herbert Marcuse, Seeman, Robert Blauner, etc., to adapt it to contemporary societies. However, critics argue that Marx misjudged the extent of alienation in the average worker. The great depth of alienation and frustration which Marx "witnessed" among the workers of his day is not "typical" of today's capitalism or its worker who tends to identify increasingly with a number of "meaningful" groups—religious, ethnic, occupational and local. This is not to deny the existence of alienation but to point out that alienation results more from the structure of bureaucracy and of mass society than from economic exploitation. Further, Robert Blauner believes that automation reverses the 'historic trend' towards increasing alienation in manufacturing industry and produced non-alienated worker.

Herbert Marcuse's *Re-examination of the Concept of Revolution* is a significant contribution to Marxist sociology. According to him, "the *Marxian concept of a revolution* carried by the majority of the exploited masses, culminating in the 'seizure of power' and in the setting up of a proletarian dictatorship which initiates socialization, *is 'over-taken' by the historical development*: it pertains to a stage of capitalist productivity and organization which has been overtaken. He argues that although the Marxian prophecy of the downfall of capitalism has not come true, Marx's concept of revolution which is at once a historical concept and a dialectical concept is relevant in two different contexts. Firstly, in the capitalist countries, there is a standing opposition whose members are drawn from the ghetto population and the middle-class intelligentsia, especially among students. These groups are vocal; they reject the system, form counter-cultures and profess adherence to radical political beliefs and new lifestyles. Yet, they cannot become agents of revolutionary change unless actively supported by a politically articulate working class freed from the shackles of bureaucratic trade unions and establishment-oriented party machinery. Secondly, in the predominantly agrarian countries of the Third World, there are peasant revolutions and national liberation movements.

Marcuse also perceives a "fateful link" between the two revolutionary movements. In the first place, the national liberation movements in the developing countries "are expressive of the internal contradictions of the global capitalist system"—the colonialism and economic exploitation perpetrated by the corporate capitalism. This position is actively endorsed by Andre Gunder Frank whose extensive research in Latin America has led him to conclude that the

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underdevelopment of the Third World countries is initiated and aggravated by the capitalist system of the developed countries which have satellized and exploited developing countries. Thus the radical protest in capitalist countries and the revolutionary tendencies in the developing nations are closely related—in their opposition to multinational corporate capitalism and their orientation to the imperatives of a global revolution.

A Note on Convergence Theory

Some scholars argue that in certain respects, the overall picture of stratification in communist societies is similar to that of the West. A number of American sociologists have argued that stratification systems in all industrial societies, whether capitalist or communist, are becoming increasingly similar. This view, sometimes known as '**convergence theory**', argues that modern industrial economies will necessarily produce similar systems of social stratification. In particular, modern industry requires particular types of workers. In the words of Clark Kerr, one of the main proponents of convergence theory, 'The same technology calls for the same occupational structure around the world - in steel, in textiles, in air transport'. Kerr assumes that technical skills and educational qualifications will be rewarded in proportion to their value to industry. Since the demands of industry are essentially the same in both East and West, the range of occupations and occupational rewards will become increasingly similar. As a result the stratification systems of capitalist and communist societies will converge.

Convergence theory has been the subject of strong criticism. Firstly, it has been argued that there are important differences between the stratification systems of East and West. Secondly, the factors which shape the two systems have been seen as basically different. Thirdly, it has been argued that the view that economic forces shape the rest of society ignores other important sources of change. Thus John. H. Goldthorpe claims that convergence theory fails to consider the influence of political and ideological forces. In the West market forces are the main factors generating social stratification. By comparison, in the East, social inequality is far more subject to political regulation. Frank Parkin makes similar points, seeking the bases of stratification in capitalist and communist societies as quality different. He argues that in the East, 'the rewards system is much more responsive to manipulation by the central authority than it is in a market based economy'. Parkin also notes a number of specific differences between the stratification systems of East and West. Firstly, income inequalities are considerably smaller in the East. Secondly the manual/non-manual distinction seems less marked in communist societies. In particular skilled manual workers are relatively highly placed and routine white-collar workers of now share the prestige and fringe benefits of their

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Western counterparts. Thirdly, the rate of upward mobility is higher in the East. In particular, there is far more recruitment from below to elite positions. However, convergence theory does not argue that the stratification systems of East and West are the same, only that they will be increasingly similar. On this particular point, only time will provide the final answer.

So far communism has failed to live up to the expectations of many of its supporters. It may be that Eastern European societies are still in the process of transition and are indeed moving towards an egalitarian goal. There is some evidence of a decline in income inequality within the mass of the population during the 1960s and early 1970s. However, there is little indication of a reduction in the privileges of the elite. From his study of elite life styles in the USSR, Mervyn Mathews concludes that not only is privilege accepted at the top, but it is 'actively promoted'. It is built into administrative practices and so institutionalized. While communal ownership of the forces of production may be essential for the creation of an egalitarian society, other changes are clearly necessary.

Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. You must send your answers for evaluation to me either by email or post. You can also come and meet me to discuss your answers.

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Emile Durkheim (1858-1917)

Emile Durkheim was born in 1858, in Epinal, France. He grew up in a traditional, orthodox Jewish family. His father was a rabbi (as his grandfather and great-grandfather had been). The family was quite poor. Like his father before him, young Durkheim expected to become a rabbi. His training began early in Hebrew and Old Testament and the Talmud. His Jewish parents nurtured their son's ambition in the strongly homogeneous and cohesive community of Jews. The Jewish minority status and his early contact with the disastrous Franco-Prussian War made a major impression upon Durkheim, which is reflected in his constant fascination with the study of group solidarity. However, Durkheim changed his mind and later on even rejected the Jewish faith. He remained a non-believer for the rest of his life. In 1879 he became a student at the most prestigious postgraduate school of higher education, the Ecole Normale Superieure in Paris. Though his primary training was in philosophy, his strong personal interest was in politics and sociology. Because he was so astute in the application of his fledgling scientific skills of political and social analysis and partly because of his rebellious demeanor vis-a-vis the more traditional ways of doing things at the Ecole, Durkheim was not always in favour with the university establishment. Upon graduation in 1882, he taught philosophy in several provincial Lycees in the neighbourhood of Paris, the University, from 1882 to 1887. Determined in his professional growth, Durkheim took a leave of absence from teaching to do further study in Germany from 1885-1886, primarily in Berlin and Leipzig where he was especially impressed with the scientific precision in the experiments of the renowned psychologist Wilhelm Wundt.

During this time, Durkheim began to publish articles, first on the German academic life and then critical articles on various kinds of scholarship thereby gaining considerable recognition from the French academy. In 1887, he was appointed to the faculty of the University of Bordeaux where the first course in social science in all of France was created for him to teach. Shortly thereafter, he married Louise Dreyfus, a Jewish girl from a strong traditional family. They had two children, Marie and Andre. Little is known about family life except that Louise seems to have been a strong and supportive wife and encouraging mother.

During the years in Bordeaux (until 1902) Durkheim was very productive and wrote three of his most important books. His students and friends described him as very disciplined, serious, and stern. Durkheim alongwith Max Weber must be credited with founding the modern phase of sociological theory. It began with his first book, *The Division of Labour in Society*, submitted as his French doctoral thesis at the Sorbonne alongwith his Latin doctoral thesis on Montesquieu in 1893. Two years after his monumental work on the *Division of Labour* (1893), he

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published his second major study, *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895), completing his Bordeaux trilogy in 1897 with his incomparable *Suicide*. Because of the tremendous impact Durkheim was having in French universities and given the increasing numbers of France's finest young intellectuals who began to cluster around him, Durkheim became convinced that a literary forum was necessary both to accommodate the burgeoning of sociological scholarship and to further enhance the already accelerating recognition sociology was receiving across the spectrum of the French academy. For this purpose, Durkheim founded in 1898, while at Bordeaux, the *L'Annee Sociologique*, a scholarly journal under his own editorship that became the organ of research, debate, and discussion among not only Durkheim and his immediate followers but of all accepted sociological work going on in France. He remained its most important contributor until the war in 1914 when journal was closed.

Four years later and as everyone was anticipating, Durkheim was called to the Sorbonne, Paris's great university and headquarters of the French intelligentsia. The chair created for him in 1902 was in sociology and education, and though education was soon dropped from his prestigious title, Durkheim remained interested in the application of sociology to the field of education throughout his career. His final and in many respects provocative book came fifteen years after his previous study and ten years after going to the Sorbonne, entitled, *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life* (1912). It was the ripe harvest of a long process of intensive cultivation. Religion, once a major passion for him in childhood, became once again a major pre-occupation, not so much as an unwitting participant but as a scrutinizing observer.

The tragedy of the First World War was a very great blow to France, and Durkheim, a man so much committed to the understanding of social solidarity, felt the strain acutely. Half of his class from his Sorbonne student days were killed in combat. Keeping the university activities going in the name of truth and scholarship became increasingly difficult. Distraction, anxieties, despair over loss of friends, students, relations, and colleagues intensified. And, just before Christmas, 1915, Durkheim was notified that his only son, Andre, had died in a Bulgarian hospital of wounds taken in battle. The pride and hope of Durkheim had been shattered by the ravages of war. The loss was too great to bear, his health failed, and in less than two years at the age of fifty-nine, Durkheim died on November 15, 1917.

Dear Candidate, to a considerable extent, the great classical theories are influenced by, and expressions of, the political and moral conflicts, economic processes, and ideological movements of the nineteenth century. Durkheim's sociology too is characterized by this tension between science and morality,

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politics and ideology. As already mentioned above, Durkheim lived through a very turbulent period in French history—the disastrous war with the Prussians, the chaos and socio-political turmoil which inevitably followed, and the instability and internal conflicts of the Third Republic. Durkheim was also involved in the greatest political conflicts of his time known as the Dreyfus Affair. In 1894, a French officer named Dreyfus was found guilty of treason for supposedly writing to the German embassy about secret French documents. What made the conviction especially controversial was that Dreyfus was a Jew and the French military had a notorious reputation for anti-Semitism. Two years later, when evidence came to light exonerating Dreyfus, the military tried to suppress it. In response to this the author Emile Zola wrote a famous letter accusing the French government of convicting an innocent man. Many leading French intellectuals defended the rights of Dreyfus and condemned the traditions of anti-Semitism and authoritarianism in the military. Because of prevailing public concerns this was soon framed as a conflict between individual rights and traditional authority. Although a Jew and therefore personally concerned about anti-Semitism, Durkheim, entered the debate on the side Dreyfus from a more abstract position. The idea of moral individualism became especially important to Durkheim after the Dreyfus affair. In his essay "Individualism and the Intellectuals," he fully develops his idea of moral individualism. He cleverly shows how a defense of the rights of the individual is the best way to strengthen our traditions and to guard against the social threat of egoism. Individualism has become our modern tradition, and to attack it not only is to risk social disorder, but is tantamount to blasphemy.

All these problems of the French society along with his own back-ground of belongingness to a highly well-knit Jewish community, pre-disposed him towards a search for the basis of moral order in society. It made him assert the primacy of 'group' over the individuals and pre-occupied him with exploring the sources of social order and disorder, the forces that make for regulation or deregulation in the body social. His overriding concern as a moral man and scientist was with the social order. Durkheim believed that the traditional sources of morality upon which the social order was built, especially religion, were no longer viable or valid without serious and rational alterations. The new source of moral integration, so necessary for the establishment and stability of society, would be found in the discipline designed to scientifically analyze social order, stability, and continuity, viz., that of sociology.

Much of his scientific work displays an interest in promoting moral reform. His general sociological aim was to define the necessary conditions for a stable, smoothly functioning, modern society. On this foundation, he thought it possible to formulate "correct," scientific solutions to the most pressing problems of his age. He was in favour of a liberal, democratic constitution, the development of the

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welfare state, and the regulation of the capitalist economy. He aligned himself with reformist socialism, but was also influenced by *conservative* ideas on the importance of morality, the family, religion, and tradition. Please note that Durkheim's interest in socialism is sometimes taken as evidence against the idea that he was a conservative, but his kind of socialism was very different from the kind that interested Marx and his followers. In fact, Durkheim labeled Marxism as a set of "disputable and out-of-date hypothesis." To Durkheim socialism represented a movement aimed at the moral regeneration of society through scientific morality, and he was not interested in short-term political methods or the economic aspects of socialism. He did not see proletariat as the salvation of society, and he was greatly opposed to agitation or violence. Socialism for Durkheim was very different from what we usually think of as socialism: it simply represented a system in which the moral principles discovered by scientific sociology were to be applied.

Although Durkheim was aware of Marx's work, and was a contemporary of Max Weber (Durkheim died in 1917, Weber in 1920), his training and intellectual orientation were quite different. Marx built his social theory on the basis of the German idealist philosophy of Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, the British political economy of Adam Smith and David Ricardo, and the French socialist tradition. Weber's social theory developed out of the philosophical debates that dominated German intellectual circles in the 1880s. In contrast Durkheim stood as the successor to a quite different current of thought in the French positivist tradition.

The roots of Durkheim's sociology reach deep into the history and intellectual life of France. His theory of the foundation and progress of modern society is based on ideas first clearly formulated during the dramatic social changes that came about from the end of the eighteenth century onwards. Durkheim's most significant predecessor was Auguste Comte, the founder of French positivism. Comte was the first to use the term "sociology" to identify the new social science, and his was one of the first attempts to establish an autonomous basis for the scientific study of society. From Comte he was inspired by the idea that it was possible and necessary to develop a knowledge of social phenomena that would be as rigorous, reliable and concrete as the positivistic knowledge provided by the biological and natural sciences. He also followed Comte in seeing human society in naturalistic terms as an organic unity. Although in his later work, Durkheim used the organic analogy less often, he always believed that a central task of social theory was to understand the linkages and dependencies between one part or organ of the social body and another. A doctor might have a specialist interest in the digestive system, but this system can only be understood in the context of the other bodily systems with which it is connected. A

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similar challenge faces the social theorist in trying to understand how one social phenomenon interconnects with another.

Durkheim sets out his own view of these tasks in his influential book *The Rules of Sociological Method*, which was published in France in 1895. The key advance he makes on Comte's approach is to emphasise that it is possible to identify a category of social phenomena, or **social facts** as he calls them, which is objectively identifiable, and which can be studied quite independently of any grand system of analysis that might be applied to them:

> "Here, then, is a category of facts with very distinctive characteristics: it consists of ways of acting, thinking, and feeling, external to the individual, and endowed with a power of coercion, by reason of which they control him….They constitute, thus, a new variety of phenomena; and it is to them exclusively that the term 'social' ought to be applied. And this term fits them quite well, for it is clear that, since their source is not in the individual, their substratum can be no other than society."
>
> Durkheim, *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895)

Durkheim believed that sociology, as an idea, was born in France in the nineteenth century. He wanted to turn this idea into a discipline, a well-defined field of study. Although the term *sociology* had been coined some years earlier by Auguste Comte, there was no field of sociology per se in late nineteenth-century universities. There were no schools, departments, or even professors of sociology. There were a few thinkers who were dealing with the ideas that were in one way or another sociological, but there was as yet no disciplinary "home" for sociology. Indeed, there was strong opposition from existing disciplines to the founding of such a field. The most significant opposition came from psychology and philosophy, two fields that claimed already to cover the domain sought by sociology. The dilemma for Durkheim, given his aspirations for sociology, was how to create for it a separate and identifiable niche.

To separate it from philosophy, Durkheim argued that sociology should be oriented toward empirical research. In his view, the two other major figures of the epoch who thought of themselves as sociologists, Comte and Herbert Spencer, were far more interested in philosophizing, in abstract theorizing, than they were in studying the social world empirically. If the field continued in the direction set by Comte and Spencer, Durkheim felt, it would become nothing more than a branch of philosophy. As a result, he found it necessary to attack both Comte and Spencer for relying on preconceived ideas of social phenomena instead of actually studying the real world. Thus Comte was said to be guilty of assuming theoretically that the social world was evolving in the direction of an increasingly perfect society, rather than engaging in the hard, rigorous, and basic work of actually studying the

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changing nature of various societies. Similarly, Spencer was accused of assuming harmony in society rather than studying whether harmony actually existed.

Thus, in order to help sociology move away from philosophy and to give it a clear and separate identity, Durkheim proposed that **the distinctive subject matter of sociology should be the study of social facts**. Briefly, *social facts* are the social structure and cultural norms and values that are external to, and coercive of, actors. Students, for example, are constrained by such social structures as the university norms and the value that a given society places on education. Similar social facts constrain people in all areas of social life. Crucial in separating sociology from philosophy is the idea that social facts are to be treated as "things" and studied empirically. This means that social facts must be studied by acquiring data from outside of our own minds through observation and experimentation. This empirical study of social fact as things sets Durkheimian sociology apart from more philosophical approaches.

> A social fact is every way of acting, *fixed or not*, capable of exercising on the individual an *external constraint*: or again, every way of acting which is *general* throughout a given society, while at the same time existing in its own right *independent* of its individual manifestations.
>
> Durkheim, *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895)

Note that Durkheim gave two ways of defining a social fact so that sociology is distinguished from psychology. First, it is experienced as an *external* constraint rather than an internal drive; second, it is *general* throughout the society and is not attached to any particular individual.

Durkheim argued that social facts cannot be reduced to individual, but must be studied as their own reality. Durkheim referred to social facts with the Latin term *sui generis*, which means "unique." He used this term to claim that social facts have their own unique character that is not reducible to individual consciousness. To allow that social facts could be explained by reference to individuals would be to reduce sociology to psychology. Instead, social facts can be explained only by other social facts. To summarize, social facts can be empirically studied, are external to the individual, are coercive of the individual, and are explained by other social facts.

Dear Candidate, let me just simplify all that we have discussed above. Durkheim simply argues that when individuals come together and start living in a group, a new level of reality emerges, that is, social reality or society. In a given society, individuals interact and enter into relations with each other giving rise to a way of life (social currents, for Durkheim). For example, members of a given

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society may develop certain norms to regulate sexual behaviour of its members or to regulate the production, distribution and exchange of goods and services. Over a period of time, these norms or social currents crystallize and take the form of social institutions such as marriage, kinship, market, etc. Thus emerge social facts. Durkheim argues that although society (and its various institutions) develop out of the continuous process of interaction of its individual members yet it comes to acquire a unique and independent existence of its own. It cannot be simply explained by reducing it to a mere aggregation of individuals. Society is not a mere sum of individuals. In other words, it is more than the sum of its parts. Despite the fact that society is made up only of human beings, it can be understood only through studying the interactions rather than the individuals. The interactions have their own levels of reality. For Durkheim, society is a *reality sui generis*. Society has an objective existence; it is independent of the consciousness of the individual members who comprise it. It is external, and enduring. Individuals may die and new members take their place, but society lives forever. This view of Durkheim (**his perspective**) is sometimes also described as '**sociological realism**' because he ascribes the ultimate sociological reality to the group and not to the individual.

Durkheim further argues that since each science is concerned with its own chosen aspect of reality, therefore, a new level of reality, *social reality*, must be studied by a new science namely Sociology. In keeping with the tradition of nineteenth century thinkers like Comte, Spencer, etc., Durkheim believed that this new science of society must be built on the lines of positive sciences. This, he thought would be possible because social reality has its own objective existence, independent of the consciousness of the individual members who comprise it.

Dear Candidate, please also note that Durkheim viewed society as an integrated whole made up of inter-connected and inter-dependent parts. These parts fulfill the needs of the society. This contribution of parts towards fulfillment of the needs of the whole is called, 'function'. Thus, these contributions of the parts enable the society to persist. An attempt to explain the persistence of society should therefore take into account the consequences of the parts for the society as a whole. You have already studied functionalism in detail in our discussion earlier.

The subject matter of sociology, Durkheim proposed, should be the study of social facts. Social facts are nothing but those aspects of social life which have an independent existence of their own, over and above their individual manifestations. According to Durkheim, ***social facts are those ways of acting, thinking and feeling which are capable of exerting an external constraint on individual members, which are generally diffused throughout a given society and which can exist in their own life independent of their individual manifestations***.

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Examples of such social facts are religion, law, language, any form of socio-economic and political institutions, etc.

On the basis of the discussion above, let us summarize the major characteristics of social facts.

Firstly, social facts have distinctive **social** characteristics and determinants which are not amenable to explanation on either the biological or psychological level;

Secondly, they are **external** to the individual; it means that social facts are external to and independent of the individual members of the society;

Thirdly, social facts are diffused throughout the collectivity and are commonly shared by most of the members. In other words, they are **general** throughout a given society. They are not the exclusive property of any single individual rather they belong to the group as a whole. They represent the socially patterned ways of thinking, feeling and acting and exclude the individual idiosyncrasies;

Fourthly, they **endure** through time outlasting any set or group of individuals;

Fifthly, they are, in Durkheim's own words, "endowed with **coercive** power, by virtue of which they impose themselves upon him, independent of his individual will". In other words, social facts constrain the individual to abide by the social norms and code of conduct. People living in groups are not free to behave according to their volition. Instead, their behaviour follows the guidance laid down by the group and the group exercises a moral pressure on the individual members, compelling them to conform to group norms. According to Durkheim, true human freedom lies in being properly regulated by the social norms.

Important: Dear Candidate, I would like to elabourate this point a little further. As discussed earlier, the prevailing problems of the French society along with his own back-ground of belongings to a highly well-knit Jewish community had pre-disposed Durkheim towards a search for the basis of moral order in society. It made him assert the primacy of 'group' over the individuals and pre-occupied him with exploring the sources of social order and disorder. His overriding concern as a moral man and scientist was with the social order. Durkheim was a sociologist of morality in the broadest sense of the word. Durkheim's view of morality had two aspects.

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First, Durkheim was convinced that morality is a social fact, in other words, that morality can be empirically studied, is external to the individual, is coercive of the individual, and is explained by other social facts. This means that morality is not something which one can philosophize about, but something that one has to study as an empirical phenomenon. This is particularly true because morality is intimately related to the social structure. To understand the morality of any particular institution, you have to first study how the institution is constituted, how it came to assume its present form, what its place is in overall structure of society, how the various institutional obligations are related to the social good, and so forth.

Second, Durkheim was a sociologist of morality because his studies were driven by his concern about the moral "health" of modern society. Much of Durkheim's sociology can be seen as a by-product of his concern with moral issues. It was not that Durkheim thought that society had become, or was in danger of becoming, immoral. That simply was impossible because morality was, for Durkheim, identified with society. Therefore, society could not be immoral, but it could certainly lose its moral force if the collective interest of society became nothing but the sum of self-interests. Only to the extent that morality was a social fact could it impose an obligation on individuals that superseded their self-interest. Consequently, Durkheim believed that society needs a strong common morality. What the morality should be was of less interest to him.

Durkheim's great concern with morality was related to his curious definition of freedom. In Durkheim's view, people were in danger of a "pathological" loosening of moral bonds. These moral bonds were important to Durkheim, for without them the individual would be enslaved by ever-expanding and insatiable passions. People would be impelled by their passions into a mad search for gratification, but each new gratification would lead only to more and more needs. According to Durkheim, the one thing that every human will always want is "more." And, of course, that is the one thing we ultimately cannot have. If society does not limit us, we will become slaves to the pursuit of more. Consequently, Durkheim held the seemingly paradoxical view that the individual needs morality and external control in order to be free. This view of the insatiable desire at the core of every human is central to his sociology.

Sixthly, social facts are not static but **dynamic** in nature. For example, as society evolves over a period of time, there is also a corresponding change in its socio-economic and political institutions (this point is important and we will come back to it in our discussion on 'Anomie'); and

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Finally, Durkheim argued that social facts can be explained only by other social facts. It implies that in order to understand social consequences, one must look for social causes.

For Durkheim, sociology is a science of such social facts. Society or '*Conscience collective*' is the ultimate social fact. Further the constituent social facts of the conscience collective exist in a state of interrelationship or interdependence. Therefore, these social facts have to be studied in terms of their interrelationship and interdependence with each other. According to Durkheim, what holds the society together as an ongoing concern is the cohesiveness between these interdependent parts. This 'cohesiveness' has been termed by him as **'solidarity.'**

Before proceeding further, I would like to briefly mention about the distinction that Durkheim made between two broad types of social facts—material and nonmaterial. *Material social facts,* such as forms of technology, styles of architecture, and legal codes are easier to understand of the two because they are directly observable. Clearly, such things as laws are external to individuals and coercive over them. More importantly, these social facts often express a far larger and more powerful realm of *moral forces* that are at least equally external to individuals and coercive over them. These are *nonmaterial social facts*. The bulk of Durkheim's studies, and heart of his sociology, lies in the study of nonmaterial social facts. He argued that a sociologist usually begins a study by focusing on material social facts, which are empirically accessible, in order to understand nonmaterial social facts, which are the real focus of his work. Some of the examples of nonmaterial social facts are morality, collective conscience, collective representations, and social currents.

Durkheim attempted to deal with his interest in common morality in various ways and with different concepts. In his early efforts to deal with this issue, Durkheim developed the idea of the c*onscience collective. Conscience collective*, a French term, when translated into English is collective conscience. In French, the word *conscience* means both "consciousness" and "moral conscience." Durkheim characterized the collective conscience in the following way:

> The totality of beliefs and sentiments common to average citizens of the same society forms a determinate system which has its own life; one may call it the collective or common conscience….It is, thus, an entirely different thing from particular consciences, although it can be realized only through them.
>
> (Durkheim, 1893)

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Several points are worth underscoring in this definition. First, it is clear that Durkheim thought of the collective conscience as occurring throughout a given society when he wrote of the "totality" of people's beliefs and sentiments. Second, Durkheim clearly conceived of the collective conscience as being independent and capable of determining other social facts. It is not just a reflection of a material base as Marx sometimes suggested. Finally, although he held such views of the collective conscience, Durkheim also wrote of its being "realized" through individual consciousness.

In simpler words, we can describe collective conscience as *"the totality of beliefs and sentiments common to the average member of the society, which forms a determinate system with a life of its own."* Thus collective conscience refers to the general structure of shared understandings, norms, and beliefs. It links successive generations to one another. Individuals come in and go out of society, however collective conscience remains. Although collective conscience can only be realized through individuals, it has a form beyond a particular person, and operates at a level higher than him. It is therefore an all-embracing and amorphous concept. As we will see later, Durkheim employed this concept to argue that "primitive" societies had a stronger collective conscience – that is, more shared understandings, norms, and beliefs – than modern societies.

Because collective conscience is such a broad and amorphous idea, it is impossible to study directly, but must be approached through related material social facts. Durkheim's dissatisfaction with this limitation led him to use the collective conscience less in his later works in favour of the much more specific concept of *collective representations*. Durkheim used the concept of collective representations in order to highlight the richness and diversity of the commonly shared beliefs and sentiments, for example, commonly shared cognitive beliefs (concepts), moral beliefs, religious beliefs, etc.

The French word *representation* literally means "idea." Initial definition forwarded by Durkheim in his book *Suicide* (1897) stated that 'essentially social life is made of representations.' Let us try to understand this. See, there is a difference between an object, and the way it is seen, the manner in which it is described, and its meaning understood commonly in a society. The object is thus presented again in terms of meanings, a word is given a meaning. The object or the word is thus 'represented.' C*ollective representation* is a term introduced by Durkheim to refer to a symbol having a common intellectual and emotional meaning to the members of a group. They include not only symbols in the form of objects, such as a flag, but also the basic concepts that determine the way in which one views and relates to the world. Collective representations express collective

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sentiments and ideas which give the group its unity and unique character. Thus they are an important factor contributing to the solidarity of a society.

Collective representations are states of the collective conscience which are different in nature from the states of the individual conscience. They express the way in which a particular group of individuals conceives itself in relation to the objects which affect the social group. Collective representations are socially generated and they refer to, and are, in some sense, about society. Durkheim states that collective representations result from the substratum of associated individuals. But they cannot be reduced to and wholly explained by features of constituent individuals. They are 'sui generis', that is, they generate themselves.

Durkheim used the term *collective representations* to refer to both a collective concept and a social "force." Examples of collective representations are religious symbols, myths, and popular legends. All of these are ways in which society reflects on itself. They represent collective beliefs, norms, and values, and they motivate us to conform to these collective claims. As stated earlier, collective representations also cannot be reduced to individuals, because they emerge out of social interactions, but they can be studied more directly because they are more liable to connected to material symbols such as flags, icons, and pictures or connected to practices such as rituals. Therefore, the sociologist can begin to study how certain collective representations fit well together or have an affinity, and others do not.

Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. Always remember that without answer-writing practice, any amount of sociological knowledge would be of little use for you in qualifying civil services examination. Thus, along with understanding the sociological ideas discussed here, you must also master the art of expressing them in your own words as per the standards of the examination and expectations of the examiner, and that too, in the given Time-and-Word Limit.

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Dear Candidate, let us now look at some of the important ideas of Durkheim discussed in his major works.

The Division of Labour in Society (1893)

The Division of Labour in Society (1893) has been called sociology's first classic. It was Durkheim's first major theoretical work. It was written during the 1880s as part of his doctoral requirement and later published as a complete study in 1893 while Durkheim was at the University of Bordeaux. In this work, Durkheim traced the development of the relationship between individuals and society. Please note that since it was the first of his major works and his methodology for sociological research was still in its formative stage, it was to some extent a speculative exercise. Durkheim presented his methodological framework with clarity and precision in his second major work '*The Rules of Sociological Method*' (1895).

In his study on division of labour in society, Durkheim was primarily responding to the rise of industrial society highlighting both, its positive and negative sides. The rise of industrial society was seen as a consequence of technological advancement which itself was regarded as a natural concomitant of increasing division of labour or specialization. However, Durkheim was not the first to discuss the consequences of division of labour. Prior to him, classical economist Adam Smith had also explained division of labour in terms of its economic consequences.

The term 'division of labour' is used in social theory to refer to the process of dividing up labour among individuals in a group so that the main economic and domestic tasks are performed by different people for the purposes of the collective maintenance of society. The process of the division of labour therefore begins as soon as individuals form themselves into groups where, instead of living isolated or alone, they cooperate collectively by dividing their labour and by coordinating their economic and domestic activities for purposes of survival. Durkheim believed that the division of labour was therefore the result of a social process taking place within the structure of society rather than the result of the private choices of individuals or the result of organic traits that emerged during evolution.

Classical economist Adam Smith was the first to introduce the term 'division of labour' into social thought and to discuss the role it played in the manufacturing process. In looking at the division of labour in different societies, Durkheim, began by making a distinction between what he called the 'social division of labour' and what Adam Smith had called the 'economic division of labour'. In the

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eighteenth century, Smith used the term economic division of labour to describe what happens in the production process when labour is divided during manufacturing. Smith had used the term initially to pinpoint the increase in productivity that takes place when production tasks are divided between workers during the manufacturing process. Smith noted that as soon as people divide their labour to perform various tasks and operations, the quantity of what they produce increases dramatically and that the process of dividing labour tends to accelerate the rate of production.

Durkheim rejected such a narrow and purely economic interpretation of division of labour. Durkheim argued that a purely economic interpretation of division of labour as given by Smith is sociologically inadequate. Since 'division of labour' is a social fact, it must be explained in terms of its overall social consequences and not simply in its economic consequences. The term social division of labour was thus used by Durkheim to describe the *social links and bonds* which develop during the process that takes place in societies when many individuals enter into cooperation for purposes of carrying out joint economic and domestic tasks. Under these circumstances, Durkheim thought that the social division of labour was distinct from the economic division of labour. When used by Smith, the division of labour referred only to the process of dividing up labour for purposes of increasing the rate of production; whereas when used by Durkheim, it referred to the ***principle of social cohesion*** that develops in societies whose social links and bonds result from the way individuals relate to one another when their labour is divided along economic and domestic tasks.

In other words, in this study Durkheim explores the consequences of division of labour for the society as a whole. Beyond focusing explicitly on the social division of labour, Durkheim looked at the question of the overall unity of society. Generally speaking, he referred to this unity as ***social solidarity***. He argued that what holds a society together is the cohesiveness or solidarity among its parts. Hence in this study of social division of labour, Durkheim probes the relationship between division of labour and the manner in which solidarity comes about in a given society. Please remember that his preoccupation with the idea of social order and solidarity was largely a by-product of his own back-ground of belongings to a highly well-knit Jewish community and a very turbulent period in French history. This pre-disposed him towards a search for the basis of moral order in society.

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Before proceeding further, let me just mention three important concerns which Durkheim was trying to address in his study of division of labour.

Firstly, Durkheim wanted to study the social dimension of division of labour. He made a clear distinction between economic and the social consequences of division of labour.

Secondly, since Durkheim and many other before him had explained the rise of industrial society in terms of increase in division of labour, he wanted to study that how division of labour affects social solidarity. In other words, how the change in the division of labour affects the structure of the society and consequently, the nature of social solidarity.

Thirdly, in the post-Enlightenment period, when individualism was on rise, how does individual, while becoming more autonomous, also becomes more solidary. As Durkheim puts it:

'This work had its origins in the question of the relations of the individual to social solidarity. Why does the individual, while becoming more autonomous, depend more upon society? How can he be at once more individual and more solidary? Certainly, these two movements, contradictory as they appear, develop in parallel fashion. This is the problem we are raising. It appeared to us that what resolves this apparent antimony is a transformation of social solidarity due to the steadily growing development of the division of labour. That is how we have been led to make this the object of our study.'

Durkheim, *The Division of Labour in Society* (1893)

Durkheim argues that the change in the division of labour has had enormous implications for the structure of society. Durkheim was most interested in the changed way in which social solidarity is produced, in other words, the changed way in which society is held together and how its members see themselves as part of a whole. To capture this difference, Durkheim referred to two types of solidarity – mechanical and organic.

He argues that in pre-modern society the division of labour is relatively undeveloped. Agrarian production close to home is the prevailing way of life, and working relationships and other kinds of social dependence associated with it are also largely immediate, local and uncomplicated. The most typical trait of such primitive societies is their *segmentary* nature. Such societies consist of clearly delimited collectivities or clans, characterized by homogeneity and equality between individuals within these collectivities. Role specialization and division of labour are rudimentary – with the exception of some authority figures. Individuals have little or no autonomy within the group. The bond among people is that they

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are all engaged in similar activities and have similar responsibilities. However, in this form of society the division of labour is not in fact able on its own to provide enough in the way of social solidarity. The remainder comes from what Durkheim calls the *collective conscience*, 'the totality of beliefs and sentiments common to average citizens of the same society', which binds individuals together not so much in terms of their daily activity but of the religious and cultural beliefs, the social and political ideology, they share. **Mechanical solidarity** is the term Durkheim uses for the association of actors that emerges here. This is the dominant foundation of cohesion in simple societies where there is little differentiation. People may be similar in many respects – in terms of housing, occupation and the use of tools, clothing, customs, cuisine and lifestyle; they may be equal with regard to power; experience the same emotions, needs, and ideas, and hold similar moral and religious attitudes. The more primitive a society, the more similarity will these be on all these dimensions, and the more conspicuous is its mechanical solidarity. Such societies are characterized by collectivism.

We may note that Durkheim takes both material and nonmaterial aspects into account – shared ideas are as important as equality in material living conditions in primitive societies. A comprehensive, strong conscience collective is an essential characteristic of any primitive society. The conscience collective is basically religious in primitive societies. By religious Durkheim means possessing a strong sense of right and wrong, of what is sacred, and this is manifest in the form of all the various rules, rituals, and ceremonies that must be observed to show respect for the sacred. As a result of equality in material living conditions and customs, the intimacy of social life and the continuous reciprocal "surveillance" of behavior, and the intense conscience collective which demands respect for rules and all that is held sacred, there will be a strong reaction to any form of deviancy in primitive societies. Deviancy is often regarded as a religious offence.

On the other hand, there is a comprehensive division of labour in modern societies. Individuals engage in different, often highly specialized occupations. They are no longer so closely bound to groups marked by a large degree of internal equality and homogeneity. They can move within and between several social groups or circles, and no single group has the kind of irresistible power – typical of collectivities in primitive societies – to rigidly impose a particular way of life on the individual. This is the primary reason why individuals in modern societies necessarily develop in different directions. Differences of many kinds emerge between individuals, just as differences also emerge between professions and trades. And because so many differences emerge between individuals, groups, and occupations, many theorists in Durkheim's day thought that high levels of conflict were inevitable in modern societies. Solidarity or a sense of collectivity would be weakened as a result of the numerous conflicts of interest resulting from all the

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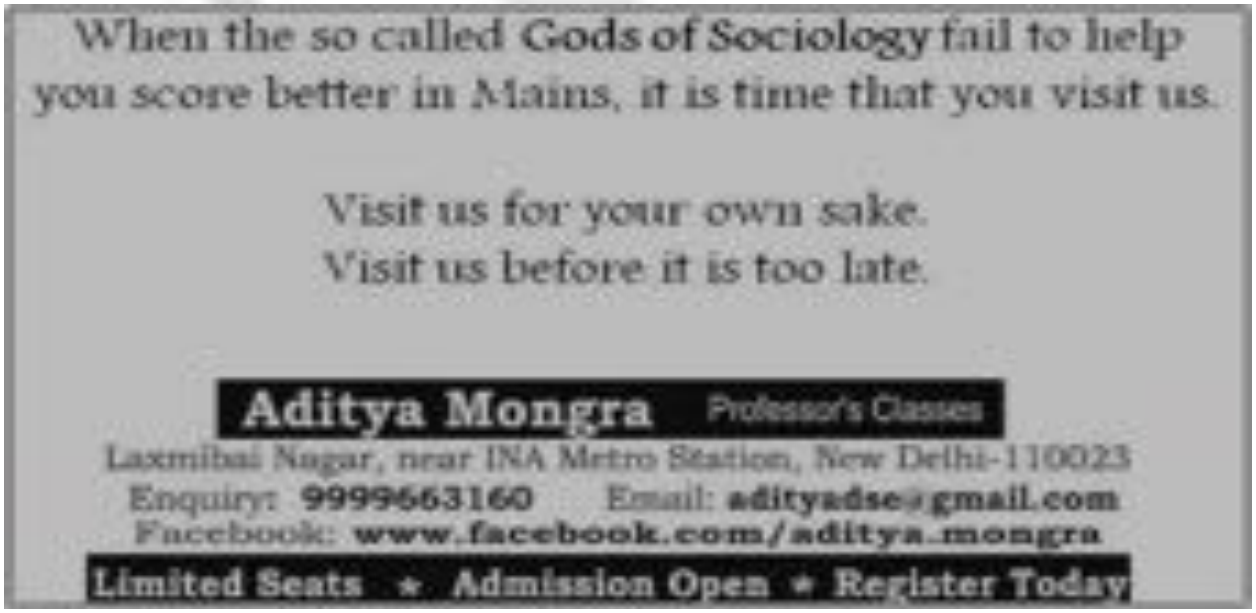
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differences. Durkheim, on the other hand, thought that in a modern society marked by increased division of labour, a specifically modern form of solidarity would emerge, which he calls **organic solidarity**.

In primitive societies, solidarity is a manifestation of "attraction through similarity." What type of attraction could possibly exist between people when similarity is replaced by numerous differences? Will these differences not rather give rise to conflict? Durkheim seeks to demonstrate that the many differences that develop as a corollary of modernization take a specific form: through occupational specialization, a large number of differences necessarily arise, but at the same time comprehensive *mutual dependency* is created between the many kinds of labour, and between individuals. The shoemaker dedicates al his working hours to making shoes, and thus simultaneously becomes dependent on others who produce the commodities he needs – clothes, tools, food, etc.. All producers are dependent on each other's products, and thus a complex dependency emerges. They complement one another, participating in a differentiated, coherent system, just as specialized organs function in a living organism (hence the term *organic* solidarity). For this reason, Durkheim also states that modern societies are "functionally integrated."
Modern society, in Durkheim's view, is thus held together by the specialization of people and their need for the services of many others. This specialization includes not only that of individuals but also of groups, structures, and institutions.

'The most remarkable effect of the division of labour is not that it increases the output of functions divided, but that it renders them solidary. Its role in all these cases is not simply to embellish or ameliorate existing societies, but to render societies possible which, without it, would not exist.'

Durkheim (1893)



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Durkheim further argued that primitive societies have a stronger collective conscience, that is, more shared understandings, norms and beliefs. The increasing division of labour has caused a diminution of the collective conscience. The collective conscience is of much less significance in a society with organic solidarity than it is in a society with mechanical solidarity. People in modern society are more likely to be held together by the division of labour and the resulting need for the functions performed by others than they are by a shared and powerful collective conscience. Nevertheless, even organic societies have a collective consciousness, albeit in a weaker form that allows for more individual differences.

Anthony Giddens points out that the collective conscience in the two types of society can be differentiated on four dimensions – volume, intensity, rigidity, and content. Volume refers to the number of people enveloped by the collective conscience; intensity, to how deeply the individuals feel about it; rigidity, to how clearly it is defined; and content, to the form that the collective conscience takes in the two types of society (see Table below).

THE FOUR DIMENSIONS OF THE COLLECTIVE CONSCIENCE

Solidarity	Volume	Intensity	Rigidity	Content
Mechanical	Entire Society	High	High	Religious
Organic	Particular Groups	Low	Low	Moral Individualism

Durkheim also argued that a society with mechanical solidarity is characterized by *repressive law*. Because people are very similar in this type of society, and because they tend to believe very strongly in a common morality, any offense against their shared value system is likely to be of significance to most individuals. Since everyone feels the offense and believes deeply in the common morality, a wrongdoer is likely to be punished severely for any action that offends the collective moral system. Theft might lead to the cutting off of the offender's hands; blaspheming might result in the removal of one's tongue. Even minor offenses against the moral system are likely to be met with severe punishment. In contrast, a society with organic solidarity is characterized by *restitutive law*, where offenders must make restitution for their crimes. In such societies, offenses are more likely to be seen as committed against a particular individual or segment of society than against the moral system itself. Because there is a weak common morality, most people do not react emotionally to a breach of the law. Instead of

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being severely punished for every offense against the collective morality, offenders in an organic society are likely to be asked to make restitution to those who have been harmed by their actions. Although some repressive law continues to exist in a society with organic solidarity (for example, the death penalty), restitutive law predominates, especially for minor offenses.

If Durkheim's theory was correct, modern society would normally have evolved relatively free of conflict. But Durkheim himself was aware of that antagonism and powerful conflicts were commonplace in the nineteenth century. He put this down to the fact that development had not occurred along "normal" lines, and attempted to explain this anomaly. He thought this was partly due to the persistence into modern society some old disparities of power and wealth – from feudalism, for instance – which were incompatible with the new order. He also argued that very rapid changes and adjustments in any given period do not allow the various elements of society time to adjust to one another.

In order to explain this anomaly between 'what ought to be' and 'what is', Durkheim makes a distinction between '***normal***' and '***pathological***' forms of division of labour. He called the above description as normal division of labour. While on the other hand, he explained the prevailing chaos and conflict of 19th century laissez-faire society, its wholly unregulated markets, extreme inequalities, etc. as the manifestations of the pathological or abnormal division of labour. He identified three abnormal forms, viz., anomic division of labour, forced division of labour, and poorly coordinated division of labour.

Anomie, in literal sense, implies 'normlessness.' Durkheim used the concept of *anomie* to refer to the breakdown of the normative regulation in a given society. The *anomic division of labour* refers to the lack of regulation in a society that celebrates isolated individuality and refrains from telling people what they should do. Durkheim further develops this concept of *anomie* in his work on suicide. In both works, he used the term to refer to those social conditions where humans lack sufficient moral constraint. For Durkheim, modern society is always prone to anomie, but it comes to the fore in times of social and economic crises. Without the strong common morality of mechanical solidarity, people might not have a clear concept of what is and what is not proper and acceptable behaviour. Even though the division of labour is a source of cohesion in modern society, it cannot entirely make up for the weakening of the common morality. Individuals can become isolated and be cut adrift in their highly specialized activities. They can more easily cease to feel a common bond with those who work and live around them. This gives rise to anomie. Organic solidarity is prone to this particular pathology, but it is important to remember that Durkheim saw this as an abnormal situation. The modern division of labour has the capacity to promote increased moral

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interactions rather than reducing people to isolated and meaningless tasks and positions.

While Durkheim believed that people needed rules and regulation to tell them what to do, his second abnormal form pointed to a kind of rule that could lead to conflict and isolation and therefore increase anomie. He called this the *forced division of labour*. This second pathology refers to the fact that outdated norms and expectations can force individuals, groups, and classes into positions for which they are ill suited. Traditions, economic power, or status can determine who performs what jobs regardless of talent and qualification. [It is here that Durkheim comes closest to a Marxist position. However, Durkheim did not elabourate in detail on the fundamental causes for the extreme economic inequalities prevailing in the modern industrial societies of Europe in those times, as Marx did in terms of the ownership and non-ownership of the forces of production. Moreover, Durkheim saw this only as an aberration of the industrial society, occurring only in an abnormal situation.]

Under the heading of the forced division of labour, Durkheim discusses those socially structured inequalities which undermine solidarity. Durkheim explicitly recognizes that class inequalities restrict the opportunities of the lower classes and prevent the realization of their abilities. Resentment accumulates and men are led to revolutionary thoughts. The problem here is not lack of rules but rather the excess of them in that rules themselves are the cause of evil. The rules have in fact arisen in order to enforce the division of labour coercively. Individual specialism and occupations are not freely chosen but forced upon each person by custom, law and even sheer chance. Individuals find themselves estranged, resentful and aspiring to social positions which have been arbitrarily closed off to them. The forced division of labour then brings about a situation which one modern author has called the *anomie of injustice*. It is this which has produced class conflict and not, as Marx would have it, the inherently exploitative nature of capitalism. Nor, did Durkheim consider that all inequality could be abolished. But whereas some inequalities are 'natural' and occur spontaneously, others are external inequality and can be mitigated. What in effect he is urging is the creation of what today is called 'equality of opportunity' or a meritocracy. For this to be possible all forms of hereditary privilege should be abolished.

Finally, the third form of abnormal division of labour is where the specialized functions performed by different people are *poorly coordinated*. Again Durkheim makes the point that organic solidarity flows from the interdependence of the people. If people's specializations do not result in increased interdependence but simply in isolation, the division of labour will not result in social solidarity.

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Durkheim argued that for the division of labour to function as a moral and socially solidifying force in modern society, anomie, the forced division of labour, and the improper coordination of specialization must be addressed. Durkheim suggested a few broad guidelines to address the problems arising out of the abnormal or pathological division of labour. Please remember that this was essentially a speculative exercise, not based on any empirical research.

Durkheim argued that the conscience collective and religion would become less and less significant in a functionally differentiated society, due to the differences between people. With increasing differentiation in working and social life, as well as the weakening of the conscience collective as a binding force, modern society would be characterized by individualism. When individualism gains too much strength, it has the effect of destroying solidarity. To avoid total disruption, individualism must be counteracted through the development of new institutional bonds between people. There is some uncertainty on this point in Durkheim's theory. Because he views society as a self-regulating system, he assumes that such a correction of individualism will emerge naturally and spontaneously. On the other hand, however, he is also interested in finding practical measures that might restrain rampant individualism. He thought the family had too limited an importance in modern society to constitute an effective counterweight. Nor did he believe in the socialist notion that a powerful state would be adequate. According to Durkheim, the state was too distant from everyday social life to be capable of having any decisive moral effect on the collectivity.

In several works after 1893 he suggested certain measures: for instance, he advocated establishing new types of organization in the economic sector – so-called corporations, which had certain similarities with the medieval guild system. The point was that those involved in a certain kind of occupation, employers and employees alike, should unite in a national organization. He thought this would lead to the development of solidarity between actors, and thus counteract the tendencies toward ruthless competition and individualism. He cites the example of professional organizations, such as lawyers' organizations, which create professional ethics governing their work. According to him, this would go a long way in controlling the anomic state of professional, industrial, and commercial life. He also thought school reforms, in the shape of new syllabuses and modes of cooperation, might restrain individualism. If children were educated in the spirit of solidarity at school, they would develop social habits that would also be important in adulthood. He also suggested restrictions on the right to divorce.

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Many commentators have pointed to a tendency in the development of Durkheim's theories: early in his career, he expressed a strong belief in society's ability to develop solidarity and unity spontaneously. Later, he came to accentuate more and more the need for active political and moral regulation of social life, especially in the economic sphere. Eventually, he concluded that the basic principles of the modern market economy largely nurtured competition and egoism, and that the economy therefore had to be actively regulated in order to ensure widespread solidarity. We could not just wait for solidarity to evolve "naturally."

Later, Durkheim also modified his previously negative judgment of individualism. He reached the perception that individualism was not necessarily the same as egoism and the radical destruction of social bonds. It became clear to him that modern societies could not be based on a strictly collectivist ethos. The problems associated with the division of functions and specialization in modern societies could be solved only by assuming values and relations that took a high level of individualism for granted. He thought a more positive and more valuable type of individualism, one distinct from egoism, was in the process of emerging. This he termed *moral individualism*. The autonomy of the individual is fundamental, but this autonomy also involves the capacity for moral reflection, and moral obligations. Given the correct form of socialization and the development of social relations, *modern* individualists would be able to strike a balance between individual independence and social bonding.

In other words, rather than driving a wedge between individuals and society the advanced division of labour gives rise to new kinds of individuals and endorses the strong notion of individuality. Modern society, just like modern industry, needs 'modern' individuals, just as individuals who want to behave in modern ways and to express modern attitudes and beliefs need an advanced division of labour where they can be expressed. The division of labour serves to reconcile the individual with society.

As Durkheim sees it, 'the problem of the individual' in modern society is that politicians and other intellectuals have been slow to recognize the emergence of this new kind of individualism. Like many other social critics, Durkheim believes that the earlier conception of 'acquisitive individualism' in which individuals are seen as selfish, egoistic and aggressively competitive, which had been popularised by utilitarian philosophers like Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill, and liberal economists like Adam Smith and David Ricardo, had to be set aside. Utilitarian conceptions of competitive individualism were being superseded by a new and properly socialized conception. This is moral individualism, in which

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individuals are seen as an embodiment of the core virtue of doing things for the common good.

The strength of modern individuality is not measured in terms of how much it promotes the selfish and egoistic interests of any particular individual, but in terms of the contribution the individual makes to the collective social body, that is, to society. Indeed, Durkheim goes so far as to suggest that the new cult of the individual becomes a central facet of the *conscience collective* of modern society. Just as it is the duty of the individual to work towards the social good, it is the function of society to provide individuals with fruitful opportunities to express themselves in as many ways as possible. The key point to grasp is that individuality and social opportunity cannot be separated one from the other.


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Dear Candidate, let us now assess Durkheim's study of division of labour both, in terms of its contribution to social theory as well as the criticisms it invited.

The key theme in Durkheim's sociological theory, the major theoretical issue he is concerned with throughout his work, is that of ***the relationship of the individual to society***. In this book-length investigation, Durkheim analyses the individual-versus-society issue in terms of the different kinds of social solidarity that hold society and individuals together. One of the advantages of linking the individual-versus-society debate explicitly with the question of social solidarity is that it allows Durkheim to argue that developments in the demands of individuals and of modern notions of individuality, are actually complimented by changes in the nature of society rather than being in opposition to them. Durkheim sees the emergence of modern individuals, and of modern notions of individuality, as an inevitable corollary of the advanced division of labour in society.

Durkheim's study of division of labour, though to an extent speculative, but proved to be a landmark study as it was for the first time that the social significance of division of labour was explored in such a comprehensive manner. As stated earlier that prior to him division of labour was studied only in terms of its economic consequences. Durkheim was one of the first sociologists to explore the social dimension of division of labour. In this study he explained that how with increase in the division of labour new forms of solidarity emerge in society to provide for its cohesiveness and stability. This finding opened new vistas of research in social sciences. It initiated a number of studies which attempted to explore that how and to what extent the experience at work can also have social implications. So much so that it gave rise to an altogether new branch of knowledge called *Sociology of Occupations and Professions*.

For example, Elton Mayo, a professor at the Harvard Business School, in his investigation (from 1927-1932) at the Hawthorne plant of the Western Electric Company in Chicago, found out that the 'sense of belongingness' to a social group is as important for a worker as the economic rewards. Mayo began with the assumptions of scientific management believing that the physical conditions of the work environment, the aptitude of the worker and financial incentives were the main determinants of productivity. The theory of scientific management was first spelt out in detail by Frederick W. Taylor whose book, *The Principles of Scientific Management* was published in America in 1911. Taylor assumed that man's primary motivation for work was financial. He argued that by increasing the monetary incentives paid to the worker, the productivity too can be maximized. In practice this usually involved a wage incentive scheme based on piece work – payment according to the amount of work done. Taylor believed that the scientific planning of work tasks, the selection and systematic training of suitable workers

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for the performance of those tasks plus a carrot and stick system of financial incentives would maximize productivity. On the contrary, Mayo in his study found that the behaviour of the worker was largely a response to group norms rather than simply being directed by economic incentives. Most of the workers belonged to one or the other informal group. The researchers discovered that the workers had established a norm which defined a fair day's work, and that this norm, rather than standards set by management, determined their output. From the Hawthorne studies, and research which they largely stimulated, developed the human relations school. It stated that scientific management provided too narrow a view of man and that financial incentives alone were insufficient to motivate workers and ensure their cooperation.

However, though a remarkable study, Durkheim's study of division of labour also came under criticism on several accounts.

Firstly, the concept of *conscience collective* as a common and determinate system of shared beliefs and sentiments was criticized on various accounts by other scholars. For Durkheim, the reality of society preceded the individual life. Durkheim frequently, especially in discussions on the collective conscience, reached a degree of sociological realism that seemed to deny altogether the social significance of individual volition or decision. Society is real, to be true, but so is the individual. And the two, it should be remembered, are always in interaction. Giving priority to one over the other is misleading in the long run.

Further, conflict theorists also argued, on Marxian lines, that modern industrial society is characterized by class divisions and extreme economic inequalities. Given the pluralistic character of modern society it is difficult to conceive of an all encompassing and shared value system which is based on consensus of all its members. Rather they argue that such collective conscience is nothing but a reflection of the values of the dominant classes in society. The values of the dominant classes are imposed on masses either by indoctrination through education and religion, or by coercion. In other words, it implies that the ideas and aspirations of the subaltern groups may find no representation in such body of belief systems.

Secondly, anti-positivist scholars also question the concepts of collective conscience and social facts. They argue that human behaviour is a meaningful behaviour, guided by meanings, motives and values. By defining collective conscience in terms of an all embracing and determinate system and according primacy to groups over the individual has somehow subordinated the individual conscience to that of collectivity. Further, by focusing on the exteriority dimension

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and empirical study of the social facts, Durkheim leaves no room for the interpretative understanding of human behaviour.

Thirdly, conflict theorists also question the suggestion offered by Durkheim of state intervention in regulating the economy in order to address the problem of abnormal division of labour. Durkheim believed that the state, being an executive organ of the conscience collective, would work for the welfare of all sections of the society. However, conflict theorists argue that state is nothing but an executive organ of only the dominant classes and would only further their interests.

Fourthly, conflict theorists also criticize Durkheim's theory for its conservative outlook. They argue that there is a built-in conservative bias in Durkheim's theory. By repeatedly emphasizing on the normative regulation and collective morality, Durkheim focus was primarily on explaining maintenance and sustenance of the stability and social order in society. Conflict theorists argue that Durkheim failed to account for conflict and conflict led change as Marx did.

Fifthly, some scholars also argue that the solutions offered by Durkheim to address the problems of abnormal division of labour are overly simplified. For example, Durkheim explained the anomic division of labour in terms of the breakdown of the normative regulation in the society. As if by restoring the normative regulation alone all problems associated with the increase in division of labour could be addressed. These scholars argue that there are certain inherent problems associated with the increase in division of labour such as de-skilling, fragmentation of work, alienation, etc., which Durkheim did not take elaborated upon.

Further, there are also some problems with the Durkheim's view of the individual. Despite having made a number of crucial assumptions about human nature, Durkheim denied that he had done so. He argued that he did not begin by postulating a certain conception of human nature in order to deduce sociology from it. Instead, he said that it was from sociology that he sought an increasing understanding of human nature. However, Durkheim may have been less than honest with his readers, and perhaps even with himself.

One of Durkheim's assumptions about human nature is that people are impelled by their passions into a mad search for gratification that always leads to a need for more. If these passions are unrestrained, they multiply to the point where the individual is enslaved by them and they become a threat to the individual as well as to society. It can be argued that Durkheim's entire theoretical edifice, especially his emphasis on collective morality, was erected on this basic assumption about people's passions. However, Durkheim provides no evidence for

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this assumption, and indeed, his own theories would suggest that such an insatiable subject may be a creation of social structures rather than the other way around.

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The Rules of Sociological Method (1895)

The Rules of Sociological Method was Durkheim's second major work. It was published in 1895 while he was at the University of Bordeaux. Largely a methodological study, the primary aim of this study was to outline the nature of sociological subject matter and to set out the steps of sociological investigation. As discussed earlier, Durkheim described 'social facts' in term of their exteriority, generality and constraint. He further argued that social facts are amenable to be studied by methods of positive sciences. Some of the important observations of Durkheim with regard to the scientific procedure to be adopted while studying social facts have been listed below:

i) Rules for the Observation of Social Facts

- Durkheim said that social facts must be treated as '*things*.' As 'things' they have to be studied by the empirical method and not by intuition.

- While studying social facts as 'things' all preconceptions must be eradicated. Sociologists must emancipate themselves from the common place ideas that dominate the mind of the layperson and adopt an emotionally neutral attitude towards what they set out to investigate.

- Observation of social facts should be confined to their external attributes only which can be tested and verified.

  In other words, when sociologists undertake the investigation of some order of social facts they must consider them from an aspect that is independent of their individual manifestations. The objectivity of social facts depends on their being separated from individual facts, which express them. Social facts provide a common standard for members of the society. Social facts exist in the form of legal rules, moral regulations, proverbs, social conventions, etc. It is these that sociologists must study to gain an understanding of social life.

- The observation and study of social facts should be as definite as possible. Here, Durkheim insisted upon the clear definition of the range or area of observation. This would ensure that knowledge about social facts can be progressively ever more exact.

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ii) Rules for Distinguishing between the Normal and the Pathological Social Facts

Having given us rules for the observation of social facts, Durkheim makes a distinction between 'normal' and 'pathological' social facts. He considers these aspects important because, as he points out, the scientific study of human beings has been held back to a large degree by the tendency of many writers to consider as 'pathological' forms of behaviour, which were different from their own. But Durkheim explains that the social fact is considered to be normal when it is understood in the context of the society in which it exists. He further adds that a social fact, which is 'general' to a given type of society, is 'normal' when it has utility for that societal type. In other words, this means that a normal social fact shall also be functional in the society in which it exists, while an abnormal or a pathological social fact shall have harmful consequences for the society.

As an illustration he cites the case of crime. We consider crime as pathological. But Durkheim argues that though we may refer to crime as immoral because it flouts values we believe in, from a scientific viewpoint it would be incorrect to call it abnormal. Firstly because crime is present not only in the majority of societies of one particular type but in all societies of all types. Secondly, if there were not occasional deviances or floutings of norms, there would be no change in human behaviour and equally important, no opportunities through which a society can either reaffirm the existing norms, or else reassess such behaviour and modify the norm itself. To show that crime is useful to the normal evolution of morality and law, Durkheim cites the case of Socrates, who according to Athenian law was a criminal, his crime being the independence of his thought. But his crime rendered a service to his country because it served to prepare a new morality and faith, which the Athenians needed. It also rendered a service to humanity in the sense that freedom of thought enjoyed by people in many countries today was made possible by people like him.

Durkheim was impressed by the way study of medicine had become scientific. The doctors study the normal working of the body and its pathological features. The study of both of these features helps one identify the nature of the body. He applied this method to study social facts. In his study of division of labour in society, he explained both, the normal as well as the abnormal features. He considered crime and punishment both as normal.

How is a social fact normal? When the rate of crime exceeds what is more or less constant for a given social type, then it becomes an abnormal or pathological fact. Similarly, using the same criteria, suicide is a normal social fact (though it may be regarded as 'wrong' or 'immoral' because it goes against a set of values that makes preservation of life absolute). But the sudden rise in the suicide rate in

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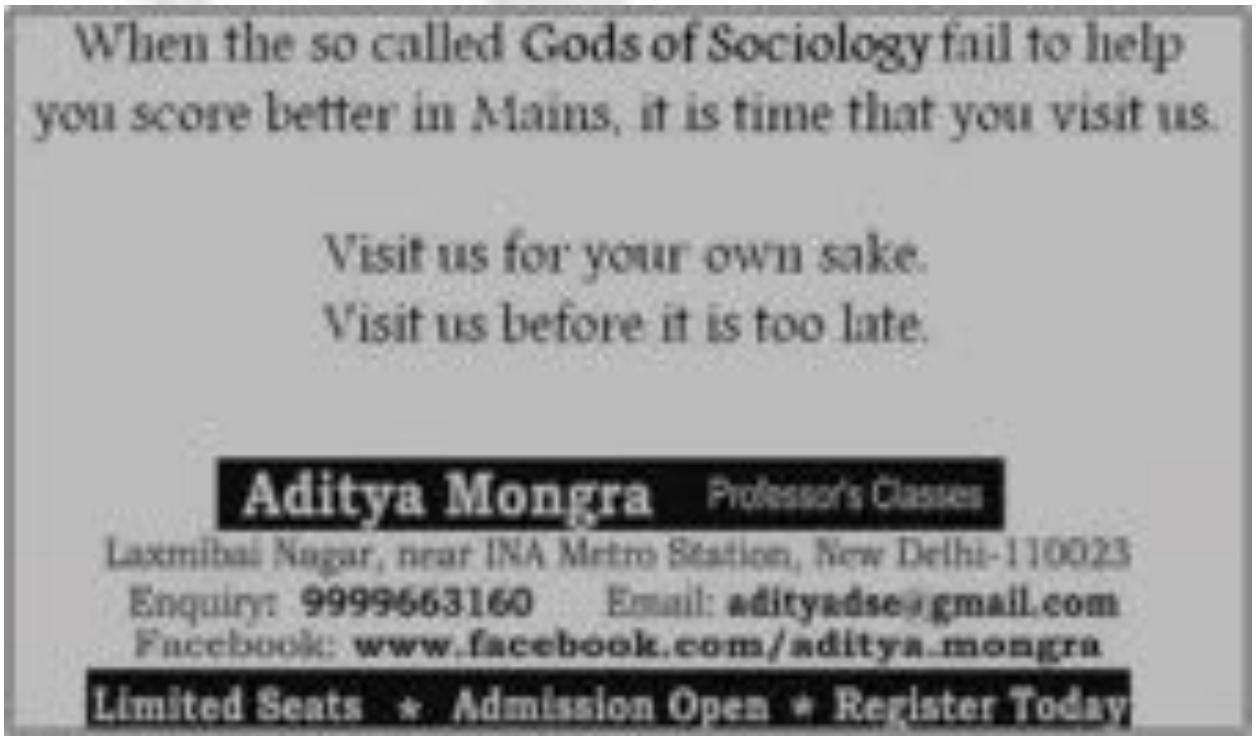
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Western Europe during the nineteenth century was a cause for concern for Durkheim and one of the reasons why he decided to study this phenomenon.

iii) Rules for the Classification of Social Types

There have been two opposing conceptions of collective life among scholars. Some historians hold that each society is unique and so we cannot compare societies. On the other hand philosophers hold that all societies belong to one species - the human species and it is from the general attributes of human nature that all social evolution flows. Durkheim takes an intermediary position. He speaks of social species or social types. Though there is so much of diversity in social facts, it does not mean that they cannot be treated scientifically i.e. compared, classified and explained. If on the other hand, we speak of only one species we will be missing out in important qualitative differences and it will be impossible to draw them together.

Classification of societies into types is an important step towards explanation as problems and their explanations will differ for each type. It is also needed to decide whether a social fact is normal or abnormal, since a social fact is normal or abnormal only in relation to a given social type. Thus Durkheim attempts to outline a system for classifying societies according to their structure and complexity, a process Durkheim referred to as 'social morphology.' Durkheim advocated the use of *comparative method* to classify societies into a typology. He himself presented one based on the type of solidarity, viz., mechanical and organic solidarity.



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iv) Rules for the Explanation of Social Facts

There are two approaches, which may be used in the explanation of social facts - the causal and the functional. The former is concerned with explaining 'why' the social phenomenon in question exists. The latter involves explaining the functions the social phenomenon in question performs for the existence and stability of the society as a whole. In other words, functional explanation involves explaining the social phenomenon in terms of the needs it fulfils of the given social type.

Let us take an example of 'punishment' from the same work. Crime offends collective sentiments in a society, while the function of punishment is to maintain these sentiments at the same degree of intensity. If offences against them were not punished, the strength of the sentiments necessary for social unity would not be preserved. (It may be pointed out here that functionalism which was dominant in Sociology, particularly in the USA in the 1940s and 50s owes a lot to Durkheim's conception of function)

Durkheim further argues that since the subject matter of sociology has a social character, it is collective in nature, the explanation should also have a social character. Durkheim draws a sharp line between individual and society. Society is a separate reality from the individuals who compose it. It has its own characteristics. There exists a line between psychology and sociology. Any attempt to explain social facts directly in terms of individual characteristics or in terms of psychology would make the explanation false. Therefore in the case of causal explanation "the determining cause of a social fact should be sought among the social facts preceding it and not among the states of the individual consciousness". In the case of functional explanation, "the function of a social fact ought always to be sought in its relation to some social end."

The final point about Durkheim's logic of explanation is his stress upon the comparative nature of social science. To show that a given fact is the cause of another "we have to compare cases in which they are simultaneously present or absent, to see if the variations they present in these different combinations of circumstances indicate that one depends on the other." According to Durkheim, experimentation is the crucial method for testing theories in science. However, experimentation is not possible in sociology. Therefore, the comparative method is the closest alternative to experimentation, for testing sociological explanations. Since sociologists normally do not conduct labouratory-controlled experiments but study reported facts or go to the field and observe social facts, which have been spontaneously produced, they use the method of indirect experiment or the comparative method. The comparative method must be based upon the principle of concomitant variations. The comparative method is the very framework of the science of society for Durkheim. According to Durkheim, "comparative sociology

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is not a particular branch of sociology; it is sociology itself, in-so-far as it ceases to be purely descriptive and aspires to account for fact."

As can be seen from the above discussion, Durkheim, in order to establish sociology as a distinct scientific discipline, takes an extreme stance. This is reflected in his advocacy of positive science methodology to study social facts and, the definition of social facts in itself reflects his extreme sociological realism position. However, the positivists' emphasis on explaining a social phenomenon exclusively on the basis of its outwardly observable characteristics ignores the human side of social behaviour. This view fails to take into account the subjective dimension of human behaviour manifested in the unique meanings, choices and motives of an individual.


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Suicide (1897)

Suicide was Durkheim's third book which was published in 1897. In broad historical terms, there are several reasons why Durkheim took up the theme of suicide when he did. First, suicide was a growing social problem in Europe by 1850 and many felt that it was associated with the development of industrial society. Industrialization had advanced individualism, accelerated social fragmentation, and weakened the social bonds tying individuals to society. Second, industrial society had made economic institutions dominant over other social institutions and this served to place individual self-interest and economic gain over the collective forces of society. As individual autonomy and political freedoms increased, the individual became the center of social life and this served to reduce the level of social restraint and to call into question the nature of collective social purposes. Third, the political crisis of the Dreyfus affair in 1894 was a serious blow to French national unity and drew attention to how much social fragmentation and egoistic forces had replaced the collective authority of society. This led Durkheim to believe that the theme of social dissolution brought about by industrial society could be examined sociologically by looking at the mechanisms in society which link individuals to social purposes outside themselves. Fourth, factual evidence made available by comparative mortality data from different societies linked suicide to social factors such as industrial change, occupation, family life and religion, and this served to focus attention on society and social institutions rather than on complex psychological factors. Durkheim found that the statistical data contained in the records of suicidal deaths for the period could be categorized according to age, religion, sex, occupation, military service and marital status, and this led directly to a search for the role played by social factors in the cause of suicide. Overall, Durkheim studied the records of 26,000 suicides, and his colleague, Marcel Mauss, helped assemble the maps contained in the study and aided in compiling the statistical tables on suicidal deaths relating to age and marital status.

One of the primary aims Durkheim had in pursuing a social theory of suicide was to look for the social causes of suicide within the existing framework of society rather than looking at the psychological states of individuals who take their own lives. This shift in perspective from a psychological to a sociological theory of suicide was disconcerting for many, and perhaps the best way to understand this shift is to look at the problem of suicide prior to Durkheim's work. At the time Durkheim began his study, suicide was largely treated as a nervous disorder and its causes were believed to derive from the psychological states of individuals. Many believed that suicide was the result of mental illness, depression, sudden tragedy, reversal of fortune and even personal setbacks and bankruptcy. In this light, suicide was seen by many as the result of a weak disposition and a psychological response

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to the burdens of life. Durkheim, however, called these views into question by shifting the focus from individual motives and psychological states to social causes in at least two distinct ways. First, by stating that the social causes of suicide precede individual causes, Durkheim eliminated the need to look at the various forms suicide assumed in individuals, including depression, personal setbacks, and psychiatric disorders. Second, in focusing his attention on the various social environments to which the individual was connected, including the family group, the religious group and the national group, Durkheim eliminated the necessity of looking at individual disposition or personality. He put this clearly when he pointed out that 'the causes of death are outside rather than within us, and are effective only if we venture into their sphere of activity.'

Durkheim defined Suicide as '*all cases of death resulting directly or indirectly from a positive or negative act of the victim himself, which he knows will produce this result*.'

Suicide is cited as a monumental landmark in which conceptual theory and empirical research are brought together. He used considerable statistical ingenuity considered remarkable for his times. His use of statistical analysis was for two primary reasons: (1) to refute theories based on psychology, biology, genetics, climatic, and geographical factors, and (2) to support with empirical evidence his own sociological explanation of suicide. In this study, Durkheim displayed an extreme form of sociological realism. He speaks of *suicidal currents* as collective tendencies that dominate some very susceptible individuals and catch them up in their sweep. The act of suicide at times, Durkheim believed, is interpreted as a product of these currents. Durkheim rejected the various extra-social factors such as heredity, climate, mental alienation, racial characteristics and imitation as the cause of suicide and arrived at the conclusion that suicide which appears to be a phenomenon relating to the individual is actually explicable aetiologically with reference to the social structure and its ramifying functions which may (a) induce, (b) perpetuate, or (c) aggravate the suicide potential.

Durkheim's central thesis is that suicide rate is a factual order, unified and definite, for each society has a collective inclination towards suicide, a rate of self-homicide which is fairly constant for each society so long as the basic conditions of its existence remain the same. No complete understanding of Durkheim's assertion that suicide had social causes is possible without looking at the concept of the '*social suicide rate*'. Durkheim arrived at the concept of the social suicide rate after a careful examination of the mortality data which had been obtained from public records of societies such as France, Germany, England, Denmark and Austria. These records contained information about cause of death, age, marital background, religion and the total number of deaths by suicide of the country from

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which they were gathered. The 'social suicide rate,' therefore, was a term used by Durkheim to refer to the number of suicidal deaths in a given society and the extent to which the 'suicide rates' themselves could be looked upon as establishing a pattern of suicide for a given society. But, what does this mean in relation to individual suicide? As we stated earlier, theories of suicide prevalent at the time had looked at individual motives and psychological causes. Suicide, many believed, was the desperate act of an individual who did not care to live or who could not face life's burdens. From this perspective, suicide was seen as an individual act dependent on factors which could only be explained psychologically.

Durkheim, however, took a completely different approach. Rather than looking at individual motives or psychological states, he began by looking at the 'social suicide rate' that existed in different countries. What he wanted to find out was whether individual suicides committed in a given society could be taken together as a whole and studied collectively. Durkheim's central question then was can the collective rates for a given society be studied independently of individual suicide? In order, therefore, to establish a theoretical footing, Durkheim began to look at the total number of suicidal deaths contained in public records of countries such as France, Germany, England and Denmark. The suicide rates for these countries had been collected between 1841 and 1872, and they contained a substantial amount of information related to social factors of suicide such as marital status, religion, occupation and military service.

After studying the rates, Durkheim made several key observations. First, he noticed that the rates varied from society to society. For example, they were higher in Germany in comparison to Italy; lower in Denmark in comparison to England and so on. Second, he observed that between 1841 and 1872, the number of suicidal deaths in each of the countries did not change dramatically and were considered to be stable. For example, between 1841-42 the number of suicidal deaths in France were 2814 and 2866 respectively; whereas in Germany for the same years they were 1630 and 1598. As far as Durkheim was concerned, the stability of the rates within a given society was crucial since it meant that each society not only produced a 'quota of suicidal deaths' but that certain social forces were operating to produce what Durkheim saw as the 'yearly precision of rates.' This turned out to be decisive because when considered collectively, the rates pointed in the direction of underlying social causes. This led Durkheim to reason that the predisposing cause of suicide lay not within the psychological motives of the individual but within the social framework of society. Third, the observed stability of the rates meant that each society was a distinct social environment with different social characteristics, different religions, different patterns of family life, different military obligations and thus different suicide characteristics. Under these circumstances, each produced rate of suicidal deaths distinct from the other.

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Fourth, when compared to the mortality rate, Durkheim noticed that the suicide rate demonstrated a far greater consistency than did the general mortality rate, which fluctuated randomly.

As a result, Durkheim drew three fundamental conclusions which turned on the question of the stability of the rates. First, he believed that the stability of the rates showed that, while individual motives for suicide vary from case to case, the regularity exhibited by the social suicide rate was consistently stable. Second, though the rates varied between societies, the stability of the rates within a particular society meant that each society produces a 'quota of suicidal deaths'. Third, Durkheim took the position that the social suicide rate must represent a 'factual order' that is separate from individual disposition and, therefore, he thought it had a regularity which could be studied in its own right. In that the 'social suicide rate' is independent of individual suicide and has a stability of its own, it should therefore be the subject of a special study whose purpose would be to discover the social causes leading to a definite number of people that take their own lives in a given society.

Durkheim believed that the social suicide rate was the clearest evidence he had for a social theory of suicide since what a study of the social suicide rate had established was that different societies had different suicide rates, and that these rates changed very little over time within any given society. For example, between 1841 and 1842 France had 2866 suicides while Germany had 1598 suicides. He went on to reason that if suicide were entirely the result of individual causes and individual psychology, it would be difficult to explain why the French would be almost twice as likely to commit suicide in comparison with the Germans. Durkheim then reasoned that once we shift the focus from the study of individual suicides to the study of the 'collective suicide rate' – France's suicide rate in relation to Germany's suicide rate – it became apparent that the collective rates pointed in the direction of underlying social causes, which in turn indicated fundamental differences in the social framework that caused France to have 2866 suicides each year, while Germany had only 1598.

Durkheim's theory of suicide is divided into two explanatory sections. In the first, Durkheim explains suicide by drawing on the concept of **social integration**, referring to the strength of the social bonds existing between the individual and society. In this case, **egoistic** and **altruistic** suicide form opposite poles of social integration. In the second part of the theory, Durkheim explained suicide by drawing on the concept of **social regulation**. Social regulation, in contrast to integration, refers to the restraints imposed by society on individual needs and wants and generally manifests itself through regulatory requirements that are imposed by society on individuals when their social needs and wants begin to

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exceed the means they have for attaining them. In the case of social regulation, **anomic** and **fatalistic** suicide form opposite poles in relation to the changes in the regulatory functions of industrial society that may lead to shifts in the suicide rate. Let us now discuss about these types of suicide in detail.

Egoistic Suicide: Egoistic suicide results from the lack of integration of the individual into his social group. Durkheim studied varying degrees of integration of individuals into their religion, family, political and national communities, and found that the stronger the forces throwing the individuals on to their own resources, the greater the suicide rate in society. For example, regardless of race and nationality, Catholics show far less suicides than Protestants. This is because, while both faiths prohibit suicide, Catholicism is able to integrate its members more fully into its fold. Protestantism fosters spirit of free inquiry, permits greater individual freedom, multiplies schism, lacks hierarchic organizations and has fewer common beliefs and practices. Catholicism, on the other hand, is an idealistic religion which accepts faith readymade, without scrutiny, has a hierarchical system of authority and prohibits variation. Thus "the superiority of Protestantism with respect to suicide results from its being a less strongly integrated church than the Catholic church."

Family, like religious group, is a powerful counter agent against suicide. Non-marriage increases the tendency to suicide, while marriage reduces the danger by half or more. This immunity even increases with the density of the family. In other words, contrary to the popular belief that suicide is due to life's burdens, Durkheim insists that it diminishes as these burdens increase. Small families are unstable and short-lived; their sentiments and consciences lack intensity. But large families are more solidly integrated and act as powerful safeguards against suicide. Again, contrary to the common belief that great political upheavals increase the number of suicides, Durkheim contends that great social disturbances and popular wars rouse collective sentiments, stimulate patriotism and national faith, and force men to close ranks and confront the danger, leading to a more powerful integration of the individual into his community, thus reducing the rate of suicide.

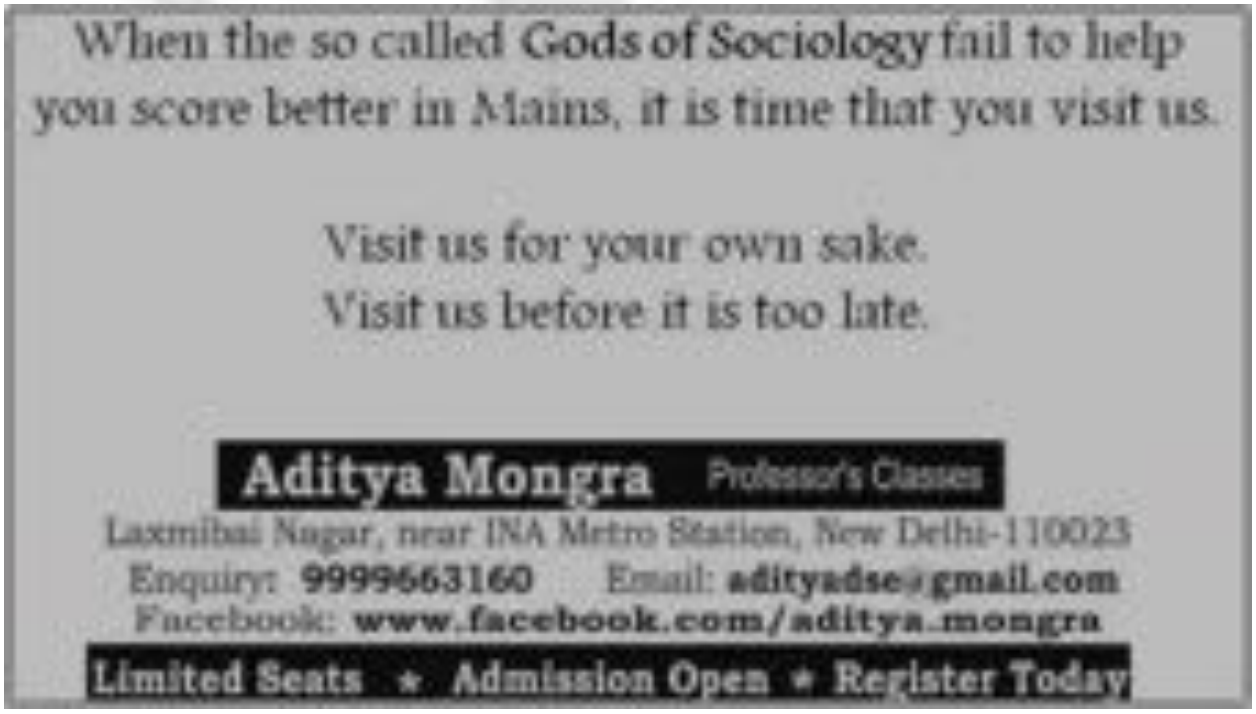
Altruistic Suicide: Altruistic suicide results from the over-integration of the individual into his social group. An individual's life is so rigorously governed by custom and habit that he takes his own life because of higher commandments. Examples are legion: women throwing themselves at the funeral pyre of their husbands (known as *sati* in India); Danish warriors killing themselves in old age; the Goths jumping to their death from high pinnacles to escape the ignominy of natural death; suicide of followers and servants on the death of their chiefs. As opposed to these obligatory altruistic suicides, there are optional varieties which do not require suicide but praise self-sacrifice or ultimate self-renunciation as a noble

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and praiseworthy act. Japanese Harakiri, self-immolation by Buddhist monks, self-homicide by army suicide squads and self-destruction in Nirvana under Brahminic influence (as in the case of ancient Hindu sages) illustrate other variants of altruistic suicide.

Durkheim believed that his analysis of military suicide lent support to his conclusion. He rejected the popular conception which attributes military suicide to the hardships of military life, disciplinary rigor and lack of liberty. While with longer service men might be expected to become accustomed to barrack life, their commitment to the army and aptitude for suicide seem to increase. While military life is much less hard for officers than for private soldiers, the former accounts for greater suicide rates than the latter. Above all, volunteers and re-enlisted men who choose military as a career are more inclined to commit suicide than men drafted against their will. This proves that where altruistic suicide is prevalent, man is always ready to sacrifice his life for a great cause, principle or a value.



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Anomic Suicide: Anomic suicide results from normlessness or deregulation in society. Although this kind of suicide occurs during industrial or financial crises, it is not because they cause poverty, since crises of prosperity have the same result, but because they are crises of the collective order. Every disturbance of social equilibrium whether on account of sudden prosperity or instant misfortune, results in a deregulation and a greater impulse to voluntary death. Durkheim attributed anomic suicide to unlimited aspirations and the breakdown of regulatory norms. Man's aspirations have consistently increased since the beginnings of history. There is nothing in man's organic structure or his psychological constitution which can regulate his overweening ambitions. Social desires can be regulated only by a moral force. Durkheim views the collective order as the only moral force that can effectively restrain the social and moral needs. However, occasionally this mechanism breaks down and normlessness ensues.

Thus any abrupt transitions such as economic disaster, industrial crisis or sudden prosperity can cause a deregulation of the normative structure. That is why, Durkheim reasons, anomie is a chronic state of affairs in the modern socio-economic system. Sudden changes upset the societal scale instantly but a new scale cannot be immediately improvised. Collective conscience requires time to reclassify men and things. During such periods of transition there is no restraint on aspirations which continue to rise unbridled. "The state of deregulation or anomie is thus further heightened by passions being less disciplined, precisely when they need more disciplining." Overweening ambition and the race for unattainable goals continue to heighten anomie.

In analyzing the consequences of anomie, Durkheim showed that there was a high rate of anomic suicide among those who are wealthy as well as among divorced persons. Sudden upward changes in the standard of living or the breakup of a marriage throws life out of gear and puts norms in a flux. Like economic anomie, domestic anomie resulting from the death of husband or wife is also the result of a catastrophe that upsets the scale of life. Durkheim also points to a number of factors that contributed to anomie in modern society. "Economic progress has largely freed industrial relations from all regulation, and there is no moral strong enough to exercise control in the sphere of trade and industry. Furthermore, religion has lost most of its power. And government, instead of regulating economic life, has become its tool and servant."

Fatalistic Suicide: There is a little mentioned fourth type of suicide – fatalistic – that Durkheim discussed only in a footnote in *Suicide*. Whereas anomic suicide is more likely to occur in situations in which regulation is too weak, fatalistic suicide is more likely to occur when regulation is excessive. While Durkheim had little to say about the characteristics of fatalistic suicide, he cited as an example the suicide

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of slaves who, seeing no alternative to life except enslavement under a master, take their own life.

Thus, to summarise, Durkheim argued that social currents cause changes in the rates of suicides. Individual suicides are affected by these currents of egoism, altruism, anomie, and fatalism. This proved, for Durkheim, that these currents are more than just the sum of individuals, but are *sui generis* forces, because they dominate the decisions of individuals. Without this assumption, the stability of the suicide rate for any particular society could not be explained.

Durkheim concludes his study of suicide with an examination of what reforms could be undertaken to prevent it. Most attempts to prevent suicide have failed because it has been seen as an individual problem. For Durkheim attempts to directly convince individuals not to commit suicide are futile, since its real causes are in society. Of course, the first question to be asked is whether suicide should be prevented or whether it counts among those social phenomena that Durkheim would call normal because of its widespread prevalence. This is an especially important question for Durkheim because his theory says that suicides results from social currents that, in a less exaggerated form, are good for society. We would not want to stop all economic booms because they lead to anomic suicides nor would we stop valuing individuality because leads to egoistic suicide. Similarly, altruistic suicide results from our virtuous tendency to sacrifice ourselves for the community. The pursuit of progress, the belief in the individual, and the spirit of sacrifice all have their place in society, and cannot exist without generating some suicides. Durkheim admits that some suicide is normal, but he argues that the modern society has seen a pathological increase in both egoistic and anomic suicide. Here his position can be traced back to *The Division of Labour*, where he argued that the anomie of modern culture is due to the abnormal way in which labour is divided so that it leads to isolation rather than interdependence. What is needed, then, is a way to preserve the benefits of modernity without unduly increasing suicides – a way of balancing these social currents. In our society, Durkheim believes, these currents are out of balance. In particular, social regulation and integration are too low, leading to an abnormal rate of anomic and egoistic suicides.

Many of the existing institutions for connecting the individual and society have failed, and Durkheim sees little hope of their success. The modern state is too distant from the individual to influence his or her life with enough force and continuity. The church cannot exert its integrating effect without at the same time repressing freedom of thought. Even the family, possibly the most integrative institution in modern society, will fail in this task since it is subject to the same corrosive conditions that are increasing suicide. Instead, what Durkheim, suggests

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is the need of a different institution based on occupational groups. Hence in the form of 'occupational associations' Durkheim proposes a social solution to a social problem.

As we discussed above, the primary problem that Durkheim saw in modern society was the lack of integration and regulation. Even though the cult of the individual provided a collective representation, Durkheim believed that there was a lack of social organizations that people could feel part of and that could tell people what they should and should not do. The modern state is too distant to influence most individuals. The church tends to integrate people by repressing freedom of thought. And the family is too particular and does not integrate individuals into society as a whole. As we've seen, the schools provided an excellent milieu for children. For adults, Durkheim proposed another institution: the *occupational association*. Genuine moral commitments require a concrete group which is tied to the basic organizing principle of modern society, the division of labour. Durkheim proposed the development of occupational associations. All the workers, managers, and owners involved in a particular industry should join together in an association that would be both professional and social. Durkheim did not believe that there was a basic conflict of interest among the owners, managers, and workers within an industry. In this, of course, he took a position diametrically opposed to that of Marx, who saw an essential conflict of interest between the owners and the workers. Durkheim believed that any such conflict occurred only because the various people involved lacked a common morality which was traceable to the lack of an integrative structure. He suggested that the structure that was needed to provide this integrative morality was the occupational association, which would encompass "all the agents of the same industry united and organized into a single group." Such an organization was deemed to be superior to such organizations as labour unions and employer association, which in Durkheim's view served only to intensify the differences between owners, managers, and workers. Involved in a common organization, people in these categories would recognize their common interests as well as their common need for an integrative moral system. That moral system, with its derived rules and laws, would serve to counteract the tendency toward atomization in modern society as well as help stop the decline in the significance of collective morality.

Durkheim's analysis has had an enormous influence on all subsequent research into suicide, and many aspects of his theory have been confirmed by a number of studies, although many of these have also served to modify the original theory. Bearing in mind that many of the statistical techniques commonly used today had not been developed at the time, his statistical approach was very advanced. Still, he has been criticized both for his social realism perspective as well as his positivist methodology. In his study of *Suicide* Durkheim displayed an

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extreme form of social realism and explained suicide as a product of suicidal currents. However, later day scholars criticized this extreme sociological realism approach of Durkheim, and rather advocated a more comprehensive 'causal pluralism' approach to explain the phenomenon of suicide. They argued that apart from social factors, biological and psychological factors must also be explored while explaining suicide. Further, British sociologist J. Maxwell Atkinson has criticized Durkheim on his positivist methodology. Atkinson has raised doubts over the reliability and validity of the very data used by Durkheim in study of *Suicide*. He maintains that the social world is a construction of actors' perceptions and subjective interpretations. As such it has no reality beyond the meanings given to it by social actors. Thus an act of suicide is simply that which is defined as suicide by social actors. Certain deaths come to be defined as suicide by coroners (investigating officers), medical practitioners, newspaper reporters, family and friends of the deceased and so on. Definitions of suicide depend on their interpretation of the event. For Atkinson, suicide is not an objective fact rather it is a subjective interpretation of the coroner. Thus, while some cases of unnatural death get classified as suicide and others are not, owing to the subjective interpretation by the coroner.


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The Elementary Forms of Religious Life (1912)

Durkheim wrote *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* between 1902-1911, and first published it as a complete study in 1912. By the time it was published, Durkheim, was 54 years old and had become one of the leading thinkers in French social thought. While he had begun working on the problem of religion as early 1902, there were several reasons why he chose to study religion as a central subject of sociological interest at the time. First, religion had been one of the leading themes in Durkheim's sociological journal, the *Annee Sociologique* where many of the issues had focused on the question of tribal religions as a result of Roberson Davies ethnographic research during the period. Second, as early as 1890, anthropologists and ethnographers had come to view religion and religious practices as the central subject matter of social and historical interest. Studies such as Spencer and Gillen's *The Native Tribes of Central Australia* published in 1899, and Benjamin Howitt's *Native Tribes of South Eastern Australia* were among the first to carry out ethnographic studies of the religious practices of tribal societies that had not been studied previously. Third, Durkheim's colleague Marcel Mauss was pursuing anthropological interests at the time and many of his articles were featured in the *Annee Sociologique*, giving it a distinct anthropological focus. By 1895, Durkheim was persuaded that religion would be a fitting subject of sociological study because it seemed to be at the center of the social framework of society.

Durkheim's last major book, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), is often regarded as the most profound and the most original of his works. The book contains a description and a detailed analysis of the clan system and of totemism in the Arunta tribe of Australian aborigines, elabourates a general theory of religion derived from a study of the simplest and most "primitive" of religious institutions, and outlines a sociological interpretation of the forms of human thought which is at the heart of contemporary sociology of knowledge.

Durkheim began with a refutation of the reigning theories of the origin of religion. Edward B. Tylor, the distinguished English ethnologist, as well as Spencer himself supported the notion of '*animism*', i.e., spirit worship as the most basic form of religious expression. Animism means the belief in spirits. Tylor believes this to be the earliest form of religion. He argues that animism derives from man's attempts to answer two questions, 'What is it that makes the difference between a living body and a dead one?' and, 'What are those human shapes which appear in dreams and visions?' To make sense of these events, early philosophers invented the idea of soul. The soul is a spirit being which leaves the body temporarily during dreams and visions, and permanently at death. Once invented, the idea of spirits was applied not simply to man, but also to many aspects of the

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natural and social environment. Thus animals were invested with spirit, as were man-made objects. Tylor argues that religion, in the form of animism, originated to satisfy man's intellectual nature, to meet his need to make sense of death, dreams and visions.

Naturism, on the other hand, means the belief that the forces of nature have supernatural power. F. Max Mueller, the noted German linguist, believes this to be the earliest form of religion. He argues that naturism arose from man's experience of nature, in particular the effect of nature upon man's emotions. Nature contains surprise, terror, marvels and miracles, such as volcanoes, thunder and lightning. Awed by the power and wonder of nature, early man transformed abstract forces into personal agents. Man personified nature. The force of the wind became the spirit of the wind, the power of the sun became the spirit of the sun. Where animism seeks the origin of religion in man's intellectual needs, naturism seeks it in his emotional needs. Naturism is man's response to the effect of the power and wonder of nature upon his emotions.

Durkheim rejected both concepts because he felt that they failed to explain the universal key distinction between the sacred and the profane, and because they tended to explain religion away by interpreting it as an illusion, that is, the reductionistic fallacy. Moreover, to love spirits whose unreality one affirms or to love natural forces transfigured merely by man's fear would make religious experience a kind of collective hallucination. Nor is religion defined by the notion of mystery or of the supernatural. Nor is the belief in a transcendental god the essence of religion, for there are several religions such as Buddhism and Confucianism, without gods. Moreover, reliance on spirits and supernatural forces will make religion an illusion. To Durkheim it is inadmissible that systems of ideas like religion which have had such considerable place in history, to which people have turned in all ages for the energy they needed to live, and for which they were willing to sacrifice their lives, should be mere tissues of illusion. Rather, they should be viewed as so profound and so permanent as to correspond to a true reality. And, this true reality is not a transcendent God but society. Thus the central thesis of Durkheim's theory of religion is that throughout history men have never worshipped any other reality, whether in the form of the totem or of God, than the collective social reality transfigured by faith.

According to Durkheim, the essence of religion is a division of the world into two kinds of phenomena, the sacred and the profane. The sacred refers to things human beings set apart, including religious beliefs, rites, deities, or anything socially defined as requiring special religious treatment. Participation in the sacred order, such as in rituals or ceremonies, gives a special prestige, illustrating one of the social functions of religion. "The sacred thing," wrote Durkheim, "is *par*

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excellence that which the profane should not touch and cannot touch with impunity." The profane is the reverse of the sacred. "The circle of sacred objects," continued Durkheim, "cannot be determined once for all. Its existence varies infinitely, according to the different religions." The dichotomy of the sacred and the profane arises out of the dualistic nature of life experience itself. Sacredness is essentially a matter of attitude on the part of the people towards various animate and inanimate objects. But it is not an intrinsic characteristic of the objects themselves. It is the society which designates certain objects as sacred and expects its members to show an attitude of awe and reverence towards these objects. For example, the holy water from Ganges is regarded as sacred by the Hindus inspite of the fact that Ganges these days is highly polluted. Thus sacredness is a quality super imposed by society only. Further, according to Durkheim, the sacred is radically opposed to profane. Unlike the profane, the sacred is non-utilitarian and non-empirical, is strength giving and sustaining, elicits intense respect and makes an ethical demand on the believer.

Accordingly, Durkheim defines religion as a *"unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden—beliefs and practices which unite in one simple moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to it.*" Beliefs and practices unite people in a social community by relating them to sacred things. This collective sharing of beliefs, rituals, etc., is essential for the development of religion. The sacred symbols of religious belief and practice refer, not to the external environment or to individual human nature but only to the moral reality of society.

Durkheim uses the religion of various groups of Australian aborigines to develop his argument. He sees their religion, which he calls **totemism**, as the simplest and most basic form of religion. Aborigine society is divided into several clans. A clan is like a large extended family with its members sharing certain duties and obligations. For example, clans have a rule of exogamy – members may not marry within the clan. Clan members have duty to aid and assist each other; they join together to mourn the death of one of their number and to revenge a member who has been wronged by someone from another clan. Each clan has a totem, usually an animal or a plant. The totem is symbol. It is the emblem of the clan, 'It is its flag; it is the sign by which each clan distinguishes itself from all others'. However, the totem is more than this, it is a sacred symbol. The totem is 'The outward and visible form of the totemic principle or god'. Durkheim argues that if the totem, 'Is at once the symbol of god and of the society, is that not because the god and the society are only one?' Thus he suggests that in worshipping god, men are in fact worshipping society. Society is the real object of religious veneration.

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Thus, instead of animism or naturism, Durkheim took the "totemism" among the Australian tribes as the key concept to explain the origins of religion. Ordinary objects, whether pieces of wood, polished stones, plants or animals, are transfigured into sacred objects once they bear the emblem of the totem. Durkheim writes:

> Totemism is the religion, not of certain animals or of certain men or of certain images, but of a kind of anonymous and impersonal force which is found in each of these beings, without however being indentified with any one of them. None possesses it entirely, and all participate in it. So independent is it of the particular subjects in which it is embodied that it precedes them just as it is adequate to them. Individuals die, generations pass away and are replaced by others. But this force remains ever present, living, and true to itself. It quickens today's generation just as it quickened yesterday's and as it will quicken tomorrow's. Taking the word in a very broad sense, one might say that it is the god worshipped by each totemic cult; but it is an impersonal god, without a name, without a history, abiding in the world, diffused in a countless multitude of things.

Totem, Durkheim explained, refers to an implicit belief in a mysterious or sacred force or principle that provides sanctions for violations of taboos, inculcates moral responsibilities in the group, and animates the totem itself. The emphasis, in keeping with his overall emphasis upon social analysis of social phenomena, was upon the collective activities as the birthplace of religious sentiments and ideas. According to Durkheim, the essence of Totemism is the worship of an impersonal, anonymous forced, at once immanent and transcendent. This anonymous, diffuse force which is superior to men and very close to them is in reality society itself.

How does man come to worship society? Sacred things are 'considered superior in dignity and power to profane things and particularly to man'. In relation to the sacred, man's position is inferior and dependent. This relationship between man and sacred things is exactly the relationship between man and society. Society is more important and powerful than the individual. Durkheim argues that, 'Primitive man comes to view society as something sacred because he is utterly dependent on it'. But why does man not simply worship society itself? Why does he invent a sacred symbol like a totem? Because, Durkheim argues, 'it is easier for him to visualize and direct his feelings of awe toward a symbol than towards so complex a thing as a clan'.

Here in lies Durkheim's functional explanation of religion. He is trying to bring out the consequences of religion, which is a part of the society, for the society as a whole. The attitudes of reverence and respect which are expressed, through religious beliefs and rituals, towards the sacred objects are in fact an indirect expressions of reverence for the society. Participation in religious worship builds respect for society's values and norms, hence, acting as an agency of social control. Further, collective participation in common rituals and holding common

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beliefs creates a sense of 'We-ness' among the members of the society and thus strengthens solidarity in the society.

Durkheim argues that social life is impossible without the shared values and moral beliefs which form the 'collective conscience'. In their absence, there would be no social order, social control, social solidarity or cooperation. In short, there would be no society. Religion reinforces the collective conscience. The worship of society strengthens the values and moral beliefs which form the basis of social life. By defining them as sacred, religion provides them with greater power to direct human action. The attitude of respect towards the sacred is the same attitude applied to social duties and obligations. In worshipping society, men are, in effect, recognizing the importance of the social group and their dependence upon it. In this way religion strengthens the unity of the group, it promotes social solidarity. The social group comes together in religious rituals infused with drama and reverence. Together, its members express their faith in common values and beliefs. In this highly charged atmosphere of collective worship, the integration of society is strengthened. Members of society express, communicate and comprehend the moral bonds which unite them.

Moreover, Durkheim claims that just as societies in the past have created gods and religion, societies of the future are inclined to create new gods and new religions when they are in a state of exaltation. When societies are seized by the sacred frenzy, and when men, participating in ritualistic ceremonies, religious services, feasts and festivals, go into a trance, people are united by dancing and shouting and experience a kind of phantasmagoria. Men are compelled to participate by the force of the group which carries them outside of themselves and gives them a sensation of something that has no relation to every day experience. During such moments of sacred frenzy and collective trance, new gods and new religions will be born.

Durkheim believed he had solved the religious-moral dilemma of modern society. If religion is nothing but the indirect worship of society, modern people need only express their religious feelings directly toward the sacred symbolization of society. The source and object of religion, Durkheim pointed out, are the collective life—the sacred is at bottom 'society personified'. Therefore, a secular sociological explanation of religion could sound something like this—the individual who feels dependent on some external moral power is not a victim of hallucination but a responsive member of society. The substantial function of religion, said Durkheim, is the creation, reinforcement, and maintenance of social solidarity. He argued that religious phenomena emerges in any society when a separation is made between the sphere of the profane—the realm of everyday utilitarian activities—and the sphere of the sacred—the area that pertains to the numerous, the transcendental, the extraordinary.

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Religion, as Durkheim saw and explained it, is not only a social creation, but is in fact society divinized. Durkheim stated that the deities which men worship together are only projections of the power of society. If religion is essentially a transcendental representation of the powers of society, then the disappearance of traditional religion need not herald the dissolution of society. Furthermore, Durkheim reasoned that all that is required for modern men now was to realize directly that dependence on society, which before, they had recognized only through the medium of religious representation. "We must," he explained, "discover the rational substitute for these religious notions that for a long time have served as the vehicle for the most essential moral ideas". On the most general plane, religion as a social institution serves to give meaning to man's existential predicaments by tying the individual to that supra individual sphere of transcendent values which is ultimately rooted in his own society. Thus, he advocated a new humanistic religion for the modern society.

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With this study of religion, Durkheim successfully demonstrated the application of functionalist methodology in sociology and social anthropology which subsequently influenced the works of B. Malinowski and A.R. Radcliffe-Brown. Durkheim's ideas remain influential, though they are not without criticism. Some anthropologists have argued that he is not justified in seeing totemism as a religion. Most sociologists believe that Durkheim has overstated his case. Whilst agreeing that religion is important for promoting social solidarity and reinforcing social values, they would not support the view that religion is the worship of society. For example, like Durkheim, Malinowski uses data from small-scale non-literate societies to develop his thesis on religion. Many of his examples are drawn from his field work in the Trobriand Islands off the coast of New Guinea. Like Durkheim, Malinowski sees religion as reinforcing social norms and values and promoting social solidarity. Unlike Durkheim, however, he does not see religion reflecting society as a whole, nor does he see religious ritual as the worship of society itself. Malinowski identifies specific areas of social life with which religion is concerned, to which it is addressed. These are situations of emotional stress which threaten social solidarity.

Anxiety and tension tend to disrupt social life. Situations which produce these emotions include 'crises of life' such as birth, puberty, marriage and death. Malinowski notes that in all societies these life crises are surrounded with religious ritual. He sees death as the most disruptive of these events. Religion deals with the problem of death in the following manner. A funeral ceremony expresses the belief in immortality, which denies the fact of death, and so comforts the bereaved. Other mourners support the bereaved by their presence at the ceremony. This comfort and support checks the emotions which death produces, and controls the stress and anxiety which might disrupt society. Death is 'socially destructive' since it removes a member from society. At a funeral ceremony the social group unites to support the bereaved. This expression of social solidarity re-integrates society.

A second category of events, undertakings which cannot be fully controlled or predicted by practical means, also produces tension and anxiety. From his observations in the Trobriand Islands, Malinowski noted that such events were surrounded by ritual. Fishing is an important subsistence practice in the Trobriands. Malinowski observed that in the calm waters of the lagoon, 'fishing is done in an easy and absolutely reliable manner by the method of poisoning, yielding abundant results without danger and uncertainty'. However, beyond the barrier reef in the open sea there is danger and uncertainty. A storm may result in loss of life. The catch is dependent on the presence of a shoal of fish which cannot be predicted. In the lagoon, 'where man can rely completely on his knowledge and skill', there are no rituals associated with fishing whereas fishing in the open sea is preceded by rituals to ensure a good catch and protect the fishermen. Although Malinowski refers to these rituals as magic, others argue it is reasonable to regard

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them as religious practices. Again we see ritual addressed to specific situates which produce anxiety. Rituals reduce anxiety by providing confidence and a feeling of control. As with funeral ceremonies, fishing rituals are social events. The group unites to deal with situations of stress, and so the unity of the group is strengthened.

Here we can see that while Durkheim analysed the functional aspect of religion for the society as a whole, Malinowski, on the other hand, also talks of the functional consequences at the individual level, thus offering a critique to Durkheim's extreme social realism. Malinowski's distinctive contribution to the sociology of religion is his argument that religion promotes social solidarity by dealing with situations of emotional stress which threaten the stability of society.

In his essay, '*The Comparative Method in Social Anthropology*', Radcliffe-Brown further extended the argument of Durkheim to explain why a particular totem is chosen by a society or group as its totem. In a comparative analysis of various tribes of Australia and north-west America, he found various instances whereby a tribe was divided into two exogamous moieties and each moiety represented by particular natural specie as its totem. For example, in case of Australian aborigines in New South Wales, the two moieties were represented by eaglehawk and crow. On the basis of his comparative study, he concluded that the selection of a particular set of natural species as the totem by the two exogamous moieties of a tribe is also associated with their inter-group social relations. He found it common that natural species were placed in pairs of opposites, with certain degree of resemblances as well as differences. He interpreted the resemblances and differences of animal species in terms of social relationships of friendship and antagonism in human society.

Further, Robert K. Merton argues that Durkheim's views on religion are more relevant to small, non-literate societies, where there is a close integration of culture and social institutions, where work, leisure, education and family life tend to merge, and where members share a common belief and value system. They are less relevant to modern societies, which have many subcultures, social and ethnic groups, specialized organizations and a range of religious beliefs, practices and institutions. Merton asserts that Durkheim's view that religion act as an agency of social control and provided solidarity, is true only for simple small scale societies which practice a single common religion. In the case of modern industrial societies religion has lost both these function. Given the highly differentiated and diversified nature of modern societies, religion can no longer act as an agency of social control. Further, the existence of a plurality of religions, quite often lead to inter-religious conflicts and therefore endanger solidarity rather than enhancing it. This could be seen in terms of the increasing communal riots at local level and deepening religious divide at international level.

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Further, contrary to Durkheim's view that religion is in fact 'society divinized' and promotes solidarity in the society, Marx argues that religion is a part of the superstructure and thus it not only reflects but also reinforces the ruling class ideology. Marx further argues that religion acts as an opiate to dull the pain produced by oppression. In Marx's words, 'Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the sentiment of a heartless world and the soul of soulless conditions. It is the opium of the people'. It does nothing to solve the problem, it is simply a misguided attempt to make life more bearable. As such, religion merely stupefies its adherents rather than bringing them true happiness and fulfillment. To Marx, religion is an illusion which eases the pain produced by exploitation and oppression. It is a series of myths which justify and legitimate the subordination of the subject class and the domination and privilege of the ruling class. It is a distortion of reality which provides many of the deceptions which form the basis of ruling class ideology and false class consciousness.

Durkheim, in his study of religion, pointed to two major functions of religion, viz. social solidarity and social control. However, as evident from Max Weber's study of *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, religion may also serve as an agent of social change. Weber's study of ascetic Protestantism argued that religious beliefs provided the ethics, attitudes and motivations for the development of capitalism. Thus, leading to the transformation of a predominantly feudal European society into a capitalistic one.

More recently, some scholars have highlighted an altogether new role that religion is playing in the contemporary world politics, as an ideology of protest. They argue that with welfare state failing to deliver on the basic amenities of life and communism still a utopia, religion has emerged as a potent ideology of protest by the disenchanted masses. This phenomenon is far more explicit and rampant mainly in the third world developing countries. Rapidly spreading and powerful currents of Islamic fundamentalism could be cited as an example here. In Indian context, we can also cite the example of Dalit movement led by Dr. B.R. Ambedkar. In its later stage Dalit movement also made use of Buddhist ideology of egalitarianism to protest against the social inequalities and injustice perpetrated by the traditional caste system.

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Durkheim: An Assessment

Durkheim has exerted a great influence on the social sciences, especially the functionalist and structuralist schools of anthropology and sociology. His was the dominant theory of social science in France from the beginning of the twentieth century. After his death in 1917, many of his students refined his core ideas. In anthropology, central theorists like Radcliff-Brown and Levi-Strauss have built on the Durkheim an inheritance. In sociology, the structural functionalist Talcott Parsons refined many of Durkheim's ideas. Parsons's central role in sociology from World War II until the 1970s contributed to maintaining an interest in Durkheim, and Parsons's heirs still consider Durkheim an important forerunner.

Durkheim's theories have also been subjected to harsh criticism by later social scientists. Most of his most important ideas (for example, those on social facts and holism) have been rejected by many supporters of individualist positions, such as rational choice theory, exchange theory, symbolic interactionism, and ethnomethodology. And his belief in integration and consensus, and his lack of concern with problems of power, have been criticized by supporters of more conflict-oriented theory, for example, Marxists.

Durkheim carved out a special field of study for sociology, established a sound empirical methodology and laid the foundation of structural functionalism, the dominant school of sociological theory today. It is a fact that despite some criticism to his concepts such as collective conscience and social facts, very few have surpassed his sociological realism or matched his substantive contribution to the many concerns of theoretical sociology.

One of the important contributions of Durkheim is that he delineated the subject matter of sociology with great precision and clarity. He was successful in distinguishing the phenomena studied by psychology and sociology. According to him, sociology must study social facts, those with are external to individual minds and which exercise coercive action on them. Durkheim showed convincingly that social facts are facts *sui generis*. In his *The Rules of Sociological Method*, he elabourated in detail the positivist methodology that a social scientist should adopt while studying a social phenomenon. Thus, to the main problems in sociological theory of his times, Durkheim gave clear answers, both for theory and method. Durkheim faced up to complex methodological problems and demonstrated by implementing in his works, the necessity of empirical research for a science of society.

Further, Durkheim was one of the first scholars to highlight the social consequences of division of labour. Prior to him, division of labour was explained

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in a narrow sense, limited only to its economic consequences. It was Durkheim who brought out vividly the social and cultural importance of division of labour. He analysed the nature and consequences of division of labour in terms of changing forms of social solidarity. In his book *The Division of Labour in Society* Durkheim analyses the individual-versus-society issue in terms of the different kinds of social solidarity that hold society and individuals together.

Durkheim's study of *Suicide* is also considered as a landmark study and the best demonstration of his application of social realism perspective and positivist methodology. It was for the first time that theoretical generalizations were arrived at on the basis of careful analysis of empirical data. This study gave sociology a firm footing among other social sciences and justified its claim of being a scientific discipline.

Durkheim also had emphasized that while studying any social phenomenon, a sociologist should seek for both causal as well as functional explanations. Durkheim's study of suicide is considered as the best demonstration of the causal explanation while his study of religion is cited as an example of functional explanation in the sociological world. He argued that it is the business of the sociologists to establish causal connections and causal laws. Although many are skeptical about this approach, a great number of causal connections and functional correlations have been established by sociology with a reasonable degree of probability. While pleading for causal explanations, Durkheim argued that since experimentation is impossible in sociology, we should go in for indirect experimentation, by using the *comparative method*. This particular method continues to be used by sociologists.

Durkheim is also considered the pioneer of functional approach in sociology. Functional approach was later pursued by Malinowski and Radcliffe-Brown in studying various small scale and pre-industrial societies. But it was Talcott Parsons and Robert K. Merton who revived functional approach and suitably modified classical functional approach to account for the dynamics unfolding in the modern industrial societies. Closely following Durkheim, Merton distinguished between 'manifest' and 'latent' functions. Also the idea of 'dysfunction' goes back to Durkheim's idea of pathological functions.

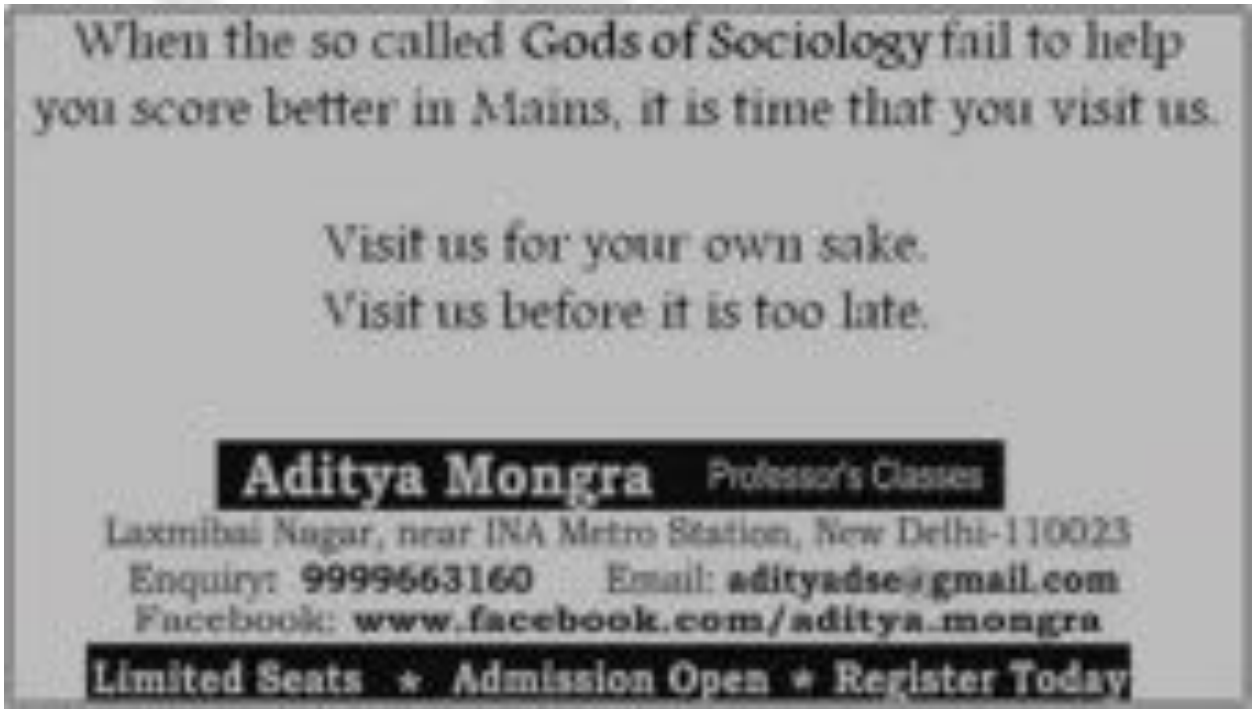
Without doubt, Durkheim shaped French sociology. His influence before the Second World War was insignificant, but following Talcott Parsons's *The Structure of Social Action* (1937) in which Durkheim was fully and admirably introduced to American sociology, his influence flourished. By the 1950s he had become along with Weber the major influence in America and all Europe.

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Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. Always remember that without answer-writing practice, any amount of sociological knowledge would be of little use for you in qualifying civil services examination. Thus, along with understanding the sociological ideas discussed here, you must also master the art of expressing them in your own words as per the standards of the examination and expectations of the examiner, and that too, in the given Time-and-Word Limit.

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Max Weber (1864-1920)

It is difficult not to compare the work of the German social theorist Max Weber (1864-1920) with that of Karl Marx. It could even be suggested that a full appreciation of key aspects of Weber's work only emerges by making this comparison. There comparisons are inevitable since the writings of Marx, and the political claims of the Marxists who followed him, provided much of the academic and political context of Weber's own social theory. It is important to remember, however, that Weber's understanding of Marx was very limited since many of Marx's most important works (the *Paris Manuscript*s, *The German Ideology*, the *Grundrisse*) were not available during Weber's lifetime. The Marx that Weber did know was mostly based on his economic writings and *The Communist Manifesto*, and even these as they were being interpreted, rather simplistically, by the German Social Democratic Party in the 1890s. For Weber, Marx was the author of an original, but rigid and one-sidedly materialist, theory of historical development, a point that he tries to prove by offering an alternative explanation of the emergence of modern capitalism in his famous essay published in 1904/05, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*.

Having boldly stated the need for comparing Weber with Marx we need to qualify this by saying that not all of Weber's work should be treated in this way. The comparison actually relates to the fairly specific topic of what social theory has to say about the origins and nature of modern industrial capitalism. To the extent that Weber's political concerns, his worries about the feasibility of socialism and the dominance of economic interests, can all be seen in terms of the rise of capitalism then the comparison is fair enough. Weber did have other interests, however, such as his analysis of German society and politics, his comparative history of the world religions, and the contribution he made to the methodology of social theory, which often have very little to do with Marx and Marxism.

Let us now briefly discuss the biographical and political context of Weber's work. The accusation that Weber produced bourgeois social theory as opposed to the proletarian social theory of Marx is partly based on the fact that Weber came from a wealthy establishment family, and thus had the benefits of a privileged education and good social and career prospects. Following his father (who was a member of the German Parliament), he trained as a lawyer in Berlin and then took a doctorate in economics in 1889. He gained his first academic post in 1893, and only three years later became professor of economics at Freiburg University in 1896 at the remarkably young age of 32 (he later held posts at Heidelberg and Munich). He then suffered the first of a series of serious bouts of psychological illness that forced him to give up his job and abandon academic work for the next six years. The period between 1905 and around 1915 was his most productive,

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beginning with the publication of two extended essays as *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* in 1904/05. He then worked intermittently on a number of detailed studies in economics, religion, the development of the legal system and other social institutions. These subsequently appeared in print as *Economy and Society* (1921), *The Religion of India* and *The Religion of China* (both published in 1916). *The General Economic History* (1927) was compiled from a series of lectures he gave in Freiburg during 1919-20, and *On the Methodology of the Social Sciences* was published posthumously in 1922 from a variety of articles and lectures given between 1903 and 1917. In most cases, complete English translations only became available during the 1950s and 1960s.Weber died from pneumonia in 1920 at the age of 56.

In terms of the kind of society in which Weber worked, the dominant political issue was the decline of the liberal, Protestant and highly individualist attitude of the established middle classes, and the emergence of an authoritarian, militarised, bureaucratic regime that accompanied the rise of the 'new Germany' following Bismark's unification of the German states in 1870. The success of the new regime rested on an alliance between the landowner class of Junkers (who were forced to rely on political power as their economic power declined), the military and the emerging classes of industrialists, financiers, bankers and career bureaucrats. In the last decades of the 19th century, Germany went thought a period of rapid industrialisation, a process that was accompanied by the emergence of the German industrial working class although not, significantly, of an independent bourgeois middle class of the kind found in Britain, France and elsewhere. For Weber and many of his contemporaries, the demise of traditional liberal values of personal responsibility and autonomy, and their replacement with a much more paternalistic notion of national service, was a matter of great concern. Both Weber and his father made various attempts to express this opposition in the political sphere. The rather pessimistic tone of Weber's work, his sense that German society and its liberal values were in decline, certainly reflects his rather dismal political outlook.

Whereas Marx began his academic career by engaging with the abstract philosophical debates engendered by Hegelian idealism, Weber started out with the altogether more practical intention of training as a lawyer and economist. The emergence of a specifically social-theoretical emphasis in his interests really only arose after he had already begun to analyse specific topics as part of his professional work. Weber tended to deal with the more conceptual challenges of social theory on a need-to-know basis. In this sense, Weber was more interested in getting on with studying actual things than in devoting time either to establishing an entire account of historical development, as Marx had done, or to developing a set of principles for turning the study of social phenomena into a proper science, in

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the manner of Auguste Comte and Emile Durkheim. This approach accounts for why there is no unifying theme in Weber's work, no overall framework into which each of his concepts and ideas can be fitted. Whether he liked it or not, however, Weber could not help but become involved in the heated discussions about the role of social-scientific study, and the differences between this and the natural sciences, that were taking place in intellectual and academic circles in Germany around 1900. These philosophical debates began with a revival during the 1890, in Germany and elsewhere, of one of the old chestnuts of chestnuts of philosophy and social theory, which is the distinction between **empirical knowledge**, that is, knowledge that comes through physical sensation, and **rational knowledge**, that is, knowledge in the form of the ideas and other intellectual constructs through which it is made intelligible in the mind.



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Immanuel Kant (1724-1804), a German philosopher, had argued that while knowledge of the real world was something that comes through our physical senses, it can only be made sense of once this information has been structured and organised by the mind. The human mind thus imposes a rational structure on the raw data of experience and feeling. All knowledge is thus a production of rational intellectual processing and as such reality cannot be regarded as a thing that is entirely distinguishable from knowledge of it. Reality 'in itself' cannot be known. (Kant's position is dualistic because he accepts the necessary combination of sense perception and cognitive reason. Hegel is monistic as he emphasises the absolute primacy of intellectual reason alone.)

Kant tried to reconcile his rationalist view with the strict objectivism and empiricism of John Locke (1632-1704) and David Hume (1711-96) who argue that all our ideas and concepts, including both physical sensations and intellectual reflections, are derived from practical experience of the world around us and not from pre-existing capacities of the human mind. From an empiricist viewpoint, there cannot be any knowledge or consciousness until *after* we have had physical contact with the material world around us. This dispute over the two basic kinds of knowledge – knowledge derived *a priori* from within the conscious mind and knowledge derived retrospectively from sense perception – provides an important backdrop to debates about the nature of social-scientific knowledge.

Kant further argued that the free individual was intuitively capable of moral self-direction. As *natural objects* (objects of investigation), the properties or behaviors of individuals could be investigated according to the same scientific methodologies that would be appropriate for any natural object. As *moral subjects*, however, individuals are not part of the natural world, for God has given the individual free choice to act in either a moral or an immoral fashion. A civilized society is one that encourages individuals to act morally. But society cannot deterministically generate morality because moral action is always, in part, an outcome of free will.

The Kantian emphasis on the dualism of the individual - the view of man as both natural object and moral subject - strongly influenced Simmel and Weber. Both of these latter theorists were Kantian in their belief that, in the final analysis, the moral decisions of individuals never could be judged good or bad from a sociological point of view. For Simmel and Weber, sociology, unlike biology or chemistry, had to come to terms with the fact that, to some extent, the individual was not, and could not be, constrained by determinate laws. Kant's greatest impact on modern thought then was perhaps the idea that as a rational, independent moral entity, the individual is free from at least some extrinsic, causal determinants of behaviour.

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The younger followers of Kant or 'neo- Kantians' were faced with the problem of defending the rationalist approach, used in the historical, cultural and social sciences, against the empiricist approach of the natural sciences. The considerable success of the natural sciences during the 19th century (a success that was reinforced with every new advance in technology or feat of industrial engineering), allowed the empiricists to suggest that the kind of knowledge that was generated by the speculative, metaphysical and inductive approach of the social sciences, really did not constitute proper knowledge at all. Indeed, there was no reason to suppose that the search for the general 'laws of motion' of social phenomena should not be carried out using the tried-and-tested empirical methodology and methods of the natural sciences.

The neo-Kantians, and other interested parties including Max Weber, thus turned their attention to these issues:

- They wanted to challenge the idea that the kind of knowledge generated by the natural sciences was *the only* kind of knowledge available.
- They wanted to show that the two kinds of science had to be different because they were looking at two fundamentally *different kinds* of phenomena.
- If these points are valid, then it was obvious that two distinct *methodologies* were required to investigate them.

These philosophical debates, between the positivists and anti-positivists, which began in Germany in the latter part of the nineteenth century, are popularly referred as *Methodenstreit*. For some three decades prior to the outbreak of the First World War, German academic life was dominated by a number of related disputes about methodology (the so-called *Methodenstreit*), the most general and probably the most important of which dealt with the relationship between the natural and social sciences.

One group led by Carl Menger, an economist, who advocated the use of positive science methods in social sciences as well. He argued that the scientific methodology of natural sciences should be used to arrive at general theories in social sciences – seeing human motives and social interaction as far too complex to be amenable to statistical analysis. On the other hand, the anti-positivist scholars (particularly the neo-Kantians) emphasized upon the subjective dimension of social reality and thus, did not see the possibility of any kind of universal generalizations in social sciences.

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It will be useful to begin by outlining the controversy between those who think of sociology in terms of natural science and those who think of it as being quite different from any natural science and perhaps more like history or philosophy. What are the differences between 'nature' and 'society' which would require radically different methods of enquiry? They were first clearly stated by Wilhelm Dilthey (1833-1911) and were then widely discussed by German historians and philosophers, especially Wilhelm Windelband (1848-1915) and Heinrich Rickert (1863-1936).

There are two major differences between the natural world and the social or cultural world. First, the natural world can only be observed and explained from the outside, while the world of human activity can be observed and comprehended from the inside, and is only intelligible because we ourselves belong to this world and have to do with the products of minds similar to our own. Secondly, the relations between phenomena of the natural world are mechanical relations of causality, whereas the relations between phenomena of the human world are relations of value and purpose. It follows from this, in Dilthey's view, that the 'human studies' should be concerned, not with the establishment of causal connections or the formulation of universal laws, but with the construction of typologies of personality and culture which would serve as the framework for understanding human strivings and purposes in different historical situations. Dilthey contrasted 'nature' and 'society' in terms of their subject-matter. He argued that reality can be divided into autonomous sectors – a fundamental distinction being that between the realms of 'nature' and 'human spirit' – with each sector being the prerogative of a separate category of sciences. In other words, Dilthey believed that since social or cultural science studied acting individuals with ideas and intentions, a special method of understanding (*Verstehen*) was required, while natural science studied soulless things and, consequently, it did not need to understand its objects.

Wilhelm Windelband (1848-1915), one of the leading neo-Kantians, on the other hand proposed a logical distinction between natural and social sciences on the basis of their methods. Natural sciences, according to Windelband, use a 'nomothetic' or generalizing method, whereas social sciences employ an 'ideographic' or individualizing procedure, since they are interested in the non-recurring events in reality and the particular or unique aspects of any phenomenon. He argued that the kinds of knowledge generated by the natural and the social sciences were different because they were looking at two different levels of reality. Whereas the natural scientists were concerned with material objects and with describing the general laws that governed their origins and interactions, social and cultural scientists were concerned with the ethical realm of human action and culture. Although knowledge of natural phenomena could be achieved directly

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through observation and experimentation, knowledge of human motivation, of norms and patterns of conduct, and of social and cultural values, necessarily had to be based on a more abstract process of theoretical reasoning. You can only infer that somebody is in love; you cannot actually see 'love'.

The association of social phenomena with values was also considered by the German philosopher Heinrich Rickert (1863-1936) who strongly influenced Weber's views on the matter. Rickert (who was himself adopting a famous distinction between fact and value that had been made by the Scottish Enlightenment philosopher David Hume [1711-76]), argued that the natural sciences are 'sciences of fact' and so questions of value were necessarily excluded from the analysis. The social sciences, in contrast, are 'sciences of value' because they are specifically concerned with understanding why social actors choose to act in the ways that they do. While it is appropriate to disregard questions of value when studying the physical or chemical properties of things, it is certainly not appropriate to do so when studying human social action and its consequences. It is relatively easy to show what the properties of carbon are, where it comes from and what will happen if you combine it with some other material. What you never need to do is explain how carbon atoms *feel* about any of these things.



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The prevalent intellectual and political context had a deep influence on Weber in shaping his perspective as well as ideas on subject matter. Weber partly accepted and partly rejected all the three major theoretical orientations. For example, he accepted the positivists' argument for the scientific study of social phenomena and appreciated the need for arriving at generalizations if sociology has to be a social science. But, he criticized the positivists for not taking into account the unique meanings and motives of the social actors into consideration. Further, he argued that sociology, given the variable nature of the social phenomena, could only aspire for *limited generalizations* (which he called 'thesis'), not universal generalizations as advocated by the positivists.

Similarly, Weber appreciated the neo-Kantians for taking into cognizance the subjective meanings and motives of the social actors in order to better understand the social reality but also stressed the need for building generalizations in social sciences. As stated earlier, taking a cue from Immanuel Kant, the neo-Kantian scholars argued that the reality is of two kinds, *natural reality* and *social reality*. What distinguishes social reality from the natural reality is the presence of '*Geist*'(Spirit or Consciousness) and by virtue of the presence of Geist, human beings respond to the external stimuli in a meaningful manner, not mechanically as the physical objects do. Therefore, human behaviour can only be understood in the light of these meanings. Thus social sciences should try to understand the human behaviour from the actor's point of view keeping in mind the meaning and motives that underlie such behaviour.

Weber, agreeing with the neo-Kantians, believed that human beings respond to their environment in a meaningful way and therefore, human behaviour has to be understood in the context of the underlying meanings. Therefore, Weber argued that to build the strategies of social research on the methods of natural sciences alone would be a serious mistake. The methodology of social sciences should focus on understanding the human behaviour. According to Weber, the cognitive aim of social sciences is to understand the human behaviour. A sociological explanation should therefore be meaningfully as well as causally adequate. (Please note that the causal explanations are used in all sciences. Social sciences should also use causal explanations but besides the causal explanation, the explanation in social sciences should be adequate at the level of meanings as well. That is how the cognitive aim of social sciences goes beyond that of the natural sciences.)

However, Weber criticized the neo-Kantians' proposition that generalizations are not possible in social sciences. Weber argued that all sciences, whether natural or social, begin with the study of a particular phenomenon and try to arrive at some generalization. Though Weber admitted that social sciences may not attain as much success in arriving at generalizations as natural sciences because

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the ability to discover generalizations is dependent upon the degree to which there is a pattern in the reality. So, given the variable nature of the social phenomena, social sciences could only aspire for limited generalizations. He further argued generalizations arrived in social sciences would not have the same exactitude as of those in natural sciences. Such generalizations would merely be indicative of a trend or tendency. Weber argued that we may call such limited generalizations as 'thesis' rather than the 'theory'.

Weber also partly accepted Marx's view on class conflict (economic factors) in society but argued that there could be other dimensions of the conflict as well such as status, power, etc. Further, Weber was also skeptical about the inevitability of revolution as forecasted by Marx. Weber accepted the Marxian logic of explaining conflict and change in terms of interplay of economic forces but at the same time criticized Marxian theory as mono-causal economic determinism. According to Weber, the social phenomenon is far too complex to be explained adequately in terms of a single cause. Hence Weber argued that the social science methodology should be based on the principle of *causal pluralism*. (Please note that Weber was not rejecting the Marxian theory but rather supplementing it. Weber agreed with Marx that economic factors do have a profound influence on social life. But he considered economic factor as only one of the factors that influence social life.)

To summarize, Weber is regarded to have been influenced by 'neo-Kantian' ideas in his perception of the nature of social life. According to him, behaviour of man in society is qualitatively different from that of physical objects and biological organisms. What accounts for these differences is the presence of meanings and motives which underlie the social behaviour of man. Thus any study of human behaviour in society must take cognizance of these meanings to understand this behaviour. The cognitive aims or objectives of sociological studies are, therefore, different from those of positive sciences. While positive sciences seek to discover the underlying patterns of interactions between various aspects of physical and natural phenomena, the social sciences, on the other hand, seek to understand the meanings and motives to explain the social phenomena. Hence positive science method alone would prove inadequate to study the social behaviour. However, Weber was not opposed to building generalization in social sciences, but, he pointed out that given the variable nature of social phenomena, only limited generalization can be made.

Weber conceived of sociology as a comprehensive science of 'social action' which constitutes the basic unit of social life. In consonance with his general perception of the nature of social reality, he defined social action as '*the meaningful action oriented towards other individuals*'. Presence of meanings

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as well as other individuals is equally important for any behaviour to qualify as social action. For Weber, the combined qualities of 'action' and 'meaning' were the 'central facts' for sociology's scientific analysis. Weber defined sociology as "a science which attempts the interpretive understanding of social action in order thereby to arrive at a causal explanation of its course and effects.' The technical category of 'action' described in Weber's work is all human behavior to which an actor attaches subjective meaning. "Action is social," explains Weber, "in so far as, by virtue of the subjective meaning attached to it by the acting individual, it takes account of the behavior of others and is thereby oriented in its course." However, an isolated social act does not exist in real social life. Only at the analytical level can one conceptualize an isolated social act. What exists in reality is an on-going chain of reciprocal social actions, which we call social interaction.

Thus, according to Weber, sociology is a science concerning itself with the interpretive understanding of social action. For Weber, social action is the basic unit of social life and hence the subject matter of sociology. This logically follows from his basic assumption that individuals are cultural beings but have an ability to take a deliberate stand of their own. Therefore, individuals are capable of attributing a subjective meaning to their behaviour. Thus, as a sociologist, one must look at human behaviour as social action. As stated earlier, there are two elements of social action viz. *presence of meaning* and *orientation towards others*. In the absence of assigned 'meanings' by the individuals, the actions are meaningless and thus outside the purview of sociology. Similarly, the actions which are not oriented towards others are also outside the purview of sociology.

Now, since meanings are the fundamental character of social action, so if the nature of meanings changes, the type of social action also undergoes change. Thus, based on the nature of meanings, Weber constructed a classificatory typology of social action. However, he cautioned that this classificatory typology is only for the purpose of analysis. Though it is rooted in reality but it does not mirror the reality. He based his classification of social action on the pure types of meanings, although such pure types of meanings are never found in reality. Weber argued that social reality is infinitely complex. There is an infinite variety of meanings that can exist in social life. However, according to Weber, all these meanings can be analytically reduced to four pure types of meanings. These four pure types of meanings are not found in reality. In reality, any given social action reflects a combination of two or more pure types of meanings.

Thus, based on these four pure types of meanings, there are four pure types of social actions. Weber classified social action into four major types on the basis of the nature of meaning involved. These four types of social action are:

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1. Goal–Rational Action (Zweckrational action):

   The actor determines the practical goal (rational, specific, and quantifiable) and chooses his means purely in terms of their efficiency to attain the goal. (Please note that in reality there is no pure goal-rational action. But the meaning involved in action tends to be predominantly goal rational).

2. Value-Rational Action (Wertrational action):

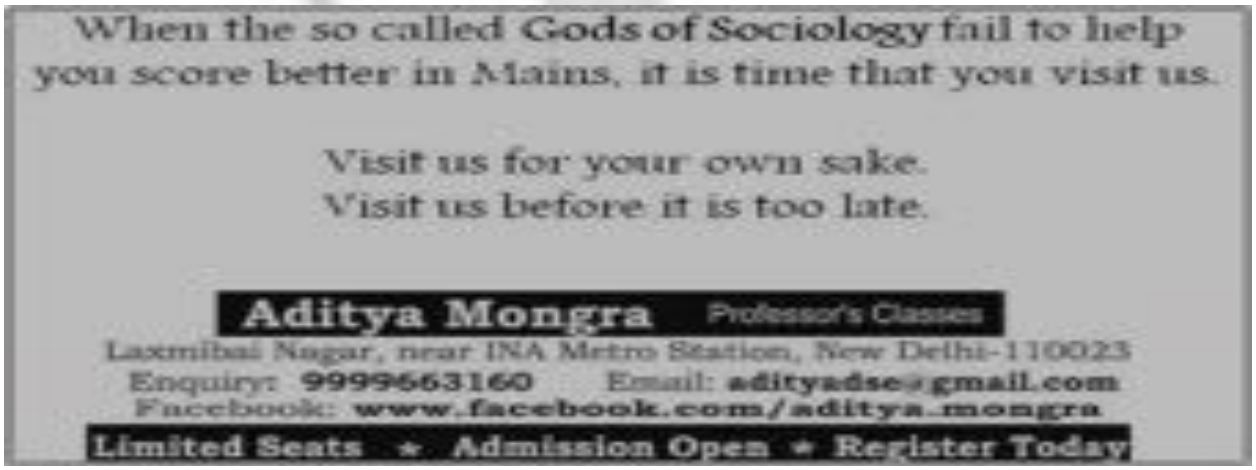
   Value-rational action is the one where the means are chosen for their efficiency but the goals are determined by value. The action of a captain who goes down with the sinking ship or that of a soldier who allows himself to be killed rather than yield in a war are examples of such action.

3. Affective or Emotional Action:

   In certain situations the sole meaning involved in people's behaviour is to give expression of their emotional state. Here emotion or impulse determines the ends and means of action. Such an action is termed as affective or emotional action. For example, the case of a mother who hugs her child, embracing an old friend, etc.

4. Traditional Action:

   Traditional actions are those where both ends and means are determined by custom. Here, the meaning involved is that of maintaining a continuity of the tradition. Rituals, ceremonies and practices of tradition fall in this category.



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After having discussed Weber's perspective and subject matter, let us now move on to his methodology. As stated earlier, the aim of sociology, according to Weber, is different from those of natural sciences. Natural sciences are primarily interested in search for the underlying patterns or laws governing the physical matter. Sociology, on the other hand, seeks to understand social behaviour in terms of meanings and motives, though sociology also attempts to arrive at limited generalizations. Therefore, social sciences cannot rely on positive science methods alone. According to Weber, since the cognitive aim of sociology is to understand human behaviour, therefore, a sociological explanation should be adequate both at the level of meanings as well as at the level of causality. Therefore Weber suggests *Verstehen* method for sociological enquiry. This expression is taken from Dilthey, but Weber used it in a somewhat different sense. The Verstehen approach is usually translated as 'interpretive understanding'.

According to Weber, the Verstehen method involves the interpretive understanding of social action through empathetic liaison in order to build a sequence of motives to trace the course and effect of social action. In other words, this method seeks to understand social action at the 'level of meanings' and then tries to build a sequence of motives which underlie the social action. Thus a sociological explanation becomes adequate both at the level of meanings as well as at the level of causality.

According to Weber, the Verstehen method involves two steps:

1. Direct observational understanding
2. Explanatory understanding

The first step involved in the Verstehen method is 'direct observational understanding' of the obvious subjective meanings of actor's behaviour. At this stage, the social scientist looks at the social phenomenon from outside and attributes natural meanings to what he observes. Direct observational understanding is obtained directly, either because one knows the rules for a certain behavior (in church, for example) or by empathy when someone expresses his feelings. We understand most every day events in this intuitive manner. For example, through direct observation, we can know the meanings of an obviously hungry man or a man aiming a gun at an animal. We can grasp these meanings because we are aware of the subjective intentions which we attach to our like actions.

Second step involves, establishing an empathetic liaison with the actor. Here, the observer identifies himself with the actor by imaginatively placing himself in the actor's situation and then tries to interpret the likely meanings which

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the actor might have had given to the situation and the consequent motives which would have given rise to the action. We gain an explanatory understanding when we know the motives behind a person's actions. In this case, the action is explained precisely by the intent behind it: what the person wanted to achieve with the action. It is this type of explanatory understanding that science should work with, according to Weber. In order to trace the course and effect of social action, the sociologists should try to build a sequence of motives linking one with the other and finally linking them to the effect or consequences of social action. Weber wanted the interpretation of social action to be adequate both at the level of meanings as well as at the level of causality. An interpretation of a sequence of events is causally adequate, if careful observations lead to the generalization that it is probable that the sequence will always occur in the same way. Such a generalization should be derived statistically, as far as possible.

Illustration – Describing Social Action

How might we go about studying a person riding a bicycle? Adopting the techniques of a natural scientist we can measure how fast he is going, in what direction, how often he changed gear. We can say how tall or heavy he is, what the conditions are like and what kinds of materials the bike is made from. What we cannot determine just by looking at the cyclist, however, is *why* he is cycling. For this we need to adopt the approach of the social scientist, going beyond bare description in order to develop theories of action and motivation. Is the cyclist peddling quickly because he is late for a lecture in social theory or because he is trying to improve his fitness? Is he getting pleasure from cycling voluntarily, or is he having to do so because somebody has stolen his car? The full picture of cycling requires more than observation; it also requires interpretation.

However, according to some sociologists, it is not clear as to what Weber really meant when he wished to reconcile the interpretation of action by the Verstehen with the causal explanation. Interpreters of Weber have variously suggested that Verstehen merely generates causal hypotheses of meanings that can function as causes. The use of Verstehen has been criticized severely on the ground that there is no way of validating Verstehen interpretations. However, the advantage of Verstehen lies in the fact that it can be applied with equal ease to study contemporary social phenomena as well as to study the past historical phenomena. As Weber states, '*One does not have to be a Caesar to know Caesar*'.

According to Weber, social and historical reality consists of manifold actions and interests. When the investigator studies this "chaos of facts" he does so from certain points of view. The statement of the problem and the selection of facts the researcher makes are always related, consciously or unconsciously, to "cultural

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values." He studies what is important for him to study. Thus, according to Weber, there can never be any objective scientific analysis of cultural life, since the investigator always ascribes cultural significance to the phenomena he studies. Attempts to write an objective history are also based on certain cultural values. The problem, then, is that this also opens the door for various other kinds of value judgments.

While social science is value-relevant, it must also be value-neutral, according to Weber. Science can speak only of facts, never of values. Weber strongly stresses that there is a fundamental difference between "existential knowledge," that is, knowledge of what "is," and "normative knowledge," that is, what "should be". Every person has his values and the choice of these values is always subjective. Consequently, science can never state an opinion on "true" values, but must rather limit itself to analyzing the effects of various actions. But it can never say what action should be chosen. There is always an insurmountable chasm between empirical knowledge and value judgments. This difference between "is" and "ought" must prevent the scientist from using his prestige and knowledge to assert his own values at the expense of others.

To solve the problem of the relationship of science to values and the value-neutrality of science, Weber developed his *ideal-type* methodology. Further, Weber states that social reality by its very nature is infinitely complex and cannot be comprehended in its totality by the human mind. Therefore, selectivity is unavoidable and in order to exercise selectivity sociologists should build "*ideal types*". This also implies that *Verstehen* cannot be applied directly to social reality. The social scientist must first build the ideal type and then apply Verstehen method to the ideal type.

Although social theorists are always faced with the dilemma that there is a reality gap between the ideas and concepts they use and the really real world 'out there' , which they hope to explain by using them, Weber suggested that his could sometimes be turned into an advantage. Given that we are free to make up whatever concepts we like, it might be useful for social theorists to develop concepts that represent the purest form, or 'ideal type', of a particular phenomenon. Although there is no expectation that any particular instance of that phenomenon can match the ideal type, it nonetheless provides a useful intellectual tool for thinking about what the most essential or typical characteristics of a particular event or action might be. For example, in making sociological comparisons between different types of family in a particular society it can be useful to refer to different general types of family rather than attempting the impossible task of describing each and every family individually. Sociologists have developed the ideal-typical descriptions of 'nuclear family' and 'extended family'

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as part of their methodology. Ideal types provide a way of conceptualising differences even if the ideal type is never observed in its pure form. Weber uses the technique of ideal type in his own analysis of social action, religious ideology, and authority, in particular, bureaucracy.

An ideal type is a mental construct – a mental picture – that the investigator uses to approach the complex reality. The ideal type has nothing to do with "ideals," but is ideal only in a purely logical sense. The investigator can create ideal types of anything and none of them assesses any value. The ideal type is an instrument for the investigator to use as he attempts to capture the manifold nature of reality, and its utility lies in its "success in revealing concrete phenomena in their interdependence, their causal conditions and their *significance*". The investigator arrives at the ideal type through "the one-sided *accentuation* of one or more point of view and by the synthesis of a great many diffuse, discrete, more or less present and occasionally absent concrete individual phenomena, which are arranged according to those one-sidedly emphasized viewpoints into a unified *analytical* construct".

An ideal type is an analytical construct that serves the investigator as a measuring rod to ascertain similarities as well as deviations in concrete cases. It is neither a statistical average nor an hypothesis; rather it is a mental construct, an organization of intelligible relations within a historical entity, formed by exaggerating certain essential features of a given phenomenon so that no one case of that phenomenon corresponds exactly to the constructed type but every case of that phenomenon falls within the definitional framework. Thus an ideal type is never an accurate representation of the real thing. For example, as constructed by Weber, the ideal type of capitalism did not fully describe any of the various types of capitalism - mercantile capitalism, entrepreneurial capitalism (characteristic of the 18th and 19th century), matured industrial capitalism, etc. From the point of view of his study only some of the features of early entrepreneurial capitalism were relevant which depicted the spirit of capitalism. Therefore Weber isolated these elements and ideally represented these elements alone. Now these elements were not necessarily present in the later forms of capitalism, especially in mature industrial capitalism and finance capitalism. Thus ideal types do not and cannot mirror the reality faithfully.

The ideal type as Weber understood it had nothing to do with moral ideal, for the type of perfection implied in the ideal is purely a logical one and not to be found in pure form in any socio-historical situation. Any social phenomenon has an ideal type, be it a brothel, a house of worship or a market place. For Weber, an ideal type is strictly a "methodological device". The ideal type is a rational grid for logical observation and analysis. In other words, an ideal type is a rational construction for the purpose of research.

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Weber uses his ideal-type methodology in part to reject the idea that science can capture reality "as it is objectively." As a Neo-Kantian, Weber believed that concepts (ideal types) are always creations of human reason that never have a counterpart in reality. This also applies to the "laws" investigators believe they find in social reality. For example, when Weber discusses Marx he says the laws Marx and the Marxists thought they had found in history and in bourgeois society were actually nothing but ideal types. As ideal types, they have a very important significance if they are used in a comparison with reality, but according to Weber they are actually dangerous if we believe they are empirically valid or express actual forces in reality.

Ideal type is a one-sided view of social reality which takes into account certain aspects of social life while ignoring others. Which aspects are to be given importance to, and which are to be ignored depends upon the object of study. Thus, an ideal type is a way of exercising selectivity.

Ideal type formulation also helps in the developing the classificatory typology of the social phenomenon, thus facilitating a comprehensive understanding of the infinite social reality. For example, Weber developed classificatory typologies of social action, religious ideology and authority.

Ideal type can also help in establishing logical interconnections between different social constellations. For example, Weber in his work, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, builds ideal types of *the protestant ethic* and *the spirit of capitalism* and establishes the relationship between the two.

Ideal type also serves the investigator as a measuring rod to ascertain similarities as well as deviations in concrete cases, thus helpful in comparison with reality.

Ideal type also has a limited utility as a source of prediction. As discussed earlier, Weber argues that the laws Marx and the Marxists thought they had found in history and in bourgeois society were actually nothing but ideal types. As ideal types, they have a very important significance if they are used in a comparison with reality.

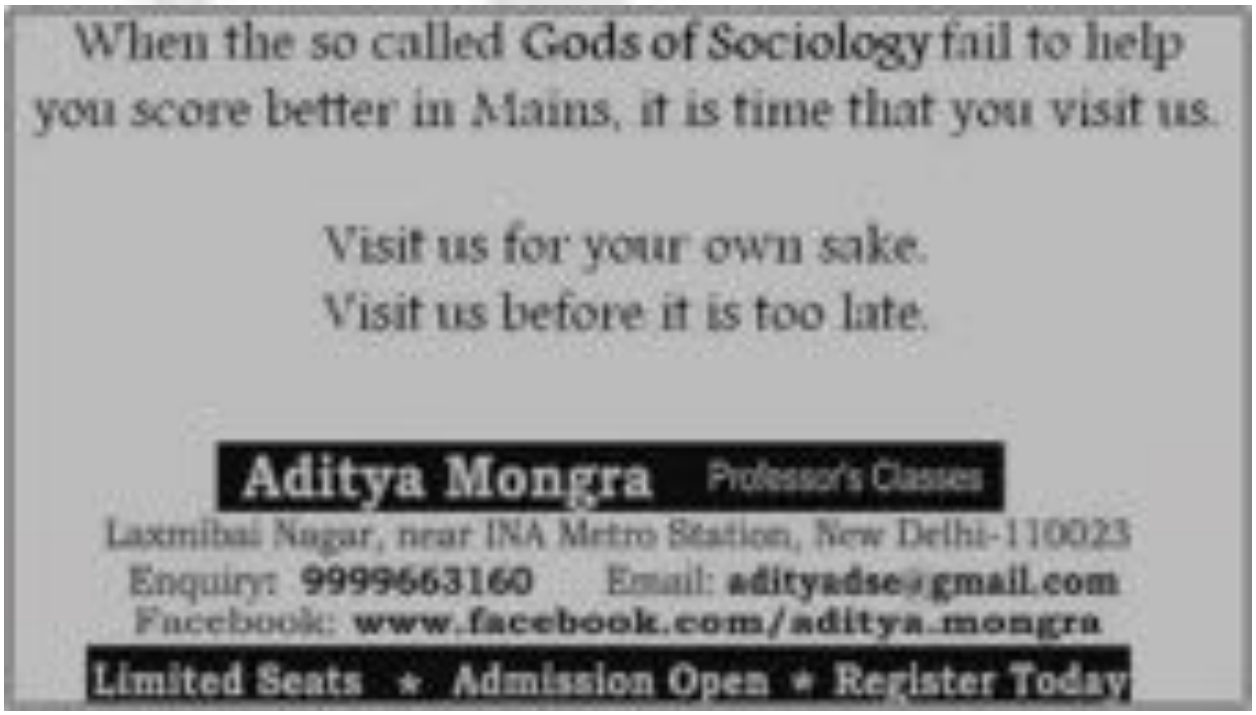
Further, although ideal type is rooted in reality, it does not represent reality in totality. It is a mental construct. Weber claims that ideal type is a social science equivalent of experimentation in physical and natural sciences. Experimentation is an essential element of scientific method to check the validity and reliability of the research findings in natural sciences. Since due to moral and ethical reasons experimentation is not possible in social sciences which are involved in the study of human behaviour, ideal type can serve as an equivalent of

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experimentation in social sciences. As experimentation is conducted under the controlled conditions, likewise an ideal type is also a rational construction based on selectivity.

Thus, according to Weber, the methodology of sociology consists in building ideal types of social behaviour and applying Verstehen method to explain this. Weber's thesis on "*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*" is a very good example of the application of this methodology. Besides contributing directly to the development of sociology by suggesting the 'Verstehen' approach and 'ideal types', Weber's general conception of the nature of social reality influenced the emergence of other approaches in sociology. For example, we can trace the origins of symbolic interactionism to Max Weber's argument that people act according to their interpretation of the meaning of their social world. But it was George Herbert Mead (1863-1931), a U.S. philosopher, who introduced symbolic interactionism to sociology in the 1920s. Similarly, ethnomethodologists draw heavily on the European tradition of phenomenological philosophy and in particular acknowledge a debt to the ideas of the philosopher–sociologist Alfred Schutz (1899-1959). Alfred Schutz, a German Social Philosopher was inspired by the ideas of Max Weber. He contributed to the rise of phenomenological approach which in turn gave rise to ethnomethodological approach in sociology.



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Another important element of Weber's methodology is *causal pluralism*. According to Weber, the social reality is extremely complex and therefore no social phenomena can be explained adequately in terms of a single cause. An adequate sociological explanation must therefore be based on the principle of causal pluralism.

Weber also stresses on the *value-neutrality* of social science methodology. He argues that since social science deals with phenomena that are value-laden, the researcher, both in choosing what to study and in reporting his findings, has to be aware of his own value and of the value-content of the phenomenon she is researching. Beginning with the problem of choice, for Weber, and again following Rickert, all observations, whether as part of a deductive or of an inductive procedure, is necessarily preceded by a judgement on the part of the observer about what is worth observing. Scientific knowledge, therefore, does not come about in an orderly fashion and following some carefully planned strategy that all the scientists in the world agree upon, but is a much more haphazard affair that reflects subjective judgements made by members or the scientific community. What we know is essentially a product of what we want to find out. Weber takes this line of reasoning a little further and argues that since it is impossible to grasp every tiny detail about a particular phenomenon, social scientists also have to be very selective when making more immediate decisions about which aspects of a phenomenon to study and in how much detail. Social- scientific knowledge can in fact only even be partial and selective.

Further, looking at value-neutrality in terms or how the observer handles the value-content of the research, Weber notes that values are not objective material entities and cannot be assessed, measured or compared in an entirely logical and dispassionate way. Adopting a rationalist approach to things, since knowledge is actually only a representation of some phenomenon or other in the mind, this representation is always arbitrary. The thing itself is not identical with the idea one has about it. Although conceptual arbitrariness is not so much of a problems when conducting experiments among things that have known and invariable properties, it makes quite a big difference when idea, values and beliefs are the objects of the analysis. The social researcher cannot disregard his own value, nor can he avoid studying values as they present themselves as social phenomena and as the motivators of social action. Being aware of the value-content of social-scientific methodology and of the subject matter itself, what the social research must strive to do is remain neutral in respect of the values that are in play. Social-scientific research fails and social-scientific knowledge is critically undermined if social researchers fail to keep their opinions to themselves. Social-theoretical knowledge, then, is the product of subjective judgement, is partial and selective, and, in at least some respects, arbitrary.

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To summarize, according to Weber, while social science is value-relevant, it must also be value-neutral. Weber admitted that at the level of technical competence values are unavoidable, for example, the very choice of the topic of research is influence by the values of the researcher. However still, the researcher must try to check his ideological assumptions from influencing his research. Further, the researcher should not pass any value judgements on the finding of his research. In other words, the researcher should remain indifferent to the moral implications of his research. Further, in order to ensure objectivity and value-neutrality in sociological research, Weber suggested that the researcher should make his value-preference clear in the research monograph. In other words, the researcher should be value-frank.



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Weber's account of the rise of modern, rational, capitalist society: 'rationality', *The Protestant Ethic and Spirit of Capitalism* and bureaucracy

As we noted in the introduction, it has become standard procedure in learning about social theory to compare Weber's explanation of the emergence of modern industrial capitalist society with Marx's account. We have to be interested in this comparison because the question of the causes and consequences of historical development remains a central part of the subject matter of social theory. Notwithstanding the fact, as already noted, that Weber was only familiar with a portion of Marx's work and was undoubtedly influenced by the simplified German Social Democratic Party reading of Marx, there were very few modern accounts to choose between and certainly Marx's historical-materialist analysis was a leading contender. Weber was, however, unhappy about the historical-materialist account for a number of reasons. A number of necessarily simplistic comparisons can be made.

First, Weber thought that it was highly unlikely that history develops according to any kind of grand plan, let alone the one that Marx describes. For Weber, human action is much more contingent than this in the sense that nobody can predict what all the circumstances and contexts of action will be. If you cannot specify the context, then there is little chance of foreseeing the action that will take place within it. The basic inability to specify what will happen next also applies to the consequences of action, many of which are quite unintended. Just because social actors hope that things will turn out in one way rather than another does not guarantee that they will. Regarding Marx's idea, for example, that capitalism must follow feudalism, Weber pointed out that capitalism is not in fact unique to modern society. Much of his historical analysis to concerned with showing that different forms of capitalistic or profit-making behaviour have characterised earlier forms of society. Modern industrial capitalism, in other words, is just one type, one variety of the different kinds of capitalism that, under different historical circumstances, could have developed. Weber is therefore inclined to be cautious about the contribution to social theory of the historical-materialist method.

A second weakness or the historical-materialist approach, as Weber saw it, was that it gave too much attention to the economic realm and thus underestimated what goes on in other aspects of social life. In trying to understand the origins of modern capitalism it is necessary to look at developments in the political, legal and religious spheres as well as in the economic sphere. Rather than accepting Marx's topographical representation of society as a pyramid with the broad economic base providing a foundation for all other superstructural phenomena, Weber is more inclined to see society as a series of overlapping realms, none of which has the power to control or dominate all of the others. He accepts the very great

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significance and influence of the economic sphere but does not see this as causative of all other phenomena in the way that Marx does.

A related weakness, according to Weber at least, is that while materialist theories inevitably give priority to material phenomena, ideational phenomena, including ideas, values and beliefs, but also the way social actors construct intellectual representations of reality in their minds, also need to be taken into account. One could press this point and suggest that at the point ideas become realised through practice, they also take on a material existence.

Having made these criticisms of the historical-materialist approach, Weber felt compelled to offer an alternative. After all, history had to develop in one way or another, and just because historical materialism fell short in its explanation this did not mean that other social theorists should not give it a try.

We will look at Weber's alternative under three headings:

- his comments about the development of a new kind of **rationality**, which became integral to the Western world view from the 16th century onwards;

- his detailed description in ***The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*** of how as new variant of the business or commercial spirit of capitalism coincided with the emergence of a particular kind of Protestant religious ethic in Northern Europe at around the same time;

- his comments about the inevitable spread of **bureaucracy.**

Rationality

Weber agreed with Marx that modern capitalism had become the dominant characteristic of modern industrial society. It was (and in fact still is) not possible to think of modern society without also thinking about the capitalist business enterprise that lies at the heat if it. Where he disagreed with Marx was over the explanation of how this state of affairs had come about. For Weber the originating cause, the fundamental root of this development, was not 'men making history' or 'the class struggle' but the emergence of a new approach to life based around a new kind of **rational** outlook. Thus new rationality had its roots in the various intellectual currents that emerged during the European Enlightenment.

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The main intention of the new rationality was to replace vagueness and speculation with precision and calculation. This was a profoundly practical kind of rationality in which social actors no longer behaved spontaneously or emotionally but only after making a careful consideration of the various alternatives available to them. The new rationality took the Enlightenment idea that people could control their own destiny and turned it into a strategy for action. It was all about controlling the outcomes of action, of eliminating fate and chance, through the application of **reason**. Weber called the new outlook **instrumental rationality** because it took the degree to which it enabled social actors to achieve the ends they had identified as its main criteria for judging whether an action was or was not rational. A characteristic of modern society is that actions are defined as rational as long as they are effective in achieving particular ends. The new instrumental rationality was also a 'universal rationality' in the sense that it affected the way in which decisions to act were made, not just in economic affairs, but across the full spectrum of activity. Weber argued that instrumental rationality had become a foundation for a new and highly rationalistic way of life or world view.

Rationalisation

In the same way that the term industrialisation describes what happens when economies take on industrial techniques, Weber used the term rationalisation to describe what happens when the different institutions and practices that surround social action take on the techniques of instrumental rationality. Modern society is modern because it has undergone this process of rationalisation. Although, as we have already noted, Weber agreed with Marx about the great significance for historical development of developments in the economic sphere, he argued that the massive expansion of the economic sphere as it entered its industrial stage was itself a consequence and not a cause of the spread of the new instrumental rationality. Weber noted, for example, that instrumental rationality was not confined to the economic sphere but also affected the development of democratic systems for electing governments, the rationalisation of government into different departments and the increasing use of bureaucracy as the most instrumentally rational way of organising complex organisations. The legal and medical professions, universities and research institutions and so on, are all similarly drawn under the influence of instrumental rationality. The uptake of instrumental rationality through rationalisation can be seen to be a driving force behind all forms of modernisation in modern society.

While factors identified by Marx, such as property relations, class conflict and developments in the means of production, clearly play an important part in how, at a lower and more descriptive level of analysis, the specific

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consequences are worked out, each of these is, according to Weber, an outlet for the underling urge to become increasingly rational. Recalling Durkheim's analysis of social solidarity and the new individualism, one might say that the instrumental rationality identified by Weber provides an important source of collective consciousness in modern society. Rationalisation and its consequences regulate the behaviour of social actor and thus contribute to social order.

Formal and substantive rationality

Before moving on to look at two detailed examples Weber provides of the actual impact of rationalisation on real situations (the capitalist business enterprise and the rise of bureaucracy), we should pause to make one further point about the new instrumental rationality. As ever, this requires some preliminary philosophical reflection on the qualitative dimensions of instrumental rationality. This concerns the distinction between **formal rationality** and **substantive rationality**. There is a tendency to assume that in describing the new instrumental rationality Weber somehow approves of it and of its effects on social life. This is partly unavoidable precisely because Weber goes to great lengths not to offer his own opinion (he would regard this as a serious transgression of the principle of value-neutrality discussed earlier). Nor does he wish to offer any suggestions about how things could be organised differently (although he is generally critical of the socialist alternative as he thinks the mode of bureaucratised social organisation it envisages would restrict individual freedom).

He does, however, make an important distinction between the rationality of something in terms of *how useful it is in a purely practical sense* (its formal rationality), and *how rational it is in terms of the ends it serves* (its substantive rationality). For example, it is clear the industrial division of labour is a more technically efficient, a more rational way of producing things than feudal agriculture. What is less clear is whether the decision to apply this type of organisation is an entirely rational one given that there is no guarantee that the general quality of life is also bound to improve. Just because social actors make sensible choices between the various techniques for doing something this does not necessarily help us decide if the ends they want to achieve are, in a more substantive sense, also rational. The atomic bomb is the most effective means of mass destruction but mass destruction is hardly a rational objective.

This dilemma runs parallel to the issue of value-neutrality discussed in the previous section. For Weber, one of the most difficult challenges of social theory is to account for the judgements social actors make, not so much over

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the best means for achieving something, but over which ends they feel are worth pursuing. The potential conflict between formal and substantive rationality is itself a consequence of the modernist perspective that emerged from the European Enlightenment. In pre-modernity crucial decisions about ultimate ends simply did not arise because the originating force in the universe was taken to be either nature or God. Having displaced nature with society and having marginalised the notion of the divine presence with the introduction of a strong concept of human self-determination, social actors in modern society have to make choices without reference to supra-human forces; choices that have been created by the powerful new technical means at their disposal.

It was the apparently indissoluble nature of these tensions between the formal and substantive rationalities of modern society, and between the rationalities of the different spheres of social action, that caused Weber to be extremely pessimistic about what the future might hold. If bureaucratic procedures cause a loss of liberty, or if, as Marx showed, the division of labour in industry cause alienation, would it be better not to use these techniques? Most fundamentally, and reflecting the instrumentality of the new outlook, Weber felt that as social actors become more and more obsessed with expressing formal rationality by improving the techniques they have for doing things, they become less and less interested in why they are doing them. The connection between means and ends becomes increasingly weakened even to the extent that ends come to be defined in terms of the unquestioned desirability of developing yet more means.

The ways in which these underlying tensions in the concept of instrumental rationality played themselves out in society provided Weber with a powerful way of theorising the sources of social conflict. Whereas Marx had correctly defined social conflict in terms of the struggle for economic resources, Weber added that important struggles also took place between one value system and another. The resources, in other words, over which social actors come into conflict, are not just economic ones but ideational and conceptual one as well. Capitalism dominated modern society not just because it is red hot at developing new techniques for producing things (it expresses very high levels of formal rationality, or in Marx's terms is very dynamic in developing the means of production), but because it engages sufficiently at the level of ideas for social actors to believe that this is a rational way to proceed.

The rational iron cage

Weber regrets the loss of high ideals and of meaning in existence that resulted from rationalization. The paradox and tragedy of our time is that rationalization has taught people to master nature, to develop technology for

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producing the means of survival, and to create administrative bureaucratic systems for regulating social life, while the existential basis of life – the choice of values and ideals and the search for meaning beyond soulless calculation of effective means for achieving a certain goal – is disappearing more and more. Modern man is trapped in a rational "iron cage of commodities and regulations" and he has lost his humanity. At the same time, he believes he has achieved the highest stage of development.



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The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism

Dropping down a level from Weber's more abstract development of the concept of rationality to describe the general causes of the process by which modern society develops, we can look at two examples of how Weber thought these principles worked themselves out in practice. The first is his influential description in *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (otherwise known as 'the Protestant ethic thesis') of how a particular set of business interests coincided with a specific religious orientation to produce the modern rational variant of capitalism (the second is his critical analysis of bureaucracy, which we will be looking at shortly). Along with his influential contribution to methodological issues in the social sciences, and of his analysis of rationality and social action, Weber's reputation as a major social theorist rest heavily on the two extended essays he published under this title in 1904 and 1905. In them, and drawing on the ideas and argument as we have just been looking at, he offers his description of the origins of modern capitalism:

> In the last analysis the factor which produces capitalism is the rational permanent enterprise with its rational accounting, rational technology and rational law, [complemented by] the rational spirit, the rationalisation of the conduct of life in general and a rationalistic economic ethic.
>
> Max Weber, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*

This brief quotation usefully summarises Weber's analysis of what is peculiar about *modern* capitalism. In contrast to earlier forms of profit making, the modern form is profoundly *rational* in the sense that its advocates try to keep risks to a minimum, behave in a highly calculating way when making business and investment decisions, and, perhaps most essentially, continue to make profits even when they have already passed the point of satisfying their own immediate needs. Reflecting the problematic nature of instrumental rationality as discussed in the previous section, profit making within modern capitalism becomes *an end in itself* rather than a means to an end. Recalling Marx's description, this amounts to a shift from the production of commodities that are valuable because of their practical use [or **use value**], to the production of commodities whose value lies in their abstract capacity for exchangeability [**exchange value**]. The production of use values is limited by the needs they satisfy, whereas the production of exchange values is unlimited.

In his sociology of religion, Weber used his ideal types to try to answer his fundamental question: Why was it in Europe that capitalism had its breakthrough and later became a dominant force in the world? This question cannot be answered as the Marxists did, simply by pointing to the initial accumulation of capital and

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the creation of a "free" class of wage laborers. Even though these institutional factors were important to the origin of capitalism, they do not explain why certain people in history began to act in a capitalist manner. According to Weber, Marxian view on the development of capitalism can at best be regarded as an ideal type construction highlighting the role of economic factor which contributed to the rise of capitalism.

Weber also rejected Engel's view that Protestantism rose in Europe as a legitimizing ideology to nascent capitalism which had already come into existence. Instead he emphasized the role of ideas as an independent source of change. Refuting Engel's argument he further states that capitalism existed in an embryo in Babylon, Roman, Chinese and Indian societies and in China and India other material conditions propitious for the development of capitalism also existed at certain stages in their history. But nowhere did it led to the development of modern capitalism. This phenomenon is peculiar to western society alone. The question arises as to why these embryos developed into the modern form of capitalism only in the west and nowhere else. An explanation in terms of the internal dynamics of economic forces alone is unable to account for this peculiarity. It is necessary to take into account specific ethos of the early European capitalistic entrepreneurs and realize that this was precisely what was absent in other civilizations.

After all, according to Weber, any explanation of a historical phenomenon must be traced back to human social action and, thus, the investigator must try to gain an explanatory understanding of why certain people acted as they did, based on those people's own conditions. It was this that Weber attempted to do in his famous study on the connection between the Protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism.

Early capitalism emerged in a part of Europe that had also undergone a religious reformation. What meaningful link was there between Protestantism and the appearance of capitalism?

Weber created two ideal types, the Protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism, to examine this question.

In his ideal type on the Protestant ethic, Weber dwells on the values and beliefs that arose within a particularly vigorous and **ascetic** variety of the Protestant faith, which developed in Northern Europe, and later in North America, during the 16th and 17th centuries. 'Asceticism' is an attitude of self-restraint, even self-denial, which imposes strict limits on the kind of enjoyment a person may take in the products of his or her work. For Weber, it was the historically fortunate coming together of this religious code of conduct or 'ethic', and the 'spirit' of the

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newly emerging and instrumentally oriented variety of capitalism, that launched rational capitalism into the modern world.

Weber argues that the originality of this new ascetic Protestantism lay not so much in ideas about living a good earthly life and having faith in the possibility of spiritual salvation, principles that had been around for quite a while already, but in the self-administered and thus psychological nature of the fear of not achieving spiritual salvation. Central to the Protestant faith is the idea that it is the individual and not the Church who carries responsibility for spiritual destiny (individual responsibility). The concept of individual conscience and individual responsibility was built around the idea of 'the calling' developed by the initiator of the Protestant faith, the German theologian Martin Luther (1483-1546). As Weber interprets it; 'The only way of living acceptably to God was through the fulfilment of the obligations imposed upon the individual by his position in the world. That was his calling'.

This key principle was supplemented soon after by the idea of 'predestination', put forward in the teaching of another Protestant theologian John Calvin (1509-64). Calvin in his doctrine of predestination argued that God, in his omnipotence, has determined the fate of every man long before that man is born. Thus God has decided which people will gain salvation and which are condemned to eternal damnation. Those who had not been chosen were destined never to achieve spiritual salvation. At first sight this position seems paradoxical. If spiritual salvation has been settled in advance then what is to be gained from pursuing earthly toil in a godly manner, why not simply lead a life of pleasure and idleness?

Calvin emphasised, however, that precisely since there can be no certainty of salvation individuals must prove their spiritual salvation by leading an exemplary life on earth. Moreover, this proof could not simply be demonstrated abstractly by believing in the possibility of salvation hereafter, but through concrete action in the present. Intense worldly activity thus became indispensable 'as a sign of election': '[It is] the technical means, not of purchasing salvation, but of getting rid of the fear of damnation'. Through frenetic devotion to one's calling, the individual is provided with a means of demonstrating how certain they are about being saved. Conveniently, 'the earning of money within the modern economic order is, so long as it is done legally, the result and the expression of virtue and proficiency in a calling'. Ascetic Protestantism thus unequivocally ties spiritual destiny to profoundly practical and energetic ethic of hard work.

Weber constructs the other ideal type, the spirit of capitalism, on the book *Advice to a Young Tradesman* written in 1748 by Benjamin Franklin (1706-90). In

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this book Franklin offers advice to those who would like to succeed in business. He believes they must remember that time is money, that credit is money, and that money, with hard work, can produce more money. This focus on the multiplication of money is also linked to a call for a moral and ascetic life in which those who have provided credit would rather hear the sound of a hammer at five o' clock in the morning then see the borrower at the pool table.

Irrespective of whether salvation is actually achieved through hard work, the practical outcome of the idea that it might gave rise to a work-obsessed class of entrepreneurs and business people whose earthly desire for commercial success ran parallel with their religious desire for spiritual redemption. Since the enjoyment of wealth is considered sinful, the only legitimate use for the increasing revenue is to reinvest it in the business itself. The pragmatic saving of capital is justified by the higher substantive aim of the saving of souls. For Weber, it is this coincidence within the Protestant ethic between obsessive hard work and an ascetic attitude towards the wealth it generates that lies at the heart of the 'elective affinity' or sympathetic association between Protestantism and capitalism:

'When the limitation of consumption is combined with the release of acquisitive activity, the inevitable practical result is obvious: accumulation of capital through ascetic compulsion to save. The restraints imposed upon the consumption of wealth naturally served to increase it by making possible the productive investment of capital.'

- Max Weber

The hard-working, hard-saving, soul-searching mentality embedded within the Protestant work ethic filtered down the social hierarchy eventually establishing itself as the most practical and legitimate way of achieving prosperity in modern society. Making good use of time, being busy not idle, avoiding frivolity, self-indulgence and wastefulness, are common principles of behaviour that have undoubtedly shaped the mentality of modern Western society.

In summary, then, the argument Weber puts forward in his Protestant ethic thesis tries to provide a multidimensional explanation of how modern capitalism really got going. The basic point he wants to get across is that although the very large amounts of capital that capitalism needed to get started did, from a technical point of view, come by way of developments in the versatility of the division of labour and the efficiency of the means of production, these developments were themselves a result of a qualitative change in the general approach to life and work; a general approach based on new ideas, values and beliefs. Weber's explanation can be much more precise about the timing of the whole modern capitalist adventure (Northern Europe in the period 1650-1750), because the release of spare capital is tied to a specific coming together of commercial attitudes and the religious teaching of Luther and Calvin. Unlike the historical-materialist

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account, which relies on the theoretical construct of developments in the means and relations of production to predict the emergence of capitalism from feudalism, Weber's thesis gives the whole event a real sense of historical actuality. Modern rational capitalism emerged because of the collision at a particular time and place of a particular set of real but unpredictable circumstances. Some of these circumstances were material ones (technical innovation, new commercial opportunities), but others came from the realm of ideas.

Getting back to Weber's underlying argument that the whole ethos of modern society changed with the emergence of the new rationality, he felt that what the twin beliefs in saving one's capital and saving one's soul had in common was the fact that they both defined rationality in highly instrumental terms. If by working hard it is possible to achieve earthly comfort, and enhance one's sense of having spiritual future thereafter, then hard work becomes the pivotal activity of one's life. Hard work is legitimately regarded as having very high levels of formal rationality because it is the practical means of achieving the substantively rational goals of prosperity and salvation. Nobody in the West is ever criticised for working too hard because hard work is the best means of achieving these highest ends.

Weber believes that even though the content of the two cultures, the Protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism, were different and based on different assumptions, they lead to similar actions. Protestant action was value-rational action, that is, it attempted, to live up to the value of being saved and to find signs of salvation. Capitalist action is purposive rational action, that is, it attempts to find effective means of achieving an end, the multiplication of money. To the Protestant, the ascetic life and diligence were part of a life lived in the glory of God and were not directed toward the multiplication of money. Despite this, however, it broke with what Weber calls the "feudal spirit," which contained an irrational use of wealth in the form of a life of luxury. In order for capitalism to rise, this form of the luxurious use of wealth had to give way to an accumulation and reinvestment of accumulated money. The Protestant ethic played a key role in this transition. According to Weber, early modern capitalism was characterized by the institutionalization of "gain spirit" where the ethical and religious ideas regulated and provided legitimization and justification of the pursuit of economic goals.

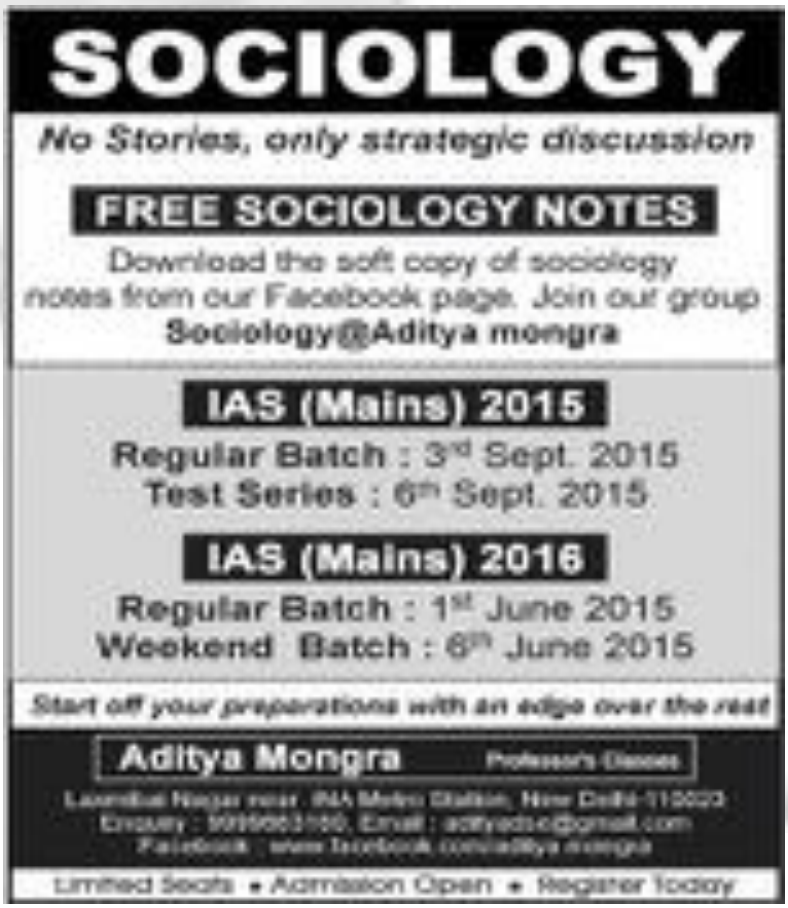
Asceticism contributed to a rational moulding of every aspect of life. Constant control through a systematic effort resulted in a rationalization of individual conduct even in the conduct of business. Thus the adherents to the Protestant ideology became adept in rationalizing economic action while leading an austere and ascetic life. This entrepreneurial attitude, hard work, rational organization of conduct and frugal living together constituted the spirit of capitalism, which according to Weber was fostered through the Protestant ethic. To

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avoid misunderstanding, Weber specified that the causal relationship between Protestantism and capitalism should not be taken in the sense of a mechanical relationship. Due to his belief in causal pluralism, Weber states that the Protestant ethos was some of the sources of rationalization of life which helped to create what is known as the *spirit of capitalism*. It was not the sole cause, not even a sufficient cause of capitalism. Raymond Aron makes Weber's position clear when he writes, 'Protestantism is not the cause but one of the causes of capitalism or rather it is one of the causes of certain aspects of capitalism'.

Thus Weber has clearly stated that only the spirit of capitalism was created by the Protestant ethos. While there were number of other contributory factors which along with the spirit of capitalism helped in the growth of capitalism. Further Weber made a comparative study of world religions in terms of their beliefs and practices and their repercussions on social life. Weber analyzed Confucianism and Taoism in China, Hinduism and Buddhism in India, and finally ancient Judaism. He also planned, but was unable to complete, studies on Islam, Talmudic Judaism, early Christianity, and various religious sects within the Reformation. The studies Weber carried out deal with the various social conditions in which the different religions operated, the social stratification, the links of various groups to different religious, and the importance of various religious leaders.



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With the help of comparative study he built a typology of religions. He pointed that religious activity can be classified into two categories:

1) Asceticism, and

2) Mysticism

Asceticism consists of the belief that God direct religious activity, so that the believer sees himself to be the instrument of the divine will. Therefore the purpose of this life is not to waste it in luxuries and pleasures of flesh, rather one should lead a disciplined life to realize the glory of God.

Mysticism, on the other hand, consists of a consciousness not so much of being an instrument of God but of what Weber calls a *vassal* of God. Religious activity, in this case, is a question of achieving a condition akin to the divine. This is accomplished by contemplation on truths than those which can be demonstrated in this world.

Next, according to Weber, asceticism can manifest itself in two forms – inner worldly asceticism and other worldly asceticism. Inner worldly asceticism is where individuals not only feel themselves to be the instrument of God's will, but seek to glorify God's name through performing good work in the world. Here success in this world itself becomes a sign of divine approval. Other worldly asceticism, on the other hand, is where the individuals renounce the world so that they may be of service to God alone, as in the case of monastic orders.

Here, Weber pointed out that only inner worldly ascetic types of religious beliefs which make the believer treat day to day working as the calling of God will foster the spirit of capitalism. The other worldly asceticism and mysticism will not be conducive to the growth of the spirit of capitalism. Certain sets of Protestantism alone were the inner worldly ascetic type and hence contributed to the rise of modern capitalism. On the other hand, other religions like Hinduism, Confucianism, and Buddhism etc., were either other worldly ascetic or had a preponderance of the mysticism and therefore failed to foster the spirit of capitalism, although material conditions propitious for the development of capitalism were present in Indian and Chinese societies.

Weber did not believe that Protestantism "caused" capitalism or that the early Protestants were cynical money-worshipers (although there were isolated examples of this). Instead, using his fundamental methodology, he attempted to understand acting people so that, on the basis of this knowledge, he could explain historical events. Once capitalism had become established, it no longer needed this value-based foundation as a criterion for action. It was sufficient that purposive

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rational action had become institutionalized, as it was in the modern capitalist company. But in the transition from precapitalist to capitalist action, some justification was needed for the first capitalist to begin acting in an ascetic and world-oriented manner. According to Weber, the Protestant ethic contributed just this kind of strong force that could make people begin acting differently and not simply on the basis of tradition.

As stated earlier, in addition to analyzing the role of Protestantism in the rise of early capitalism, Weber also worked on a major comparative study of world religions. This study did not deal with the metaphysical "essence" of the various religions, rather Weber analyzed the importance religion had for the "the conditions and effects of a particular type of social action". Weber was particularly interested in how various religions hindered or promoted a special sort of economic rationality and, in this sense, the study of world religions was part of Weber's overall investigation of what specific factors led to the rational capitalism of the Western world.

Weber summarized his results in a brief introduction when his collected studies on religion were published. The fundamental question he asks is "to what combination of circumstances the fact should be attributed that in Western civilization, and in Western civilization only, cultural phenomena have appeared which (as we like to think) lie in a line of development having universal significance and value". As a result of his analysis of the various religions of the world and their respective social conditions, Weber distinguished a number of factors that separated the West from other societies. These factors are:

1 Science. To be sure, empirical knowledge, consideration of the problems of the world and of life, and philosophical and ideological wisdom have developed in other cultures as well, but they lack the systematic development of knowledge based on natural science and experimentation that is found in the West. The West has also developed systematic forms of thought and rational concepts within historical research and law.

2 Art. In music the West has developed a rational harmony-based music with counter-point and chordal harmony, a notation system that allows the composition and performance of modern musical works, and a number of instruments such as the organ, piano, violin, etc. In architecture, only the West has developed a rational use of the Gothic arch to distribute weight to reach over all kinds of rooms. Only in the West has a printing art appeared that is aimed solely at literature.

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3 Administration. Although other cultures have also had institutions of higher learning similar on the surface to the Western university, it is only here that there is a rational, systematic, and specialized practice of science by trained experts. This has led to the development of professionally trained organizations of officials and to the fact that the "most important functions of the everyday life of society have come to be in the hands of technically, commercially, and above all legally trained government officials".

4 The State. Of course, there is a form of "state" in all cultures, but "the State itself, in the sense of a political association with a rational, written constitution, rationally ordained law, and an administration bound to rational rules or laws, administrated by trained officials, is known, in this combination of characteristics, only in the Occident".

5 Economics. In all cultures and in all groups there is and has always been a "lust for money" and it is not that distinguishes Western capitalism from the economies of other cultures. Rather, it is the rational bridling of this irrational impulse that makes possible the appearance of a rational capitalism. This capitalism is based on the "expectation of profit by utilization of opportunities for exchange, that is on (formally) peaceful chances of profit". In addition, it is only here that the specifically capitalist organization of labour has developed with rational calculation, based on a free labour force. Only here has the economy developed a systematic use of technology and, moreover, "modern rational capitalism needs… a calculable legal system and administration in terms of formal rules".

The final result of this comparative sociology of religion is that the specific nature of Western development is that there is a "specific and peculiar rationalism of Western culture". Thus, according to Weber, the basis of this unique Western development is not to be found in the economy, but in its unique rationalization process. Weber believed inner worldly asceticism to be a crucial factor in the rationalisation of social life. Capitalism is simply an expression of this rationalization, just as the modern state with its administration and armies, bureaucracy, legitimatization of power, science, and art all are. It is the discovery of this rationalization process that is perhaps Weber's most important contribution to social science. This argument of Weber implies that any religious (or secular) ideology which emphasises on the inner worldly ascetic attitude towards life would lead to rationalisation of social life.

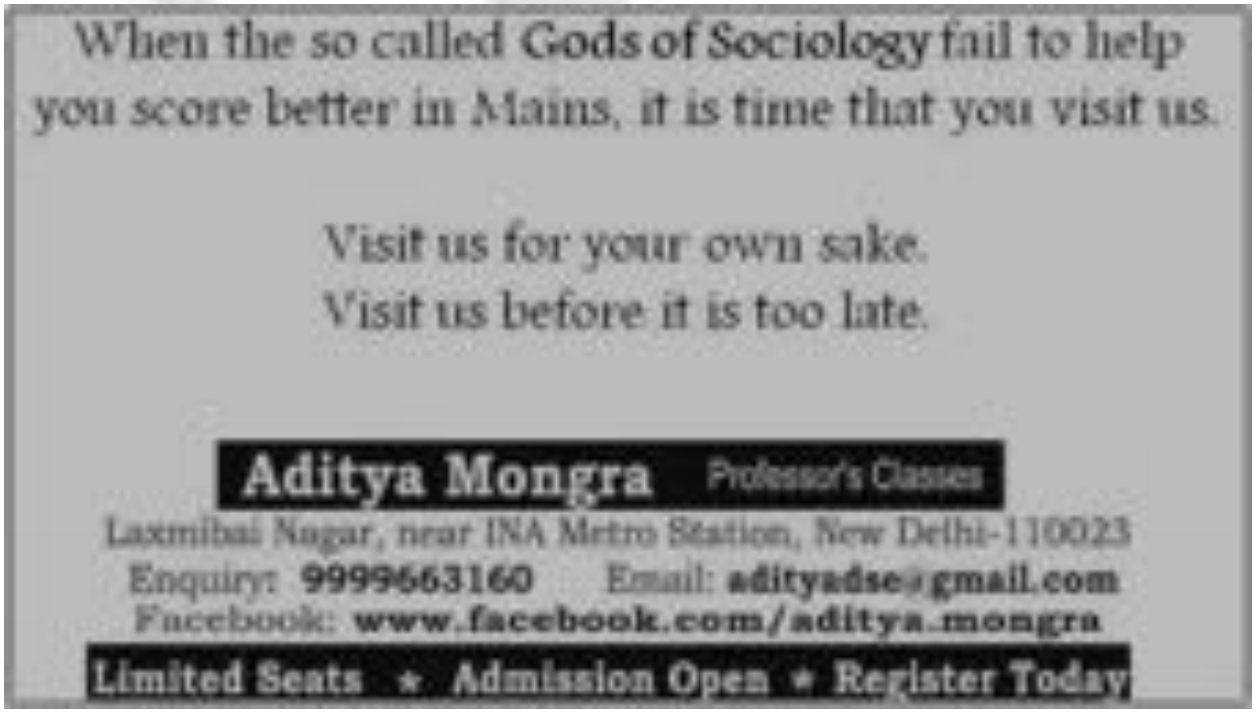
Balwant Nevaskar, in his book, *Capitalist without Capitalism: Jains of India and the Quakers of the West* (1971), states that Max Weber was the first sociologist to have sociologically studied the major religions of India. These studies are

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contained in his book "*The Religion of India*" (by Max Weber, the original edition was in German and was published in 1916). Max Weber maintains that the Jains are an exclusive merchant sect and that there is apparently "a positive relationship between Jainism and economic motivation which is otherwise quite foreign in Hinduism". Weber seems to suggest that although Jainism is spiritualized in the direction of world renunciation, some features of inner worldly asceticism are also present in it. To begin with, it can be observed that the twin doctrines of "predestination" and the "calling" implied in Protestantism are only indirectly present in Jainism but they must be understood in the light of Karma, and not in relation to God. Many aspects of rational conduct promoting savings such as thriftiness, self-discipline, frugality and abstention as part of this worldly asceticism, however, are directly present in Jainism.

In "*The Protestant Ethic and the Parsis*," Robert Kennedy does just this and suggests that Zoroastrianism — an ancestral monotheism — set the stage for Modernity, which encompasses not only capitalism but also science. Kennedy identifies five abstract values associated with Modernity: (1) an underlying order in nature, (2) sensory standard of verification, (3) material work is intrinsically good, (4) maximization of material prosperity, and (5) accumulation rather than consumption of material goods. Using historical data on the Parsis or Zoroastrian Persians who fled from Iran to India after the Islamic conquest in the 8th century AD, Kennedy examines their beliefs, culture, and society for correspondences. Finding many, Kennedy suggests that modern economy and science may have roots in Zoroastrian religion.



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Similarly, Clifford Geertz carried out his study in East Java, Indonesia, in the early 1950s with an intention to find a local variant of the Protestant ethic in Muslim societies — inspired by Weber's famous "*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*." Please note that the dominance of the Weberian perspective among US scholars in general at the time was one factor. Geertz was a student of Talcott Parsons, and Parsons was the one who introduced Weber to American academia by translating "The Protestant Ethic" into English. But of course Geertz's choice to use the Weberian perspective was not simply because of this teacher-student relation. The most important reason was because he tried to find the relation between religious ideas and human conduct, politics and economic development — between religion and social change. For this analytical endeavor, Weber provided very useful tools.

Weber study of "*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*" opened up new vistas of research on the factors contributing to the rise of modern industrial capitalist society in Europe and elsewhere. Please note that Weber emphasized on the role of ideas in shaping the motivations and life styles of future capitalists. For him, it was an independent factor responsible of the rise of capitalism. He did not totally reject Marxian theory of rise of capitalism which sought to explain capitalist development in terms of economic forces. He regarded the Marxist view as an ideal type model highlighting the role of one set of factors i.e. economic factors. Weber advocated that the rise of modern capitalism can be explained only by taking into account the multiplicity of factors at work.

After Weber, a number of scholars have attempted to explain the development of capitalism and in the process have highlighted some new factors which contributed to the growth of modern capitalism. These later day theories of capitalism should be treated as complementary to those of Marx and Weber.

For example, Neil Joseph Smelser, an American sociologist, in his study of third world countries, found that the state played an important role in the rise of capitalism. He argued that nationalistic ideology (secular inner worldly asceticism) in the third world societies has played the same role which protestant ethos did in the case of Europe in the rise of capitalism.

Werner Sombart, a German economist and sociologist, was deeply influenced by the ideas of Marx and Weber. According to Sombart, the development of capitalism can be divided into three stages:

Early capitalism, ending before the industrial revolution;
High capitalism, beginning about 1760; and,
Late capitalism, beginning with World War I.

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The moving force during the first stage of capitalism was a small number of enterprising businessmen, emerging from all groups of population – noble men, adventurers, merchants and artisans. Here he also highlighted the importance of the flow of *precious metal* (Gold, Silver, etc.) into Europe from South America. Sombart, in his book *The Jews and Modern Capitalism*, also highlighted the role of Jews in the development of modern capitalism. In addition, he accepted Weber's views that Protestant ethic emphasized values of hard work while deferring gratification and such an attitude favoured creation of capital and its productive reinvestment rather than consumption.

Another scholar, Andre Gunder Frank (1929–2005), a German-American economic historian and sociologist, who promoted dependency theory after 1970s, has emphasized the role of colonial rule or imperial domination in the development of capitalism among imperial powers. The colonial expansion divided the world into two major zones and created an international division of labour. In such a division, the colonies supplied cheap raw materials to the European imperial powers to feed their manufacturing industries. The manufactured goods were exported back to the colonies which served also as markets. This colonial relationship helped in the rapid capitalist development in the European countries while destroying the handicraft industries of the colonies and suppressing economic growth there.

Weber's thesis on Protestant ethic and the rise of Spirit of Capitalism has also been criticized on various accounts. Famous English historian R H Tawney has pointed out that the empirical evidence on which Weber's interpretation of Protestantism was based was too narrow. According to him, England was the first country to develop capitalism. However, the English Puritans did not believe in the doctrine of predestination. However, sympathisers of Weber argue that this criticism is based on the narrow interpretation of his work. They argue that it was only an ideal type construction which sought to establish a connection between certain aspects of Protestantism with only some aspects of early entrepreneurial type of capitalism. All that Weber was trying to say was that Protestant ethic contributed to the rationalization which preceded modern capitalism. At no stage did Weber claim it to be the sole cause. In fact, Weber did admit to the possibility of building other ideal types linking other contributory factors to capitalism. Thus Weber's thesis should not be treated as a general theory of capitalism development. It is more ideographic in nature. Further Weber clearly states that the spirit of capitalism was only one component, albeit an important one. There are other components too which together with the spirit constituted the modern capitalism. These components are private ownership of the means of production, technological development such as mechanization or automation, formally free labour, organization of capitalist producers into joint stock companies, a universalistic

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legal system which applied to everyone and is administered equitably, etc. All these elements together form the basis of the ideal type of modern capitalism.

Critics also point out that modern capitalism is no longer guided by inner worldly asceticism but hedonism. In this regard it can be stated that Weber in his work was only concerned with one dimension of capitalism, that is, the emergence of early capitalism and it link to the protest ethos. Weber had stated in his methodology that since social reality is infinite we can study social reality scientifically only with the help of ideal types. Further, he stressed on the fact given the infinite and dynamic nature of social reality, the researcher should only aim at limited generalisations. As far as the challenges of late capitalism are concerned, Weber did express his concern for the predomination of formal or instrumental rationality at the expense of substantive rationality.



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Bureaucracy

As previously discussed, Max Weber has defined power as, "the chance of a man or a number of men to realize their own will in a communal action even against the resistance of others who are participating in the action." Power is therefore an aspect of social relationships. An individual or group do not hold power in isolation, they hold it in relation to others. Power is therefore power over others.

Depending on the circumstances surrounding its use, sociologists classify power in two categories. When power is used in a way that is generally recognized as socially right and necessary, it is called legitimate power. Power used to control others without the support of social approval is referred to as illegitimate power. Thus from legal point of view, power has been classified into legitimate and illegitimate power. **Authority** is that form of power which is accepted as legitimate, that is as right and just, and therefore obeyed on that basis. In other words, when the power is legitimized it becomes authority and only then it is accepted by people voluntarily. **Coercion** is that form of power which is not regarded as legitimate by those subject to it. For example, government agents demanding and receiving sales tax from a shopkeeper are using legitimate power; gangsters demanding and receiving protection money from the same shopkeeper by threat of violence are using illegitimate power.

Thus when power gets institutionalized and comes to be accepted as legitimate by those on whom it is being exercised, it is termed authority. Weber's study of authority has to be understood in the context of his general typology of social action. As discussed earlier, Weber built various ideal types of social action which are distinguished by the meanings on which they are based. These include traditional action, affective action, and rational action (both goal-rational and value rational).

Max Weber further argues that the nature of authority is shaped by the manner in which the legitimacy is acquired. Thus, Weber identifies three ideal types of authority systems viz., the traditional authority, the charismatic authority and the legal-rational authority.

The traditional authority is the characteristic of those societies where the 'traditional action' is predominant. Traditional action is based on established custom. An individual acts in a certain way because of an ingrained habit, because things have always been done that way. In those societies where traditional action is a predominant mode of behaviour, exercise of power is seen as legitimate when it is consonance with the tradition and conforms to the customary rules. Such type

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of authority was termed by Weber as traditional authority. Weber identified two forms of traditional authority i.e. patriarchalism and patrimonialism. In patriarchalism, authority is distributed on the basis of gerentocratic principles. Thus the right to exercise authority is vested in the eldest male member. This type of authority is to be found in case of very small scale societies like the Bushmen of Kalahari desert or in case of extended kin groups in agrarian societies like lineage or joint families in India.

When the patriarchal domination has developed by having certain subordinate sons of the patriarch or other dependents take over land and authority from the ruler, Weber calls this patrimonial domination and a patrimonial state can develop from it. In the patrimonial state, such as Egypt under the Pharaohs, ancient China, the Inca state, the Jesuit state in Paraguay, or Russia under the czars, the ruler controls his country like a giant princely estate. The master exercises unlimited power over his subjects, the military force, and the legal system. Patrimonial dominance is a typical example of the traditional exercise of power in which the legitimacy of the ruler and the relationships between him and his subjects are derived from tradition. Patrimonialism is characterized by the existence of hereditary office of a king or a chief and an administrative staff consisting of courtiers and favourites who together form a nascent bureaucracy. The king or the chief exercises absolute and arbitrary power, subject only to customary rules.

Second type of authority is charismatic authority which corresponds to affective action. Charisma refers to a certain quality of an individual's personality by virtue of which, he is set apart from ordinary men and treated as endowed with the supernatural, superhuman or at least specifically exceptional power or qualities. These qualities are not accessible to an ordinary person but are regarded as of divine origin and on the basis of them the individual concerned is treated as a leader and is revered. Charismatic type to authority can exist in all types of societies. Charismatic authority gains prominence in the times of crisis where other forms of authority prove inadequate to deal with the situation. Thus heroes who help to win the war or people with the reputation for therapeutic wisdom who come to regarded as saviours in times of epidemics and prophets in times of general moral crisis come to acquire charismatic authority.

Please note that the administrative staff of a charismatic leader does not consist of officials at least its members are not technically trained. It is not chosen to the basis of social privilege nor from the point of view of personal loyalty. It is rather chosen in terms of the charismatic qualities of its members. The prophet has his disciples, the war lord his selected henchmen, the leader generally his followers. There is no such thing as appointment, no career, no promotion. There is only a call at the instance of the leader on the basis of his charismatic qualities.

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There is no hierarchy, the leader merely intervenes in general or in individual cases when he considerers the members of his staff inadequate to a task which they have been entrusted with. Often there is no definite sphere of authority and of competence though there may be territorial mission. Also there is no such thing as salary or benefit. Disciplines or followers tend to live primarily in a communal relationship with their leader, means for which have been provided for by voluntary gifts. There is no system of formal rules or legal principles, or judicial process oriented to them.

Charismatic authority lies outside the realism of everyday routine and the profane sphere. In this respect it is sharply opposed, both to rational or bureaucratic authority and to traditional authority. Both bureaucratic and traditional authorities are bound by certain type of rules, while charismatic authority is foreign to all rules. Due to this freedom from established rules, charismatic authority can act as a great revolutionary force.

The charismatic movement, with its charismatic authority, differs on several important points from both traditional organizations and bureaucracies. Charisma is a force that is fundamentally outside everyday life and, whether it be religious or political charisma, it is a revolutionary force in history that is capable of breaking down both traditional and rational patterns of living; but charismatic domination is unstable in nature. The authority of the charismatic leader stems from "the supernatural, superhuman, or, at least, specifically exceptional powers" he possesses, at least in the eyes of his followers. This force lies outside the routines of everyday life, and the problem arises when this extraordinary force is to be incorporated into a routine everyday life. Weber calls this process the "routinization of charisma," which means that the leader (or if he is dead, his successor) and the followers want to make "it possible to participate in normal family relations or at least to enjoy a secure social position." When this happens, the charismatic message is changed into dogma, doctrine, regulations, law, or rigid tradition. The charismatic movement develops into either a traditional or a bureaucratic organization, "or a combination of both".

As stated earlier, charismatic authority is inherently unstable. This is on account of several reasons. Firstly, charismatic authority is the product of a crisis situation and therefore lasts so long as the crisis lasts. Once the crisis is over the charismatic authority has to be adapted to everyday matters. This is called the process of routinization of charisma. Thus charismatic authority may be transformed into either traditional or legal-rational authority. Secondly, one of the decisive motives underlying all cases of routinization of charisma is naturally the striving for security. This means legitimizing on one hand of the position of authority and on the other hand of the economic advantages enjoyed by the followers of the leader. Thirdly, another important motive, however, lies in the

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objective necessity of adaptation of the patterns of order, of the organization, and of the administrative staff to the normal, everyday needs and conditions of carrying on the administration. Finally, there is the problem of succession which renders charismatic authority unstable since basis of authority is the personal charisma of the leader. It is not easy to find a successor who also possesses those charismatic qualities. Thus in charismatic authority, discontinuity is inevitable. One of the solutions to the problem of discontinuity is to transform the charisma of the individual into the charisma of the office which can be translated to every incumbent of the office by ritual means. Most important example is the transmission of the charisma of a royal authority by anointing and by coronation. This ideal type of charismatic authority is extremely helpful in the study of radical transformation of traditional societies like Russia, China, India, Egypt and other Third World countries. All these societies had charismatic leaders to meet the crisis of transition. Thus you can understand the significance and nature of the authority exercised by Gandhi in India, Lenin in Russia, Mao in China and Nasser in Egypt.



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The third ideal type of authority, which corresponds to rational action, is legal-rational authority or bureaucracy. Having begun to define modern society in terms of the spread of instrumental rationality, Weber goes on to argue that as society becomes more and more complex (both in terms of its economics arrangements, and in terms of its increasing institutional sophistication), the quest for an appropriately rational means of organisation also becomes increasingly urgent. Since the most rational means of organisation is bureaucratic organisation, he felt it was inevitable that bureaucracy would become an ever more dominant feature of modern society. The importance of this development for Weber's social theory is that bureaucracy provides a fine example of a technique of formal rationality that is found in all spheres of social life. In fact, whether in the economy or in the legislative and administrative functions of the state, progress comes to depend on the availability of bureaucratic means of organisation and administration.

In other words, according to Weber, all societies are gradually moving away from traditional type of authority to legal-rational type of authority. Europe was the first to experience this transformation. But, Weber regarded those processes as inevitable in all societies advancing towards industrial civilization. In industrial societies, rational action becomes the most predominant form of social behaviour. Weber has termed this process of increasing preponderance of rational action as rationalization. With increasing rationalization, legal-rational authority becomes the most common form of authority system.

Legal-rational authority differs sharply from its charismatic and traditional counterparts. Legitimacy and control stem neither from the perceived personal qualities of the leader and the devotion they exercise, nor from a commitment to traditional wisdom. Authority is based on the acceptance of a set of impersonal rules. Those who possess authority are able to issue commands and have them obeyed because other accepts the legal framework which supports their authority. Thus a judge, a tax inspector or military commander are obeyed not on the basis of tradition or as a result of their charisma but because of the acceptance of legal statuses and rules which grant them authority and define the limits of that authority. These rules are rational in the sense that they are consciously constructed for the attainment of a particular goal and they specify the means by which that goal is to be attained. As Weber's view of rational action suggested, precise calculation and systematic assessment of the various means of attaining a goal are involved in the construction of rules form the basis of legal- rational authority.

Like other forms of authority, legal-rational authority produces a particular kind of organizational structure – the bureaucracy. Weber defined bureaucracy as, "a hierarchical organization designed rationally to coordinate work of many individuals in the pursuit of large-scale administrative tasks and organizational

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goals. Weber constructed an ideal type of the rational-legal bureaucratic organization. He argued that bureaucracies in modern industrial societies are steadily moving towards his pure type.

The main characteristics of the ideal-type bureaucracy as envisaged by Weber can be summarised as follows:

- Bureaucracy is an expert system of administration based on detailed documentation and record-keeping. The regular activities required for the purposes of the organizations are distributed in a fixed way as **official duties**. Each administrative official has a clearly defined area of competence and responsibility.
- Bureaucracies have a rigidly **hierarchical organisational structure** with clear lines of communication and responsibility.
- The operation of bureaucracy is governed by a **legalistic framework** of formal rules and regulations.
- Decisions are made through the application of specific procedures designed to **eliminate subjective judgements**. The legitimacy of bureaucracy and of bureaucrats is based on a strict separation of individual personality from the task being done. The ideal official performs his duties in a spirit of formalistic impersonality, without hatred or passion. The activities of a bureaucrat are governed by the rules, not by personal consideration such as his feeling towards colleagues or clients. His actions are therefore rational rather than affective. Business is conducted according to calculable rules and without regard for persons.
- Authority is a characteristic of the post not of the post holder.
- It is not possible to become a bureaucrat without the correct formal qualifications and credentials. Officials are appointed on the basis of **technical knowledge** and **expertise**. Weber states, "Bureaucratic administration means fundamentally the exercise of control on the basis of knowledge. This is the feature which makes it specifically rational." Thus official are selected in terms of the contribution their particular knowledge and skills can make to the realization of organizational goals. Once appointed, the official is full time paid employee and his occupation constitutes a career. Promotion being based on seniority or achievement or a combination of both.
- Finally, bureaucratic administration involves **a strict separation between private and official incomes**. The official does not own any part of the organization for which he works nor can he use his position for private gain. In Weber's words, bureaucracy segregates official activity as something distinct from the sphere of private life.

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The ideal type is most closely approximated in capitalist industrial society where it becomes the major form of organization control. The development of bureaucracy is due to its 'technical superiority' compared to organizations based on charismatic and traditional authority. In Weber's words, "the decisive reason for the advance of bureaucratic organization has always been its purely technical superiority over any other form of organisation". This superiority stems from the combination of specialist skills being subordinated to the goals of the organization. It drives from the exclusion of personal emotions and interests which might detract from the attainment of those goals. It results from a set of rational rules designed explicitly to further the objectives of the organization. Compared to other forms of organizations, tasks in a bureaucracy are performed with greater precision and speed, with less friction and lower costs.

Although Weber appreciated the technical advantages of bureaucratic organization, he was also aware of its disadvantages. He saw the strict control of human freedom and the uniform and rational procedures of bureaucratic practice as preventing spontaneity, creativity and individual initiative. The impersonality of official conduct tends to produce specialists without spirit. Weber foresaw the possibility of men trapped in their specialized routines with little awareness of the relationship between their jobs and the organization as a whole. Weber saw the danger of bureaucrats becoming preoccupied with uniformity and order, of losing sight of all else, becoming dependent on the security provided by their highly structured niche in the bureaucratic machine.

Even the level of formal rationality, however, Weber felt problems were likely to arise because few bureaucracies ever match up to the ideal type. The substance of many decisions is likely to be based on subjective judgement, even if the process is intended to prevent this. Sometimes rule-governed procedures can become rule-bound in the sense that too much red tape prevents decisions being made quickly. Even more seriously, to the extent that the personal career interests of bureaucrats depend on the status of the bureaucracy itself, they have a vested interest in putting the particular aim of increasing the power and authority of the bureaucracy ahead of the universal ends that were supposed to be served by the bureaucracy. Civil servants might become more concerned with protecting the status of the civil service, even of one government department against another, than with delivering a decent service to the public.

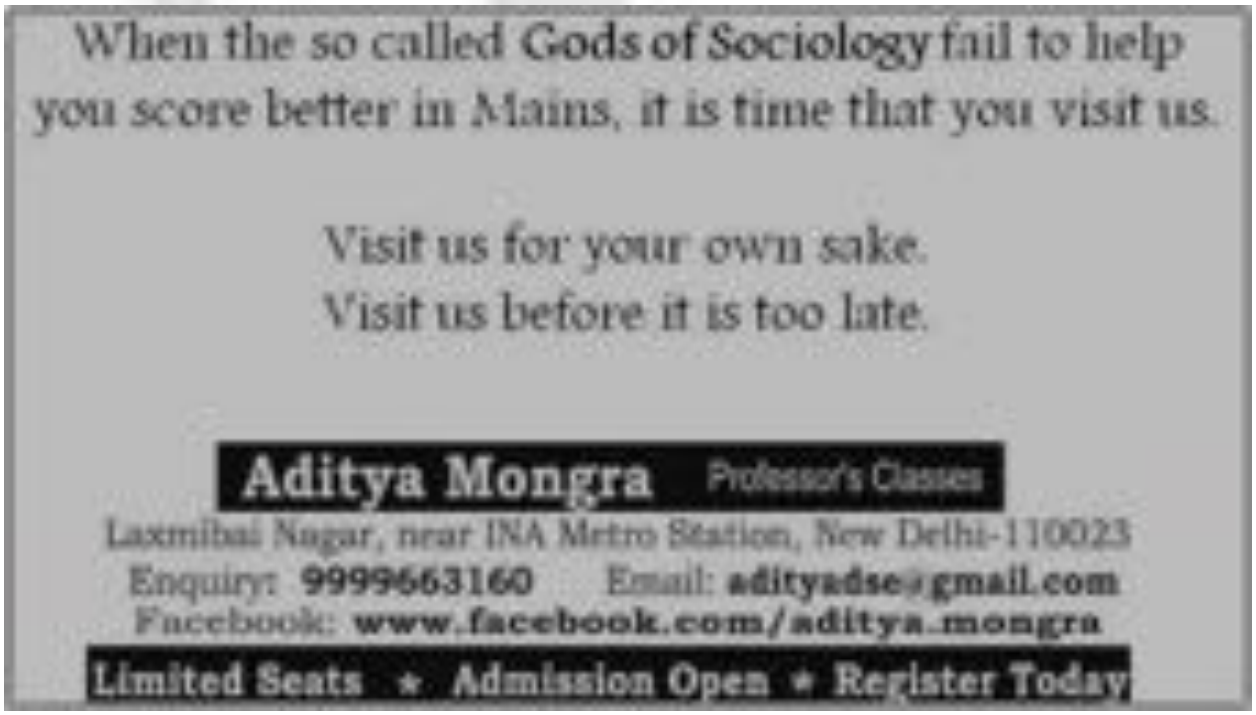
In terms of its political and cultural impact, Weber was also very concerned that bureaucracy has irrational tendencies in the sense that it might override individual freedom and integrity. Based on his own analysis of what was happening in German society during the 1890s, he feared that as more and more aspects of the decision-making process became gathered into fewer and fewer hands, bureaucracies, and the bureaucrats who ran them, would smother personal

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freedoms resulting in the emergence of what he famously called 'a new iron cage of serfdom'. In the political sphere, the turn towards democracy also meant the spread of detailed procedures for conducting democratic elections, which in turn entailed greater reliance on the electoral process and electoral officials. Consequently, democratization of a state also means bureaucratization, particularly since modern political parties themselves are developing more and more into bureaucratic organizations. This tension between the wider purposes (substantive rationality) of the political process, and the narrow functional priorities (formal rationality) of bureaucracy, is a good example of the kind of value conflict we discussed earlier.

Weber was greatly concerned that aided by the increasing centralisation of authority, a new class of professional bureaucrats might be tempted to subvert bureaucratic authority for their own ends. His major reservations about the prospects of a socialist Germany were less to do with the values of the socialist belief system, than with the practical problems it would create through the yet further bureaucratisation of society. As it turned out, the concerns expressed by Weber were amply substantiated in respect of the version of socialist/communist society that emerged as the Soviet Union during the 20th century. This society was profoundly criticised because of the way the bureaucracies of party, state and military contrived, so it seemed, to deprived citizens of representation, right and liberty.



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Despite his foreboding, Weber believes that bureaucracy was essential to the operation of large scale industrial societies. In particular, he believed that the state and economic enterprise could not function effectively without bureaucratic control. It therefore made little sense to try and dispense with bureaucracy. However, Weber was fearful to the end to which bureaucratic organizations could be directed. They represented the most complete and effective institutionalization of power so far created. In Weber's view, bureaucracy has been and is a powerful instrument of the first order, for the one who controls the state bureaucratic administration. He saw two main dangers if this control was left in the hands of bureaucrats themselves. Firstly, particularly in times of crisis bureaucratic leadership would be ineffective. Bureaucrats are trained to follow order and conduct routine operations rather than to make policy decisions and take initiatives in response to a crisis. Secondly, in capitalist society, top bureaucrats may be swayed by the pressure of capitalist interests and tailor their administrative practices to fit the demands of capital.

Weber believed that these dangers could only be avoided by the strong parliamentary control of the state bureaucracy. In particular, professional politicians must hold the top positions in various departments of the state. This will encourage strong and effective leadership since politicians are trained to take decisions. In addition, it will help to open the bureaucracy to public view and reveal any behind the scenes wheeling and dealing between bureaucrats and powerful interests. Politicians are public figures, open to public scrutiny and the criticism of opposition parties. They are therefore accountable for their actions.

But even with politicians at the head of state bureaucracies, problems remain. The professional politician lacks the technical knowledge controlled by the bureaucracy and may have little awareness of its inner working and procedures. He is largely dependent on information supplied to him by bureaucrats and upon their advice as to the feasibility of the measures he wishes to take. He may well end up being directed by the bureaucrats. **Seymour M. Lipset** shows that it is possible for government bureaucracy to exercise considerable control over its 'political masters' in his study of the Cooperative Commonwealth Federation (CCF), a socialist government, in the Canadian province of Saskatchewan. Lipset found that the entrenched bureaucracy was successfully able to scuttle the reformist policies of this new socialist government. People's representatives appointed as ministers to control the bureaucracy proved ineffective.

Lipset's study illustrates Weber's fears of the power of bureaucrats to act independently from their "political masters". Weber believed that only strong parliamentary government could control state bureaucracy. He suggested that state bureaucrats should be made directly and regularly accountable to parliament for their action. The procedure for doing this is the parliamentary committee which

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would systematically cross-examine top civil servants. In Weber's view, 'This alone guarantees public supervision and a through inquiry.

Weber's view of bureaucracy is ambivalent. He recognized its 'technical superiority' over all other forms of organization. He believed that it was essential for the effective operation of large-scale industrial society. While he saw it as a threat to responsible government, he believed that this threat could be countered by strong political control. However, he remained pessimistic about the consequences of bureaucracy for human freedom and happiness.

Much of the later research on organizations can be seen as a debate with Weber. Students of organizations have refined, elaborated and criticized his views. In particular, they question the proposition that bureaucracy organized on the lines of the Weber's ideal type is the most efficient way of realizing organizational goals. It has been argued that certain aspects of the ideal type bureaucracy may in practice, reduce organizational efficiency. The critical remarks of some of the important scholars have been discussed below.

For example, in contrast to Weber's ideal type of bureaucracy and his stress on formal and contractual relationships, **Robert E. Cole** in his study *Japanese Blue Collar: The Changing Tradition* states that Japan has been able to achieve high industrial growth by harmonically synthesising the traditional familial structures, loyalty and paternalistic attitude of the management with the demands of the industry.

In an article entitled, *Bureaucratic Structure and Personality*, **Robert K. Merton** argues that certain aspects of bureaucratic procedure may be dysfunctional to the organization. In particular, they may encourage behaviour which inhibits the realization of organizational goals.

Firstly, the bureaucrat is trained to comply strictly with the rules but, when situations arise which are not covered by the rules this training may lead to inflexibility and timidity. The bureaucrat has not been taught to improvise and innovate and in addition he may well be afraid to do so. His career incentives such as promotions are designed to reward conformity. Thus he may not be inclined to bend the rules even when such actions might further the realization of organizational goals.

Secondly, the devotion to the rules encouraged in bureaucratic organization may lead to a displacement of goals. There is a tendency for conformity to official regulation to become an end in itself rather than the means to an end. That in this way, so called bureaucratic red tape may stand in the way of providing and efficient service for the clients of the organization.

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Thirdly, the emphasis on impersonality in bureaucratic procedures may lead to friction between officials and the public. For example, patients in a hospital or unemployed youth in an employment exchange may expect concern and sympathy for their particular problems. The businesslike and impartial treatment they might receive can lead to bureaucrats being seen as cold, unsympathetic, abrupt and even arrogant. As a result, clients sometimes feel that they have been badly served by bureaucracies. While agreeing that the various elements of bureaucracy outlined in Weber's ideal type serve to further organizational efficiency, Merton maintains that they inevitably produce dysfunctional consequences. He suggests that 'the very elements which conduce towards efficiency in general produce inefficiency in specific instances'.


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Weber presented an ideal type bureaucracy and argued that organizations in modern industrial society were increasingly moving towards that model. However, he had little to say about why actual organizations varied in terms of their approximation of the ideal type apart from suggesting that bureaucracy was particularly suited to the administration of routine tasks. Alvin W. Gouldner's study of gypsum plant in the USA seeks to explore this problem. It is concerned to 'clarify some of the social processes leading to different degrees of bureaucratization'.

Alvin Ward Gouldner (1920 – 1980), an American sociologist, carried out an intensive analysis of one plant owned and operated by the General Gypsum Company. The plant consisted of two parts, a gypsum mine and a factory making wallboards for which gypsum is a major ingredient. There was a significant difference in the degree of bureaucratization between the mine and the factory. In the mine the hierarchy of authority was less developed, the division of labour and spheres of competence were less explicit, there was less emphasis on official rules and procedures and less impersonality both in relationships between workers and between them and the supervisors. Since, in Gouldner's view, these elements are 'the stuff of which bureaucracy is made', then 'bureaucratic organization was more fully developed on the surface than in the mine'. The following example illustrates this point.

In the mine, supervisors usually issued only general instructions leaving it to the miners to decide who was to do the job and how it was to be done. If a miner wanted assistance, he rarely went through the 'proper channels' to obtain orders to direct others to assist him. He simply asked his workmates for help. Official duties were not clearly defined. Miners rotated jobs amongst themselves and often repaired machinery, a job which in the factory was the clear prerogative of the maintenance engineer. Lunch hours were irregular, varying in length and the time at which they were taken. Supervisors accepted and worked within this informal organization. They were 'one of the lads' and placed little emphasis on their officially superior status. One miner summarized the situation as follows, 'Down here we have no rules. We are our own bosses'. By comparison, the factory was considerably more bureaucratic. The hierarchy of authority, the division of labour, official rules and procedures and impersonality, were more widespread and developed.

Gouldner gives the following reasons for the difference in degrees of bureaucratization between mine and surface. Work in the mine was less predictable. The miners had no control over the amount of gypsum available and could not predict various dangers such as cave-ins. No amount of official procedures could control such factors. Miners often had to make their own

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decisions on matters which could not be strictly governed by official rules, for example, strategies for digging out the gypsum and propping up the roof. Since the problems they encountered did not follow a standard pattern, a predetermined set of rules was not suitable for their solution. By comparison, the machine production of wallboard in the factory followed a standard routine and could therefore be 'rationalized' in terms of a bureaucratic system. Fixed rules and a clearly defined division of labour are more suited to predictable operations. The ever present danger in the mine produced strong work group solidarity which in turn encouraged informal organization. Miners depended on their workmates to warn them of loose rocks and to dig them out in the event of a cave-in. In the words of one old miner, 'Friends or no friends, you *got* all to be friends'. A cohesive work group will tend to resist control from above and to institute its own informal work norms.

Part of Gouldner's study is concerned with the arrival of a new manager at the gypsum plant. He came with instructions from head office to cut costs and raise productivity. From the start he attempted to abolish unofficial practices, insisted on the rigorous application of formal rules and instituted a set of new rules which severely limited the workers' autonomy – for example they were not allowed to move round the factory at will. Rule breaking was to be reported to the appropriate authorities, official reports of the details were to be passed up the administrative hierarchy and punishments were to be strictly imposed in accordance with the rules. The new manager thus attempted to increase the degree of bureaucratization in the plant. Gouldner argues that management will tend to do this when it believes that workers are not fulfilling their work roles. The degree to which it achieves this will depend on the 'degree of bureaucratic striving on management's part' and the 'degree of resistance to bureaucratic administration among the workers.'

Despite the forceful attempts of the new manager to impose a strongly bureaucratic system, it was effectively opposed by the miners. Gouldner attributes their success to strong work groups solidarity. They were able to present a united front to management and frustrate many of its demands. In addition, the miners' immediate supervisors, who worked with them underground, were also opposed to the new system. They believed that the miners should be exempt from certain rules and that this privilege was justified by the dangers of the job.

A number of tentative conclusions may be drawn from Gouldner's study. Firstly, bureaucratic administration is more suited to some tasks than others. In particular, it is not well suited to non-routine, unpredictable operations. Secondly, the advance of bureaucracy is not inevitable as Weber and others have implied. As the case of the gypsum miners indicates, it can be successfully resisted. Thirdly, Gouldner suggests that sociologists who are concerned with a utopian vision which

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involves the abolition of bureaucracy would be more fruitfully employed in identifying 'these social processes creating variations in the amount and types of bureaucracy. For these variations do make a vital difference in the lives of men'. By directing their research to this area, sociologists may be able to give direction to those who wish to create organizations with greater democracy and freedom.

In his major work, *Patterns of Industrial Bureaucracy* (1954), Gouldner lead an ethnographic study in a mine and identified there various patterns of bureaucracy and bureaucratization. He analyzed how, after the appointment of a new manager the bureaucratization process emerged. Gouldner identified three types of bureaucracy in his studies, with very specific patterns. These are:

- Mock bureaucracy
- Representative bureaucracy
- Punishment-centered bureaucracy.

Mock bureaucracy: This type comes from outside agency and is implemented officially, but not in daily behaviors. Both management and workers agree in this case to act the same way. The rules are not enforced in this case, neither by management, nor by the workers. No conflict seem to emerge in this case. "Smoking" is in this case seen as inevitable. The "no-smoking rule" is an example of mock-bureaucracy.

Representative bureaucracy: Both management and workers enforced this rule and it generated very few tensions. In this context, the focus was on the education of workers as management considered them as ignorant and careless regarding security rules. The safety program is an example of representative. Meetings happened regularly to implement this program and it was as well the occasion to voice some concerns for workers. For the management, this program was a way to tighten the control over workers.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: This type of program was initiated by management and generated many tensions. Management viewed workers as deliberately willing to be absent. Therefore, punishment was installed in order to force the workers not to be absent. For example, the "no-absenteeism" rule is an example of the punishment-centered bureaucracy.

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Summary of factors associated with the three patterns of bureaucracy:

1. *Who Usually Initiates the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: The rule or rules are imposed on the group by some "outside" agency. Neither workers nor management, neither superiors nor subordinates, identify themselves with or participate in the establishment of the rules or view them as their own. For example, the "no-smoking" rule was initiated by the insurance company.

Representative bureaucracy: Both groups initiate the rules and view them as their own. For example, pressure was exerted by union and management to initiate and develop the safety programme. Workers and supervisors could make modifications of the program at periodic meetings.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: The rule arises in response to the pressure of either workers or management, but is not jointly initiated by them. The group which does not initiate the rule views it as imposed upon it by the other. For example, through their union the workers initiated the bidding system. Supervisors viewed it as something to which the Company was forced to adhere.

2. *Whose Values Legitimate the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: Neither superiors nor subordinated can, ordinarily, legitimate the rule in terms of their own values.

Representative bureaucracy: Usually, both workers and management can legitimate the rules in terms of their own key values. For example, management legitimated the safety program by tying it to production. Workers legitimized it via their values on personal and bodily welfare, maintenance of income, and cleanliness.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: Either superiors or subordinates alone consider the rule legitimate; the other may concede on grounds of expediency, but does not define the rule as legitimate. For example, workers considered the bidding system "fair", since they viewed it as minimizing personal favoritism in the distribution of jobs. Supervisors conformed to it largely because they feared the consequences of deviation.

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3. *Whose Values Are Violated by Enforcement of the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: Enforcement of the rule violates the values of both groups. For example, if the no-smoking rule were put into effect, it would violate the value on "personal equality" held by workers and supervisors, since office workers would still be privileged to smoke.

Representative bureaucracy: Under most conditions, enforcement of the rules entails violations of neither group's values. For example, it is only under comparatively exceptional circumstances that enforcement of the safety rules interfered with a value held by management, say, a value on production.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: Enforcement of the rules violates the values of only one group, either superiors or subordinates. For example, the bidding rules threatened management's value on the use of skill and ability as criteria for occupational recruitment.

4. *What Are the Standard Explanations of Deviations from the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: The deviant pattern is viewed as an expression of "uncontrollable" needs or of "human nature". For example, people were held to smoke because of "nervousness."

Representative bureaucracy: Deviance is attributed to ignorance or well-intentioned carelessness – i.e. it is an unanticipated byproduct of behaviour oriented to some other end and thus an "accident". This we call a "utilitarian" conception of deviance. For example, violation of the safety rule might be seen as motivated by concern for production, rather than by a deliberate intention to have accidents. If, for example, a worker got a hernia, this might be attributed to his ignorance of proper lifting technique.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: In the main, deviance is attributed to deliberate intent. Deviance is thought to be the deviant's end. This we call a "voluntaristic" conception of deviance. For example, when a worker was absent without an excuse, this was not viewed as an expression of an uncontrollable impulse, or as unanticipated consequence of other interests. It was believed to be willful.

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5. *What Effect Do the Rules Have Upon the Status of the Participants?*

Mock bureaucracy: Ordinarily, deviation from the rule is status-enhancing for workers and management both. Conformance to the rule would be status impairing for both. For example, violation of the no-smoking rule tended to minimize the visibility of status differentials, by preventing the emergence of a privileged stratum of smokers.

Representative bureaucracy: Usually, deviation from the rules impairs the status of superiors and subordinates, while conformance ordinarily permits both a measure of status improvement. For example, the safety program increased the prestige of workers' job by improving the cleanliness of the plant (the "good housekeeping" component), as well as enabling workers to initiate action for their superiors through the safety meetings. It also facilitated management's ability to realize its production obligations, and provided it with legitimations for extended control over the worker.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: Conformance to or deviation from the rules leads to status gains either for workers or supervisors, but not for both, and to status losses for the other. For example, workers' conformance to the bidding system allowed them to escape from tense relations with certain supervisors or to secure jobs and promotions without dependence upon supervisory favors. It deprived supers of the customary prerogative of recommending workers for promotion or for hiring.

6. *Summary of Defining Characteristics or Symptoms*

Mock bureaucracy:

(a) Rules are neither enforced by management nor obeyed by workers.

(b) Usually entails little conflict between the two groups.

(c) Joint violation and evasion of rules is buttressed by the informal sentiments of the participants.

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Representative bureaucracy:

(a) Rules are both enforced by management and obeyed by workers.

(b) Generates a few tensions, but little overt conflict.

(c) Joint support for rules buttressed by informal sentiments, mutual participation initiation, and education of workers and management.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy:

(a) Rules either enforced by workers or management, and evaded by the other.

(b) Entails relatively great tension and conflict.

(c) Enforced by punishment and supported by the informal sentiments of either workers or management.

This completes our discussion on Gouldner's contributions in facilitating our understanding of the various patterns of industrial bureaucracy. In response to Weber's ideal type of bureaucracy, Gouldner argued that bureaucracy may manifest different patterns under different contexts.

Gouldner's conclusions are supported by the findings of research by **Tom Burns** and **G.M. Stalker**. From a study of twenty Scottish and English firms, mainly in the electronics industry, Burns and Stalker argue that bureaucratic organizations are best suited to dealing with predictable, familiar and routine situations. They are not well suited to the rapidly changing technical and commercial situation of many sectors of modern industry such as the electronics industry. Since change is the hallmark of modern society, bureaucratic organizations may well be untypical of the future.

Burns and Stalker construct two ideal types of organization which they term '**mechanistic**' and '**organic**'. The firms in their research range between these extremes. The mechanistic organization is very similar to Weber's model of bureaucracy. It includes a specialized division of labour with the rights and duties of each employee being precisely defined. Specialized tasks are coordinated by a management hierarchy which directs operations and takes major decisions. Communication is mainly vertical: instructions flow downward through a chain of command, information flows upward and is processed by various levels in the

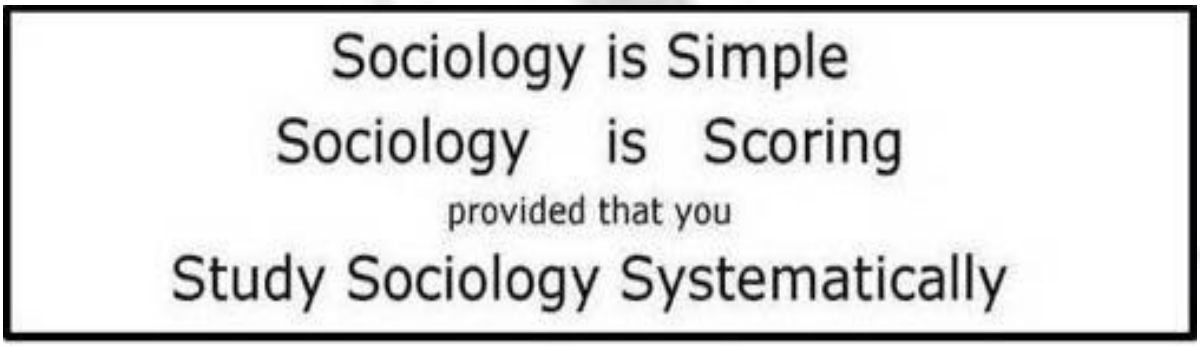
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hierarchy before it reaches the top. Each individual in the organization is responsible for discharging his particular responsibility and no more.

By comparison, areas of responsibility are not clearly defined in organic organizations. The rigid hierarchies and specialized divisions of labour of mechanistic systems tend to disappear. The individual's job is to employ his skills to further the goals of the organization rather than simply carry out a predetermined operation. When a problem arises, all those who have knowledge and expertise to contribute to its solution meet and discuss. Tasks are shaped by the nature of the problem rather than being predefined. Communication consists of consultation rather than being predefined. Communication consists of consultation rather than command, of 'information and advice rather than instructions and decisions'. Although a hierarchy exists, it tends to become blurred as communication travels in all directions and top management no longer has the sole prerogative over important decisions nor is it seen to monopolize the knowledge necessary to make them. Burns and Stalker argue that mechanistic systems are best suited to stable conditions, organic systems to changing conditions.

Weber has often been criticized for focusing exclusively on the formal structure of bureaucracy, that is the official rules and procedures, the authorized hierarchy of offices and the official duties attached to them. His critics have argued that unofficial practices are an established part of the structure of all organizations. They must therefore be included in an explanation of the functioning of organizations. **Peter Blau** claims that Weber's approach 'implies that any deviation from the formal structure is detrimental to administrative efficiency'. However, on the basis of his study of the functioning of a federal law enforcement agency in Washington DC, Peter Blau argues that the presence of both formal and informal structures in the organization may together enhance the efficiency of the organization. On the other hand, the presence of formal structures alone, may act as a hindrance towards the attainment of organizational goals.



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Weber: An Assessment

Weber's importance as a classical sociologist did not begin until Talcott Parsons introduced him to the American public. Parson himself studied and defended a dissertation in Heidelberg during the latter half of the 1920s. And in 1930 he translated *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* into English. Parsons later based much of his book *The Structure of Social Action* (1937) on Weber, and as Parsons's influence grew in American and later in international sociology, Weber also gained more and more status as a classic.

Weber's contribution to modern sociology is multi dimensional so much so that he can be legitimately considered as one of the founding fathers of modern sociology. He contributed a new perspective on the nature of subject matter of sociology and laid down the foundations of interpretative sociology. In addition, he carried out penetrating analysis of some of the crucial features of western society like social stratification, bureaucracy, rationality and growth of capitalism. As should be clear from this introduction to Weber's work his influence on social theory has been considerable.

Firstly, by viewing the subject matter of sociology in terms of social action, he highlighted the significance of subjective meanings and motives in understanding social behavior. This view of Weber presented an alternative and a corrective to the positivist approach in sociology. The positivists like Durkheim, by assuming a deterministic perspective had almost totally ignored the role of the individual's subjectivity in shaping social behavior. They had restricted the study of social behaviour to externally observable aspects only. Thus Weber's emphasis on exploring the subjective dimension provided a corrective to overly social determinist perspective of the positivist.

Secondly, in terms of methodology, Weber extends the conceptual tool kit of social theory by drawing attention to uniqueness of social phenomena and especially to their qualitative and subjective dimensions. While recognising the difficulty of doing so, he recommends that social phenomena need to be seen from the point of view of social actors themselves, and not just from the abstract vantage point of the social theorist. His discussions of *Verstehen*, ideal types, causal pluralism and value-neutrality are intended to assist in this process. Thus, Weber came to be seen as one of the founders of a "subjectivist" and phenomenological sociology.

Thirdly, Weber extends the analysis of social development offered by Marx in order to include not only material economic factors, but intellectual ones as well. It is the struggle over ideas that fuels social development not just technological innovation. Raising an issue that has been taken up by social theorists such as

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Anthony Giddens during the 20th century, Weber also draws attention to the fact that social events are much more contingent than we might like to think they are. He still tells us an interesting and persuasive story about the historical origins of modern capitalism, but all the while insists that things could have turned out quite differently. Social theory needs to work at the level of actual events rather than trying to interpret events in order to substantiate a general theory of how thing ought to or must have developed.

Fourthly, corresponding with his methodological recommendation of trying to understand social action from the point of view of the individual social actor Weber strongly supports the need for social theory to include non-material phenomena. He thus prepares the way for a much more forthright analysis of the importance of **hermeneutic** or meaning-laden aspects of social phenomena that was to follow later in the 20th century.

Further, Weber's methodological individualism also sets him apart from Durkheim and Marx, both of whom adopt a strongly collectivist interpretation of social action. Although Weber accepts that social actors often act together, and with shared ideas and common aims in mind, he resists the idea that individuals are drawn towards particular ways of acting by the pull of collective forces. Weber's social theory is more **voluntaristic** in the sense that social actors choose how to act rather than being compelled to do so by social forces beyond their control. For much the same reason, Weber concentrates on a theory of social action and not on a theory of society.

Finally, and in terms of his own sociological analyses of modern society, Weber identifies the crucial significance in social development of the general concept of rationality, which was central to Enlightenment thought and the idea of reason. He then refines this into a robust and thoroughly modern concept of instrumental rationality. Although opinion differs over the exact formula of instrumental rationality it is widely accepted that this is the kind of rationality that is most characteristic of modern society. One of the major preoccupations of critical social theory and the Frankfurt School, and of Jurgen Habermas, is to continue to explore the negative impact on modern society of the idea of instrumental rationality described by Max Weber.

During the past decade, in particular, with its debate over "postmodernism," Weber's critique of blind faith in science and rationality seems to have appealed to many. Thus, he is not just an early predecessor of modern sociology and social science, but he is definitely present, participating in the debate over the problems of modern society.

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A note on the conflict tradition after Marx and Weber:

Although the foundations of the conflict approach to the study of social phenomena were laid down by Karl Marx. However to adapt this approach to contemporary societies, it had to be interpreted in the light of the criticism and modification suggested by Weber. Thus, the imprint of Weber's ideas is clearly visible in the works of contemporary conflict theorists like C.W. Mills and Ralf Dahrendorf. Even those belonging to the Frankfurt School of thought namely Theodor Adorno, Herbert Marcuse, Jurgen Habermas etc. have also been influenced by Weber's ideas. However, Ralf Dahrendorf a contemporary German scholar has presented the conflict theory in a more systematized manner.

Ralf Dahrendorf in his book *Class and Class Conflict in Industrial Society* also examines the usefulness and applicability of Marx's sociological work to the study of modern industrial society. He argues that Marx's analysis of 19th century capitalist society was largely correct and his concepts and theories were valuable. However these concepts and theories require to be modified if they are to be applied to the modern industrial society because they refer to specifically to the 19th century capitalistic society. There have been highly significant changes in the social structure since Marx's time. In fact these changes have been great enough to produce a new type of society, that is, modern industrial or post-capitalist society. Dahrendorf wishes to generate a body of concepts and theory which will be general enough to explain both capitalist and post capitalist societies. He endeavors to generate his new theory directly out of Marx's analysis preserving, modifying and occasionally abandoning some concepts. Dahrendorf suggest that the following changes of the social structure have been sufficient to produce a post capitalist society.

- **Decomposition of capital** (stock holders and managers): This implies the separation of ownership and control over large corporations such as joint stock companies where the ownership (in the form of equity) lies with the public at large while the control is exercised by the management, professionals, technocrats and other experts. With the growth in the scale of business companies due to technological advances and due to the development of joint stock limited liability companies, the link between the ownership and control of industry has weakened. Much control is now exerted by salaried managers, who tend to legitimize their position in industry and in society rather differently than old style capitalist. Capitalists too play a somewhat different role as shareholders or as company directors.

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- **Decomposition of labour** (from homogeneous group of equally unskilled and impoverished people, to differentiated occupational groups, with differentiated attributes and status (prestige, responsibility, authority)): Dahrendorf believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegrating of the manual working class. Contrary to Marx's prediction, the manual working class has become increasingly heterogeneous or dissimilar by the emergence of new differentiations of skill. He sees this resulting from changes in technology arguing that 'increasingly complex machines require increasingly qualified designers, builders, maintenance and repair men and even minders'. Dahrendorf claims that the working class is now divided into three distinct levels: unskilled, semi-skilled and skilled manual workers. Differences in economic and prestige rewards are linked to this hierarchy of skill. In view of the differences in skill, economic and status rewards and interests within the ranks of manual workers, Dahrendorf claims that 'it has become doubtful whether speaking of the working class still makes much sense'. He believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegration of the manual working class. In other words, like the controlling groups, the workers have also become more differentiated. The proportions of both skilled and semi skilled workers have grown and the proportion of unskilled workers has fallen. Far from becoming homogenized in terms of class consciousness, the workers are becoming increasingly aware of the differences between themselves.

- **Institutionalisation of class conflict (**industrial bargaining): According to Dahrendorf, the tension between labour and capital is recognized as a principle of the structure of the labour market and has become a legal institution of society. As workers have become increasingly skilled, educated and better paid, they have become more integrated into the middle layers of society. The traditional sources of discontent and labour militancy have been dissolved. The basis for class struggle is gone. Conflicts now develop within imperatively coordinated associations (institutional structures such as business organizations, unions and so forth) and are resolved rationally and fairly through mediation, arbitration or adjudication.

- **Development of a new middle class:** This term is misleading in that it refers to a large and growing collection of different groups which have been created or have expanded with the industrialization of society. It is a category rather than a class in terms of Marx's use of this concept and is made up of white collar workers such as teachers, accountants, surveyors, nurses and clerks, etc.

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- **Growth of social mobility:** There is much more inter generation mobility between occupations and self recruitment – where the son follows the father's occupation – is great only in the very top and the very low occupations.
- **Growth of equality:** Over the last hundred years social and economic inequalities have been reduced as the state has guaranteed a minimum standard of living to its citizens and has heavily taxed those with the highest incomes and those with the greatest wealth.

Dahrendorf concludes that society can be characterized correctly in terms of conflict between competing interest groups. In a post-capitalist society, however conflicts have becomes institutionalized i.e. more orderly patterned, predictable and controllable. Workers have the right to express their interests legitimately through socially acceptable machinery like collective bargaining which is conducted through their own bona fide organisations like trade unions. Conflict is not now so bitter and as potentially destructive of the social system because the changes in social structure listed above give everyone some stake in the system. Interests are pursued according to the rules of the game. The rules require the use of the established machinery for dealing with conflicts created by competing interest groups.

In the light of these arguments Dahrendorf points out what he considers to be the weakness of Marx's theories and suggests ways in which they can be modified in order to give a useful basis for analyzing both capitalist and post-capitalist societies. For him, the basic weakness of Marx's approach is in the way Marx toes power – economic, social and political – to the ownership of the means of production. Dahrendorf argues that social classes are not necessarily and inevitably economic groups, that social conflict is not necessarily shaped or determined by the economic base. For Dahrendorf, authority relationships represent the key feature of a society. In any society some individuals have the right or authority to give commands to others. These others have in turn the duty to obey. Thus individuals who share identical interest of commanding or of obeying in some sphere of activity, whether it be political, economic and industrial, may be described as a quasi group i.e. a potential group. If these interests are articulated so that members become conscious of them, then these interests become manifest and become the basis of organized and self conscious interest groups. Dahrendorf defines social classes as organized or unorganized categories of people who share manifest or latent interests arising from their positions in the authority structures in which they find themselves. For him then conflict is merely any conflict of groups arising from authority relationships. Dahrendorf argues that most people in society are unlikely to be engaged in one mighty political, economic, social, and industrial

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conflict which is generated from one structural source, that is, property relationships. Instead changes in social structure (as listed above) create the social structural basis for a plurality of interest groups and hence a plurality of bases for control.

In this way, Dahrendorf attempts to refine and develop Marx's approach to understand the social world. However, not all writers share his view that a new type of society has succeeded capitalism. For example, John Westergaard, a British sociologist, in his ironically titled article *The Withering Away of Class – A Contemporary Myth* suggests that despite some changes modern industrial societies are still similar in their basic structure to capitalist societies. Though certain changes since Marx's time have obscured the visibility of the working of the social system and have made the growth of class consciousness harder to achieve, the system is still largely built around the private ownership of the means of production and social life is, therefore, shaped in most respects by this fact.



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A note on Marxian view of bureaucracy:

To Weber, bureaucracy is a response to the administrative requirements of all industrial societies, whether capitalist or communist. The nature of ownership of the forces of production makes relatively little difference to the need for bureaucratic control but from a Marxian perspective, bureaucracy can only be understood in relation to the forces of production. Thus in capitalist society, where the forces of production are owned by a minority, the ruling class, and state bureaucracy will inevitably represent the interest of that class. Many Marxists have seen the bureaucratic state apparatus as a specific creation of capitalist society. Weber believed that responsible government could be achieved by strong parliamentary control of the state bureaucracy. This would prevent the interests of capital from predominating. Lenin, though, maintained that Western parliaments were 'mere talking-shops' while the 'real work of government was conducted behind closed doors by the state bureaucracy'. In his view, 'The state is an organ of class rule, an organ for the oppression of one class by another'.

Since state bureaucracy is ultimately shaped by a capitalist infrastructure, its control can only be eliminated by a radical change in that infrastructure. In terms of Marxian theory, this requires the communal ownership of the forces of production. Since state bureaucracy is basically a repressive means of control, it must be smashed and replaced by new, truly democratic institutions. Lenin believed that after the dictatorship of the proletariat was established in the USSR in 1917, there would be a steady decline in state bureaucracy. He recognized that some form of administration was necessary but looked forward to the proposals outlined by Marx and Engels. Administrators would be directly appointed and subject to recall at any time. Their wages would not exceed those of any worker. Administrative tasks would be simplified to the point where basic literacy and numeracy were sufficient for their performance. In this way, everybody would have the skills necessary to participate in the administrative process. Members of a truly communist society would no longer be imprisoned in a specialized occupational role. Lenin looked forward to a future in which 'all may become "bureaucrats" for a time and that, therefore, nobody may be able to become a "bureaucrat"'. He envisaged mass participation in administration which would involve 'control and supervision by all'. In this way the repressive state bureaucracies of the West would be replaced by a truly democratic system.

Lenin offers little more than a vague and general blueprint for the future. He gives few specific details of how the democratization of state bureaucracy is to be accomplished and of how the new institutions will actually work. In practice, the 1917 revolution was not followed by the dismantling of state bureaucracy but by its expansion. Lenin puts this down to the 'immaturity of socialism', but there is no evidence that the increasing maturity of the USSR has reversed the trend of

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bureaucratization. In fact many observers have seen bureaucracy as the organizing principle of Soviet society. For example, Alfred Meyer argues that, 'The USSR is best understood as a large, complex bureaucracy comparable in its structure and functioning to giant corporations, armies, government agencies and similar institutions in the West'. Milovan Djilas draws a similar picture with particular emphasis on what he sees as the exploitive nature of bureaucratic control. According to Djilas, political bureaucrats in the USSR direct the economy for their own benefit. The mass of the population is seen to have little opportunity to participate in or control the state administration.

While admitting that 'bureaucratization does militate against democratic control', David Lane maintains that in the case of the USSR, 'this must not detract from the fact that a centralized administration has been a major instrument in ensuring industrialization and social change '. Lane claims that these changes have benefitted all members of society. He believes that the state bureaucracy is committed to the development of an industrial nation leading eventually to a classless society. As such it will operate in a very different way from state administrations in the west. Whatever the merits of these various viewpoints, one thing remains clear. Communal ownership of the forces of production has not resulted in the dismantling of bureaucratic structures.

Probably the most valiant attempt to remove bureaucratic control was made in China under the leadership of Mao Tse-tung. Ambrose Yeo-chi King gives the following details of the ideals and practice of administration during the 'Cultural Revolution'. While recognizing the need for some form of administrative organization, the Maoists rejected the model of bureaucracy provided by Weber's ideal type. They insisted that organizations must be controlled by and directly serve the 'masses', that is those at the base of the organizational hierarchy and the clientele of the organization. This is to be achieved not simply by the participation of the masses but by placing control of the organization directly in their hands.

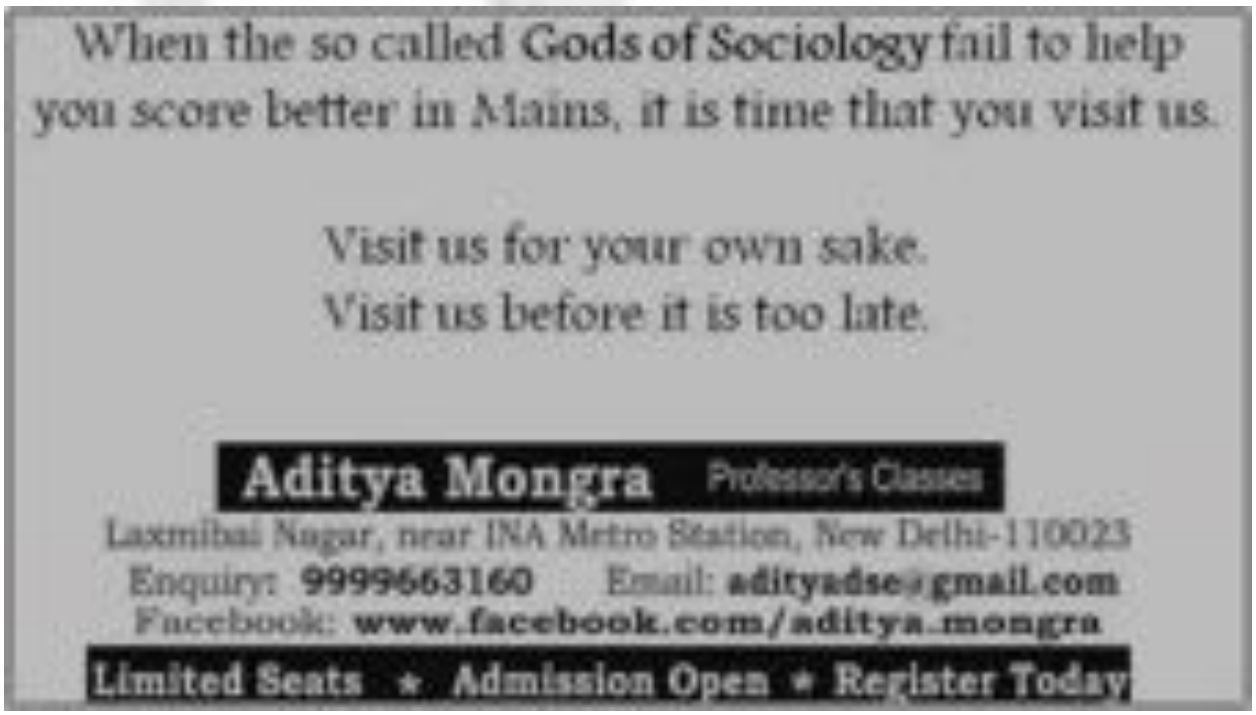
The ideal organization is pictured as follows. The rigid hierarchy of officials will be abolished. Hierarchies are seen to block communication, to encourage 'buck passing' and to stifle the creative energies and initiative of the masses. Leaders will remain but they will lead rather than command. The specialized division of labour and the fragmentation of tasks are rejected in favour of a system whereby everyone should 'take care of everything' within the organization. The expert will become a figure of the past since his technical knowledge and expertise will be spread amongst the masses. The full-time professional administrator will disappear. All administrative leaders must spend some of their time involved in actual production in the fields and factories. Finally, the fixed rules and regulations which characterize the typical bureaucracy are seen as instruments to repress the

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masses. They should therefore be changed as the masses see fit. Yeo-chi King notes that these ideals were put into practice in the following ways. Firstly by means of the 'role shifting system' whereby leaders moved to the base of the organization. In theory, this would allow them to empathize with the masses and minimize, if not eliminate, status differences. Secondly by means of 'group-based decision making systems', where for example, workers directly participate in the various decisions required for running a factory.

While applauding the spirit of these measures, Yeo-chi King has serious doubts about their practicality. At best he believes they have 'a high tendency towards organizational instability'. He sees them offering little hope for the economic modernization of China on which the Maoists placed such emphasis. With China's more recent moves towards the West, it appears that the organizations by which 'the Masses take command' have been put to one side. Yeo-chi King suggests that 'Mao's intervention was a kind of charismatic breakthrough from the bureaucratic routinization'. If Weber is correct and charismatic authority is rapidly routinized into traditional or rational-legal authority structures, then the organizational experiments of the Cultural Revolution were necessarily shortlived.



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